

1. After the Moon Assembly

The wing had gone almost completely silent after Leora left.

Only the low crackle of the brazier remained, mixed with the occasional soft chime of Kohaku's fox bell whenever the infant shifted in sleep.

Moonlight filtered through the paper screens in pale bands across the floor.

Friedhelm lay stretched beside the fire in loose dark layers, one knee bent slightly, pale hair spilling untidily across the cushions beneath him. One arm rested folded beneath his head.

Across the room, Sukuna watched him.

And very quickly realized something dangerous.

Friedhelm flushed harder the longer he was looked at.

Not embarrassment.

Something closer to overstimulation.

His skin warmed visibly beneath focused attention alone.

Interesting.

Sukuna leaned one shoulder lightly against a wooden pillar.

> “You turn red easily.”

Friedhelm exhaled once through his nose without opening his eyes.

> “You stare too much.”

Instead of stopping, Sukuna moved closer.

Bare feet silent against the floorboards.

> “And yet you haven’t told me to leave.”

That landed immediately.

Friedhelm’s breathing changed.

Tiny shift.

But obvious once noticed.

Sukuna’s attention sharpened.

Pulse fluttering faintly in Friedhelm’s throat.

Fingers flexing unconsciously against the blankets.

Shoulders tightening slightly before forcing themselves to loosen again.

His focus scattering around the edges.

And instead of backing off—

Sukuna became fascinated.

Because Friedhelm reacted nothing like Leora.

Leora melted beneath intensity.

Reached toward it instinctively.

Friedhelm overheated beneath it.

Sharpened.

Fragmented around the edges like glass under too much pressure.

Sukuna moved closer again.

Eventually he stood directly above him while Friedhelm remained half reclined beside the fire.

Not threatening.

Just immense.

Certain.

Friedhelm visibly shivered.

That nearly ruined Sukuna's restraint entirely.

Because Friedhelm did not look frightened.

He looked affected.

Deeply.

Like his body could not decide whether to move away or closer.

Sukuna lowered himself into a crouch beside him.

Closer now.

Warmth from the brazier catching gold-red against his markings.

> "Are all Ten Brinkens this responsive?"

Friedhelm shut his eyes briefly.

Dangerous decision.

Sukuna watched the movement in his throat carefully.

Then softer:

> “Or is it just me?”

Friedhelm still did not answer.

Which was answer enough.

From the crib nearby came a sleepy little growling sound.

Kohaku.

Friedhelm escaped immediately.

He rose too quickly from the floor and crossed to the crib before Sukuna could say another word.

Carefully he gathered Kohaku against his chest.

The infant settled almost instantly beneath his hand, tiny fox ears flickering faintly through silver hair before disappearing again.

Sukuna watched the entire thing silently.

The contrast was devastating.

Friedhelm flushed and overwhelmed one moment—

then impossibly gentle the next.

Grounded entirely by the child in his arms.

Kohaku gave one tiny sleepy chirr against Friedhelm's shoulder.

Friedhelm adjusted the blanket around him automatically.

Precise.

Protective.

Then once the infant drifted deeper into sleep, Friedhelm placed him carefully back into the crib.

The black fox bell chimed once.

Soft.

Clear.

Silence followed.

And when Friedhelm turned around—

Sukuna was already there.

Too close.

Friedhelm stopped immediately.

Sukuna slowly advanced another step.

No touching.

Only presence.

Only pressure.

Until Friedhelm's shoulders nearly brushed the wall behind him.

Then quietly:

> “Does this happen with everyone?”

Friedhelm swallowed once before answering.

> “You enjoy cornering people too much.”

A faint smile pulled briefly at Sukuna’s mouth.

> “That wasn’t an answer.”

And there—

the shift.

Because Friedhelm refused to let Sukuna keep the advantage any longer.

Instead of retreating again, he lifted his chin slightly and asked:

> “Would you react differently if I turned it around on you?”

Sukuna stilled instantly.

Not offended.

Interested.

Very interested.

The room changed around them.

Friedhelm stepped forward deliberately this time.

Measured.

Controlled despite the lingering heat beneath his skin.

Then slowly he reached for Sukuna's wrist.

Sukuna allowed it immediately.

Friedhelm guided Sukuna's hand upward—

and placed it against the side of his own neck.

Not submissive.

Not provocative.

Grounding.

Sukuna went completely still.

Because the gesture contained enormous trust.

Friedhelm's pulse beat firmly beneath his palm.

Warm.

Real.

And quietly, Friedhelm said:

> “Pressure helps.”

He encouraged Sukuna to tighten a bit. The reaction was immediate. A small involuntary sound escaped. One that screamed relief.

That landed harder than anything else tonight.

Sukuna understood immediately.

This was not fear.

Not surrender.

Regulation.

Anchoring.

Friedhelm was grounding himself through certainty.

Through controlled physical presence.

And once Sukuna understood that, everything else changed too.

The steadier Sukuna held him—

the steadier Friedhelm became.

Breathing evening gradually.

Shoulders lowering.

Eyes sharpening back into focus instead of scattering away.

Sukuna adjusted instinctively after that.

More precise.

More careful.

Never careless.

Friedhelm reacted to that almost unbearably.

Because most people became less controlled when emotional.

Sukuna became more exact.

More deliberate.

Eventually Sukuna asked quietly:

> “You trust me this much?”

No teasing now.

A real question.

Friedhelm answered immediately.

Without hesitation.

> “You’ve had every opportunity not to deserve it.”

Silence settled heavily between them.

Because Sukuna understood exactly what he meant.

Friedhelm had tested him before.

Again and again.

Not to provoke cruelty—

but to determine whether Sukuna would ever truly lose control with him.

Whether intensity would become danger.

Whether emotion would become recklessness.

And every single time—

Sukuna had stopped himself before real harm.

Every time.

Friedhelm's eyes lowered briefly before he said:

> "Most people become less careful when they're emotional."

A pause.

Then quieter:

> "You become more precise."

That struck deeper than praise had any right to.

Because Friedhelm valued control more than almost anything.

Especially after a life where bodily autonomy had repeatedly been taken from him.

What affected him most was not dominance.

It was safe restraint from someone powerful enough to destroy him.

And Sukuna finally understood that completely.

Usually Sukuna directed pace automatically.

Cornered.

Consumed space.

Controlled momentum without thinking about it.

But now he noticed something important:

Every time he pushed too hard—

Friedhelm reacted harder than expected.

Not fear.

Intensity.

Overload.

So Sukuna deliberately stilled.

And quietly said:

> “Then show me what works.”

That was enormous for him.

Not weakness.

Trust.

Friedhelm approached him slowly afterward.

And Sukuna realized almost immediately that Friedhelm was now controlling the interaction completely—

while somehow making it feel mutual.

Carefully Friedhelm adjusted:

where Sukuna’s hands rested on his waist and ribs,
how firmly he held him when he moved against him,
how close they stood and what angles.

Not manipulative.

Instinctive.

Entirely calibrated toward remaining present inside himself.

The firmer the grounding contact became—

the calmer Friedhelm became.

And Sukuna found himself intensely curious about how fundamentally different that was from Leora.

Eventually Friedhelm lifted one hand and rested it lightly against Sukuna's jaw and throat.

Not restraining.

Just steadying him there.

Holding him still for one quiet moment.

And Sukuna let him.

Completely.

No resistance at all.

Because he understood suddenly—

Friedhelm was not trying to control him.

He was confirming something.

You are here.

I am here.

We are both real.

The stillness between them became almost unbearably intimate.

Then Friedhelm said quietly:

> “You calm down too.”

Sukuna went still.

Because he had not consciously noticed it.

But Friedhelm had.

Friedhelm’s thumb shifted once lightly against his jaw.

> “You get quieter when someone you trust touches you back.”

And something changed permanently between them after that.

Not predator and prey.

Not dominance and surrender.

Just—

two dangerous people realizing they regulated each other.

Friedhelm pulled Sukuna towards the bed. He began untying their robes before discarding them. He kissed Sukuna neck leaving a myriad of marks there.

Sukuna made a low noise in his chest. Friedhelm ran his fingers through his hair and pulled. Sukuna grabbed his wrists, sensing what Friedhelm really wanted now.

When he pushed Friedhelm on the bed he covered him with his weight, pinning him exactly the way Friedhelm always moved him to do. Friedhelm made another small noise. Sukuna wanted more of those delicate noises.

He lifted his hips up, smoothed his hands up Friedhelm’s ribs, digging his fingers into his sides like he knew he loved. Friedhelm mewled.

Sukuna made another noise that betrayed a massive amount of strength.

Friedhelm pulled him in for a kiss while Sukuna’s hands and fingers did the rest of the work.

By the time Friedhelm had become needy and restless, he began pushing Sukuna’s restraint openly. Hotter kisses, hair pulled in just the right spots, breathy moans he knew Sukuna would have to close his eyes for a moment to resist, and then nips of teeth to his lips and neck.

Sukuna never lost control but he did become rougher and more sure. Friedhelm responded beautifully. Occasionally begging for more pressure or more presence.

Sukuna was burning by the time he had enough. He pressed Friedhelm’s wrists on either side of his head and looked at him. Friedhelm’s reaction was immediate. A strong shiver, arched back, and eyes that promised to make it interesting if Sukuna would just give him what he wanted.

All it took was one more sound falling from Friedhelm's beautiful mouth for his restraint to snap.

Later, the room settles into quiet naturally.

Not awkwardly.

Not cautiously.

Just slowly, like snow burying sound outside the screens.

The fire burns lower.

Kohaku sleeps in the crib nearby, tiny breaths soft beneath the occasional faint chime of the fox bell whenever he shifts in his blankets.

And for the first time in a very long time—

Friedhelm falls asleep beside someone else willingly.

Sukuna lies behind him in the warmth of the bed, one arm resting heavily around Friedhelm's waist beneath the blankets.

No games anymore.

No testing.

Just heat.

Weight.

Presence.

Friedhelm had gone quiet gradually after the conversation ended, exhaustion finally beginning to win against the strain of the Assembly, the storm, Leora, the silence between siblings, everything.

But even half asleep—

he still reached back first.

Still found Sukuna's wrist automatically.

Just like Leora always did.

That same unconscious motion.

Fingers wrapping securely around his pulse like grounding himself against something real before sleep could fully take him.

Sukuna felt the realization hit him almost physically.

Leora did that.

Always.

Without thinking.

And now Friedhelm too.

As though both of them instinctively anchored themselves to the certainty of him before letting themselves become vulnerable.

Dangerous thing.

Dangerous knowledge.

Friedhelm's breathing slowly deepened afterward.

And Sukuna realized something else.

For the first time since he had known him—

Friedhelm actually slept deeply.

No tension lingering in his shoulders.

No abrupt waking at every sound.

No carefully maintained awareness beneath the surface.

Just sleep.

Complete enough that his grip loosened slightly around Sukuna's wrist as unconsciousness fully claimed him.

That hit harder than Sukuna expected too.

First Leora.

Now Friedhelm.

Both of them sleeping heavily only when held against him.

Trusting him enough to stop guarding themselves.

Outside, wind moved softly through the snow-covered gardens.

Inside, Kohaku gave one tiny sleepy growl from the crib.

The fox bell chimed once.

Sukuna closed his eyes eventually.

And sometime later—

counting Kohaku's breaths became sleep.

—

The forest arrives wrong immediately.

Too dark.

Too wet.

Trees towering impossibly high overhead while mist coils low against the roots like something alive.

Sukuna hears Leora screaming.

Far away.

Not words.

Pain.

Pure animal panic.

His body moves before thought catches up.

Branches split beneath his hands as he runs.

But the sound echoes strangely.

Every direction at once.

Left.

Right.

Behind him.

Ahead.

He cannot tell where she is.

Leora screams again.

Worse this time.

Fear sharp enough to rip through bone.

Then pain—

unimaginable pain.

The kind no human survives.

The kind no body should physically be capable of enduring while conscious.

Sukuna runs faster.

The forest distorts around him.

Roots twist wrong beneath his feet.

The screams keep changing direction.

Every second they become more frantic.

More broken.

More desperate.

Then suddenly—

silence.

Sukuna freezes.

And sees white-silver hair through the trees ahead.

Relief hits instantly.

Violently.

He moves toward it—

and then the world stops.

Because Leora is not standing.

Not moving.

Not screaming.

Pieces of her lie scattered across the forest floor beneath the moonlight.

White-silver hair soaked dark.

One hand several feet away.

Blood across the roots.

Too much blood.

Far too much.

Her body torn apart so completely his mind cannot process it correctly at first.

For one impossible second he still expects her to breathe.

Then understanding arrives all at once.

Something ruptures inside him.

And Sukuna wakes violently.

Breath sharp.

Body already upright before consciousness fully catches up.

The room is dark except for dying embers.

Kohaku still sleeps nearby.

Tiny breathing.

Tiny bell chime.

Friedhelm shifts beside him slightly at the abrupt movement but does not wake fully.

And for one horrible lingering second—

Sukuna still smells blood.

2. Morning after the dream / After Moon assembly

Morning arrives gray and cold.

Snowlight presses pale against the screens while the brazier burns low beside the bed.

Sukuna is already awake.

Irritated.

Every single time sleep took him again during the night—

the dream returned.

The forest.

Leora screaming.

Blood across roots.

White-silver hair scattered through black mud.

Dismembered.

Again.

Again.

Again.

By the final waking, Sukuna had stopped trying to sleep entirely.

Now he sits upright against the headboard in loose dark robes while Kohaku squirms awake against his chest.

The wet nurse had barely crossed the threshold before Sukuna held out one hand impatiently.

> “Give him here.”

The woman obeyed immediately.

Now Kohaku kicks sleepily in his blankets while gripping at Sukuna’s fingers with tiny hands, silver ears flickering faintly through messy hair as the fox bell chimes softly against his wrappings.

The child makes a pleased growling noise when Sukuna adjusts him higher against his chest.

And something inside Sukuna’s ribs pulls painfully.

Little Kiba.

His strange impossible fox grandchild.

And beneath that—

something rawer still connected to Leora.

The dream lingered beneath his skin like poison.

Kohaku grabs one of Sukuna's fingers with both hands.

Holds on fiercely.

Sukuna stares down at him for a long moment.

Then from beside him:

> "You're glaring at an infant."

Friedhelm's voice sounds rough with sleep.

Sukuna glances over.

And immediately notices something strange.

Friedhelm looks rested.

Not merely awake.

Rested.

Like someone who had finally slept deeply for the first time in years.

His pale hair spills loose across the pillows while he watches Sukuna quietly from beneath half-lidded eyes.

Not wary.

Not guarded.

Softened.

That expression lingers too long.

Sukuna clicks his tongue softly.

> “If you intend to stare all morning, paint me instead.”

Usually Friedhelm would have answered immediately.

Dry.

Sharp.

Instead he only watches him another second longer.

Almost—

sentimental.

Dangerous expression.

Then Friedhelm's gaze drops toward Kohaku.

His hand moves slowly across the blankets until one finger brushes lightly against the infant's tiny fist.

Kohaku immediately catches it.

Friedhelm smiles faintly.

And the blankets shift downward across his waist.

Just enough skin exposed beneath the loosened layers for Sukuna to see pale moonstone skin in the cold morning light.

Not merely pale.

Luminous.

Almost unreal against the dark sheets.

Sukuna stares instinctively.

Then immediately reaches over and yanks the blankets back up over Friedhelm's waist and stomach entirely.

Firmly.

Completely.

Friedhelm blinks.

Actually startled.

> "...What was that about?"

Sukuna's jaw tightens immediately.

More irritation.

He clicks his tongue sharply against his teeth.

Doesn't answer.

And then Friedhelm understands.

The realization crosses his face slowly.

Sukuna doesn't want anyone else seeing him like that.

Not the servants.

Not the nurses.

Not anyone.

Friedhelm looks at him carefully after that.

And Sukuna, visibly annoyed at being understood so quickly, pulls the blankets even higher over him just as another wet nurse enters carrying warmed water, fresh blankets, and clean clothes for Kohaku.

The woman kneels immediately.

> “My lord, if you’d allow—”

Sukuna cuts her off.

> “No.”

She freezes.

Then bows lower immediately.

Sukuna takes the fresh cloth himself.

Friedhelm watches silently afterward while Sukuna changes Kohaku with absolute efficiency.

No hesitation.

No uncertainty.

The infant squirms and growls softly in complaint while Sukuna wraps him back into layers so securely and thoroughly that almost no cold could possibly touch him afterward.

Firm wrapping.

Careful layering.

Perfectly sealed warmth.

Friedhelm watches the entire thing quietly.

And cannot help admiring it.

Not only the competence.

The certainty.

The instinctive protectiveness in every movement.

Kohaku finally settles once more, tiny hands still gripping Sukuna's finger tightly.

The fox bell gives one soft chime.

Friedhelm waits.

Carefully.

Until the moment Sukuna's attention softens fully toward the child again.

Then quietly:

> "When Leora goes to her wing with Chōbei..."

Sukuna glances up.

Friedhelm holds his gaze steadily despite the faint color returning beneath his skin.

Then asks:

> "Would you like to come here?"

Friedhelm goes very still.

Not frozen.

Focused.

Like all his attention narrows carefully onto Sukuna at once.

The morning light catches strangely across his face now that the teasing atmosphere has shifted into something sharper. The softness from waking is still there, but controlled tighter.

Kohaku yawns sleepily against Sukuna's chest, tiny fox ears flickering briefly through silver hair before disappearing again.

Neither of them looks away from the other.

Friedhelm answers quietly:

> "I wouldn't have asked otherwise."

Simple.

No evasion.

That honesty lands harder than flirtation would have.

Sukuna's thumb brushes once absently over Kohaku's tiny hand where it grips his finger.

The infant immediately tightens his hold stubbornly.

Possessive little thing.

Sukuna feels something unpleasantly warm twist low in his chest again.

Irritating.

Friedhelm watches the motion too.

Watches the way Sukuna automatically adjusts Kohaku closer against his body afterward without even thinking about it.

And Sukuna realizes Friedhelm is observing him the same way he observed Friedhelm last night.

Carefully.

Studying reactions.

Learning him.

That should annoy him more than it does.

Instead—

it sharpens his attention.

Friedhelm shifts slightly against the pillows, pale hair slipping over one shoulder.

The blankets remain tucked high now after Sukuna's earlier interruption.

Deliberately so.

And the awareness of that hangs quietly between them too.

Friedhelm knows why Sukuna covered him.

Sukuna knows Friedhelm knows.

Neither says it aloud.

Outside, snow slides softly from one of the estate roofs.

The room stays warm.

Contained.

Kohaku gives a tiny growling chirp in his sleep.

Friedhelm's mouth softens immediately at the sound.

There.

That again.

That unbearable gentleness he only seems to allow around the children.

Sukuna watches it happen in real time and understands suddenly why Leora leaves infants with Friedhelm so instinctively.

Not because Friedhelm is merely kind.

Because every movement around them becomes careful.

Measured.

Intentional.

Even now, Friedhelm's eyes keep flicking automatically toward Kohaku to ensure the child remains warm enough.

Breathing evenly enough.

Comfortable enough.

Sukuna says dryly:

> "You stare at him almost as much as you stare at me."

Friedhelm blinks once.

Then, unexpectedly:

> "You're both difficult not to look at."

Sukuna stills.

The answer comes too naturally to be flirtation.

Which somehow makes it worse.

Friedhelm seems to realize that a heartbeat later because faint color immediately rises beneath his skin again.

But this time he does not retreat from it.

He just watches Sukuna steadily through it.

And Sukuna feels that dangerous pull low beneath his ribs again.

The same one from last night.

Not lust alone.

Not affection alone.

Something more structurally catastrophic than either.

Attachment.

The realization irritates him instantly.

Because attachment creates vulnerability.

Predictability.

Need.

Yet here he is anyway.

In Friedhelm's bed.

Holding Leora's grandchild.

Calmer than he had been since waking from blood-soaked nightmares.

Friedhelm says carefully after a long silence:

> "You don't have to answer immediately."

Sukuna's eyes flick toward him.

Friedhelm continues quieter:

> "I only wanted you to know you were welcome here."

That—

more than anything else—

nearly undoes the fragile restraint Sukuna has maintained all morning.

Because there is no demand in it.

No attempt to trap him.

No emotional coercion.

Just:

a door left open willingly.

For him.

Kohaku squirms sleepily again.

Sukuna adjusts the blankets around him automatically.

Then says without looking away from the child:

> “You assume I would keep coming back.”

Friedhelm is quiet for one beat too long.

Then:

> “No.”

A pause.

> “I hoped.”

That word settles heavily into the room.

Hope.

Not expectation.

Not entitlement.

Hope.

Sukuna finally looks at him fully then.

Really looks.

At the carefully controlled posture.

At the intelligence behind the restraint.

At the visible effort Friedhelm makes not to reach emotionally too fast despite clearly wanting to.

And abruptly Sukuna understands something infuriating:

Friedhelm is treating him carefully.

The same way Friedhelm handles frightened animals.

Or exhausted children.

Or people recovering from wounds.

Not because Friedhelm thinks Sukuna fragile.

Because he understands exactly how dangerous pushing too hard would be.

That level of perception is rare enough to border on alarming.

Sukuna's mouth shifts slightly.

Not quite a smile.

Closer to one than most people ever survive seeing.

Then finally:

> “You and Leora are troublesome in identical ways.”

Friedhelm’s expression changes immediately.

Soft surprise first.

Then something warmer.

More relieved.

Because Sukuna did not say no.

Kohaku chooses that exact moment to sneeze violently in his sleep.

The fox bell jingles.

And both of them look down simultaneously.

The silence breaks instantly.

Friedhelm laughs first.

Quiet.

Real.

Sukuna stares at him for half a second longer than necessary afterward.

Then clicks his tongue and mutters:

> “The entire bloodline conspires against me.”

The door slid open without warning.

One of the younger attendants entered first, bowing quickly as snow-cooled air slipped briefly into the room.

Behind her came an older woman wrapped in layered winter robes the color of faded plum silk.

Sukuna recognized her immediately.

Not Ayu. Ayu had served for over forty years until sickness took her. She had guided Leora through childbirth and child rearing. She had taught her how one takes care of a child before anyone knew that Leora was born to be a mother. She still credited Ayu despite her being a natural.

Because Ayu was the only mother figure she had had at the time at the estate or maybe ever. Sukuna didn't think Leora had ever had many women in her life, certainly none that were maternal. When he found out that Alraunes have their daughters cut out of their wombs before natural labor or birth just to sever the maternal connection further, it made sense.

Thinking of Leora cut open, discarded like trash to bleed out and die; Never letting her hold any of their children, never nurse them, bathe them, rock them, or care for them made him feel things that words could not describe. Only acute, surgically precise violence could.

Instead of Aya, it was now her daughter Akiko.

Older now than Ayu had been when Leora first arrived at the estate half-starved and furious and too proud to cry in front of strangers.

But the resemblance was there in the eyes.

Steady.

Unimpressed.

Entirely immune to fear.

Unlike most servants, she did not hesitate beneath Sukuna's gaze.

She looked directly at him and said:

> "The child should go to the nursery."

Then:

> "You and Lord Friedhelm are needed in the family room."

Not asked.

Informed.

Sukuna's eyes narrowed slightly.

> "Why?"

The woman folded her hands calmly.

> “Lady Kaguya instructed me not to say.”

That landed differently.

Beside him, Friedhelm immediately pushed himself upright, already reaching for the blankets.

Because everyone in the household knew one thing absolutely:

if Kaguya asked something of Sukuna—

Sukuna did it.

Sukuna placed one hand flat against Friedhelm’s shoulder before he could fully rise and pushed him gently but firmly back into the bed.

> “You move too fast after waking.”

Friedhelm blinked once at him.

The older servant’s mouth twitched faintly.

Almost amusement.

Then the younger attendant approached carefully toward the bed.

> “My lord, the infant—”

Sukuna visibly disliked handing Kohaku over.

Enough that both women noticed immediately.

Kohaku noticed too.

The moment the attendant lifted him from Sukuna’s arms, the infant made a sharp offended noise.

Then another.

Tiny growls.

Fussy chirping complaints.

His fox bell jingled furiously.

Sukuna’s eyes followed him the entire way across the room.

By the third upset sound, he looked genuinely close to taking the child back by force.

Friedhelm watched him with poorly hidden amusement.

The older servant noticed that too.

Neither commented on it.

Once the attendants disappeared with Kohaku, the room felt abruptly colder.

Quieter.

Friedhelm finally looked sideways at Sukuna and said dryly:

> “The servants have certainly seen me in less clothing than this before.”

Sukuna’s expression darkened instantly.

> “That knowledge displeases me.”

Friedhelm laughed softly under his breath as he finally rose properly from the bed.

3. Linnea Part I

The family room glowed warm with low winter firelight when they entered.

The storm had faded completely now.

Snowlight pressed pale against the screens.

Leora sat curled sideways near the brazier with a cup of mulled wine in one hand.

Chōbei lounged beside her lazily.

Or attempted to.

Because the moment Sukuna saw him, his eyes narrowed.

Chōbei looked like he had survived a fight he enjoyed immensely losing.

Marks covered his throat.

His jaw.

Half-hidden bruising disappeared beneath the collar of his robes.

Leora looked perfectly smug beside him.

Chōbei caught Sukuna staring and grinned immediately.

Unrepentant.

Sukuna walked directly toward them.

Stopped beside Leora.

Then asked flatly:

> “Why don’t you mark me like that?”

Silence.

Leora blinked.

Then brightened so instantly and sincerely it bordered on catastrophic.

> “Would you let me?”

The genuine excitement in her voice hit Sukuna like physical violence.

Chōbei barked out a laugh immediately.

Leora was already looking at Sukuna like she was mentally planning it.

Neck.

Shoulders.

Mouth.

Sukuna regretted speaking almost instantly.

Because the amount of restraint currently holding his life together suddenly felt dangerously insufficient.

He clicked his tongue sharply.

Leora only looked more delighted.

> “You would let me mark you openly? Wherever I please?”

> “Leora.”

> “I’m only asking.”

> “You ask like a threat.”

She smiled into her wine.

Completely pleased with herself.

Around them, the rest of the household slowly filtered inward.

Sleepy.

Cold.

Wrapped in winter layers.

Mizuki looked half-dead with exhaustion, silver hair loose over his shoulders as he collapsed dramatically onto one of the cushions nearest the fire.

> “Pregnancy is demonic,” he informed the room immediately.

No one argued.

Tsukihiko entered warmer than the others, cheeks faintly pink from sleep.

The moment he saw Chōbei, he walked directly over and settled into his lap automatically.

No hesitation whatsoever.

Chōbei's entire posture softened on instinct.

One arm wrapping around Tsukihiko's waist immediately.

Tsukihiko tucked himself closer against him, still half asleep.

Sukuna watched Leora turn slightly toward them.

Watched silver hair spill over her shoulder.

And suddenly—

the dream came back.

Not gently.

A violent flash.

Silver-white hair against blood-dark forest ground.

Dismembered limbs.

Screaming that stopped too suddenly.

Something in Sukuna's chest clenched hard enough to hurt.

Leora looked at him immediately.

Noticed at once.

Of course she did.

The amusement faded from her face instantly.

Chōbei noticed too.

His eyes sharpened subtly from across the room.

The atmosphere shifted quietly around Sukuna before anyone spoke.

Then—

the door opened again.

Tōma entered carrying a child.

Not carefully.

Not ceremonially.

Protectively.

Like he still could not fully believe someone might allow him to hold her.

The room went silent immediately.

Tiny.

Wrapped in pale winter cloth.

Dark hair already visible against the blankets.

Tōma looked exhausted.

Stunned.

Terrified.

Happy in a way that almost looked painful.

And behind all of it—

disbelief.

Like some part of him still expected the world to wake him up and take this away.

His eyes found Sukuna first.

Then Leora.

Then Friedhelm.

And finally Chōbei.

Who stared at the child for exactly one heartbeat before grinning slowly.

Warm.

Crooked.

Dangerously emotional.

Tsukihiko made a soft sound against his shoulder.

Leora stood first.

Slowly.

Like approaching something sacred.

Then quietly:

> “Kaguya?”

Tōma’s expression softened instantly.

Completely.

> “Alive,” he said hoarsely.

A pause.

Then, with visible awe:

> “And furious.”

Mizuki laughed first.

Short.

Sharp.

Unable to help himself.

Leora’s eyes snapped toward him immediately.

Recognition hit her face all at once.

> “You knew.”

Tōma looked down at the infant in his arms and smiled despite himself.

Softly:

> “He delivered her.”

Mizuki groaned instantly.

> “Don’t say it like that.”

But Tōma ignored him completely.

His eyes never left the child.

> “Kaguya only wanted me and Mizuki there.”

Leora’s expression changed so quickly it almost hurt to witness.

Pride.

Love.

Relief.

So intense it softened her entire face.

Sukuna watched it happen in silence.

Watched the way her eyes shone immediately at the thought of their daughter reaching for family first.

Mizuki shifted uncomfortably beneath the attention.

> “Tōma helped.”

The admission clearly cost him something.

Not because he resented Tōma.

Because he hated admitting vulnerability at all.

Especially his own limits.

Tōma looked at him immediately.

Fierce.

Protective.

> “You were the one holding her soul in place.”

Mizuki clicked his tongue hard.

But his ears had gone faintly pink.

Leora’s attention sharpened instantly.

> “The soul started slipping?”

Silence settled briefly over the room.

Tōma answered quietly.

> “The baby got stuck.”

His hand tightened unconsciously around the blanket.

> “Kaguya started fading.”

Something cold moved through Sukuna’s spine.

Leora’s face lost all color.

Mizuki, meanwhile, looked deeply annoyed everyone was reacting so strongly.

> “I handled it.”

Leora stared at him.

Then asked carefully:

> “Did you go into death?”

Mizuki blinked once.

> “Yes?”

Like it was obvious.

Then, after a pause, visibly uncomfortable beneath everyone's expressions:

> "Is it hard or something?"

The room went dead silent.

Leora looked genuinely shocked.

Friedhelm stood so abruptly his chair scraped against the floor.

He and Leora looked at each other immediately.

Not fear.

Astonishment.

The kind born from understanding something enormous all at once.

Because Mizuki had said it casually.

Too casually.

Like stepping into death itself had not terrified him at all.

Like he had crossed the threshold between life and death and returned carrying Kaguya's child without fully realizing what that implied about him.

Tōma broke first.

Not dramatically.

Not loudly.

Just—

quiet tears suddenly slipping down his face.

Exhausted.

Overwhelmed.

He looked at Mizuki like he did not know how to survive gratitude this large.

> "Without him," Tōma said softly, voice shaking,

> "she wouldn't be here alive."

He looked down at the infant.

Then lower:

> "Only her body."

The room tightened painfully around the words.

Mizuki looked horrified by the emotional direction this was taking.

> “Oh, gods, stop looking at me like that.”

Chōbei stood immediately.

Pure instinct.

Moving toward Tōma before anyone else could.

> “See?” Chōbei announced loudly,

> “This is why I keep saying the creepy twin thing is useful.”

Mizuki glared at him.

> “I will poison you.”

> “You’ve said that for two years and yet here I remain.”

Chōbei reached them and immediately leaned sideways toward the infant.

> “Let me see the little parasite that nearly killed everyone.”

Tōma made a wounded sound.

But he handed the child over anyway.

Carefully.

Trustingly.

Chōbei took her into his arms—

looked down at her for exactly two seconds—

and immediately turned away from the room.

Completely.

Shoulders rigid.

Silent.

Tsukihiko blinked softly from across the room.

Leora's expression broke instantly into helpless affection.

Because Chōbei was crying.

Actually crying.

Trying desperately not to let anyone see it.

His hand came up hard over his mouth.

Like he could physically stop the emotion from escaping.

It did not work.

A rough laugh broke out of him instead.

Half wrecked.

Half disbelieving.

> “Oh, that’s bad,” he muttered hoarsely.

> “That’s really bad.”

The room held its breath.

Nobody moved.

Because Chōbei was still standing with his back turned to them, shoulders shaking once—twice—as he completely lost the battle to stay composed.

It was almost surreal to witness.

The Bandit King of Iyo.

The man who laughed through executions.

Who bit through pain like it insulted him personally.

Who walked through violence grinning.

Standing in the middle of Sukuna's family room crying over a newborn child.

Then Tōma moved.

Fast.

Straight to him.

One arm wrapped hard around Chōbei's shoulders while the other steadied the baby carefully between them.

And the second Tōma touched him—

Chōbei broke completely.

A wrecked laugh tore out of him.

Tōma was crying too now.

Openly.

Not trying to hide it even a little.

> “I never thought this would happen.”

His voice cracked violently.

> “Not ever.”

Chōbei lowered his head hard against Tōma’s shoulder, still laughing helplessly through tears.

Tōma kept going anyway.

> “We lived.”

A shaky breath.

> “We escaped that island and now—”

He looked down at the infant.

Then at Chōbei.

Absolutely overwhelmed.

> “Now we’re both married with beautiful children.”

Chōbei barked out another laugh instantly.

> “They’re only beautiful because of Tsukihiko and Kaguya.”

Tsukihiko made an offended sound from across the room while still comfortably curled in Chōbei’s abandoned seat.

But Chōbei wasn’t done.

Still emotional.

Still crying.

> “Actually, no, that’s not true.”

He scrubbed violently at his face with one hand.

> “Kohaku’s beautiful because a god custom designed him.”

Then he looked at Tōma.

Really looked at him.

And something in his expression softened almost painfully.

> “And you were always pretty enough to be a girl anyway.”

Tōma groaned through tears.

> “Why are you like this?”

> “Because gods hate me specifically and love you specifically.”

Chōbei reached up and grabbed a fistful of Tōma’s hair suddenly, yanking him closer the same way he had since they were children.

Grounding.

Affectionate.

Rough.

Tōma made an irritated noise automatically—

but leaned into it anyway.

Their foreheads knocked together briefly.

And for one quiet second they looked very young.

Not executioner and outlaw.

Not survivors.

Just brothers.

Tōma’s face crumpled again.

> “I’m glad you’re my brother.”

The room went still all over again.

Because Tōma said it with his whole chest.

No restraint.

No embarrassment.

Just truth.

Chōbei stared at him for a second too long after that.

Then laughed softly through the remains of his tears.

Small.

Disbelieving.

> “Yeah?”

His hand tightened once in Tōma’s hair.

> “I’m glad you trusted me enough to give this place a try and then decided to stay.”

4. Linnea Part II

Kaguya’s exhausted voice drifted weakly from the doorway behind Tōma:

> “Papa would have gathered Toma for me eventually. I always get what I want and I wanted him.”

Every single head in the room snapped toward her immediately.

Kaguya ignored everyone immediately.

Especially Leora.

Who had already risen halfway from her seat with visible alarm.

> “You should be resting.”

Kaguya looked deeply unimpressed.

Pale.

Exhausted.

Wrapped in heavy robes with her silver hair hanging loose down her back.

But still unmistakably Sukuna’s daughter.

> “Mama,” she said flatly,

> “I gave birth. I don’t have plague.”

Sukuna made a low amused sound instantly.

Leora looked betrayed.

> “That is not funny.”

Kaguya continued like nobody had interrupted her at all.

> “You’re not weak. Neither am I.”

Then, with absolute confidence:

> “I’m sure Papa made you stay in bed longer than you actually needed to anyway.”

Sukuna’s mouth twitched.

> “He still does,” Mizuki muttered.

> Sukuna muttered, “That happened years ago.”

Kaguya ignored both of them.

Her eyes moved immediately to Tōma.

> “Did you show Papa the baby yet?”

Mizuki groaned dramatically.

Actually slumping backward in his chair.

> “Wonderful.”

He waved one hand vaguely through the air.

> “Everyone prepare yourselves for Otōsan to never care about the rest of us again.”

Sukuna scoffed.

Tōma, meanwhile, had already crossed the room carefully with the baby.

Straight toward Sukuna.

At first Sukuna genuinely did not understand why.

He looked down at the infant bundled against Tōma's chest with mild suspicion.

Then at Kaguya.

Then back at the child.

Leora immediately moved to sit beside Sukuna the second Tōma stopped in front of them.

Curious already.

Excited.

Tōma carefully lowered the baby into Sukuna's arms.

And Sukuna took her automatically despite himself.

Large hands impossibly careful.

The baby stirred once beneath the blankets.

Tiny face scrunching.

Then settled again.

Leora leaned in close to look—

and suddenly made the softest, brightest sound Sukuna had ever heard from her.

A full delighted squeal.

Sukuna frowned immediately.

> “What.”

Leora touched the bridge of the baby’s tiny nose gently with one finger.

Smiling so hard she looked almost emotional again.

> “She has your nose marking.” Leora was in love. She had always loved Sukuna’s markings. Of course she knew they were marks that often the world perceived as meaning he was a criminal in exile but she didn’t care. They suited him in her opinion and she would continue to love them and adore them.

Sukuna stilled.

Completely.

Then looked down properly.

And saw it.

Tiny.

Delicate.

Right there across the bridge of the infant’s nose—

the exact same marking he carried himself.

Not black.

Silver-grey.

Soft as moonlight against her skin.

Sukuna’s eyes widened slightly.

The room went utterly silent.

Even Mizuki stopped talking.

Kaguya smiled immediately when she saw Sukuna finally recognize it.

Proud.

Certain.

> Kaguya's voice was smug and truthful, "I love it."

Sukuna did not speak.

Could not, briefly.

Because something strange had happened inside his chest all at once.

The child carried his face.

Not metaphorically.

Not like Mizuki who was his mirror image.

Not symbolically.

Literally his mark.

On Kaguya's daughter.

His most precious, only daughter's daughter.

The reality of it struck with frightening force.

Leora leaned against his shoulder lightly, still smiling at the baby.

> "She looks like she was touched by moonlight and the King of Curses."

Tōma looked seconds away from crying again.

Mizuki stared at the infant with adoration.

And Sukuna—

for the first time in centuries—

felt something dangerously close to being overwhelmed.

Sukuna cleared his throat once.

The sound immediately quieted the room again.

He continued staring down at the infant in his arms for another long moment before saying flatly:

> "This child and Kohaku are currently my favorites."

A beat.

Then:

> “Outside of Leora and Kaguya.”

Mizuki looked disgusted.

> “That’s horrifying favoritism.”

> “Earn better ranking,” Sukuna replied calmly.

Kaguya snorted softly despite herself.

Tōma looked entirely too emotional all over again.

Meanwhile Sukuna had already shifted into inspection.

Careful.

Methodical.

The infant’s tiny hands.

Her breathing.

Eyes.

Skin tone.

Watching for abnormalities now with full attention.

Kaguya noticed immediately.

So did Tōma.

Tōma made a small nervous sound under his breath.

Sukuna’s eyes flicked upward instantly.

> “What.”

Tōma visibly regretted being perceived.

Kaguya looked toward him too now.

Mizuki shifted in his seat suddenly.

Uneasy.

That got everyone’s attention immediately.

Leora’s expression sharpened.

> “What aren’t you saying?”

Tōma rubbed the back of his neck once.

> “If you’re looking for something strange...”

A pause.

Then quieter:

> “There is something.”

Mizuki looked deeply unhappy about that sentence being spoken aloud.

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed immediately.

> “Explain.”

Toma sighed, “The deity Vallraun blessed her. Flowers grow in her hair and there are few other beautiful but strange blessing effects.”

Sukuna opened his mouth to ask more questions but then door groaned.

5. Linnea - The Interruption - Part III

Before anyone could continue—

the doors opened violently.

An attendant entered first, pale-faced and visibly shaken.

And behind her—

a Moon-Kept representative collapsed directly to his knees so hard the impact echoed through the room.

Then lower.

Hands flat against the floor.

Head bowed completely.

Terrified.

> “Forgive this intrusion—”

His breathing was ragged.

Panicked.

> “Please—”

He looked physically unable to raise his head fully.

> “Please permit me to speak with Lady Leora and Lord Sukuna immediately.”

The atmosphere changed at once.

Sukuna’s expression hardened.

Leora stood slowly beside him.

Kaguya shifted abruptly in her seat.

Uncomfortable.

Protective.

> “I don’t want Papa leaving the room.”

That landed harder than expected.

Sukuna looked toward her immediately.

Not because of the request.

Because of the instinct beneath it.

Kaguya's hand had unconsciously tightened around the blankets beside her.

Leora noticed too.

And softened instantly.

> "That's okay."

She moved toward Kaguya first briefly, touching her hair gently.

Then she turned.

Her eyes moved across the room once before landing on Chōbei.

> "Come with me."

Silence.

Chōbei blinked.

Actually surprised.

> “Me?”

Leora nodded once.

Simple.

Certain.

> “Yes.”

Chōbei looked immediately suspicious.

Deeply suspicious.

His eyes narrowed slowly as though convinced this was somehow a trap specifically designed for him.

> “Wh?.”

Sukuna answered before Leora could.

> “You are qualified.”

That made it worse.

Chōbei stared at him in open distrust now.

> “That’s not the sort of endorsement I want.”

Tōma looked alarmed already.

Chōbei pointed vaguely between Sukuna and Leora.

> “You two don’t ask me to participate in politics unless something is completely screwed and I can’t make it worse..”

The representative on the floor made a deeply distressed noise at that.

Which did not help matters.

Leora sighed.

> “Chōbei.”

He looked at her immediately.

She held his gaze for one quiet second.

Then said softly:

> “Please.”

That ruined his ability to argue almost instantly.

Chōbei clicked his tongue hard enough to sound irritated about it.

> “You fight dirty.”

The corridors were colder away from the family rooms.

Quieter too.

Only the distant crackle of lantern fire and the muted sound of snowfall against the outer screens followed them as Leora and Chōbei walked beside the representative through the estate.

The man still looked terrified.

Not merely nervous about delivering bad news.

Terrified in the deep, animal way people became when something inside the order of their world had gone wrong.

Leora noticed immediately.

So did Chōbei.

Which was why he became entirely serious and silent by the time they reached the smaller audience chamber near the outer administrative wing.

The representative fell to his knees again the second the doors shut behind them.

Breathing unevenly.

Leora moved first.

Always.

She crouched in front of him before he could force himself lower.

> “Look at me.”

Gentle.

Steady.

The man obeyed shakily.

His eyes were bloodshot from exhaustion.

Fear sat visibly in the whites of them.

> “Tell us what happened.”

His mouth trembled once before he managed:

> “There are strangers entering the territory.”

Chōbei leaned against one of the pillars nearby, arms crossed loosely.

Watching carefully now.

> “Bandits?” he asked.

The representative swallowed hard.

> “Not like normal ones.”

That immediately sharpened the room.

Leora’s expression changed first.

Then Chōbei’s.

The man continued quickly now, like speaking faster might somehow outrun what he was describing.

> “At first it was only theft.”

> “Storehouses.”

> “Travel routes.”

> “Livestock.”

A pause.

> “Then villages started disappearing supplies overnight.”

Chōbei frowned slightly.

Too organized.

The representative’s breathing worsened.

> “And now sickness is spreading.”

Leora stilled completely.

> “What kind of sickness?”

> “We don’t know.”

His voice cracked.

> “The healers don’t recognize it.”

Another pause.

> “Fever first.”

> “Then blackened coughing.”

> “People stop waking properly.”

Chōbei’s eyes narrowed instantly at the word blackened.

Not fear.

Recognition.

The representative kept going.

Almost unable to stop now.

> “And there’s... there’s one man among them.”

Silence sharpened.

Leora’s face lost warmth immediately.

> “What man.”

The representative visibly struggled to answer.

> “The villages say he targets women.”

Chōbei straightened slowly away from the pillar.

The representative's hands began shaking.

> "He kills them."

A horrible pause.

> "But not quickly."

Leora's eyes darkened.

The room temperature seemed to drop around her.

> "How."

The man swallowed hard enough it looked painful.

> "With knives."

His voice dropped lower.

Sicker.

> "He cuts their faces."

> "Their mouths."

> "Their eyes."

Chōbei went still.

Completely still.

The representative stared at the floor now.

Unable to look at either of them anymore.

> “Some of the bodies were... arranged afterward.”

Silence.

Heavy.

Wrong.

Leora rose slowly to her feet.

Not frantic.

Not emotional.

Something colder.

Older.

Chōbei knew that posture immediately.

The one she wore right before violence.

> “How long.”

The representative answered instantly.

> “Three weeks.”

Chōbei’s voice cut in sharply.

> “And nobody came sooner?”

The man flinched.

> “We thought it was isolated.”

> “Then the roads became unsafe.”

A pause.

> “Then people started disappearing entirely.”

Leora looked toward Chōbei then.

And he saw it immediately.

Not fear.

Calculation.

The same realization forming in both of them at once:

This was not random violence anymore.

This was organized movement inside Moon-Kept territory.

Which meant one of two things.

Either someone believed Sukuna’s territories could finally be tested—

or someone wanted attention badly enough to survive provoking them.

And both possibilities were dangerous.

The attendants moved immediately once Leora gave the order.

Medicine bundles.

Clean cloth.

Dried herbs.

Winter stores.

Moon-Kept efficiency.

The representative nearly collapsed with relief as servants rushed past him carrying supplies for the afflicted villages.

Leora squeezed his shoulder once before turning away.

> “You’ll leave before dawn.”

The man bowed deeply.

> “Yes, my lady.”

Chōbei followed her out into the corridor in silence.

The doors slid shut behind them.

And immediately the atmosphere changed.

The estate corridors were dim this late.

Only scattered lanterns burned between long stretches of shadow and pale winter moonlight spilling across polished floors.

Leora reached for his hand first.

Chōbei let her take it automatically.

But she could feel the tension in him instantly.

Too still.

Too focused.

The violence described in that room had gone somewhere deep and ugly inside him.

Especially the women.

Especially the knives.

Leora knew exactly what kind of thoughts Chōbei had when he went this quiet.

So without warning—

she shoved him backward into the wall.

Hard enough to force his attention onto her completely.

Chōbei blinked once in genuine surprise as his shoulders struck wood.

Then Leora kissed him.

Immediate.

Demanding.

Hot enough to interrupt thought itself.

For a second he resisted automatically—

not the kiss.

The redirection.

But Leora crowded closer, one hand tangled in his braid, forcing him fully back into himself instead of whatever violent spiral his mind had started building.

And slowly—

he gave in.

His hands slid to her waist.

Fingers tightening hard enough to wrinkle fabric.

Her body pressed between his legs as they parted instinctively to pull her closer.

Warm.

Burning.

Gods, she felt like fire lately.

Chōbei made a low sound against her mouth before kissing her back properly now.

Hungry.

Dangerous.

Alive.

For several long seconds neither of them remembered the villages.

The sickness.

The dead women.

Only heat.

Pressure.

Breathing.

Then suddenly Leora pulled back.

Too fast.

Her forehead rested briefly against his before she whispered:

> “Sorry.”

Chōbei stared at her.

Actually stared.

The look that crossed his face made something shiver down her spine immediately.

One hand lifted slowly to her cheek.

Thumb brushing lightly beneath her eye and then across her lips.

> “Why would you say sorry?”

Leora answered instantly.

No hesitation whatsoever.

> “Because you’re too much.”

A shaky breath escaped her.

> “I want you all the time lately.”

> “I can’t control it.”

Her eyes stayed fixed on his.

Completely honest.

Or honest enough to sound like it.

> “You make me lose my mind.”

Chōbei smirked automatically—

then immediately had to glance away because the force of that confession nearly destroyed his own restraint.

His grip on her waist tightened once.

He muttered something low and rough beneath his breath.

Leora smiled faintly.

Then kissed him once more.

Quick this time.

Sharp enough to steal breath.

Her teeth caught lightly against his lower lip before she pushed away entirely and turned down the corridor.

Walking ahead like nothing had happened.

Leaving Chōbei against the wall trying to remember how breathing worked.

He scrubbed one hand down his face hard.

> “Fuck...”

Further ahead, Leora exhaled quietly to herself.

Because she had just lied directly to him.

And Chōbei—

for all his instincts,

all his sharpness,

all his terrifying perception—

had not noticed at all.

6. Linnea Part IV

The family room remained warm despite the storm beyond the estate walls.

Firelight moved softly across dark wood and sleeping exhaustion.

Leora and Chōbei returned quietly from the corridor.

Leora crossed the room immediately and settled beside Sukuna without hesitation, one arm sliding against his shoulder as though returning to a place she belonged naturally.

Sukuna glanced toward her.

> “What did the representative want?”

Leora’s expression did not change.

> “Something we can discuss later.”

Smooth.

Dismissive.

Chōbei, still lingering near the doorway, added casually:

> “Nothing pressing.”

The speed of the agreement made Sukuna’s eyes narrow slightly.

But he let it go.

For now.

Because the newborn shifted faintly in his arms.

Tiny.

Warm beneath layered blankets.

The silver-grey marking across the bridge of her nose caught faintly in the firelight every time she moved.

Too much like him.

Leora immediately leaned closer to look at her again, visibly exhausted but unable to stop watching the child.

Across the room Kaguya rested against cushions while Tōma remained beside her so closely he touched her constantly without seeming aware of it.

A hand at her wrist.

Her sleeve.

The edge of the blankets.

Like he needed physical confirmation she was still there.

Mizuki sat further back near the brazier, pale and drained from dragging both mother and child back from death.

And Chōbei—

dangerously relaxed.

Mulled wine in hand.

Like someone deliberately pretending nothing important had happened tonight.

Sukuna finally looked toward Tōma.

Then down at the infant.

> “What is her name?”

The room quieted naturally around the question.

Tōma immediately looked toward Kaguya.

Kaguya met his eyes.

Then nodded once.

Small.

Certain.

Permission.

Trust.

Tōma exhaled slowly through his nose.

Then looked down at the floor briefly before speaking.

> “I thought I’d always name her myself.”

Even Sukuna stilled slightly at that.

Tōma kept his eyes on the child instead of the room.

> “Chōbei and I were born to a retainer family in Akō.”

His voice stayed calm.

Plain.

Which somehow made every word heavier.

> “Then the domain collapsed.”

A pause.

> “Our father lost everything.”

> “Our mother died sick.”

Silence deepened around the room.

> “Then our father was executed too.”

Leora visibly tightened against Sukuna.

Tōma continued anyway.

> “After that... it was just us.”

Kaguya reached quietly for his sleeve.

Tōma’s hand immediately covered hers without thought.

> “Bandits took us eventually.”

A beat.

Then bluntly:

> “They meant to sell us.”

The room went still.

Tōma's expression hardened faintly.

> "And they looked at me more than him."

Everything changed at once.

Mizuki's face twisted immediately with understanding.

Friedhelm lowered his eyes.

And suddenly tears began slipping silently down his face.

No sound.

Just grief.

Because he understood exactly what kind of danger that meant.

Tōma glanced briefly toward the sleeping infant.

Then said quietly:

> "It was obvious I wasn't going to stay whole long enough to be sold."

The silence afterward became unbearable.

Sukuna noticed Leora noticing Friedhelm immediately.

Noticed her hand tighten once harder against his arm.

Tōma swallowed once before continuing.

> “They tried separating us.”

A pause.

> “And I remember thinking I’d rather die than lose him.”

Even Chōbei looked uncomfortable now.

Tōma laughed softly once.

Broken around the edges.

> “How do you explain someone like that?”

Then quieter:

> “Brother?”

> “Father?”

> “Mother?”

A beat.

> “He was all of it.”

Leora’s grip tightened again.

Sukuna allowed it without looking away from Tōma.

Then:

> “So Chōbei stood up.”

Immediately—

> “Stop.”

Chōbei’s voice cut sharply across the room.

Not angry.

Worse.

Embarrassed.

Deeply unwilling to be looked at this way.

> “It wasn’t a big deal.”

Tōma ignored him completely.

> “He told them if they wanted entertainment, he’d give them something better to stare at than me.”

The fire cracked softly.

Then Tōma said:

> “And he took a dagger from one of them...”

His fingers lifted unconsciously beneath his own eye.

> “...and cut across his face.”

Leora inhaled sharply.

Kaguya covered her mouth.

Mizuki looked physically sick.

And Chōbei—

actually looked angry now.

Not at Tōma.

At the room hearing it.

Tōma continued before anyone could stop him.

> “After that, every time they looked at me too long...”

> “He gave them something else to look at.”

His voice shook slightly now.

> “Every time somebody touched me...”

> “Every time somebody stood too close...”

> “Every time somebody grabbed my hair or my shoulders...”

Silence sharpened painfully.

> “He cut himself first.”

The scars reorganized instantly in everyone’s minds.

Not recklessness.

Protection.

Weaponized survival.

Tōma's voice dropped softer.

> “Eventually he stopped needing the knife.”

A glance toward Chōbei.

> “Because eventually he could just kill them.”

No one spoke.

Then Tōma stepped toward Chōbei slowly.

And placed the infant carefully into his arms.

Chōbei froze instantly.

Like the child weighed far too much suddenly.

Then Tōma said quietly:

> “So I want you to name her.”

Chōbei’s expression hardened immediately.

> “Don’t start.”

But Tōma continued anyway.

> “Everything I have belongs to him first.”

That landed heavily.

Then softer:

> “Every second I’m alive is borrowed.”

Chōbei looked away sharply.

Then Tōma said:

> “When we reached the island... I fell.”

Immediate change.

Chōbei went pale instantly.

> “Tōma.”

Real warning now.

But Tōma looked at him calmly.

> “I thought that was finally the moment you’d leave me behind.”

Dead silence.

Then Tōma smiled faintly.

> “Instead you just went looking for a better weapon.”

Mizuki stared at them both like he had stopped breathing entirely.

Then Tōma adjusted the blankets around the infant carefully and said:

> “And if you won’t do it...”

He looked toward Mizuki.

> “Then let Mizuki.”

Mizuki visibly startled.

Actually stunned.

Because this was not politeness.

This was acceptance.

Family.

Tōma's voice softened further.

> "Because either way... none of this exists without our brothers."

Kaguya broke immediately then.

Crying openly.

Tōma moved to her side instinctively before the first tear fully fell.

And suddenly Chōbei was left standing there holding another infant everyone expected him to name.

Again.

Sukuna watched him for a long moment.

Chōbei looked genuinely miserable.

He stared down at the child.

At the silver marking across her nose.

Then toward:

Leora.

Sukuna.

Tōma.

Mizuki.

And muttered:

> “Looks like Sukuna.”

Another glance downward.

Softer:

> “Feels like Leora and Tōma.”

Then toward Mizuki:

> “Saved by Mizuki...”

Then finally:

> “Fuck.”

The room waited.

Completely still.

For the name.

The room does not interrupt him.

Not Leora.

Not Kaguya.

Not Mizuki.

Not even Sukuna.

Because something about the way Chōbei holds the infant now makes it clear this is not performance anymore.

It is memory becoming speech.

Chōbei clicks his tongue softly, eyes still on the baby.

> “Leora’s been teaching me to read.”

Chōbei immediately turns away from everyone like it irritates him.

> “Don’t make that face.”

But he doesn’t stop.

He adjusts the infant slightly in his arms—careful, unfamiliar in a way that suggests he is learning his own strength in real time.

> “There was a story.”

A pause.

He searches for it, not the words.

> “About a flower that grows where it shouldn’t.”

His eyes narrow faintly.

> “Cold places. Broken ground. Snow.”

Mizuki's attention sharpens at once.

Kaguya stills beside Tōma.

Chōbei continues, voice flattening into something steadier.

> "It keeps coming back. Even when winter should've killed it."

A beat.

Then:

> "Leora said people from her land call it survival."

Another pause.

> "She taught me it's also called the twinflower."

Leora's expression shifts immediately—softening, recognizing the memory before it finishes forming.

Chōbei glances briefly toward Mizuki.

Not gentle.

Not cruel.

Just direct.

> “You kept her here.”

That lands hard.

Mizuki’s breath catches.

Kaguya’s hand tightens slightly at her side.

Chōbei continues anyway.

> “And she didn’t break.”

A pause.

Now quieter.

> “So it felt right.”

He exhales once through his nose.

Then looks down at the child again.

> “Linnea.”

Friedhelm, softly, repeats it once under his breath—testing the shape of it.

Chōbei points at him immediately.

> “Yeah. That.”

A beat.

Then, irritated again:

> “Annoying flower name.”

No one laughs.

Because his grip on the child changes slightly.

More certain now.

Less unsure.

Chōbei’s voice drops further.

> “Leora’s flower.”

A pause.

> “Mizuki’s proof.”

Kaguya goes completely still.

Mizuki doesn’t speak.

Chōbei continues, quieter now, almost to himself:

> “And you came out of both of them not letting go.”

He adjusts the baby closer to his chest.

Not possessive.

Grounded.

Then:

> “Linnea Ryomen.”

Silence tightens.

His jaw works slightly, like he is deciding whether to continue speaking.

Then, finally:

> “Seems like something that refuses to die properly.”

A beat.

Then softer still:

> “Good.”

He shifts his gaze—finally—up to Sukuna.

The room feels the change immediately.

Because now it is not mythology speaking.

It is judgment being requested.

Chōbei tilts his head slightly.

A smirk returning just enough to make it bearable.

> “That sound good to you, chief?”

Sukuna does not answer immediately.

He looks at Chōbei first.

Not at the baby.

At *Chōbei*.

Like he is weighing whether the name came from sentiment, deflection, or something more dangerous—meaning.

The room stays completely still.

Even the fire seems quieter.

Then Sukuna's gaze drops.

Finally.

To the infant.

Linnea.

His expression shifts almost imperceptibly.

Something in him recognizes the structure of the name before he consciously explains it to himself.

Survival logic disguised as softness.

Endurance wrapped in something delicate enough to be mistaken for fragility.

His tongue clicks once against the back of his teeth.

Low.

Measured.

> “Annoying flower name.”

A pause.

Then, more deliberately:

> “But not incorrect.”

That lands.

Because it is approval.

From him.

Sukuna shifts his hand slightly, resting it against his own knee as he continues to study the child.

The nose marking.

The stillness.

The fact that she is alive at all.

Then:

> “It will hold.”

Not a question.

A statement.

A judgment of structure rather than sentiment.

His eyes flick briefly back to Chōbei.

A faint huff leaves him—almost irritation, almost amusement.

Then Sukuna finally looks fully at Chōbei again.

> “But, you are asking if it sounds good to me.”

A pause.

Sukuna leans back slightly.

Kohaku is not in his arms now, but the absence of the infant is noticeable—like something in him is still oriented toward small living things that should not survive him.

His gaze sharpens just a fraction.

> “No.”

Silence tightens instantly.

Then Sukuna continues, calm as ever:

> “You are asking the wrong person.”

A beat.

Then, colder—precise in a way that feels almost like correction:

> “She is not named for my approval.”

His eyes shift toward Kaguya.

Then Mizuki.

Then Leora.

Not in judgment.

In acknowledgment of origin points.

> “She is named for what kept her alive.”

Another pause.

Then Sukuna looks down at Linnea again.

Longer this time.

And something in his voice lowers, almost grudging in its honesty:

> “It suits her.”

A slight tilt of his head.

> “Unfortunate.”

Then, after a beat—

a final glance at Chōbei:

> “Keep it.”

And that is when the room understands:

Sukuna did not *approve* the name.

He *recognized it as inevitable.*

A quiet, controlled acceptance of something that already exists too strongly to be argued with.

7. Linnea Part V

Everyone begins to disperse after the naming settles into silence.

The warmth of the family room fractures into smaller movements—chairs shifting, sleeves brushing, soft footsteps returning to corridors that lead back into private wings.

Chōbei and Tsukihiko retrieve Kohaku from the nursery together.

The infant immediately clings to Tsukihiko's sleeve, still half-asleep, making a low fox-like sound of protest when he is lifted.

Chōbei clicks his tongue.

> “He’s getting attached.”

Tsukihiko adjusts Kohaku carefully against his chest.

> “He should be.”

Sukuna watches them for a moment longer than necessary.

Leora notices.

She always does.

Leora's gaze slides to Sukuna as the room empties further, then she leans slightly into him.

Sukuna speaks without looking away from Kohaku.

> "Bring Higan to our chambers."

An attendant nearby bows quickly.

> "Young Master Higan is currently with Young Master Kurohiko and Lady Kiyomi."

Sukuna's eyes narrow faintly.

Leora, already smiling like she's seen this before, tilts her head.

> "Let them keep him."

Sukuna exhales through his nose.

> "That is not the arrangement."

Leora hums softly.

> "They might be practicing."

A pause.

Sukuna looks at her now.

She continues lightly:

> “For their own child.”

That lands just enough to shift his expression.

A long sigh.

Then:

> “...Fine.”

The servant bows and leaves quickly, clearly relieved.

Leora’s smile widens a fraction.

> “You are a good grandfather.”

Sukuna clicks his tongue immediately.

> “Do not label me.”

Leora bumps her shoulder into his deliberately.

Once.

Twice.

Just enough to keep him aware of her.

> “It suits you.”

That earns her a sharp look.

She ignores it completely.

By the time they leave the corridor toward their private wing, she is doing it more often—small, deliberate contact.

Pushing him slightly off his line of walking.

Testing his patience.

Sukuna tolerates it longer than he should.

Not because he has to.

Because he is watching her.

And by the time they reach their chambers, Leora stops directly in front of him.

Looks up.

And then she does exactly what she did to Chōbei earlier—except slower.

Intentional.

Sukuna barely has time to register the shift before his back hits the wall.

Not hard.

But final.

Leora is already there.

Kissing him with a force that erases thought for one brief, devastating moment.

Sukuna's mind goes white at the edges.

Not confusion.

Interruption.

Her body presses in closer, and he feels her between his legs, anchoring him in place as if she has decided the world ends where she stands.

Her nails catch lightly through his robes at his shoulders and the side of his neck—sharp enough to register, not enough to wound.

Sukuna doesn't move.

Not because he is restrained.

Because for a moment—

he doesn't feel the need to.

And that is what irritates him most.

He barely registers how long it lasts.

Only that it does.

Then—

she pulls back.

Just as suddenly.

And looks at him like she is evaluating the result of something completed correctly.

Sukuna exhales once.

Slow.

Controlled.

But his eyes are darker now.

Focused.

Leora tilts her head.

Smiles.

That small, knowing curve.

Sukuna thinks, distantly, that she really might be something fox-shaped in a human body.

She steps back from him deliberately, letting the space return.

Then, almost casually, she speaks:

> “Earlier... you asked you why I don’t mark you like Chōbei.”

Sukuna’s gaze sharpens slightly.

Leora’s eyes glint.

> “I think I should right that wrong immediately.”

A pause.

Not a threat.

An offer.

Then she turns and walks into their chambers.

Leaving him there.

At the threshold.

Sukuna does not follow immediately.

For a rare moment, he simply stands still—processing the fact that Leora has left him outside his own space.

His tongue clicks once.

Quiet.

Irritated.

Then, almost imperceptibly—

interested.

Inside the estate, elsewhere in the darkening forest line beyond the protective wards, something moves.

Not openly.

Not loudly.

A presence threading through trees and distance, careful not to disturb the world that has just settled into fragile peace.

Plans are being spoken in low voices.

Not yet loud enough to become war.

But already shaped like it.

Ryomen heirs.

Children.

Names.

Targets.

And the forest listens without responding.

8. The Kitchen - Apfelkuchen

The servant who called Sukuna hesitates before speaking again, as if saying it out loud might make it worse.

> “They haven’t moved, my Lord... for almost an hour.”

Sukuna does not respond immediately.

He is already walking.

When Sukuna arrives, he understands instantly why the servant sounded uncertain.

Leora and Friedhelm are standing in the kitchen.

Not speaking.

Not reacting.

Not even acknowledging the staff moving around them.

Just staring.

At the counter.

At two objects placed there like offerings rather than food.

Cheese.

Not any familiar kind.

A pale, unfamiliar block—too soft at the edges, too rich-looking to belong to anything local.

And beside it—

apples.

But wrong apples.

Pale-skinned. Almost translucent in places. The kind of color that does not belong to anything grown under the same sun Sukuna recognizes.

The entire kitchen is functioning around them as if they are statues that accidentally started breathing.

Then stopped again.

A cook moves cautiously behind them, as though afraid to disturb a ritual.

Leora tilts her head slightly.

Friedhelm does the same.

Perfectly synchronized.

Neither speaks.

Neither blinks much.

Sukuna stops at the doorway.

Clicks his tongue once.

Nothing changes.

That is the first sign something is truly wrong.

🌙 THE SECOND SIGN

Chōbei walks in halfway through.

Wet hair.

Relaxed posture.

On his way from the onsen, clearly not expecting *this* level of whatever this is.

He pauses.

Looks at the scene.

Then:

> "...What are they doing?"

No one answers.

Because no one knows.

Leora slowly reaches out.

Friedhelm mirrors her exactly half a second later.

They both touch the cheese at the same time.

Then stop.

Like the act itself requires reverence.

A cook makes a small, distressed sound in the background.

Sukuna watches more closely now.

Not concern.

Assessment.

Because this is not madness.

This is recognition.

● CHŌBEI RETURNS WITH WINE

Chōbei clicks his tongue and walks away again without explanation.

He returns moments later with mulled wine.

Hands one cup to Sukuna without looking away from the siblings.

> “This is your problem, I think.”

Sukuna takes it.

Does not deny it.

They both lean back against the wall near the side table normally used for peeling vegetables and prep work.

Not because it is comfortable.

Because it gives them a full view.

Chōbei takes a sip.

> “They’re going to ruin something expensive.”

Sukuna’s eyes do not leave Leora.

> “They already have.”

Chōbei snorts once.

They watch.

🌙 THE SHIFT — WHEN THEY COME BACK TO LIFE

And then—

something changes.

Leora moves first.

Not slowly.

Not carefully.

Suddenly alive again.

She picks up the cheese with both hands like it is something she has decided belongs to her.

Friedhelm reacts immediately after.

They begin moving.

Talking.

Too fast for the silence they were in before.

The kitchen staff collectively exhales in relief and panic at the same time.

A cook opens his mouth to protest—

Leora smiles at him.

He closes it again.

Immediately.

Friedhelm is already arranging ingredients.

Leora is already correcting him without speaking much.

It becomes cooking.

Real cooking.

Fast.

Precise.

Dangerously coordinated.

Like two people remembering how to exist inside a body after briefly forgetting what bodies are for.

● SUKUNA AND CHŌBEI OBSERVE

Chōbei leans slightly toward Sukuna.

> “Do they usually do that?”

Sukuna clicks his tongue.

> “No.”

A pause.

Then, colder:

> “When they do not move for an hour, something is wrong.”

Chōbei takes another sip of wine.

> “Or something is right.”

Sukuna does not respond.

Because both answers feel equally plausible.

Leora laughs suddenly from the kitchen.

Friedhelm answers her with something sharp.

A disagreement.

Not hostility.

Familiarity.

Sukuna's eyes narrow slightly.

● THE KITCHEN BECOMES THEIRS

At some point, the staff stops trying to manage them.

Instead, they just... observe.

Because Leora and Friedhelm have taken over the space completely.

Not through force.

Through certainty.

Chopping. Stirring. Testing.

The cheese is no longer an object.

It is an ingredient.

The apples are no longer strange.

They are part of a decision.

Leora tastes something and immediately reaches to adjust Friedhelm's hand positioning without looking at him.

Friedhelm allows it.

Then corrects her in return.

The balance is seamless.

Sukuna watches this with a stillness that is almost unusual for him.

Chōbei notices.

> "You're thinking too hard."

Sukuna clicks his tongue.

> "I am watching."

> "Same thing."

● END BEAT

Leora finally looks up—mid-motion, hands still busy.

Her eyes briefly find Sukuna across the kitchen.

She smiles.

Small.

Confident.

Then goes back to cooking like she was never interrupted at all.

Friedhelm does not look over.

But his posture changes slightly when she smiles.

Chōbei finishes his wine.

> “So,” he says quietly. “Do we die if we try it?”

Sukuna finally shifts his gaze.

> “Probably.”

A pause.

Then:

> “But not immediately.”

Chōbei hums.

> “Comforting.”

And they continue watching the two moon-like figures dismantle and rebuild something as simple as food—

as if it is one of the few things in the world that still obeys them completely.

The kitchen changes again when Leora and Friedhelm finish.

It doesn't become quieter.

It becomes **aware**.

Both of them lift their heads at the same time.

Slowly.

Like they've just remembered there are other people in the room.

Sukuna and Chōbei are already watching.

And both of them—

instantly, catastrophically—

are affected.

Not in the way either of them are prepared for.

Leora looks over first.

Friedhelm follows a heartbeat later.

And whatever expression they wear now is almost unfair.

Shy.

Soft.

Uncertain in a way that makes no sense coming from either of them.

Leora's hands hover near her sleeves.

Friedhelm clears his throat once.

Small.

Careful.

Leora lowers her gaze immediately after.

Friedhelm does the same.

Both of them look like they're trying to ask permission just to exist in the same space as the people watching them.

It is unbearable.

Chōbei clicks his tongue sharply under his breath.

> "...This is disgusting."

Sukuna does not look away.

> "Yes."

But neither of them move.

Because they physically cannot.

Leora shifts slightly.

Adjusts her sleeve cuff with two fingers.

Friedhelm mirrors it, almost unconsciously.

Both are blushing.

Both visibly trying to hold themselves together.

Friedhelm exhales, then looks up just slightly.

Leora follows immediately after.

They step forward together.

And place two plates on the table.

Carefully.

As if presenting something sacred.

Leora tucks a strand of hair behind her ear.

Chōbei makes a noise under his breath that he immediately regrets.

Sukuna's hand tightens on the chair behind him.

The wood *cracks*.

Neither of them acknowledges it.

Friedhelm hesitates.

Then reaches out—

not to the table.

Not to the food.

To Sukuna.

His fingers lightly catch Sukuna's forearm for a moment.

Just long enough to ground himself.

Then, even more tentatively, his hand shifts toward the fabric near Sukuna's abdomen.

Not grabbing.

Not pulling.

Just... anchoring.

That single touch nearly changes Sukuna's entire posture.

Friedhelm doesn't look up when he speaks.

Leora speaks at the same time.

Their voices overlap.

Soft.

Careful.

Almost shy enough to be unrecognizable.

> "Do you want to join us?"

The synchronization hits like impact.

Chōbei *moves instantly* toward the table.

Nearly knocks it.

Sukuna follows a fraction slower—but only because the chair he grips fractures under his hand before he sits.

Wood groans.

Then breaks.

He sits anyway.

Chōbei drops into his seat like refusing to lose to the situation.

Leora and Friedhelm sit afterward.

Immediately they start serving.

Plating.

Adjusting portions.

Working in tandem again, but differently now—less kitchen coordination, more... offering.

Chōbei leans slightly toward Sukuna.

> “What is this?”

Sukuna watches the plate.

Apples.

Cheese.

Pastry.

Something baked into something else that should not have been combined so confidently.

> “Mistake,” Sukuna mutters.

But he eats anyway.

Chōbei follows a second later.

Silence.

Then—

both of them stop.

Not because it is bad.

Because it is not.

It is so unexpectedly good it is almost disorienting.

Chōbei slowly looks at Sukuna.

> “We should not trust them.”

Sukuna does not answer immediately.

He takes another bite.

Then, reluctantly:

> “We already have.”

Across the table, Leora watches them eat.

Friedhelm mirrors her, waiting for a reaction.

Hopeful.

Still shy.

Still soft.

And somehow—

that makes it worse.

Because Sukuna realizes, with mild irritation and something far more inconvenient beneath it:

this is what they look like when they want approval.

And worse—

they are both *extremely good at earning it without trying*.

Friedhelm sets his fork down carefully.

Like the name itself is something fragile.

“It’s called Apfelkuchen.”

Leora nods immediately.

A soft, proud smile appears on her face—small, genuine, unguarded in a way that does not match anything Sukuna has seen from her in recent days.

“Yes.”

Friedhelm looks down into his plate as if embarrassed by how much he enjoys that reaction from her.

But he is smiling too.

Not controlled.

Not restrained.

Just... relieved.

Leora shifts her attention across the table.

Her eyes land on Chōbei.

“What do you think?”

She asks it simply.

Openly.

Like it matters.

Friedhelm looks up immediately afterward, expectant in the same quiet way.

Waiting.

Both of them are.

And Sukuna notices it at once.

The shift.

Leora is no longer the composed, overwhelming presence she was earlier.

She looks—

younger.

Not in age.

In expression.

Like something in her posture has softened just enough that the defenses fall away.

Vulnerable in a way she does not usually allow to exist in front of others.

It bothers Sukuna immediately that he notices it so clearly.

And it bothers him even more that he does not dislike it.

He just recognizes it.

Friedhelm, beside her, looks even more altered.

As if something heavy has been set down off his shoulders without permission.

He looks—

lighter.

Strangely 18 again, in the way people look when they forget to carry what they've been dragging for too long.

Sukuna watches both of them in silence.

Fascinated in a way that is sharp and controlled and slightly dangerous.

Chōbei, meanwhile, is staring at Leora like the rest of the room does not exist.

It is not subtle.

It is not even something he seems aware of.

He looks... completely affected.

Almost disarmed.

Sukuna's eyes narrow slightly at that realization alone.

Then he leans back in his chair.

Slowly.

Measuring them both.

And, against his usual restraint—
he speaks.

“Are you two actually fox spirits?”

The table goes quiet.

Leora blinks once.

Friedhelm looks up immediately, startled out of his softness.

Chōbei exhales through his nose like he has been physically dragged back into awareness.

Leora tilts her head slightly.

Then smiles again—smaller this time, but still bright.

“No.”

Friedhelm adds, more quietly:

“We would be better at being fox spirits if we were.”

That earns a flicker of something from Sukuna that might almost be amusement.

Almost.

Chōbei clicks his tongue.

“They’re worse than fox spirits.”

Leora looks at him.

“That’s not an answer.”

Chōbei finally breaks eye contact first.

“It’s the only one you’re getting.”

But even he sounds less stable than before.

Because the Apfelkuchen sits on the table between them like something deceptively ordinary—

while everyone in the room quietly realizes it has done something far more invasive than poison or politics ever could.

It made them relax.

Together.

And Sukuna does not like how difficult it is becoming to decide whether that is dangerous.

Or simply inevitable.

Leora smiles a little more tentatively now, like she is testing whether the softness is allowed to stay.

> “You both hate it when you realize you’re relaxing.”

Her gaze moves between Sukuna and Chōbei.

> “It’s like you’re always expecting something to happen.”

She hesitates, then her expression shifts into something quieter.

More honest.

> “But sometimes... things can just be nice.”

A pause.

> “And sometimes they can just be easy.”

Her eyes lift again, meeting them both directly now.

And there it is again—that unsettling openness.

Not guarded.

Not performing.

Just—

> “Both of you feel easy to me.”

Friedhelm nods slightly, as if that thought has already been forming in him.

> “Sukuna especially.”

Leora brightens instantly, a small, delighted spark returning to her face.

> “Right?”

Friedhelm lets out a soft laugh through his nose, then looks down at his mug.

His fingers trace the rim gently, grounding himself in something physical while he thinks.

> “If Sukuna and Chōbei were animals,” he says slowly, “what would they be?”

Leora’s eyes light up immediately.

Like she has been waiting for this exact kind of conversation without knowing it.

> “I’ve thought about it before.”

Friedhelm laughs a little more openly now.

> “So have I.”

That alone makes Chōbei click his tongue.

Sukuna’s eyes narrow slightly—but he does not interrupt.

Leora leans forward a fraction.

> “Chōbei would definitely be a wounded wolf.”

Friedhelm shakes his head immediately.

> “No.”

Leora tilts her head.

> “No?”

> “An iron boar,” he says instead.

Leora pauses.

Then grins.

> “That’s worse.”

Friedhelm shrugs faintly.

> “It’s more accurate.”

Leora turns her attention toward Sukuna now, visibly pleased with the game.

> “Sukuna would be a dire wolf.”

Chōbei lets out a quiet, unimpressed sound.

> “Of course he would.”

But Friedhelm speaks over him immediately.

> “No.”

Both Leora and Chōbei look at him.

Friedhelm considers Sukuna carefully now, not teasing anymore—more precise.

> “He’s a fox.”

A pause.

Then, more firmly:

> “But not a trickster.”

Sukuna’s expression shifts almost imperceptibly at that.

Leora looks delighted again.

> “See?”

Friedhelm continues, calm and certain:

> “He doesn’t move like something trying to deceive.”

His gaze stays on Sukuna now.

> “He moves like something that already knows where everything will end up.”

That lands heavier in the room than anything playful should.

Chōbei clicks his tongue.

> “That sounds like a problem.”

Sukuna finally speaks, voice dry.

> “It is.”

Leora laughs softly at that—like she agrees and also does not care.

Then she leans back, satisfied.

> “Still a fox.”

Sukuna glances at her.

> “And you?”

Leora doesn’t hesitate.

She smiles.

Soft.

Certain.

> “Something that doesn’t stay in one shape long enough to name properly.”

Friedhelm nods once.

> “That fits.”

Chōbei mutters:

> “Unfortunately.”

And for a moment, the room settles again.

Not tense.

Not guarded.

Just—

quietly aware that none of them have actually stopped watching each other.

Even while laughing.

Friedhelm stands first.

Carefully.

Like the motion itself requires intention.

His eyes shift toward Sukuna.

> “Would you like to come with me?”

Sukuna does not answer immediately.

Not because he is uncertain.

Because he is evaluating.

The question splits into multiple possibilities in his mind:

- * observation efficiency if separated
- * behavioral drift if left alone
- * Leora’s proximity variable
- * Friedhelm’s reaction patterns under continued exposure

Staying together is logically preferable.

But Sukuna also notices something else.

The simplest variable:

He wants to see more of both of them.

That alone is irritating.

Chōbei breaks the silence first, leaning back with a grin that already looks like trouble.

> “Come on, fox.”

A pause.

> “Let’s go somewhere peaceful and make it dangerous.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrow slightly at him.

But then he notices it—

Leora’s reaction.

A faint blush that rises too quickly.

Too honest.

Friedhelm sees it too.

And *he* is also blushing now.

Sukuna exhales through his nose once, slow.

This is becoming inefficient in the worst possible way.

Before anything else can resolve—

Tsukihiko enters briefly from the corridor.

Kohaku in his arms.

The infant is making soft, unhappy sounds—small cries threaded with exhaustion.

Tsukihiko looks relieved just to have found Chōbei.

> “There he is.”

He shifts Kohaku slightly.

> “See? Everything is okay.”

Kohaku reaches immediately.

Fingers grasping toward Chōbei with sudden insistence.

Chōbei's entire expression changes at once.

All arrogance gone.

He moves instantly.

No hesitation.

No thought.

Just reaches out and takes his son.

The shift is so complete it makes the room feel briefly unreal.

Tsukihiko exhales like someone who has been holding tension for hours without noticing.

Chōbei glances toward Leora.

> "Sorry."

Leora waves it off immediately.

Soft smile.

> "Go. Take care of him."

That is not dismissal.

That is permission.

Tsukihiko leans in and kisses Chōbei briefly.

Nothing dramatic.

Just familiar.

Then they leave.

And the room loses something warm.

But gains something sharper.

Sukuna remains standing.

Now the room is quieter.

Smaller.

He notices it immediately.

Leora is still there.

Friedhelm is still there.

And now—

there is a gap where Chōbei's chaos used to be.

Which means Leora would be alone if Sukuna leaves.

That calculation lands heavier than expected.

Leora and Friedhelm exchange a look.

Not long.

Not obvious.

But something passes between them anyway.

Then—

they both stand.

Together.

Friedhelm begins calmly clearing the remaining dishes.

Leora helps without speaking.

Efficient.

Natural.

As if the decision was already made before Sukuna ever considered it.

Sukuna watches them.

Expression unreadable.

The kitchen is being restored to order with unsettling coordination.

Then they pause at the doorway.

Both of them turn.

Looking at him.

Expectant.

Friedhelm tilts his head slightly.

Leora's expression is soft again—but not shy this time.

Just certain.

> “Are you coming with us?”

Sukuna freezes.

Not physically.

But internally.

Because this is not a question that fits into any category he is comfortable with.

It is not strategic.

Not political.

Not necessary.

It is simply—

Invitation.

An invitation to be with...both of them at the same time.

Leora's presence makes it worse.

Friedhelm's makes it stranger.

Both of them waiting.

For him.

Sukuna's eyes narrow slightly.

> "Depends on where you're going."

A pause.

Then—

both of them smile.

Almost in sync.

> "To bed."

Silence.

Complete.

Sukuna stares at them.

For once, no immediate calculation presents itself cleanly enough to dominate the moment.

Which is its own kind of problem.

Leora turns first.

Friedhelm follows.

They leave together.

Like the answer was never uncertain.

Sukuna remains alone for a moment in the kitchen.

Looking at the remnants of Apfelkuchen.

Warm light.

Quiet room.

Empty chairs.

Then he exhales once through his nose.

Slow.

Irritated.

And stands.

Because apparently—

he is following them.

Inside of their own

9. The Crisis Part I

Rain hit the estate like a wall.

Heavy.

Unrelenting.

The world outside the training yard blurred into gray motion, like even the sky had lost its structure.

Kurohiko was closest when the scream went up.

Not a shout.

Not alarm.

A raw, breaking sound from one of the servants stationed near the outer yard.

He moved before anyone else had fully processed it.

Boots hitting wet stone.

Fast.

Faster than thought.

And when he arrived—

he stopped.

Because there was something on the ground.

At first it did not register as a person.

Mud and blood had erased shape, reduced everything into torn texture and collapsed motion.

Deep gashes cut across what remained visible.

Skin split.

Bone exposed in places that should not be visible.

One arm dragged forward weakly, fingers scraping through wet earth as if trying to remember how to belong to a body.

The servant behind him screamed again.

Longer this time.

Panic completely uncontained.

Kurohiko crouched.

Slowly.

Like approaching something already gone.

He did not speak.

Did not call for help.

Did not move closer than necessary.

His gaze tracked the breathing first.

The wet, broken rhythm of something refusing to stop.

A lost cause, his mind registered.

Not cruelty.

Just fact.

The body tried to crawl forward again.

Failed.

Blood shifted in the lungs with a wet, drowning sound.

Kurohiko tilted his head slightly, studying it the way Sukuna would have without thinking.

Then—

the figure lifted its head.

Slowly.

Painfully.

Mud slid from its face in uneven streaks.

And Kurohiko saw the eyes.

Piercing blue.

Unmistakable.

The world did not immediately make sense of it.

Because it refused to fit into anything he understood.

His breath stopped.

The rain kept falling.

The training yard noise disappeared entirely.

Only one thought formed, sharp and wrong and impossible:

Mama.

Leora.

For a second, nothing in his body responded correctly.

Then everything did at once.

Kurohiko surged forward, dropping to his knees in the mud beside her.

“—Mama?”

His voice cracked on the word.

The servant behind him screamed again, louder now, backing away as if the air itself had turned poisonous.

Leora’s lips moved.

Barely.

Something tried to form in her throat.

It came out broken.

Not speech.

Not yet.

But she was looking at him.

Seeing him.

And that alone shattered every assumption the estate had been holding together for days.

The rain made everything worse.

Not just visibility—sound, distance, judgment.

It turned the entire estate into something half-submerged, like reality itself had been pressed underwater.

Sukuna was already moving before the second alarm reached him.

Not because he panicked.

Because something in the estate's rhythm had broken.

Mizuki was beside him a heartbeat later, faster than most attendants could even think to follow.

Chōbei arrived from the opposite direction, already halfway armed, expression sharp in a way that said he had been in motion long before anyone had called him.

None of them spoke at first.

Because the scream was still echoing through the training yard.

And because Sukuna could feel it—

the way guards were clustering incorrectly.

The way people were hesitating instead of reacting.

Wrong information.

Wrong perception.

Something had already failed upstream.

They reached the outer training yard together.

And stopped.

Not in unison.

But close enough that it looked like it.

Because there was a body on the ground.

Mangled by rain and mud and something far more violent than weather.

A servant was still screaming nearby, but the sound felt distant now, like it belonged to a different layer of the world.

Sukuna's gaze narrowed immediately.

He assessed first like always.

- * Deep trauma

- * multiple lacerations

- * structural collapse of tissue

- * exposure of bone

- * blood in lungs indicated by wet, drowning respiration pattern

Unidentified attacker.

Or execution gone wrong.

Or something returned from outside the estate walls.

His mind moved cleanly.

Cold.

Chōbei stepped forward first, clicking his tongue once.

> "What the hell is that..."

Mizuki didn't answer.

He was already scanning the perimeter.

No enemies visible.

No pursuit.

No second body.

Which made it worse.

Sukuna moved forward a step.

Then another.

Not hurried.

Controlled.

The body tried to move again.

Barely.

A crawl that failed halfway through its own intention.

Sukuna's eyes sharpened slightly.

> “Still alive,” he said flatly.

Not surprise.

Confirmation.

Chōbei grimaced.

> “Barely.”

Mizuki crouched slightly, closer now, studying the angle of the wounds.

> “This isn’t a normal blade pattern,” he muttered. “It’s... too scattered.”

Sukuna said nothing.

He was already looking at the face.

What was left of it.

Rain had washed most detail away.

Hair plastered down.

Mud obscuring bone structure.

He stepped closer again.

And for the first time—

something in his expression shifted.

Very slightly.

Because the eyes lifted.

Through blood.

Through rain.

Through collapse.

Blue.

Piercing.

Wrongly familiar in a way his mind did not immediately accept.

Sukuna paused.

Just a fraction longer than he ever allowed himself to.

Chōbei noticed first.

His voice lowered.

> “...Leora?”

Mizuki snapped his head toward him.

> “What?”

Chōbei didn’t answer immediately.

Because the body tried to move again.

And the sound it made—

was not recognition yet.

Not speech.

But strain.

Sukuna stepped forward.

Slow now.

Measured.

As if the world had narrowed into a single point.

The servant behind them screamed again, finally collapsing to their knees in shock.

Mizuki's breath hitched slightly.

> “No,” he said quietly, like he was refusing the possibility before it could become real.

Chōbei moved faster now, kneeling.

Closer.

Rain dripping off his jaw.

> “That’s not—”

But his voice stopped.

Because the body shifted again.

And the face tilted just enough.

Enough for Sukuna to see the eyes properly.

And something in his chest went cold.

Not fear.

Not shock.

Recognition delayed too long.

The world did not soften around it.

It snapped.

Sukuna's voice dropped.

Quiet.

Dangerously controlled.

> "...Leora."

Mizuki froze.

Chōbei went completely still.

Even the rain seemed to hesitate for half a breath.

And in that moment—

everything in the yard stopped being a training yard.

And became something far worse.

Because Sukuna was already moving down toward her.

And this time—

there was no assessment left to complete.

10. The Crisis Part II

Sukuna did not fully register the motion of his own body.

One moment he was standing.

The next he was kneeling in the mud beside her.

The rain struck his shoulders like impact, but he didn't feel it properly anymore.

His hand went to her immediately.

Not gentle.

Not hesitant.

Precise.

Fingers pressing at her throat first.

Then her wrist.

Then the faint, failing rhythm beneath skin that should not have been this cold.

Still there.

Barely.

His expression tightened in a way that made nearby guards instinctively step back.

> “Alive,” he said again.

But this time it wasn’t confirmation.

It was disbelief forced into shape.

Chōbei moved in on her other side, slower now.

His usual sharpness gone.

Just focus.

Just shock carefully held together.

> “...Leora?” he said again, quieter. “What happened?”

Mizuki was still frozen half a step behind them.

His eyes scanning her face like his mind refused to commit to what it was seeing.

> “That’s not her,” Mizuki said abruptly. “That can’t be—”

But his voice failed him.

Because the blue eyes were still there.

Still looking.

Still trying.

Leora’s mouth moved again.

This time something came through.

Not clear words.

Not even language.

Just breath forced into shape.

Sukuna leaned closer immediately, rain sliding down his jaw.

> “Don’t speak,” he said, low and absolute.

Not comfort.

Command.

Her fingers twitched against the mud.

Reaching.

Not toward the ground.

Toward *them*.

Chōbei caught it instantly and grabbed her hand without thinking.

The moment he did—

his entire face changed.

Because her grip tightened.

Weak.

But intentional.

Recognizing.

His breath hitched.

> "...No," Chōbei whispered.

Not denial anymore.

Understanding breaking through.

Sukuna's hand shifted to her shoulder, testing stability.

The body beneath his touch was wrong in too many places.

But not gone.

Not finished.

His gaze lifted sharply.

> “Get her inside,” he ordered.

Mizuki finally snapped out of it.

> “Inside where? She needs—”

> “Inside,” Sukuna repeated.

No room for argument.

The kind of tone that ended conversation before it began.

Chōbei nodded once, abruptly, like his mind had caught up too late.

He slid one arm under her shoulders.

Careful.

Terrified of breaking what was already broken.

Sukuna moved to lift her legs.

The moment they shifted her weight—

Leora made a sound.

Small.

Pain-filled.

And the estate, for the first time in days, stopped pretending it was safe.

Chōbei's voice cracked slightly.

> "Leora... stay with me."

Mizuki moved in automatically to support her midsection, hands shaking despite his control.

> "Who did this?" he said under his breath.

No answer came.

Because Sukuna was already walking.

Carrying part of her weight without asking anyone's permission.

Rain blurred the edges of everything.

The servants scattered as they passed.

No one spoke.

No one dared.

And behind them, the training yard remained frozen in the shape of a discovery no one had been prepared to name out loud.

Leora.

Alive.

Barely.

And the estate—without yet understanding it fully—

had just shifted into war footing without anyone issuing the order.

11. The Crisis Part III - Friedhelm

The moment Friedhelm arrived, the air in the corridor changed.

Not because he spoke loudly.

Because he didn't.

He stopped dead at the sight of her being carried.

And for the first time since Sukuna had known him, Friedhelm's composure didn't simply tighten.

It **fractured**.

> "Bring her to my wing," he said immediately.

No hesitation. No deference.

A command shaped like instinct.

Chōbei shifted her slightly, already moving to comply.

But then Friedhelm stepped closer.

And actually saw her.

Really saw her.

The damage.

The depth of it.

The wrongness of the breathing.

The way her body wasn't holding itself together so much as refusing to fully fall apart yet.

Something in his face changed.

Fast.

Sharp.

> “No,” he said, suddenly. “Floor. Now.”

Sukuna’s gaze flicked to him.

Not questioning.

Measuring.

Chōbei didn’t argue.

They laid her down in the nearest sheltered space they could reach—half corridor, half threshold between rooms.

The stone beneath her was cold enough that even the rainwater steaming off her skin looked wrong.

Friedhelm dropped beside her immediately.

Kneeling.

Leaning over her like he was trying to understand what reality had done to her.

Leora's eyes were open.

Still.

Focused.

On him.

And Sukuna froze for the first time since the discovery.

Because there was something in her gaze that did not belong to injury.

Not panic.

Not resignation.

Not even pain in the usual sense.

It was... *awareness*.

Steady.

Present.

Almost disturbingly intact.

Like she was choosing to stay there.

Friedhelm exhaled once, shaking.

Then reached into his satchel.

> “Hold her still,” he said.

Chōbei did instantly.

Mizuki hesitated—but Sukuna’s hand shot out and stopped him with a single pressure at his arm.

Friedhelm poured something over her wounds.

It hissed immediately.

A sharp, reactive sound—like metal meeting heat.

Steam rose off her skin.

The smell was sharp enough to make Chōbei flinch.

Leora did not scream.

Did not thrash.

Did not even close her eyes.

She only kept looking at Friedhelm.

Sukuna's mind tried to classify it.

Shock suppression.

Nerve damage.

Tao interference.

But none of it explained the *absence* of reaction.

Friedhelm worked quickly now, hands steady in a way his face wasn't.

He adjusted her shoulder.

Pressed at her ribs.

Checked something Sukuna couldn't immediately interpret.

Then paused.

Just for a moment.

Looking down at her properly.

Leora's lips parted.

A wet, broken sound pushed through.

Not coherent at first.

Friedhelm leaned closer instinctively.

And then—

clear enough to land.

> “My fault.”

The corridor went silent in a way that felt like pressure.

Chōbei's grip on her tightened.

> “What?” he said, voice rough.

Mizuki stepped forward half a pace.

> “That's not—”

But Sukuna didn't speak.

Because Leora was still looking at Friedhelm.

Not pleading.

Not apologizing in panic.

Confirming.

As if she was stating a conclusion she had already reached long before she collapsed.

Friedhelm's expression shifted again.

Something far older than shock rising beneath it.

> "No," he said immediately, sharper now. "Don't do that. Not now."

He pressed another dressing into place, harder this time.

Leora didn't flinch.

Just kept watching him.

Like she was anchoring herself to his presence more than her own body.

Sukuna finally spoke, voice low and absolute:

> “Explain.”

Friedhelm didn’t look up.

> “Later.”

> “Now.”

A beat.

Rain hammered the stone around them.

Leora’s breathing hitched once—small, controlled.

Like she was refusing to lose consciousness purely out of stubbornness.

Friedhelm leaned closer again, quieter now, but firmer.

> “You’re still here,” he said to her. “Stay there.”

And for the first time—

Sukuna understood something that made his stomach tighten.

Not what had happened.

But that she had *chosen something in it*.

And whatever that choice was—

it was still active.

12. The Crisis Part IV - Friedhelm's Recognition

Friedhelm stopped.

Just like that.

His hands came away from her wounds and hovered for a fraction of a second—like his body didn't fully accept the decision—before he let them drop entirely.

The dressing slid slightly in the rainwater pooling beneath her.

Steam still rose faintly from where he had poured the medicinal wash, but now it felt distant. Uncontrolled. Like something left unfinished.

He leaned back on his heels.

And looked at her.

Really looked.

Not as a patient.

Not as something to stabilize.

As something that had already crossed a threshold he could not pull her back from cleanly.

Leora's eyes snapped sharper.

Anger flickered through them immediately.

Not panic.

Not despair.

Defiance.

Reluctant, furious defiance—as if even her body being like this was an insult she refused to accept quietly.

Sukuna saw it then.

Fully.

The extent.

The body on the stone was not simply injured.

It was *compromised beyond restoration in any ordinary sense*.

Rain washed blood down the corridor in thin, branching streams.

Hair stuck to her skin in wet, uneven strands.

And Sukuna's mind began to assemble the truth with brutal clarity.

First:

If he had not bound her immortality into existence—

she would already be gone.

Not “at risk.”

Not “dying.”

Gone.

Second:

That immortality was not immunity.

It was the same classification as his own.

A structure of endurance, not invulnerability.

A curse disguised as continuity.

Something that could persist through damage—but still fail under sufficient force, sufficient dominance, sufficient inevitability.

Which meant—

she had been pushed to the edge of even that.

And third:

Even if she survived this—

she would not return as she was.

Sukuna's gaze drifted down her form again.

And the realization settled into him like weight rather than thought.

Never the same.

Never moving the same.

Never holding anything the same way again.

Never—

His eyes caught it.

A section of her scalp torn cleanly away.

Hair gone in a jagged absence, as if reality itself had been ripped and failed to finish the job properly.

The remaining strands hung unevenly, matted with blood and rain, cut at unnatural lengths where force had not been consistent enough to be merciful.

Something in Sukuna's chest tightened sharply.

Not surprise.

Recognition.

Because his mind, uninvited, gave him something he did not want:

the dream.

The forest.

Her voice.

The sound of her screaming somewhere he could not locate.

The endless wrong direction.

The running that never reached her in time.

And now—

that dream had a shape.

A physical reference.

A body on the ground.

Leora's eyes stayed open through it all.

Still locked on Friedhelm.

Still present in a way that made no sense for what remained of her body.

Sukuna's fingers curled slightly at his side.

Not outwardly.

Not yet.

Friedhelm finally spoke again, voice lower now.

Careful in a way that meant control was slipping into calculation.

> “This isn’t stabilization anymore.”

A pause.

He looked down at his hands, as if confirming what he already knew.

> “It’s containment.”

Chōbei shifted sharply.

> “What the hell does that mean?”

Friedhelm didn’t answer immediately.

Because he was still looking at Leora.

And Leora—

despite everything—

looked back at him like she was waiting to see whether he would continue treating her as something worth saving.

Sukuna understood something else then.

Not just injury.

Not just immortality.

But scale.

Whatever had done this—

had not been trying to kill her cleanly.

It had been trying to erase her ability to return to herself at all.

And somewhere under the blood, under the damage, under the broken geometry of her body—

Leora was still *choosing to stay conscious enough to be seen*.

That realization hit Sukuna harder than the wounds.

Because it meant one thing:

She had made it back.

Not intact.

Not safe.

But *intentional*.

And whatever had done this was still out there.

Sukuna's gaze lifted slowly.

Cold.

Measuring.

The air around him changed in a way that did not need words.

Friedhelm noticed.

So did Chōbei.

Leora's defiant eyes softened just slightly—not in fear, but in recognition of what was forming in him.

And Sukuna finally spoke.

Quiet.

Absolute.

> “No one else touches this again.”

Not a request.

Not a vow.

A classification of consequence.

13. The Crisis Part V - Friedhelm's Choice - Helheim Arc

Friedhelm swallowed.

Small movement.

Barely visible.

But Leora reacted to it instantly.

Her entire body went still beneath the blood and ruined bandages.

Not relaxed.

Not weak.

Still in the way prey becomes still when it finally sees the trap closing.

Her eyes locked onto him with terrifying focus.

Watching.

Calculating.

Waiting for him to decide something.

Friedhelm exhaled slowly.

And Leora's pupils widened.

Just slightly.

Enough that Sukuna noticed immediately.

Then her voice came out wet and broken through the blood in her lungs.

> "Don't."

The word barely survived her throat.

Friedhelm laughed.

And every person in the corridor felt wrongness crawl down their spine at the sound.

Because it wasn't amusement.

It wasn't hysteria either.

It sounded like someone standing at the edge of an abyss and realizing they had already chosen to jump long ago.

Chōbei's head snapped toward him immediately.

Mizuki went rigid.

Sukuna's eyes narrowed.

Friedhelm was smiling.

Not softly.

Not kindly.

And he still hadn't looked away from Leora.

But now there was something profoundly unnerving in the way he regarded her.

Ancient.

Intimate.

Catastrophically familiar.

Like two beings staring at each other across the memory of something no one else in the world was supposed to witness.

Then Friedhelm said quietly:

> “It’s going to cost us.”

Leora made a horrible sound.

A wet choking gurgle deep in her chest.

Blood bubbled at the corner of her mouth.

But still—

still—

she held onto consciousness through sheer impossible force of will.

And somehow forced out:

> “No.”

Friedhelm leaned down.

Closer.

And for the first time Sukuna saw it clearly—

the side of her head where part of the ear was simply gone.

Not torn halfway.

Gone.

The realization hit all three men at once.

Chōbei recoiled visibly.

Mizuki's face drained white.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna felt something inside himself become perfectly, deathly cold.

Because suddenly the dream came back again.

Not symbolic anymore.

Not fear.

Memory before memory.

Something trying to warn him.

Friedhelm whispered into the ruined place where her ear had been.

Too quietly for anyone else to hear.

But whatever he said—

Leora's eyes widened in pure fury.

Not fear.

Fury.

And then—

they vanished.

No smoke.

No flash.

No visible Tao.

One second:

blood,
rain,
broken body,
Friedhelm kneeling beside her—

And the next:

nothing.

Empty stone.

Blood left behind in dark pools across the floor.

But no bodies.

No presence.

Gone.

The silence afterward was so abrupt it felt violent.

Rain hammered the courtyard roof.

Someone far away screamed again.

But inside the corridor—

nothing moved.

Chōbei stared at the empty ground like his mind refused to process it.

Then suddenly lurched forward—

like he thought if he reached fast enough he could still stop whatever had happened.

Mizuki caught his arm hard.

> “Don’t.”

Chōbei nearly struck him on instinct before recognizing him.

> “Where did they go?”

No one answered.

Because no one knew.

Sukuna stood perfectly still.

And for the first time in a very long time—

he felt something dangerously close to genuine fear.

Not fear of death.

Not fear of battle.

Fear of absence.

Because Leora had looked at Friedhelm like she knew exactly what he intended.

And had still been unable to stop him.

Which meant whatever Friedhelm had just done—

was something older than trust.

Older than permission.

Something between them built long before Sukuna entered either of their lives.

Mizuki spoke first.

Quietly.

Like he regretted the realization already.

> “They went somewhere only the two of them can reach.”

Sukuna’s eyes shifted toward him instantly.

Mizuki swallowed.

Then lower:

> “...and I don’t think Leora wanted him to take her there.”

14. The Crisis Part VI - Tsukihiko Part I

Mizuki folded.

Not physically at first.

Internally.

Sukuna saw it happen in real time.

The moment the shock finally reached whatever part of Mizuki still thought Leora was untouchable.

His breathing shortened violently.

His face drained white beneath the rain.

And suddenly he looked impossibly young.

Not the sharp-eyed twin who walked beside death.

Not the cold son of the Ryomen household.

Just—

a child.

A terrified child.

“Where’s Kurohiko?”

His voice cracked.

Mizuki grabbed Sukuna’s sleeve hard enough to wrinkle the fabric.

“Where’s Mama?”

Sukuna’s chest tightened instantly.

Because Mizuki was panicking wrong.

Not outwardly hysterical.

Worse.

Like his body no longer understood where safety was supposed to exist.

“Where is she?”

Chōbei made a rough sound beside them.

Not speech.

Air.

Like his lungs had suddenly stopped working correctly.

Sukuna looked toward him sharply and realized with immediate irritation that fatherhood had changed him catastrophically.

Because Chōbei was imagining it now too.

Kohaku on the ground like that.

Tsukihiko.

Leora.

All of them breakable.

All reachable.

And before Sukuna could force the situation back under control—

another scream tore across the estate.

Different direction.

Closer.

All three moved instantly.

Rain lashed sideways across the courtyard as they ran.

Servants scattered from the path ahead.

Then Sukuna saw the crowd.

And in the center—

Tsukihiko.

On the ground.

Blood soaked through his robes and spread black-red into the rainwater beneath him.

Not mutilated like Leora.

But wounded badly enough that any ordinary person would already be unconscious.

A deep tear through his side.

Another through his thigh.

Mud and blood covering pale skin.

And burned into his arm—

a handprint.

Perfectly shaped.

Darkened flesh.

Like something had gripped him hard enough to brand him through skin and muscle.

Tsukihiko gritted his teeth against the pain.

And Sukuna froze for half a second.

Because the look in his eyes—

was Leora's.

Not softness.

Not fragility.

The same impossible refusal to collapse.

The same furious determination to remain standing no matter what damage had already been done.

It hit Sukuna like a physical blow.

Tsukihiko looked at Chōbei first.

Immediately.

Urgently.

“Leave me.”

Chōbei dropped to his knees beside him.

“Absolutely not.”

Tsukihiko grabbed his sleeve hard.

“Go to Kohaku.”

Chōbei hesitated.

Torn cleanly apart.

Tsukihiko’s face twisted.

Not weakness.

Rage.

“Do as I say.”

The command cracked through the rain sharply enough that even Sukuna went still.

Because Tsukihiko never sounded like that.

Ever.

And Chōbei—

for the first time since Sukuna had known him—

obeyed instantly without argument.

He ran.

Straight toward the nursery.

Mizuki dropped beside Tsukihiko immediately and began tearing open soaked fabric to assess the damage.

Tsukihiko shut his eyes briefly from pain.

Then reached blindly outward.

His fingers caught Sukuna's pant leg.

Held tightly.

And Sukuna looked down at him with growing unease.

Because this version of Tsukihiko was wrong.

Not soft.

Not delicate.

Not gentle.

There was something hard in him right now.

Something furious.

Near-feral beneath the pain.

Like whatever attacked him had reached something ancient hiding underneath all that warmth and kindness.

Mizuki pressed hard against the wound in his side.

Tsukihiko hissed through his teeth but did not cry out.

"Stay down," Mizuki snapped.

Tsukihiko ignored him entirely.

By the time Chōbei returned—

Kohaku held tightly against his chest beneath heavy blankets—

Tsukihiko was already forcing himself upright.

Blood running down his leg.

One hand braced against the wall.

Still standing.

Sukuna stared at him.

"What happened?"

Tsukihiko looked immediately toward Kohaku.

Only Kohaku.

The infant made soft upset noises against Chōbei's shoulder.

Tsukihiko's expression changed instantly at the sound.

Not calmer.

Focused.

Anchored.

Then he answered quietly:

"I don't really know."

A pause.

Rain slid down his face like tears he refused to shed.

"I was... embarrassingly unprepared."

Another breath.

"Pathetic."

Chōbei's expression darkened violently.

But before he could speak, Sukuna asked:

"Did you see Leora?"

Tsukihiko froze.

Completely.

Then slowly looked at him.

Real confusion in his face.

"No."

A beat.

"I haven't seen Mama today."

Silence crashed down around them.

Sukuna felt the shape of the realization instantly.

Separate attacks.

Separate locations.

Separate timings.

Which meant this was not one breach.

Not one enemy slipping through.

Multiple points.

Coordinated.

Intentional.

And someone had targeted:

Leora.

Tsukihiko.

The bloodline.

The heirs.

The children.

Something cold and enormous settled into Sukuna's chest.

Not rage yet.

Something worse.

Calculation sharpened by fury.

Because one attack could be explained.

Two could not.

And that—

that was unacceptable.

15. The Crisis Part VII - Tsukihiko Part II

A sound rolled across the estate.

Low.

Deep.

Not thunder.

A horn.

Every guard in the corridor reacted instantly.

Tsukihiko did too.

Except unlike everyone else—

he became colder.

Sharper.

The pain vanished from his face so completely it was almost frightening.

He straightened despite the blood still running down his side.

And began giving orders immediately.

Not hesitating once.

> “Seal the eastern wings.”

Guards moved.

> “Moon-Kept militia to second defensive positions.”

> “Archers on the inner walls.”

> “No open courtyards.”

Another breath.

Another order.

Precise.

Fast.

> “Double guard rotation around Kaguya’s wing.”

Mizuki looked up immediately.

Tsukihiko pointed at him.

> “Go to Kaguya.”

> “If Kurohiko is there, bring him inside immediately.”

Mizuki vanished without argument.

Then Tsukihiko turned toward the servants.

> “Kiyomi, Sieg, and Higan are to be moved to Kaguya’s chambers now.”

No hesitation.

No softness.

The servants scattered instantly.

Then Tsukihiko looked at Chōbei.

Kohaku was still pressed tightly against his chest beneath the blankets.

The child had gone quiet again.

Only those tiny fox ears twitching faintly beneath the cloth.

Tsukihiko stepped toward them.

> “Take him to Friedhelm’s wing.”

Chōbei blinked.

> “What?”

> “Third room past the western veranda.”

Tsukihiko spoke without pause.

> “There’s a false wall behind the cabinet.”

> “Push the lower panel.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed slightly.

A hidden room.

Tsukihiko continued:

> “Wait there.”

> “Give Kohaku the tea in the pink bag if he wakes up or starts crying.”

Chōbei stared at him now.

Really stared.

Because this was no longer Tsukihiko speaking like a soft nobleman pretending at authority.

This was strategy.

Preparation.

Knowledge.

Inheritance.

And then Tsukihiko stepped closer.

Something in him shifted fully into place.

The warmth disappeared.

The sweetness.

The fragility.

For one terrifying second—

Sukuna could see exactly whose son he was.

Tsukihiko's voice dropped.

Controlled.

Absolute.

> “Go now.”

Another step closer.

> “Do not disappoint me.”

Chōbei froze.

And Sukuna watched something almost imperceptible happen in him.

Recognition.

Not submission.

Recognition.

Because Chōbei suddenly realized Tsukihiko was not asking.

The same way Sukuna did not ask.

The same way Leora did not ask when death was approaching.

Chōbei adjusted Kohaku once against his chest.

Then left immediately.

No argument.

No joke.

Gone into the rain.

And Sukuna stared after him.

Slowly—

very slowly—

he turned back toward Tsukihiko.

Tsukihiko met his eyes.

And in that moment Sukuna understood him completely.

Kaguya was the next target.

Not Kohaku.

Not Tsukihiko.

Kaguya.

The newborn.

The heirs gathered together.

Which meant Tsukihiko had just done something deeply ugly.

And deeply intelligent.

He had sent his son away from his sister.

Away from the concentration point.

Away from the primary target.

He had chosen:

Kohaku.

Chōbei.

Survival.

Over staying beside Kaguya and Linnea.

Even though he loved them.

Even though it hurt him.

Even though Sukuna could see in his face exactly what that decision cost him.

In theory—

it was the logical choice.

Protect the more vulnerable infant.

Separate the bloodline targets.

Reduce casualty concentration.

Perfectly rational.

Sukuna just stood there realizing something deeply unsettling.

How had he never seen this inside Tsukihiko before?

This ruthlessness.

This instinct to compartmentalize emotion in favor of survival.

This willingness to prioritize strategically even when it broke him internally.

Tsukihiko swayed once from blood loss.

Then steadied himself again immediately.

Still standing.

Still issuing orders.

Rain hammered the estate roof overhead.

And Sukuna suddenly realized with absolute certainty:

whoever had come for them tonight had made a catastrophic mistake.

Because they had managed to awaken every dangerous survival instinct buried inside the Ryomen household all at once.

16. The Crisis Part VIII

The roof exploded inward.

Tiles shattered across the corridor.

Several guards reached for weapons instantly—
then stopped.

Kurohiko slid down the broken slope of the roof hard enough to crack wood beneath him before catching himself on one hand.

Blood covered him.

Not all his.

Rainwater streamed from his hair and sleeves.

For one split second Sukuna thought he'd been mortally wounded too.

Then Kurohiko lifted his head.

Alive.

Breathing hard.

His pupils too wide.

Disturbed.

Not frightened.

Disturbed.

He looked down at them from the ruined roofline.

Then said flatly:

> "I followed Mama's blood into the forest."

The corridor went silent.

Even the guards stopped moving.

Kurohiko's voice sounded wrong.

Too controlled.

Like he was forcing words through shock manually.

> "The destruction is worse than anything I've ever seen."

Rain dripped from his jaw.

> “Trees torn apart.”
> “Ground split open.”
> “Bodies everywhere.”

A pause.

Then quieter:

> “Whatever happened out there...”

His eyes unfocused slightly.

> “...was beyond comprehension.”

Sukuna watched him carefully.

Kurohiko never looked overwhelmed.

Not visibly.

Not like this.

Then Kurohiko swallowed once.

And for the first time since arriving—

his composure cracked slightly.

> “She fought.”

Another pause.

> “Gods, she fought.”

Something ugly moved beneath Sukuna’s ribs at the raw disbelief in Kurohiko’s voice.

Because Kurohiko admired violence.

Understood it.

Measured people through it.

And even he sounded shaken.

Then Kurohiko said quietly:

> “But her hair...”

His expression shifted.

Actually disturbed now.

> “It was everywhere.”

Sukuna’s stomach turned violently.

Dream.

Forest.

Silver hair.

Dismembered.

His fingers flexed once.

Kurohiko continued:

> “Something ambushed her.”

> “Something lured her out.”

Another breath.

> “There’s no other explanation.”

And then—

Tsukihiko’s cursed energy erupted.

Not intentionally.

Not controlled.

It expanded so violently the corridor walls groaned.

Servants collapsed immediately.

Several guards stumbled backward.

Even Sukuna flinched slightly before catching himself.

And that—

that irritated him almost as much as it unsettled him.

Because how had he not noticed this either?

Tsukihiko stood there bleeding through his clothes with one hand pressed against his side—

and still his power flooded the estate hard enough to distort the air.

Cold.

Dense.

Predatory.

Not like Leora's.

Not like Sukuna's.

Worse in some ways.

Sharper.

Like compressed emotional devastation weaponized into force.

Kurohiko's eyes glinted immediately toward him.

Not intimidated.

Matching.

Then he asked:

> "Where is Kiyomi?"

The question hit the corridor strangely.

Because it came too fast.

Too immediate.

Sukuna's eyes narrowed.

Then—

another scream tore through the estate.

Closer this time.

Female.

Cut off abruptly.

Everyone moved at once.

Tsukihiko limped forward immediately despite his wounds.

Sukuna caught his shoulder hard enough to stop him.

> “You stay standing first.”

Tsukihiko jerked against the grip instantly.

Feral.

> “Let go.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed further.

Because there it was again.

That same thing Leora had when cornered.

Not fear.

Not panic.

Protectiveness violent enough to override injury.

Kurohiko dropped from the roof fully now.

Mud and blood splashing beneath his boots.

> “That scream came from the inner halls.”

And suddenly Sukuna realized something horrific.

The eastern wings had already been sealed.

Which meant—

whatever was inside the estate now...

had already gotten past the outer defenses before Tsukihiko gave the order.

The realization spread visibly across everyone’s faces at the same time.

Too late.

They had reacted too late.

Then somewhere deeper inside the estate—

something massive hit a wall hard enough to shake the floor beneath them.

17. The Crisis Part VIII

The scream came from Kiyomi.

By the time they reached her—

half her body was already inside it.

Not eaten.

Not crushed.

Absorbed.

Something black and shifting clung to her like wet shadow given shape.

No face.

No limbs.

Just hunger.

The air around it felt wrong.

Cold in a way that stole heat from bone.

Kiyomi's fingers clawed desperately against the floorboards as the thing dragged her inward inch by inch.

And everywhere the shadow touched—

the wood beneath her rotted pale and hollow.

Like life itself had been sucked out.

A servant corpse nearby looked mummified.

Empty.

Drained.

Kiyomi's eyes found Sukuna for one split second—

then her hand moved instead toward something tied at her waist.

Handpipes.

Leora's.

Kiyomi ripped them free with shaking fingers.

And even through the chaos Sukuna remembered Leora once saying calmly over tea:

> "Any wrong note can be worse than the reason you blew them."

Kiyomi lifted the pipes to her mouth anyway.

And played.

One single note split the corridor.

The effect was immediate.

The shadow screamed.

Not metaphorically.

Actually screamed.

The sound ruptured through the walls hard enough to burst lantern glass.

The thing writhed violently around her body.

Kiyomi screamed too.

Pain exploded across her face instantly.

Blood poured from her mouth.

Too much blood.

She doubled over coughing so hard Sukuna thought her lungs might tear free from her throat entirely.

And suddenly Sukuna understood.

This wasn't a curse.

Or at least not one he recognized.

Because cursed energy didn't react like this.

This thing recoiled from the pipes like something ancient remembering a predator.

Kurohiko moved first.

No hesitation.

He tore into the shadow with his bare hands and sharp whistled notes between his teeth.

The sound cut through the thing strangely.

Like blades.

The entity convulsed.

Then released Kiyomi all at once.

She hit the floor hard.

Deathly pale.

Too pale.

Like something had been taken out of her.

Not blood.

Not flesh.

Soul.

Kurohiko caught her immediately.

> “Kiyomi.”

No response.

His composure fractured instantly.

Just enough.

And Sukuna saw it.

That same thing.

That same unbearable fury when something dared touch what belonged to you.

What was yours.

Leora.

The thought hit him like a weapon.

Where are you?

The world narrowed violently.

Everything else became secondary.

Kiyomi gasping weakly.
Kurohiko covered in blood.
Tsukihiko barking orders somewhere behind him.

Meaningless.

Because Leora was still gone.

Gone.

He couldn't touch her.

Couldn't hear her.

Couldn't feel her beside him.

And somewhere out there—

her hair decorated the forest.

Silver strands tangled through mud and broken trees.

Wrong.

Deeply.

Profoundly wrong.

Something inside Sukuna recoiled from the reality of it so violently it nearly became rage without shape.

After the shadow thing died—

he stopped thinking clearly.

Or perhaps he began thinking more clearly than ever before.

Anyone not personally recognized was killed immediately.

No questions.

No hesitation.

Servants.
Messengers.
Guards.

If Sukuna did not know their face—

they died.

The estate became a slaughterhouse.

He tore through corridors fast enough walls cracked from proximity alone.

Every room searched.

Every ceiling opened.

Every cabinet destroyed.

Every hidden passage uncovered.

He ripped doors off hinges.

Split floors apart.

Turned the countryside surrounding the estate into devastation.

Trees uprooted.

Buildings shattered.

Bodies left in pieces.

Because he was not going to miss someone.

Not again.

Not after the dream.

Not after seeing her blood.

And underneath all the violence—

something far worse began happening quietly inside him.

The realization.

Was he truly supposed to live without her?

The thought felt impossible.

Not emotionally difficult.

Impossible.

Like imagining the sky removed from the world.

Like imagining silence where there should be breath.

No Leora in the mornings.
No silver hair across his chest at night.
No hands grabbing his robes.
No voice laughing at him.
No presence reorganizing entire rooms around itself without effort.

No one looking at him like she did.

No one touching him like he was both catastrophe and sanctuary simultaneously.

No one standing beside him while making him quieter instead of crueler.

And worse—

he realized suddenly that she had infected everything.

Kaguya's smile.
Friedhelm sleeping beside him.
Kohaku's tiny fox ears.
Linnea's nose marking.
The warmth of the kitchens.
The ridiculous pie.
The sound of Chōbei laughing.

She threaded herself through all of it.

Every room.

Every person.

Every structure.

So removing her now—

what remained?

Sukuna stood in the rain outside the ruined estate breathing hard while blood ran from his hands.

And for the first time in centuries—

Ryomen Sukuna understood why ordinary humans lost their minds after grief.

Because this did not feel survivable.

Not for them.

For him.

18. The Crisis Part X - Hair

Sukuna returned to the training yard alone.

No guards.

No servants.

No one stupid enough to follow him.

Rain fell harder now.

Cold against skin already slick with blood.

Leora's blood.

He stood where Kurohiko had stood earlier.

And looked.

The trail cut through the grounds violently.

Not dragged.

Not carried.

Fought.

The earth itself looked wounded.

Deep trenches carved through mud and stone.

Trees split apart.

Walls gouged open.

And silver hair—

everywhere.

The sight stopped him immediately.

Not strands.

Not shedding.

Not normal.

Entire lengths.

Long swaths of silver-white stretched across branches and roots like torn silk caught in catastrophe.

Some of it wrapped around broken trunks.

Some embedded in bark.

Some soaked red.

Too much.

Far too much.

It looked less like hair and more like something exploded out of her.

Sukuna stared at it for a long moment.

Then followed the trail deeper into the forest.

Part of him already knew this would change him.

If it disturbed Kurohiko—

then whatever waited ahead was not ordinary devastation.

But if he was honest—

he still did not understand what he was truly walking toward.

Then he reached the clearing.

And stopped.

Everything there was wrong.

The clearing itself looked unnatural.

Not simply destroyed.

Altered.

Trees bent outward as though something immense had expanded violently from the center.

The ground was sliced apart in thousands of directions.

And over everything—

hair.

Silver-white hair draped from tree to tree.

Across corpses.

Over shattered earth.

Through broken weapons.

It moved slightly in the rain like living threads.

Sukuna stared.

The bodies were everywhere.

Or what remained of them.

Not cut apart normally.

Not hacked.

Not dismembered.

Reduced.

Razor-fine slices so precise some corpses still remained upright despite being segmented into hundreds of pieces.

Rain loosened them slowly.

Sections slipping apart almost delicately.

The sight mirrored his own work enough to unsettle him immediately.

Because this—

this was technique.

Controlled.

Intentional.

And Leora had never shown him anything like it.

Not once.

The more he looked—

the worse the realization became.

There were patterns in the destruction.

Angles.

Repetition.

Precision beyond frenzy.

This wasn't desperation alone.

This was skill.

Old skill.

Hidden skill.

And suddenly Sukuna realized something deeply unpleasant:

there were parts of Leora he had never truly seen.

Not emotionally.

Violently.

This level of brutality—

he had not believed her capable of it.

Not like this.

Not with such surgical annihilation.

And if this—

this nightmare of shredded bodies and ruined forest—

was what she had needed to do just to crawl back to the estate barely holding together—

then what in the name of the gods had attacked her?

Who were these people?

Because they were not ordinary.

Even ruined, their remains radiated wrongness.

Several corpses had markings burned beneath their skin.

Others had teeth filed into points.

One body still clutched something metallic that seemed to absorb rainlight instead of reflecting it.

Not human.

Or not fully.

Then suddenly—

pain snapped across his wrist.

Sukuna jerked slightly.

Leora's bracelet.

The one she gave him.

It burned.

Actually burned.

The metal cracked sharply against his skin with a sound like splitting ice.

Something electric moved through the clearing.

Not visible.

Felt.

Like coils tightening around reality itself.

The bracelet reacted violently.

The symbols carved into it flared faintly.

Sukuna's instincts screamed immediately.

Pressure began building in the forest.

Not cursed energy.

Something older.

Something he did not understand.

And for perhaps the first time in centuries—

Ryomen Sukuna felt something he did not want to stay and confront unprepared.

Not caution.

Not hesitation.

True instinctive rejection.

Leave.

Now.

The forest itself suddenly felt aware of him.

The rain changed.

The air thickened.

And somewhere deeper in the clearing—
something shifted.

Not movement.

Recognition.

The bracelet cracked harder.

Sukuna stepped backward instantly.

For one ugly humiliating moment—

he realized if Leora had still been here when this awakened—

then whatever she faced may have been even worse than the slaughter around him suggested.

The realization hollowed him out.

Then survival instinct overrode pride.

So Sukuna left.

Quickly.

Without pretending otherwise.

Without conquering it.

Without understanding it.

He left the clearing behind with rain hammering against his shoulders and Leora's bracelet
burning against his wrist—

while somewhere behind him in the forest—

something continued waking up.

The Crisis Part XI - Tsukihiko Part III

The Moon-Kept militia returned near dawn.

Mud-covered.

Exhausted.

Several wounded.

But disciplined enough that panic never fully took hold.

One group approached carrying a body bound tightly in soaked cloth and rope.

Not respectfully.

Carefully.

Like something poisonous.

The moment they set it down, Tsukihiko's expression changed.

He had patched himself roughly sometime during the chaos.

Bandages wrapped hard around his side and thigh beneath dark clothing already stained through again with blood.

He refused assistance from everyone.

Including Mizuki.

Especially Mizuki.

Instead he moved through the estate issuing orders with frightening precision while still visibly injured.

Sukuna watched him now as Tsukihiko crouched beside the corpse.

The cloth was pulled back.

And Tsukihiko spat immediately.

Not disgust alone.

Offense.

Deep offense.

When he looked up at Sukuna his face had gone cold in a way Sukuna had only seen once before—

when Tsukihiko realized Kaguya was the next target.

> “Todkrieger.”

The word meant nothing to Sukuna.

But it clearly meant something terrible to everyone else.

Several militia members lowered their eyes instantly.

One muttered a prayer beneath his breath.

Tsukihiko stood.

> “Burn every body.”

Immediate.

Absolute.

> “Every piece.”

He pointed toward the corpse sharply.

> “Do not leave blood. Do not leave teeth. Do not leave bone.”

Then colder:

> “And bury the ash by the river.”

Nobody questioned him.

Not one person.

The militia dispersed immediately.

Tsukihiko was already moving before they fully obeyed.

He commandeered tables.

Maps.

Ink.

Paper.

Breaking people into groups rapidly.

Some he assigned to evacuations.

Others to patrol rotations.

Others to escort children and elderly villagers away from the eastern routes entirely.

He drew maps quickly from memory.

Marked paths.

Marked rivers.

Marked fallback points.

Then he stopped midway through issuing instructions and snapped:

> “Switch with someone literate.”

Two men immediately traded places with others.

Sukuna remembered suddenly:

Leora introduced schools.

Even here.

Even in remote villages.

Tsukihiko continued without missing rhythm.

Efficient.

Controlled.

Unquestioned.

And Sukuna watched the men watching him.

It happened in real time.

The same thing people did around Leora.

Around himself.

Attention bending unconsciously toward gravity.

Tsukihiko stood bloodied and half-bandaged giving orders while rainwater dripped from his hair—

and the militia looked at him like certainty itself.

Like if he pointed toward hell they would march smiling because surely Young Master Tsukihiko already knew the way back out.

Beautiful like Leora.

Dangerous like Sukuna.

And somehow worse for being both simultaneously.

When the last group finally departed, the estate quieted slightly.

Only then did Tsukihiko exhale.

Sukuna looked down at the corpse again.

The skin looked wrong now that he was closer.

Too tight in some places.

Too loose in others.

As though assembled rather than grown.

Beneath torn flesh strange black stitching threaded through muscle and tendon.

Not sewing.

Binding.

Sukuna's eyes narrowed.

> "Explain."

Tsukihiko wiped rainwater from his face impatiently.

> "Todkriegers are in the Book of the Dead."

A pause.

> "Constructed war corpses."

Sukuna remained silent.

Tsukihiko continued colder:

> "Creating one is nearly impossible."

He gestured sharply toward the body.

> “You don’t just raise corpses. You build them.”

> “Bones. Souls. binding rites. memory anchors. replacement tissue. reinforcement.”

His jaw tightened.

> “And they become worse if they had natural inclination while alive.”

That caught Sukuna’s attention immediately.

> “Inclination?”

Tsukihiko nodded once.

> “Natural compatibility with death work. spirit work. violence.”

Then flatter:

> “Some people are born too close to the boundary already.”

The rain tapped steadily against the ruined roof nearby.

Tsukihiko looked back toward the corpse with open contempt.

> “One Todkrieger can be someone’s life work.”

A pause.

> “Years. Sometimes decades.”

Then quieter:

> “But this many?”

He shook his head once.

Actually disturbed.

> “Multiple creators. Multiple workshops.”

His eyes hardened.

> “Working constantly.”

Another pause.

Then:

> “For at least a decade.”

Sukuna looked back toward the forest instinctively.

Toward the clearing.

Toward the thing waking up there.

Tsukihiko noticed immediately.

And for the first time since this began—

something uncertain flickered across his face.

Not fear.

Recognition of scale.

Then he admitted quietly:

> “I don’t think I could ever make one.”

That statement landed harder than Sukuna expected.

Because Tsukihiko was not modest.

Not falsely.

If he said something exceeded him—

then it truly exceeded him.

And suddenly Sukuna understood something profoundly unpleasant:

whatever attacked Leora was not random.

Not opportunistic.

Not a rogue curse.

This was organized.

Patient.

Old.

And it had come specifically for his family.

Tsukihiko had been speaking without pause for nearly an hour.

Orders.

Routes.
Burial instructions.
Supply chains.
Rotations.

Then suddenly—

he stopped.

Not physically.

Mentally.

Something caught up to him all at once.

Sukuna saw it immediately.

The exhaustion underneath the momentum.

Tsukihiko rubbed once at his eyes before speaking.

> “Go get Mama and Uncle Friedhelm.”

Sukuna stilled.

Tsukihiko continued while reorganizing maps.

> “I need both of them for the ward structure.”

No response.

Tsukihiko looked up.

Annoyed already.

> “Now, Otōsan.”

Sukuna’s voice came out flat.

> “I can’t.”

Tsukihiko frowned immediately.

> “This is not the time for your love drama.”

Sharply:

> “I need them and nobody has found them.”

Then, irritated beyond belief:

> “How am I supposed to believe you don’t have Mama hidden somewhere safe like I do Chōbei?”

Sukuna froze.

Tsukihiko kept going, frustrated and exhausted and not realizing what he was saying.

> “We’re the same.”

A bitter laugh.

> “Friedhelm is probably hidden somewhere too.”

Then drier:

> “I bet you gave him watercolors and tea before locking him into whatever absurd secret room you built.”

That hit Sukuna so hard he physically retched.

The motion startled even him.

Blood and bile hit the stone floor.

Because suddenly—

horribly—

he understood.

No safe room.

No contingency.

No hidden sanctuary prepared for either of them.

Not Leora.

Not Friedhelm.

Because somewhere deep inside himself he had never truly imagined them absent from battle.

Leora always fought beside him.

Friedhelm always stayed behind with the children.

That was the structure.

The certainty.

And now both were gone simultaneously—

and he had prepared nothing.

The realization hollowed him out so violently he almost staggered.

Tsukihiko's expression shifted immediately.

> "...Otōsan?"

Sukuna looked at him finally.

And said quietly:

> "They're gone."

Silence.

Tsukihiko stopped breathing for a second.

Sukuna did not say:
they aren't dead.

Because he didn't know.

That was the worst part.

Tsukihiko laughed suddenly.

Sharp.
Broken.

Wrong.

Then rubbed one hand over his face hard enough to leave red marks.

> "Friedhelm is going to hate me."

Not:
they're dead.

Not:
they're gone.

That.

Because Tsukihiko already understood what it meant if Friedhelm disappeared while under his protection.

Then instantly:

> "Get Mizuki and Kurohiko."

The nearest guards sprinted.

Sukuna watched Tsukihiko carefully now.

The composure remained.

But only structurally.

Like someone continuing movement after catastrophic internal injury.

Sukuna asked quietly:

> “What can I do?”

Tsukihiko looked up sharply.

And for the first time since childhood—

he looked unnerved by Sukuna.

Not frightened.

Disturbed.

Because Ryomen Sukuna was asking for direction.

Not taking it.

Tsukihiko’s face changed slowly.

Then he said quietly:

> “Mama must really be gone.”

The words landed like curses.

But he kept moving anyway.

Always moving.

> “I need to establish death wards.”

He grabbed another scroll from the Book of Death and spread it open violently.

Symbols Sukuna didn’t recognize covered the pages.

Not cursed script.

Older.

> “I can’t build them fast enough alone.”

His eyes moved rapidly across the diagrams.

> “I need magically inclined people.”

Then colder:

> “Death walkers if possible.”

The guards returned with Mizuki and Kurohiko almost immediately.

Both looked furious.

Kurohiko first:

> “This is stupid.”

Mizuki at the same time:

> “Everyone else is vulnerable if we’re here.”

Tsukihiko pointed at them without even looking up.

> “I don’t care about your feelings.”

That shut both of them up instantly.

Then he began listing names from the militia and guard rotations.

Specific men.

Specific women.

Certain bloodlines.

Certain villages.

People Leora apparently identified years ago.

People with “inclination.”

Kurohiko caught on first.

His expression darkened.

> “You’re serious.”

Tsukihiko didn’t look up.

> “Obviously.”

Then finally:

> “I’m going to baptize them.”

Mizuki went pale immediately.

Kurohiko swore.

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed.

Tsukihiko continued anyway.

> “Then we build new wards before nightfall.”

The room felt colder suddenly.

Not physically.

Conceptually.

Because everybody present understood this was no longer normal estate defense.

This was war preparation.

Against something old enough to require rites from the Book of Death itself.

Tsukihiko finally looked at Sukuna directly again.

Calm.

Certain.

Too much like him.

> “Maintain the estate defenses while we’re in death.”

A pause.

Then colder still:

> “If I don’t come back—”

Kurohiko looked up sharply.

Tsukihiko ignored him.

> “—Kurohiko takes over the wards.”

Kurohiko blinked once.

Actually startled.

Tsukihiko added flatly:

> “You’ll figure it out intuitively.”

Kurohiko stared at him.

> “That’s not how wards work.”

Tsukihiko finally looked tired again.

Not physically.

Anciently.

> “For you it probably is.”

The Crisis Part XII -Skugga

The threshold into Death stood beneath the eastern shrine.

An old gate half-swallowed by black roots and silver moss.

The Moon-Kept militia gathered silently before it while freezing rain fell across the estate behind them.

Nobody spoke above a whisper.

Even hardened men avoided looking directly at the opening.

Because beyond it—

the world bent wrong.

Tsukihiko stood at the front of the procession with the fox bell hanging from one hand.

Its silver surface reflected no light.

Mizuki stood beside him.

Kurohiko slightly behind.

Then the guards.

Then the militia.

Tsukihiko looked over them once.

Bandages visible beneath his robes.
Blood still soaking through his side.

But his posture remained perfectly straight.

> “Stay close.”

Calm.

Direct.

> “Do not touch the water unless instructed.”

His eyes moved toward several younger militia men.

> “And if something calls your name from the reeds—”

A pause.

> “You ignore it.”

Nobody argued.

Then Tsukihiko stepped through the threshold.

Death opened around them instantly.

Black water stretched beneath dead reeds that swayed despite nonexistent wind.

Silver roots moved beneath the surface like veins.

Snow drifted upward into a dark sky.

Distant bells rang somewhere impossibly far away.

Foxfire floated lazily between pale trees.

And beneath still ponds—

flowers bloomed upside down.

The guards visibly struggled the moment they crossed over.

Breathing changed.
Hands tightened around weapons.
Several men looked seconds away from panic.

Death pressed against instinct.

Against soul.

Against the primitive certainty that living things were not supposed to walk here willingly.

But Tsukihiko moved calmly through it.

Not fearless.

Familiar.

Like someone raised beside people who entered Death often enough that the boundary no longer felt sacred.

The fox bell chimed softly from his hand.

And every time it did—

the men steadied slightly.

Mizuki noticed immediately.

Not the bell.

Tsukihiko himself.

The way he moved through Death resembled Friedhelm unnervingly.

The same certainty.

The same unbroken rhythm.

But emotionally—

he was Sukuna.

Composed.

Direct.

Absolutely merciless toward hesitation.

Kurohiko noticed something worse.

Foxfire followed Tsukihiko.

Not randomly.

Attentively.

Shadows avoided touching him entirely.

And dead things—

things buried beneath the black water—

turned slowly toward him as he passed.

Then the fox bell chimed once.

Softly.

Every foxfire in the forest brightened simultaneously.

The air warmed.

Only slightly.

But enough that everyone felt it immediately.

The guards froze.

Because something enormous had just noticed them.

The black water rippled outward in perfect circles.

And then Skugga appeared.

Not emerging.

Present.

Tall.

Beautiful in a deeply inhuman way.

Silver-white hair drifted around pale skin glowing softly like winter moonlight.

Long dark robes trailed through black water without disturbing the surface.

Foxes moved constantly around him.

White.

Silver.

Shadow-black.

Their gold eyes reflected through the reeds like lanterns.

And when Skugga smiled—

Mizuki's stomach turned violently.

Not because it was cruel.

Because emotionally—

it resembled Friedhelm.

Too fond.

Too observant.
Too quietly attached.

The realization unsettled him instantly.

Skugga's eyes landed on Tsukihiko.

And warmed visibly.

Not polite recognition.

Affection.

Like family arriving home.

His gaze shifted immediately toward the fox bell.

Then lower—

toward lingering traces of Kohaku's scent.

Then back to Tsukihiko himself.

> "Did you bring One-Eye?"

Nobody reacted at first.

Then Tsukihiko blinked once.

Realization.

> "...Chōbei?"

Kurohiko looked horrified.

Mizuki stared openly.

A deity knew Chōbei personally.

Skugga smiled wider immediately.

> "Beautiful creature."

Fond.

Amused.

> "Still refusing to die correctly?"

Tsukihiko actually snorted softly.

Which disturbed the guards even more.

Skugga continued almost dreamily:

> “I like the scars.”

Foxes circled lazily through the reeds around him.

> “Most people scar toward endings.”

A pause.

> “He scars toward continuation.”

His eyes gleamed faintly gold.

> “Very rare.”

Mizuki felt cold suddenly.

Because the deity was not speaking about Chōbei like a mortal.

He sounded fascinated.

Admiring.

Like Chōbei represented something spiritually significant.

Then Skugga looked at Tsukihiko again.

Softer now.

> “And Kiba?”

Tsukihiko’s face changed immediately.

Tiny.

Human.

> “Sleeping.”

Skugga’s expression warmed impossibly further.

> “He’s getting bigger.”

Then gently:

> “You’re doing a good job.”

That hit Tsukihiko hard enough Mizuki saw it physically.

Not dramatic emotion.

But something beneath his ribs loosened painfully.

Parental praise.

Real praise.

The kind Tsukihiko almost never received openly.

Mizuki realized suddenly:

Skugga had likely watched Friedhelm for years.

Maybe longer.

That same continuation.

That same impossible persistence through fragmentation.

Before anyone could speak again—

the forest changed.

Completely.

Every fox vanished.

Instantly.

Snow stopped moving.

The bells ceased.

And pressure descended hard enough several guards collapsed to their knees choking.

Kurohiko reached for a weapon automatically despite clearly understanding it was useless.

Mizuki stiffened violently.

Because something immense had arrived.

Then Eirvorr appeared.

Massive.

Still.

So impossibly still he resembled a monument more than a living being.

Black antlers stretched upward through dead branches.

Four pale eyes looked down at the procession without blinking.

Dark robes remained motionless despite the moving air.

Frost spread slowly beneath his feet.

His hands looked faintly stained red.

Not fresh blood.

Old permanence.

The guards could barely breathe near him.

Not fear alone.

Inevitability.

Like gravity itself had become conscious.

Eirvorr did not greet them.

Did not acknowledge the militia.

Did not look at Skugga.

Immediately:

> “Where is Sukuna?”

The words struck the forest like impact.

Several militia members visibly panicked.

Because the god had expected Sukuna specifically.

Tsukihiko answered carefully.

> “He remained in life.”

Eirvorr reacted immediately.

Not anger.

Annoyance.

Disappointment.

Like arriving late to something important.

Mizuki understood first.

The god did not care about:

the procession.
the baptisms.
the wards.

Only Sukuna.

And suddenly that terrified him more than everything else tonight.

Because it meant Sukuna was becoming mythologically important.

Not politically.
Not spiritually.

Cosmically.

Eirvorr spoke once more.

Flatly:

> “Troublesome.”

Then stepped forward.

Not through the threshold.

Through the boundary itself.

Reality tore.

The separation between Life and Death bent around him like weak fabric.

The guards screamed.

One militia member vomited instantly.

Because the boundary was supposed to matter.

Gods were not supposed to cross that way.

But Eirvorr simply entered Life as though the distinction did not apply to him at all.

Then he was gone.

Silence crashed down afterward.

Several guards collapsed completely.

Breathing returned unevenly.

The foxfire slowly reignited between the reeds.

Snow resumed drifting upward.

And Skugga remained entirely calm.

Almost amused.

Kurohiko finally managed hoarsely:

> “Why does a god want Otōsan?”

Skugga smiled softly.

Foxfire drifted around his robes.

> “Because Sukuna keeps doing impossible things.”

A fox brushed silently against his sleeve.

> “He entered Death.”

Another pause.

> “And returned himself.”

His golden eyes gleamed faintly.

> “Most beings change when touched by endings.”

Then quieter:

> “Your father refuses endings incorrectly.”

The fox bell chimed softly in Tsukihiko’s hand.

And suddenly every person there understood the same terrible thing at once:

the gods were no longer merely watching their family.

They were beginning to move toward it personally.

The Crisis Part XIII - Eirvorr

Rain hammered the estate hard enough to blur the edges of the world.

Blood and mud ran together through the courtyard channels.

Bodies still lay beneath hastily thrown coverings.

The eastern wing remained sealed behind layered wards that pulsed faintly silver beneath the storm.

And Sukuna stood alone outside it.

Motionless.

Watching.

Listening.

Waiting for something else to try touching what belonged to him.

The estate no longer felt like a home.

It felt like a wound holding itself shut.

Leora was gone.

Friedhelm was gone.

And for the first time in longer than he cared to measure, Sukuna could feel something inside himself beginning to come apart around the absence.

Not grief.

Something worse.

Disorientation.

He kept expecting her to appear beside him.

To hear her voice.

To feel her fingers against his robes.

But every corridor remained empty.

Every doorway stayed wrong.

And the more time passed, the more certain he became of something horrifying:

he could feel the shape she left behind.

The rain shifted.

Not physically.

Existentially.

Sukuna noticed immediately.

The storm sounds dulled.

The wind stopped touching the trees.

Even the distant screams and movement from the estate seemed suddenly far away.

Then the temperature dropped.

Fast.

Frost spread slowly across the stone beneath Sukuna's feet.

And blood began dripping from nowhere.

One drop.

Then another.

Dark red striking pale stone.

Sukuna looked up slowly.

Did not move.

Did not tense.

But something inside him sharpened instantly.

Predatory.

Interested.

Dangerous.

The shadows ahead deepened unnaturally.

Then split apart.

Not like a doorway opening.

Like reality itself reluctantly allowing passage.

Something stepped through.

Tall.

Massive.

Wrong in ways the human mind was never meant to fully arrange.

Black skin.

Long dark robes untouched by rain or wind.

Massive stag antlers branching upward like dead winter trees.

Blood dripped slowly from both hands.

And where eyes should have been—

four pale flames hovered instead.

They moved independently.

Watching too much at once.

Sukuna stared at him.

And immediately understood two things.

The first:

this thing could destroy almost anything it wished.

The second:

it reminded him of himself.

Not visually.

Emotionally.

The stillness.

The certainty.

The unbearable pressure of something that did not need to prove it could kill.

For a long moment neither of them spoke.

Rain continued falling around them but never seemed to touch the figure fully.

Then Sukuna asked flatly:

> “Who are you?”

The flames shifted toward him together.

Focused.

Interested.

The figure tilted his head slightly.

Then said:

> “Your focus is less.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed immediately.

Because the statement did not feel observational.

It felt intimate.

Like this thing had looked directly into him and found missing pieces.

The figure slowly looked around the courtyard.

Past the shattered walls.

Past the blood.

Past the eastern wing.

Expectant.

Searching.

Then finally asked:

> “Where is the Vetrbrúð?”

Sukuna stared at him.

> “Clarify.”

For the first time, something almost pleased entered the creature’s posture.

Then he answered simply:

> “Leora.”

>

> “The Vetrbrúð.”

>

> “My winter bride.”

Something cold slid down Sukuna's spine.

Not jealousy.

Recognition.

Because he knew that tone.

Knew it instinctively.

Not lust.

Not worship.

Chosen fixation.

The kind of attention that reorganized itself permanently around one existence.

This god spoke about Leora the same way Sukuna thought about her.

As though her existence itself had become structurally important.

Sukuna's jaw tightened slightly.

Rainwater slid down his face.

Then he said:

> "She is gone."

The flames stilled.

The frost spread further outward.

For one suspended moment the world itself seemed to wait.

Then the figure answered:

> "No."

Absolute certainty.

Not comfort.

Not reassurance.

Fact.

> "She is not gone."

Sukuna's attention sharpened dangerously.

The figure continued calmly:

> “She is... in Helheim.”

And suddenly annoyance crossed his expression.

Not sorrow.

Irritation.

As though Leora’s current location represented an inconvenience.

A complication.

Somewhere difficult even for gods.

The realization unsettled Sukuna more than he wanted to admit.

Because this thing was speaking about crossing worlds the way one might discuss retrieving an object misplaced in another room.

Then the figure looked back at him fully.

The pale flames narrowed slightly.

And he asked, almost casually:

> “Do you want me to retrieve her for you?”

The courtyard went completely silent.

Even the rain seemed quieter.

And Sukuna—

for one catastrophic second—

actually considered it.

Not because he trusted this being.

Not because he understood him.

But because the absence inside himself had already become unbearable enough that the offer reached something instinctive and violent in him immediately.

Of course he wanted her returned.

Of course the world should give her back.

The realization hit him like a blade between the ribs.

Because this god understood that impulse without explanation.

Understood Sukuna specifically.

Sukuna stared at him for a long moment.

Then asked quietly:

> “Why do you care?”

The flames flickered softly.

And the creature smiled.

Inhumanly.

Beautifully.

Terribly.

> “Because permanence notices itself.”

The frost climbed higher across the courtyard stones.

Blood continued dripping slowly from his hands.

Then, softer:

> “And because she always remains.”

The flames shifted again.

Watching Sukuna too carefully.

> “My bride.”

>

> “And yours.”

Something inside Sukuna lurched violently at the words.

Not because they offended him.

Because they felt true in ways he did not want examined.

The creature before him understood attachment the same way he did:

not as affection.

As inevitability.

As structural permanence.

As something the world itself reorganized around once formed.

And suddenly Sukuna realized something far worse than gods merely watching their family.

They were becoming emotionally invested in it.

In Leora.

In the children.

In Friedhelm.

In him.

The figure stood motionless beneath the storm.

Antlers disappearing into darkness.

Blood dripping steadily from open hands.

Frost consuming the courtyard inch by inch.

And Sukuna stared back at something ancient enough to understand him completely.

Which, somehow,

felt more dangerous than hatred ever could have.

The Crisis Part XIV - Eirvorr Part II

The storm did not ease.

If anything, it thickened—pressing down on the courtyard like a held breath that refused to release.

Eirvorr stood still after speaking.

Too still.

As if even rage, for him, required permission to exist.

Then he spoke again, voice flat with something that had begun to sharpen underneath it.

> “It does not matter what you say.”

The pale flames in his eye sockets flickered once.

> “I will retrieve Vetrbrúð.”

A pause.

The frost at his feet spread further, creeping into cracks in the stone.

> “I will retrieve Heilsundr.”

The second name landed heavier than the first.

Not just Leora.

Something broader.

Something that included Friedhelm in the same conceptual weight.

As if both of them had become a single category of importance in the structure of whatever Eirvorr governed.

Sukuna’s gaze narrowed slightly.

Not in resistance.

In assessment.

Because that was not a promise spoken emotionally.

It was a declaration of inevitability.

Then—

Eirvorr stopped.

Completely.

The shift was immediate.

The frost halted mid-spread.

Even the rain above them seemed to hesitate for a fraction of a second too long.

His head turned slowly.

Toward the edge of the training yard.

Sukuna followed his gaze.

And saw it.

Strands of hair.

Caught in broken stone and snapped wood.

Long.

Silver-dark.

Stained.

Almost invisible at first—until you realized how wrong it was for it to be there at all.

Eirvorr's expression changed.

Not gradually.

Instantly.

Rage did not build in him.

It arrived.

Whole.

Complete.

Like something that had always been waiting behind stillness.

> "Who cut her hair?"

His voice was quiet.

But the air around it tightened.

Sukuna exhaled slowly through his nose.

Not answering immediately.

Because he understood the implication.

Hair was not just damage.

It was violation after survival.

It was aftermath made visible.

Eirvorr lifted one hand.

The strands lifted from the stone without wind.

Without touch.

They drifted into his palm as if reality itself was reluctant to refuse him.

He looked down at them.

Very still.

Then—

> “They tried to dismember her.”

The words were not spoken with question.

They were spoken as confirmation of something already unacceptable.

> “They touched her.”

The hair vanished.

Not burned.

Not destroyed.

Simply... removed from existence as if it had never been permitted to remain.

Eirvorr’s voice lowered further.

Dangerously calm now.

> “They actually touched her.”

A long pause.

Then he turned his head slightly—like listening to something beyond the estate.

Something Sukuna could not hear.

> “Tsukihiko is returning.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed again.

Eirvorr’s attention returned to him.

And for the first time, something like instruction entered his tone.

Not advice.

Not warning.

A fact being placed into Sukuna's hands whether he accepted it or not.

> "When I bring Vetrbrúð back,"

A pause.

The flames in his eyes dimmed slightly, focusing.

> "expect more men who believe they own her."

Silence.

Rain.

Frost.

Blood.

Then Eirvorr added, almost absently—like he was noting a structural flaw in a building:

> "They will not stop trying."

His gaze drifted once more toward the estate.

Not looking at destruction.

Looking past it.

As if already seeing what would come after.

And Sukuna realized something with cold clarity:

this was not a rescue being offered.

It was a recalibration of the world.

Because whatever had touched Leora—

had just become relevant to something that did not understand restraint.

The Crisis Part XV

Tsukihiko returned the way he always did when something had gone wrong beyond correction.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

But wrong in a way the body could not fully hide.

The moment his presence crossed the threshold of the estate, Sukuna felt it—like a thread pulled taut snapping back into place.

He was there.

And he was *wrong*.

Rain clung to him. Mud streaked across his sleeves. Blood—old and new—darkened the edges of his wrappings where he had re-secured them himself, too tightly, too quickly. His breathing was controlled, but only just. The kind of control that only existed because it had to.

Sukuna was already moving before anyone else reacted.

He reached Tsukihiko in a few steps and caught him at the waist.

Firm.

Anchoring.

Tsukihiko stiffened immediately.

> “I am fine.”

It was automatic.

Reflexive.

A refusal more than a statement.

He tried to push off Sukuna’s grip.

But his legs betrayed him for a fraction too long.

That fraction was enough.

Sukuna tightened his hold.

Not forceful.

Just absolute.

Tsukihiko’s jaw clenched.

A flicker of frustration crossed his face—sharp, almost offended—like his body had dared to contradict his authority.

Then something in him shifted.

Not surrender.

Adjustment.

He allowed a small portion of the weight to settle back into Sukuna's support, just enough to remain standing without collapsing outright.

> "We finish the wards," Tsukihiko said hoarsely.

It was not a request.

It was continuation.

As if falling had never been part of the equation.

Sukuna did not argue.

He simply matched his pace.

And together they moved through the estate's bones.

● THE WARDS BEFORE NIGHTFALL

The work was precise.

Deliberate.

Tsukihiko directed everything with a voice that grew steadier the longer he spoke—like motion itself was what kept him intact.

He pointed.

He assigned.

He corrected.

He did not hesitate even when his hand shook slightly between gestures.

Mizuki and Kurohiko worked beside him without question.

The militia followed orders without needing explanation now. Something in Tsukihiko had made resistance feel like ignorance rather than choice.

Sukuna stayed close.

Not leading.

Not commanding.

Simply there when Tsukihiko's balance faltered for a breath too long.

A hand at his back.

A shift in position.

A silent correction of gravity.

Tsukihiko never thanked him.

But he never pulled away either.

● THE DISMISSAL

By the time the last ward was set, the sky had begun to deepen.

The estate's boundaries now felt... thicker.

Not safer.

But defined.

Like something had been drawn in blood and bone into the world itself.

Tsukihiko stood at the center of it for a long moment.

Still.

Calculating.

Then he turned to the militia.

> "You are dismissed."

No ceremony.

No softness.

But something in the way he said it made it final in a way authority rarely achieves.

The men hesitated.

Tsukihiko's gaze sharpened.

> "Go."

That was enough.

They moved.

Servants were already waiting with supplies—bundled food, medicine, cloth, coin. Enough to return them to villages that still existed, or rebuild what did not.

Tsukihiko had already accounted for it.

As if even crisis had logistics.

As if grief still required administration.

Mizuki lingered only long enough to ensure the wounded were stable.

Kurohiko remained until the last instruction was acknowledged.

Then—

they were gone.

The estate exhaled.

● AFTER

Silence returned in layers.

Not peace.

Just absence of motion.

Tsukihiko stood for a moment longer than necessary.

Then his shoulders lowered by a fraction.

Not visibly.

But enough.

The exhaustion that had been delayed finally found its place in him.

Sukuna noticed immediately.

> “Tsukihiko.”

No answer.

Tsukuna stepped closer.

Tsukihiko tried to straighten.
Failed halfway through the motion.
And that was the moment it happened.
Not collapse.
Not dramatic fall.
Just the body finally refusing to continue pretending.
Tsukihiko dropped to one knee first.
Then caught himself with a hand against the ground.
Breathing uneven.
Controlled—
but breaking at the edges.
Sukuna was there instantly.
Not letting him fall further.
Tsukihiko's head tilted slightly downward.
Eyes still open.
Still conscious.
Still trying.
> "Don't... interfere," he muttered.
But there was no force behind it now.
Only habit.
Sukuna held him anyway.
And for the first time, Tsukihiko did not resist.

The Crisis Part XVI

The infirmary was quiet in the way only places meant for suffering could ever be quiet.

No wind came through the shutters.

No servants lingered longer than necessary.

Even the lamps burned low, as if reluctant to witness too much.

Tsukihiko lay still beneath Sukuna's hands.

Too still for someone like him.

That was the first wrongness Sukuna noticed—not the blood, not the torn fabric, not the shallow bruising mapped across bone and muscle like territorial lines.

It was the absence of motion.

As if Tsukihiko had finally been forced to stop becoming anything at all.

Sukuna cleaned him anyway.

Methodically.

Without haste.

Warm water, cloth, pressure applied exactly where it needed to be applied. Wrapping wounds. Binding fractures. Replacing torn dressings with steady precision that did not match the violence of what Tsukihiko had endured.

If someone had walked in, they might have mistaken it for something gentle.

Domestic.

Even intimate.

As if Tsukuna were tending a sleeping child instead of a boy who could still, faintly, bend the edge of Death itself.

Tsukuna's hands did not shake.

But his thoughts did.

They kept returning—uninvited, relentless—to a version of Tsukihiko that no longer existed in this room, but still lived somewhere under his skin.

Small once.

Quiet in a way that was never weakness.

The child who watched Sukuna too closely.

Who followed emotion like a thread through a collapsing world.

Who never flinched from him.

Never feared him.

That had always unsettled Sukuna more than fear ever could.

Because fear was simple.

Understanding was not.

Tsukuna tightened the bandage around Tsukihiko's ribs.

Friedhelm's mirror.

That thought arrived unbidden.

And Sukuna paused for half a breath longer than he meant to.

Because yes—there it was again.

That same structure of presence.

That same terrifying clarity.

Friedhelm had restraint like containment.

Tsukihiko had restraint like judgment.

And somewhere between them both—

Leora.

The axis they did not admit they revolved around.

Sukuna's hand stopped at Tsukihiko's shoulder for a moment longer than necessary.

Warm.

Alive.

Barely.

And suddenly the thought arrived with no softness at all:

Was this my doing?

Not as accusation.

As calculation.

Tsukuna looked down at him properly now.

At the damage.

At the exhaustion layered beneath it.

At the way Tsukihiko's body had clearly continued functioning long after it should have failed.

Half curse.

The phrase returned with new weight.

Not as strength.

As exception.

As survival that had learned to tolerate injury instead of ending.

Sukuna's jaw tightened.

Because he could see it now, if he let himself.

The shape of what Tsukihiko had inherited.

Not just blood.

Not just lineage.

But pressure.

Expectation.

The impossible architecture of everyone around him refusing to fall apart.

Leora refusing to break.

Friedhelm refusing to end.

Sukuna refusing to lose anything he had claimed as his own.

And Tsukihiko—

Tsukihiko becoming the thing that held all of it together when everything else collapsed.

Sukuna reached for fresh cloth again.

Cleaned blood from Tsukihiko's hands more carefully than before.

And for the first time, something unpleasant twisted in his chest.

Not guilt.

Sukuna did not have guilt in the way most people did.

It was recognition.

A cold, invasive understanding that did not ask permission to exist:

If I am the center of their orbit... then I am also the weight that bends them.

He tied the final wrap at Tsukihiko's wrist.

Fingers lingering there for a fraction too long.

Tsukihiko's breathing shifted slightly in sleep.

Not waking.

Just reacting.

Even unconscious, still responsive to him.

That alone made something in Sukuna's expression sharpen.

Not softened.

Not softened at all.

Sharpened.

Because it confirmed what he was afraid to fully name:

They did not merely endure him.

They were shaped by him.

And Leora—

Leora, who never stepped away even when she should have.

Who did not present herself as fragile.

Who instead rearranged everything around her until even Sukuna had begun to forget where he ended and she began.

Sukuna's gaze drifted briefly to the doorway.

Imagining her absence again.

The estate without her presence bending its air.

The silence that followed her not as peace—

but as rupture.

His hand tightened slightly on Tsukihiko's blanket.

And the thought surfaced, sharper now:

Did I choose her... or did I ruin what would have been whole without me?

He exhaled slowly through his nose.

A controlled sound.

Almost irritation.

But it did not dissipate the weight in his chest.

It only clarified it.

Tsukihiko shifted faintly again, and Sukuna adjusted the blanket immediately—precise, practiced, immediate.

Then he stopped.

Looked at him properly.

At the son.

At what had been built.

At what had been survived.

And something in Sukuna's mind settled into an uncomfortable stillness.

Not resolution.

Understanding.

Because whatever blame existed here—it was not clean enough to assign to one person.

It was structural.

It was inherited.

It was chosen.

It was repeated.

And still—

Sukuna stayed.

His hand remained at Tsukihiko's side until the breathing evened out again.

Until the body beneath his care stopped resisting existence.

Only then did he finally sit back.

And in the quiet infirmary, Sukuna allowed himself a thought he would not speak aloud:

If this is what I have built... then I will also decide what survives it.

The Crisis Part XVII - Infirmary and loss

Sukuna left and went to his chambers.

Leora's things were everywhere.

Her outer robes folded carelessly over the cedar chair by the window.

Hair ribbons.

Books stacked beside the bed.

The fox bell cord she'd replaced twice because she disliked the color of the first one.

Her brush still held strands of silver-white hair.

The room smelled like her.

Moonflower oil.

Smoke.

Cold air.

Something sweet beneath it.

Sukuna stood motionless for a long time.

Then crossed the room slowly and sat on her side of the bed.

The blankets still held warmth faintly trapped inside them.

That almost destroyed him immediately.

He laid down before he fully realized he was doing it.

Then grabbed her pillow violently and forced his face into it, breathing in deeply.

Once.

Again.

Again.

As though he could pull her back through scent alone.

And then—

a sound tore from him.

Sharp.

Choking.

Wrong.

Sukuna froze afterward in horror at himself.

His hand clenched so tightly in the pillow fabric it ripped slightly beneath his claws.

A life without Leora.

The thought would not settle correctly in his mind.

It rejected structure.

Rejected reality.

How was he supposed to exist in a world where she did not?

Who would walk beside him?

Who would look at him like he was something easy?

Who would shove him against walls smiling like a fox spirit before ruining his self-control deliberately?

Who would tug at his sleeves?

Steal bites from his plate?

Laugh at him?

Fight beside him?

Sleep against him?

Who would understand the worst parts of him and stay anyway?

And worse—

would he really never touch her again?

Would he never kiss her again?

The thought made something in his chest twist so violently he pressed harder into the pillow like he could suffocate the feeling.

Eirvorr's voice echoed in his skull.

> "She is not gone."

And Friedhelm—

Friedhelm had taken her somewhere.

Somewhere Sukuna could not follow.

For the first time in centuries, Sukuna had been left behind.

Powerless.

Unable to reach what belonged beside him.

Then—

a quiet sound behind him.

A throat clearing.

Sukuna sat upright instantly.

Chōbei stood in the doorway.

He looked horrific.

Not physically.

Emotionally.

His eyes were bloodshot.

Hair disheveled.

Clothes damp.

And the expression on his face looked dangerously close to collapse.

For once, Chōbei did not smirk.

Did not tease.

Did not provoke.

He just stood there breathing heavily like remaining upright required effort.

Sukuna rose slowly.

Neither spoke.

They simply looked at each other.

And suddenly Sukuna understood exactly why Chōbei came here instead of anywhere else.

Because there was only one other person in the estate who understood what it felt like to have your entire internal world suddenly hanging by a thread tied to someone else's survival.

Sukuna motioned silently toward the hall.

Chōbei followed immediately.

Neither spoke while walking through the darkened corridors.

Rain hammered against the estate roof.

Distant patrol bells echoed outside.

The infirmary doors slid open quietly.

Tsukihiko still slept.

Bandaged heavily.

Pale.

Breathing shallow but steady.

The second Chōbei saw him—

he broke.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

Worse.

Silently.

He crossed the room too fast and dropped beside the bedding hard enough the floor shook faintly.

Then grabbed Tsukihiko's hand in both of his like he thought someone might try taking it away.

And immediately started kissing it.

His knuckles.

His fingers.

His wrist.

Again.

Again.

Again.

Like devotion had replaced oxygen.

Sukuna stood near the doorway watching.

Chōbei pressed his forehead against Tsukihiko's palm and finally made a broken sound in the back of his throat.

Small.

Ruined.

Sukuna looked away instinctively.

Because suddenly all he could think was:

> Would he really never kiss Leora again?

The thought struck so hard his stomach twisted.

Leora smiling against his mouth.

Leora half asleep reaching for his wrist.

Leora kissing him with sharp little bites because she enjoyed watching him lose control.

Leora alive.

Warm.

Whole.

And then—

hair hanging from trees.

Her body barely attached together.

Blood everywhere.

The missing ear.

The missing scalp.

Sukuna shut his eyes briefly.

Across the room Chōbei whispered hoarsely:

> “He was yelling at me earlier.”

Another kiss pressed desperately against Tsukihiko’s hand.

> “Bossing everybody around.”

A laugh escaped him.

Broken straight through.

> “Threatening guards.”

His shoulders shook once violently.

> “And now look at him.”

Sukuna said nothing.

Because there was nothing to say.

After a long silence, Chōbei finally looked up.

His eyes were vicious with grief.

> “What the fuck happened to us?”

Sukuna looked at Tsukihiko.

At Friedhelm’s face sleeping beneath Leora’s eyes.

At the pieces of himself hidden inside the boy too.

Then answered quietly:

> “We became attached.”

Chōbei laughed sharply through his nose.

Miserable.

> “Yeah.”

> “Great fucking idea.”

Then silence again.

Heavy.

Unbearable.

Finally Chōbei asked quietly:

> “You think they’re alive?”

Sukuna should have lied.

Instead he remembered Eirvorr.

> *She is not gone.*

And somehow—

despite everything—

the world still felt like Leora existed somewhere inside it.

Far away.

But present.

Like reality itself still bent slightly around her.

So Sukuna answered honestly.

> “Yes.”

Chōbei lowered his head again immediately.

Another kiss against Tsukihiko’s wrist.

Then quietly:

> “If Tsukihiko dies...”

His voice broke completely.

He stopped speaking.

He didn't need to continue.

Sukuna understood anyway.

And for the first time since the nightmare began—

the room became quiet enough for both men to realize something terrible:

Neither of them knew how to survive this family anymore if the people they loved stopped returning to them.

The Crisis Part XVIII - Death's River

Death was quieter here.

Not empty.

Never empty.

But deep.

Ancient.

The kind of silence that existed beneath oceans and inside tombs.

Silver-black water moved endlessly through the vast river basin of Helheim, carrying moonlight that did not belong to any sky humanity had ever seen.

The river flowed around two sleeping bodies carefully.

Protectively.

As though Death itself understood they were not to be touched roughly.

Leora lay half-submerged in the glowing current.

Friedhelm beside her.

Their bodies were ruined.

Even now.

Even after Eirvorr retrieved them.

Leora's limbs had been reattached imperfectly by immortality struggling desperately against catastrophic damage.

Skin knit slowly together beneath silver light.

Bone regrew in pale branching structures beneath translucent flesh.

Her missing scalp threaded itself back strand by strand as moonlight spun through her hair like patient fingers weaving silk.

But the bruises remained.

Deep.

Violent.

Hand-shaped.

Finger-shaped.

Marks left by things that had touched her.

Eirvorr hated them.

He stood knee-deep in the river watching silently.

His true form towered darkly against the endless death-water.

Antlers disappearing upward into drifting frost.

Four pale flames burned where eyes should have been.

Then Leora stirred weakly in her tiefgeschlof.

Anxious.

Even unconscious, her body searched.

Reached.

Distressed.

Eirvorr watched her for a long moment.

Then slowly—

his form changed.

The antlers receded.

The black skin smoothed into pearlescent darkness.

Four flames became four familiar eyes.

Ryomen Sukuna stood at the river's edge.

Perfectly replicated.

Almost.

Eirvorr leaned down carefully and touched Leora's face.

Immediately—

she moved toward the hand instinctively.

Like a flower bending toward sunlight.

And something ancient and terrible softened inside Eirvorr at once.

Beside her, Friedhelm whimpered faintly.

Even unconscious, he reached immediately.

His hand found Leora's wrist.

Her arm.

Their legs pressed together beneath the silver current.

Bodies seeking contact automatically.

Like separation itself caused pain now.

Eirvorr looked down at them both silently.

Then sighed.

The bruising along Leora's jaw displeased him profoundly.

His fingers brushed lightly against it.

Moonlight gathered there instantly.

Repairing.

Reweaving.

Above them hung the anomaly moon.

Not the human moon.

Something older.

A pale impossible celestial body only visible within certain regions of Death.

Its light threaded slowly through Leora's hair, knitting silver strands back into existence one by one.

Beautiful.

Fragile.

Wrongly harmed.

Eirvorr touched her lips gently with Sukuna's borrowed hand.

Then—

foxfire bloomed across the river.

Soft gold lights drifted through the reeds.

The water warmed faintly.

Skugga appeared smiling.

Foxes moved around his robes endlessly.

White.

Silver.

Black-shadowed.

Their paws skimmed the river surface without sinking.

Skugga took one look at Eirvorr wearing Sukuna's form and laughed softly.

> "You've fallen hard."

Eirvorr said nothing.

Did not deny it.

Which amused Skugga even more.

His attention drifted toward the sleeping pair.

Toward the matching wrist holds.

Toward the way Friedhelm unconsciously curled protectively around Leora despite his own catastrophic injuries.

Then Skugga smiled warmly.

> “You made a child for your One-Eye and Moon Prince.”

Still Eirvorr remained silent.

Skugga moved first toward Friedhelm.

And the entire atmosphere around him changed immediately.

Softer.

Fonder.

Like returning home.

He crouched within the river and gently smoothed a hand through Friedhelm’s pale hair.

Friedhelm relaxed instantly beneath the touch.

Even unconscious.

Skugga’s expression became unbearably affectionate.

Too ancient to hide emotion correctly.

> “I have always loved this one the best.”

Eirvorr scoffed quietly.

> “Love.”

Skugga glanced sideways at him.

Foxfire drifted lazily around his shoulders.

> “They continue and they transform.”

> “They finish things and become inevitable.”

His fingers moved carefully through Friedhelm’s hair again.

> “I think it is acceptable to have feelings for creatures as magnificent and unique as them.”

Then Skugga leaned down and pressed a kiss gently against Friedhelm’s forehead.

The river brightened softly beneath them.

Friedhelm's damaged ribs shifted audibly beneath healing flesh.

Silver bloomed beneath his skin like roots.

Skugga sat back afterward and smiled knowingly toward Eirvorr.

> "You keep wearing his skin because ultimately you want her to notice you."

A pause.

Then, delighted:

> "And join you in eternity."

Eirvorr turned away immediately.

Which only made Skugga laugh harder.

The sound echoed strangely through Death.

Not mocking.

Fond.

Eirvorr stood motionless at the river edge staring into black water.

But his borrowed appearance flickered subtly.

Sukuna's face shifting unevenly beneath something older.

Something less human.

Behind him, Leora stirred again.

And this time—

her fingers reached weakly toward him.

Toward Sukuna's shape.

Eirvorr froze completely.

The river around them deepened into silver moonstone spirals.

And slowly—

very slowly—

the sleeping pair began to change.

Not just heal.

Change.

Leora's regrown hair shimmered unnaturally beneath the death-moon.

Silver strands threaded now with faint lines of black.

Her blood moved differently beneath her skin.

Ancient.

Colder.

And Friedhelm—

Friedhelm's fox-shadow stretched beneath the river independently now.

Too large.

Too alive.

Foxfire gathered beneath his closed eyelids.

Skugga watched with visible delight.

> "Ah."

The foxes around him lifted their heads simultaneously.

> "There it is."

Eirvorr finally spoke quietly.

Still facing away.

> "They crossed too deeply."

Skugga smiled.

> "No."

A fox curled beside Friedhelm's shoulder.

> "They were always going to become this."

Skugga watched the sleeping pair for a very long time.

Foxfire drifted lazily around the river.

The moon above Helheim pulsed softly through silver fog.

And beneath the water, Leora and Friedhelm continued changing.

Not quickly.

Not violently.

Inevitably.

Their souls had crossed too deeply into Death.

The river recognized them now.

Wanted them.

The foxes gathered closer around Friedhelm.

One curled beside his throat.

Another rested near Leora's shoulder where her hair floated through the current like woven moonlight.

Skugga smiled softly.

Almost wistfully.

> "If we let it happen..."

His fingers traced idly through the black water.

Silver roots bloomed beneath the surface.

> "They will remain with us forever."

Eirvorr stood motionless at the river edge.

The dark robes around him did not move despite the current.

He looked down at Leora.

At the bruises fading slowly from her skin.

At the instinctive way she kept reaching unconsciously toward Sukuna's stolen shape.

And for one dangerous moment—

he considered it.

Keeping them.

Not as prisoners.

Not even as stolen things.

Simply...

remaining.

Permanent.

The river would hold them gently forever.

No more pain.

No more mortal fear.

No more men trying to tear them apart.

Leora made a soft distressed sound in her sleep.

Tiny.

Broken.

Eirvorr looked at her immediately.

Then he remembered.

Her children.

The way her entire being bent instinctively toward them.

Toward Kohaku.

Toward Tsukihiko.

Toward Kaguya.

Toward all the strange wounded creatures she gathered endlessly against herself.

And worse—

he remembered Sukuna.

Not merely that she loved him.

That she chose him.

Despite what he was.

Despite what he would become.

She chose.

And once Leora chose something—

she orbited it completely.

Friedhelm too.

Both of them anchored themselves around Sukuna like moons around inevitability itself.

And around that center—

they grew.

Changed.

Continued.

Eirvorr finally spoke.

Quietly.

Absolutely.

> “No.”

The river stilled instantly.

Eirvorr reached back into the silver current.

His hand slid gently beneath Leora’s hair.

> “It is not her time.”

Then lower:

> “Vetrbríð and Heilsundr must return.”

Skugga’s smile widened immediately.

Delighted.

Warmly approving.

> “Wise.”

Foxfire brightened softly around him.

He looked down at Friedhelm again with unbearable fondness.

Like something ancient already mourning a future separation.

Then Skugga leaned down.

And kissed Friedhelm's lips so softly it felt almost sacred.

A blessing.

A promise.

A claim that required no ownership.

Friedhelm exhaled faintly in his sleep.

Foxfire flickered beneath his skin.

Skugga smiled against his mouth for one lingering second before pulling away.

> "I will wait for this one."

No fear existed in the statement.

Only certainty.

Then Eirvorr threaded his fingers slowly through Leora's half-regrown hair.

Silver strands wrapped around his wrist instinctively.

The death-moon brightened overhead.

And for the first time—

Eirvorr's expression softened into something almost human.

Almost longing.

> "And I shall have her when the time is right."

The river deepened around them.

Silver.

Moonstone.

Black.

And somewhere far above Death—

in the world of the living—

Sukuna suddenly woke with Leora's name caught violently in his throat.

The Crisis Part XVIII

Sukuna woke violently.

Not slowly.

Not confused.

Ripped upward from sleep like something had hooked into his spine and dragged him breathing back into the world.

His chest heaved once.

Then again.

Rain hammered outside the estate.

Cold air moved faintly through the chamber screens.

And for one terrible second—

he did not know where he was.

Only what he saw.

Leora.

Broken in the mud.

Her body barely assembled correctly.

Blood flooding the training yard stones.

And him—

standing there looking down at her coldly.

The memory struck harder this time.

Sharper.

Because now he understood what he had actually done.

He had not recognized her.

Sukuna sat motionless on the edge of the bed.

Breathing too slowly.

Too carefully.

Trying to force the memory back apart.

But it would not separate.

He remembered stepping around her.

Like she was another casualty.

Another ruined body.

Another dying thing.

Not special.

Not hers.

Not his.

Only when she looked at him—

only then—

had curiosity even entered him.

Curiosity.

The realization made something inside Sukuna recoil violently.

How had he not known?

How?

His hand slammed against the bedframe hard enough to splinter wood.

But even that barely touched the rising horror underneath.

The woman who bore him five children.

The woman who had spent decades beside him.

Lover.

Wife.

Companion.

The one person whose body he knew more thoroughly than his own.

He knew the shape of her breathing in sleep.

The exact weight of her against his chest.

The texture of her hair after rain.

The scars on her hips.

The sound she made before laughing.

The way her heartbeat changed when frightened.

He knew every inch of her.

And still—

he had looked directly at her and failed.

The thought hollowed him out instantly.

Sukuna pressed both hands hard against his face.

Not from grief.

Something uglier.

Because this felt like failure on a level he did not know how to survive.

If Leora had looked at him like that—

if he had crawled bleeding toward her—

she would have known him instantly.

Even dismembered.

Even burned.

Even half-dead.

She would have known.

And he—

he had stared at her like she was ordinary.

Rain thundered outside.

Sukuna suddenly remembered the look in her eyes.

Not fear.

Not confusion.

Recognition.

Even like that.

Even torn apart.

She looked at him and still knew him immediately.

That realization finally broke something.

A choking sound tore from his throat before he could stop it.

Raw.

Animal.

He bent forward sharply, gripping the edge of the bed hard enough his claws cut into the wood.

His mind replayed it endlessly now.

Leora lifting her head.

Those blue eyes.

Blood in her mouth.

And him not understanding what he was seeing.

How long had she laid there before he realized?

How long had she looked at him while he failed to know her?

Sukuna suddenly understood something unbearable:

if she truly died—

that would be the final memory between them.

Not warmth.

Not love.

Not holding her.

Not kissing her.

This.

Her broken in the mud while he stared down at her like a stranger.

The room felt wrong suddenly.

Too large.

Too empty.

Leora's brush still sat near the mirror.

One of her robes hung folded near the screen divider.

Her presence remained everywhere except where it mattered.

Sukuna looked toward the empty side of the bed.

And for the first time since meeting her—

he understood what it meant to fear himself.

The Crisis Part XX

Chōbei rocked Kohaku carefully against his chest while staring at Tsukihiko.

The room smelled like medicine.

Rain.

Blood.

And exhaustion so deep it felt woven into the walls.

Tsukihiko had not moved in hours.

Not truly.

Only shallow breathing beneath layers of bandages.

Too still.

Too pale.

Kurohiko had finally said the word neither of them wanted spoken.

> “It’s probably a coma.”

Chōbei hated him for saying it aloud.

Kiyomi rested further down the infirmary hall, barely responsive, eyes half-lidded and unfocused whenever she woke. Kurohiko refused to leave her side for longer than moments at a time.

Sieg handled the atmosphere in the only way a child could.

Poorly.

One minute crying.

The next trying to entertain Kohaku by laying him safely on blankets and dangling carved wooden animals over his head while whispering dramatic battle noises under his breath.

Kohaku occasionally reached for them sleepily.

Higan was worse.

Restless.

Crying constantly.

Searching every doorway.

Every voice.

Every movement.

Looking for Leora.

The servants had finally surrendered and brought him to Chōbei because nobody else could calm him for more than seconds.

Now Higan pressed tearfully into Chōbei’s chest while Kohaku slept against his shoulder.

Two children.

Both warm.

Both alive.

And somehow the sight only made the terror worse.

Chōbei looked toward the rain-streaked window.

Then froze.

Outside—

movement.

White.

Silver.

Black.

Foxes.

Dozens of them.

Not wandering.

Gathering.

Moving quickly through the rain in one direction.

Purposefully.

Every instinct in Chōbei sharpened instantly.

He stood so abruptly Kohaku startled.

Chōbei carefully transferred him to blankets beside Sieg before thrusting Higan toward Kurohiko.

> “Watch him.”

Then toward Sieg:

> “Just keep doin’ what you’re doin’.”

Sieg blinked.

> “...okay.”

But Chōbei was already moving.

He shoved through the infirmary doors and into the rain immediately.

Cold water soaked him within seconds.

The foxes rushed around him.

Past him.

None afraid.

None slowing.

Like they expected him to follow.

And Chōbei did.

Down stone paths slick with rainwater.

Across dark courtyards.

Past lanterns flickering weakly against the storm.

His heart hammered harder the farther he ran.

Because something inside him already knew.

The foxes converged near one of the smaller garden pavilions.

Hidden beneath old trees.

Safe from the rain beneath curved black roofing.

The foxes circled it silently.

Watching.

Waiting.

And there—

under the pavilion—

two bodies lay side by side.

Chōbei stopped so hard his sandals skidded against wet stone.

Leora.

Friedhelm.

For one horrible second they looked dead.

Too still.

Too pale.

Their soaked hair spread beneath them like spilled moonlight and silver ash.

Then Chōbei saw it—

breathing.

Slow.

Deep.

Wrong.

Their bodies had healed.

Technically.

But the healing itself looked unnatural.

Bruises spread everywhere.

Not ordinary bruising.

Deep black-violet marks beneath the skin like the wounds still existed underneath them.

Every finger.

Every hand.

Wrists.

Arms.

Ribs.

Throat.

Legs.

Everywhere they had been touched.

Everywhere violence had reached them.

Friedhelm's body pressed instinctively toward Leora even unconscious.

Their wrists tangled together.

Legs touching.

Like even asleep they refused separation.

And Leora—

Chōbei's stomach turned violently.

Her hair.

It had returned.

Long again.

But uneven in places still.

Moonlight-white strands threaded strangely through silver lengths like they had been woven back together by hands that did not fully understand human bodies.

Foxes crowded around them protectively.

One rested beside Friedhelm's head.

Another curled against Leora's side.

Watching Chōbei calmly.

Not threatening.

Guarding.

Chōbei stepped forward slowly.

Rain hammered the pavilion roof overhead.

Neither of them woke.

But when he crouched beside them—

Leora made a faint sound.

Small.

Distressed.

And Friedhelm's fingers immediately tightened around her wrist harder.

Protective even unconscious.

Chōbei stared at them.

At the bruises.

At the impossible healing.

At the foxes.

And suddenly his entire body went cold.

Because whatever brought them back—

was not human.

The Crisis Part XXI

Chōbei crouched beside them carefully at first.

Trying to think.

Trying to stay rational.

He checked Leora's breathing.

Then Friedhelm's.

Both alive.

Both warm.

Wrongly warm.

Like fever beneath winter skin.

The bruising spread beneath their bodies in impossible patterns, deepening and fading slowly as though whatever restored them had not finished deciding what they should become.

The foxes watched every movement.

Silent.

Golden-eyed.

Waiting to see what he would do.

Chōbei reached for Leora's wrist gently.

And stopped breathing.

Her skin—

everywhere—

was marked.

Not wounds anymore.

Evidence.

Finger-shaped bruises around her arms.

Dark pressure along her throat.

Violence mapped across her body so thoroughly it stopped resembling injury and became something almost unbearable to witness.

His eyes moved lower involuntarily.

Then immediately away.

Because it was too much.

Too intimate.

Too horrific.

Leora and Friedhelm were naked beneath the foxes and moonlight.

Not exposed in any human way.

Ruined.

Restored.

Handled by things beyond people.

Chōbei's breath broke sharply.

He grabbed his own hair hard enough to hurt.

Tears forced themselves out before he could stop them.

He tried to swallow them down.

Failed.

Because every bruise on her made something inside him lose its mind.

Someone touched her.

Someone hurt her.

Someone tried to take her apart.

Leora—

his Leora—

reduced to this beneath cold moonlight while he hid underground with Kohaku.

The thought gutted him.

He suddenly reached for her without thinking.

Pulled her carefully against him.

And kissed her desperately.

Forehead.

Cheek.

Mouth.

Rainwater and tears mixing together.

Immediately several foxes growled sharply.

One snapped at his sleeve.

Another nipped his wrist hard enough to warn.

Protective.

Possessive.

Chōbei barely noticed.

His sobs echoed horribly through the pavilion.

Then he reached for Friedhelm too.

Dragging him gently closer with shaking hands.

Friedhelm instinctively curled toward Leora even unconscious.

Still protecting her.

Still reaching for her.

Chōbei broke completely then.

Because even now—

even destroyed—

they were still trying to hold each other together.

Footsteps splashed through rain.

Tōma appeared beneath the pavilion entrance—

and froze.

His face lost all color instantly.

Eyes widening at the sight before immediately filling with tears.

But unlike Chōbei—

Tōma moved.

Fast.

Useful.

He immediately began stripping off layers of his outer robes with trembling hands.

Voice shaking violently:

> “Let’s get them somewhere warm...”

He dropped beside them carefully, covering Leora first.

Then Friedhelm.

Trying to preserve dignity.

Trying to preserve humanity.

Trying not to look too long at the bruises.

At the marks.

At what had been done to them.

Tōma swallowed hard.

Looked toward Chōbei.

And somehow still managed softly:

> “Clean them up... put them to bed, okay onii-chan?”

The title nearly shattered Chōbei again.

But it anchored him too.

Something to do.

Someone to protect.

Chōbei nodded once roughly.

Then very carefully—

like lifting something sacred—

he slid his arms beneath Leora.

She felt terrifyingly light.

Fragile.

Not weak—

never weak—

but delicate in a way he had never associated with her before.

Her head rolled against his shoulder slightly.

White-silver hair spilling over his arm.

One fox pressed briefly against her hand before retreating.

Tōma watched Chōbei closely.

Saw the way he held her.

Respectfully.

Reverently.

Like if he squeezed too hard she might disappear again.

Then Tōma bent and lifted Friedhelm with the same care.

Friedhelm stirred faintly at movement.

A soft distressed sound escaping him immediately until his hand brushed weakly against Leora's arm.

Only then did he settle.

Tōma's face crumpled seeing it.

The foxes parted around them silently as the brothers carried them through the rain toward the main estate.

Like the forest itself was returning something precious home.

The Crisis Part XXII

They tried not to think.

That became the only way through it.

Not while washing blood from Leora's hair in slow careful motions.

Not while discovering bruises hidden beneath bruises.

Not while Friedhelm whimpered in his sleep every time Leora's hand slipped too far from his own.

Tōma focused on practical things.

Warm water.

Clean cloth.

Dry blankets.

He sent servants away repeatedly until it was only the two of them left.

Only family.

Only people allowed to see them like this.

Clothes had been brought from Friedhelm's wing and from Leora's private chambers—the ones she rarely used because she preferred sleeping elsewhere.

Because she preferred people.

Chōbei dressed her himself.

Carefully.

So carefully it became unbearable to watch.

Tōma would look away to wring out cloths or prepare warming stones and then glance back—and stop breathing.

Because Chōbei handled Leora like she might vanish if touched wrong.

His huge rough hands trembling while fastening ties.

Adjusting sleeves.

Drying strands of silver-white hair one piece at a time.

At one point he became stuck staring at bruising around her wrist.

Completely still.

Tōma had to quietly touch his shoulder to make him continue.

Friedhelm woke several times.

Never fully.

His eyes would open faintly—

disoriented.

Searching.

Not understanding where he was.

But every single time his gaze found either Tōma or Chōbei—

he relaxed instantly.

As though merely recognizing them was enough.

Then he would drift back under.

Once, he weakly reached toward Leora without waking.

Chōbei silently moved their hands together.

Only then did Friedhelm settle again.

The warming stones were wrapped carefully and tucked into the bedding before they finally carried them into Leora's chambers.

The room still smelled like her.

Moonflower oil.

Tea.

Snow-soaked silk.

Sukuna.

Chōbei visibly almost lost composure again stepping inside.

But he kept moving.

They laid Leora down first.

Then Friedhelm beside her.

Immediately—even unconscious—they shifted toward each other.

Wrists touching.

Legs brushing.

Friedhelm pressing instinctively toward her warmth.

Tōma swallowed hard.

Because whatever happened to them—

whatever Death had done—

they still found each other automatically.

Chōbei adjusted the blankets one last time.

Then sat there staring for too long.

Tōma watched him quietly.

Watched the exhaustion in his face.

The devastation.

The tenderness.

Something about it pulled at him strangely.

Finally—

they left.

The doors slid shut softly behind them.

Rain whispered against the estate roof.

The corridor lanterns burned low and gold.

Tōma stopped walking first.

Chōbei took another step before realizing.

Then turned slightly.

Tōma looked pale still.

Emotionally wrung hollow.

But there was something intent in his expression now.

Careful.

Serious.

He stared at Chōbei for a long moment before asking quietly:

> “Do you really love Leora?”

The question landed strangely.

Not accusing.

Not jealous.

Almost confused.

Like Tōma was trying to understand something enormous.

Chōbei stared at him.

Then barked out a rough laugh immediately.

Too fast.

Deflective.

> “What kinda stupid question is that?”

But Tōma didn’t back down.

Didn’t smile.

Didn’t soften it.

> “I’m serious.”

The corridor became very quiet.

Rain.

Distant thunder.

The muffled crackle of brazier fires.

Chōbei's face slowly lost the sharp edge of humor.

Tōma spoke softly now.

Honest in a way only Tōma could be.

> "I've never seen someone look at her the way you do."

A pause.

Then:

> "Not even Sukuna."

That startled Chōbei enough he actually looked at him fully.

Tōma's eyes lowered briefly.

Searching for words.

> "When you thought she was dead..."

His voice shook slightly.

> "You looked like your body didn't know how to stay standing anymore."

Chōbei clicked his tongue hard and looked away immediately.

Jaw flexing.

Uncomfortable.

Exposed.

Tōma continued anyway.

Quietly relentless.

> "And when you dressed her..."

A long silence.

Then:

> "You touched her like she was the most precious thing you'd ever been trusted with."

That one hit.

Hard.

Chōbei scrubbed a hand over his face roughly.

Trying to regain control.

Trying to become himself again.

But exhaustion had worn him too thin tonight.

Finally he muttered:

> “Course I love her.”

Tōma watched him carefully.

And Chōbei laughed once under his breath.

Broken around the edges.

> “That woman ruined my whole damn life.”

But his voice softened immediately after.

Without permission.

Without performance.

> “She walked into it and suddenly everything mattered.”

Tōma’s eyes widened slightly.

Chōbei stared down the dark corridor toward Leora’s chambers.

And for the first time in years—

looked afraid.

Truly afraid.

> “When I saw her like that...”

His voice almost failed.

> “I thought the world was ending.”

Silence stretched between them.

Then Tōma moved forward suddenly and hugged him.

Hard.

Like family.

Like gratitude.

Like relief.

Chōbei froze in shock for exactly one second—
before grabbing him back just as tightly.

The Crisis Part XXIII

Chōbei held Tōma tightly.

One arm wrapped around the back of his head.

The other locked across his shoulders hard enough to feel grounding.

Protective.

Possessive.

Tōma could hear his heartbeat.

Too fast.

Still unstable from everything that had happened.

For a while, Chōbei said nothing.

Just breathed against his hair.

Then finally, rough and low:

> “Leora made Tsukihiko.”

Tōma went still immediately.

Chōbei’s grip tightened slightly.

> “That boy...”

His voice caught unexpectedly.

He swallowed hard.

> “He’s the air I breathe.”

Silence stretched.

Rain whispered beyond the corridor.

> “The soul wearin’ my skin.”

Another breath.

> “The purpose and meaning of every damn thing.”

Tōma’s eyes burned instantly.

Because Chōbei almost never spoke like this.

Not openly.

Not without hiding behind jokes or violence.

But tonight he sounded carved open.

Chōbei laughed once quietly against his hair.

Broken.

> “And she knew.”

Tōma looked up slightly.

Chōbei stared somewhere distant now.

Toward nothing.

Toward years already lived.

> “The second she saw you, she knew.”

His hand smoothed once over Tōma’s hair automatically.

Like instinct.

> “Knew I loved you more than I’d ever loved myself.”

Tōma’s face crumpled immediately.

But Chōbei kept speaking.

Steady now.

Certain.

> “If you hadn’t come to the estate...”

A pause.

Then honestly:

> “I would’ve left eventually.”

That startled Tōma enough he physically pulled back slightly.

Chōbei met his eyes directly.

No hesitation.

> “You think I’d stay somewhere you couldn’t follow?”

Tōma’s throat tightened painfully.

And Chōbei continued:

> “If you don’t wanna become immortal...”

A shrug.

Simple.

Absolute.

> “Then I won’t either.”

Tōma stared at him in shock.

Real shock.

Because Chōbei was not saying it dramatically.

Not sacrificially.

Just truthfully.

Like the answer had always existed.

Then Chōbei sighed and scrubbed a hand over his face.

> “I’ve always loved people different ways.”

He leaned back against the corridor wall now.

Exhaustion dragging at him visibly.

> “But it’s all the same intensity.”

His eyes drifted toward Leora’s closed doors.

And his expression changed again.

Softer.

More helpless.

> “And Leora...”

He barked out a tired laugh.

> “The hell is she supposed to be to me?”

Tōma listened quietly.

Chōbei counted almost bitterly now.

Like each realization only made things worse.

> “Mother figure?”

> “Lover?”

> “Mother-in-law?”

> “Grandmother of my son?”

Another laugh.

Disbelieving.

> “The most beautiful woman I’ve ever seen?”

> “The smartest woman I’ve ever known?”

> “The best sparring partner?”

> “My teacher?”

> “My nurse when I’m sick?”

> “The woman who birthed my soulmate, my lover, my everything, my Moon Prince himself - Tsukihiko?”

His voice softened more with every word.

Until finally:

> “What is she?”

Silence.

Then Chōbei looked at Tōma directly.

Eyes red.

Destroyed.

Honest.

> “How could I not love her?”

Tōma’s breath hitched.

Chōbei’s jaw tightened violently.

> “How could I not fall apart seeing her disgraced like that?”

His voice shook now.

Actually shook.

> “Seeing violence written all over her skin?”

Tōma felt tears spilling again.

Because Chōbei looked furious even now.

Furious at the world itself for allowing it.

And then—

the fear returned.

Sharp enough to hollow him visibly.

> “Tsukihiko’s in a coma.”

His breathing became uneven suddenly.

> “Every second he doesn’t wake up...”

A pause.

Then quietly:

> “Feels like part of me dies.”

Tōma stepped closer immediately.

But Chōbei kept going.

Like once started, he couldn't stop.

> “So yeah.”

His eyes drifted once more toward Leora's chambers.

> “I love her. I love him more than love.”

And now his voice became something else entirely.

Something mythic.

Certain.

Like naming natural law.

> “I love Leora the way mountains love clouds.”

> “Like swift rivers love hard stones.”

Tōma's breath caught painfully.

Then Chōbei smiled faintly.

Destroyed and beautiful at once.

> “And I love Tsukihiko like a dying man loves air.”

His eyes closed briefly.

> “Like the sun risin' in the east and settin' in the west.”

A long silence.

Then:

> “Like the natural order of the universe.”

Tōma broke completely then.

Tears spilling openly.

And Chōbei reached for him immediately again.

Pulling him close.

Holding him against his chest.

Then finally, softer than anything he'd said yet:

> “And I love you the way a father loves his child because now I know what that actually feels like and I would bleed for you, suffer for you, die for you.”

Tōma made a small broken sound against him.

And Chōbei held him tighter.

Like losing any of them would tear the world apart permanently.

The Crisis Part XXIII

Sukuna stops at the threshold.

Not because anything blocks him.

Because something in him does.

The room is quiet in a way that feels almost unreal after everything.

Not the tense quiet of waiting.

Not the fractured quiet of aftermath.

Just... sleep.

Two people breathing.

Alive.

Together.

Leora and Friedhelm.

Sukuna’s eyes don’t move for a moment after he sees them properly.

Because his mind refuses, for a brief second, to accept the contradiction.

He had seen Leora broken.

He had seen Friedhelm like something barely held together by will alone.

He had seen things he cannot yet name without his thoughts sharpening into something violent.

And now—

they are here.

Whole enough to be sleeping.

Curled together like instinct has decided survival is allowed again.

Sukuna takes a slow step forward.

Then stops again.

His gaze drops to Leora first.

Her face is turned slightly toward Friedhelm's chest. Hair spilling over the pillow in uneven strands that no longer match memory cleanly.

But she is breathing.

That is the part that catches him.

Breathing.

His jaw tightens almost imperceptibly.

He didn't hear about this.

Didn't see it happen.

Didn't understand the path that led here.

He only has what remains in his mind:

blood in a clearing that should not exist.

hair scattered where no living thing should still be whole.

the feeling—sharp and absolute—that something fundamental had been taken.

And yet—

Leora is here.

Sukuna's hand flexes once at his side.

Not reaching.

Not touching.

Just reacting.

Friedhelm shifts slightly in sleep.

Leora follows the movement instinctively, as if her body refuses to let distance form between them even unconscious.

Sukuna's eyes narrow faintly.

Something inside his chest tightens again.

Because he does not know how to place this.

Not emotionally.

Not logically.

Not even physically.

He steps closer.

Slow.

Measured.

Until he is at the bedside.

He looks down at them again.

This time longer.

More searching.

As if the answer to everything might be written somewhere in the simple fact of their existence.

But nothing explains it.

Nothing resolves the violence his memory insists is still true.

His throat works once.

Barely noticeable.

Then he exhales through his nose—controlled, restrained, almost forced into calm.

Leora makes a small sound in her sleep.

Not pain.

Just awareness shifting.

Her fingers curl slightly into Friedhelm's sleeve.

Friedhelm responds immediately, even asleep, adjusting as if he is built to hold her in place against the world.

Sukuna watches that.

Still.

Silent.

His expression doesn't soften.

But it changes in a way that is harder to define.

Less certainty.

More pressure.

Like something in him is trying to reconcile two incompatible truths:

* what he knows happened

* and what is in front of him now

Leora is alive.

Friedhelm is alive.

They are together.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna realizes, with a slow internal fracture of thought—

he does not know where to put his grief.

Because grief requires something to be final.

His hand lifts slightly.

Stops halfway.

Then lowers again without touching them.

He turns his head just a fraction, as if listening for something that isn't there.

The estate feels too large suddenly.

Too full of unanswered absence.

Too unstable.

Sukuna looks back at them once more.

Longer this time.

And finally understands something uncomfortable without fully naming it:

he is afraid to leave the room.

Not because they are gone.

But because he still does not trust that they are truly here.

Sukuna's hand moves before he fully decides to.

Not to wake her.

Not to disturb.

Just—understanding seeking confirmation.

The edge of the blanket lifts slightly.

Carefully.

Enough.

And the moment he sees what lies beneath, something in his expression tightens in a way that is almost imperceptible at first.

Because it is not just injury.

It is *history written onto skin.*

Bruising layered over bruising.

Marks of pressure that are too specific to be accidental.

Fingers.

Hands.

A grip that did not let go when it should have.

Leora's jaw bears it most clearly.

Faint discoloration along the line where someone held her still.

Her neck carries it too—darker, deeper, as if memory itself pressed there.

Sukuna's eyes lower further.

And he understands, with a clarity that arrives too late to soften anything:

Friedhelm did not come back intact.

Not because he was weak.

Because he chose otherwise.

Sukuna exhales once.

Slow.

Controlled.

But it does not remove what he is seeing.

The realization settles in layers:

Friedhelm did not *fail* to protect her.

He absorbed it.

Took what should have killed her and made it his instead.

And what remained was this—

Leora still breathing.

Still alive.

Still here.

But not untouched.

Sukuna's gaze sharpens slightly.

Memory rises without permission.

The clearing.

The scattered remains.

The impossible geometry of violence that had not matched any known technique.

Even Kurohiko—

Kurohiko, who understood death as naturally as breath—

had gone still when he saw it.

> "She fought."

His son's voice echoes in Sukuna's mind.

Raw, unsettled in a way Sukuna had rarely heard from him.

> “Gods, she fought.”

Sukuna’s eyes return to Leora’s face.

And for the first time since seeing her again in that bed, something like anger begins to surface—not directed outward yet, not aimed, but gathering.

Because the other truth arrives with it.

She did not die where she fell.

She did not break and end.

She moved.

Dragged herself.

Through distance that should have finished her.

Through terrain that should have stopped her.

More than a kilometer.

Back toward the estate.

Toward *him.*

Sukuna’s hand hovers again—this time closer to her shoulder, still not touching.

And he realizes what unsettles him most is not the violence.

Not even the survival.

It is the certainty that remains underneath everything:

Leora would have known him anywhere.

Even like that.

Burned.

Broken.

Reduced.

In darkness, in emptiness, in nothing—

she would still have known him.

The thought sits in him like a weight that does not resolve.

Behind him, the room feels too quiet again.

Leora shifts slightly in sleep, a faint sound escaping her throat, and Friedhelm tightens instinctively around her without waking.

Protecting what is already protected.

Sukuna lowers the blanket again slowly.

Carefully.

As if undoing even that small exposure might preserve something that is already irreversibly changed.

His expression hardens.

Not outwardly.

Inwardly.

Because now there is a third realization forming, unavoidable and cold:

whatever happened in that forest did not end with survival.

It ended with *cost.*

And Sukuna is no longer looking at absence.

He is looking at what remains after something tried—and failed—to erase her completely.

The Crisis Part XXV

Sukuna left and Leora and Friedhelm awoke.
Something in both of them stirred uncomfortably.
Tsukihiko.

The infirmary was still, wrapped in that strange half-light that only came after too many nights without real sleep.

Tsukihiko lay unmoving.

Too still to be restful. Too deep to be natural.

Chōbei had collapsed in a chair beside him sometime earlier and never made it further than that. One arm hung loosely over the bedframe as if he had simply given up mid-guard. His breathing was slow, uneven—exhaustion dragging him under.

In the small crib nearby, Kohaku made soft, pleased little sounds at the world, completely unaware of what anything meant.

Friedhelm stopped at the doorway when they entered.

Leora did not.

She crossed the room carefully, every step controlled through pain she refused to acknowledge. Friedhelm followed a half-step behind her, watching the way she moved like he was memorizing the fact she could still move at all.

Kohaku chirped when Friedhelm passed.

Immediately, instinctively, Friedhelm lifted him.

The motion was so natural it didn't even look like thought. Just inevitability.

Leora paused beside Chōbei.

She looked down at him for a long moment.

Something soft crossed her face—tired, affectionate, almost fragile.

Then she leaned down and pressed a kiss to his lips.

Quiet.

Careful.

Chōbei stirred instantly, like his body had been waiting for that exact signal to remember how to exist again.

Friedhelm looked away.

Not because it was unfamiliar.

Because it was too familiar.

Something about it made his chest tighten in a way he didn't have words for.

Leora moved to Tsukihiko next.

She placed her hand gently against his forehead.

Her expression changed immediately.

A small crease formed between her brows.

Not fear.

Assessment.

Concern sharpened into something colder.

Friedhelm made a low, displeased sound beside her—barely audible, more instinct than speech.

And then—

Chōbei moved.

Fast.

Like he hadn't been asleep at all.

His hands found Leora's waist and stomach in the same motion, pulling her into him with an urgency that was half relief, half panic finally allowed to breathe.

Leora let herself be pulled down into his lap.

Friedhelm turned away fully this time.

Not out of politeness.

Out of restraint.

Behind him, Chōbei's breath broke.

He was checking her.

Hands shaking slightly as they moved over her like he needed proof she was still real. Still here. Still not something he had failed to protect again.

Tears slid down his face without ceremony.

Leora's hand came up, resting against his face.

Grounding him.

Then Chōbei spoke, voice rough with exhaustion and something heavier underneath it.

"Can you wake him up?"

"Please. Leora, please."

A pause.

"Please, please wake him up."

His grip tightened slightly.

“Friedhelm...”

A strangled noise.

“Every second he’s out... he’s missing Kohaku grow up.”

The words landed differently than anything else in the room.

Friedhelm froze.

Because it wasn’t dramatic.

It was simple.

And that made it worse.

Leora exhaled slowly.

She turned slightly, eyes finding Friedhelm.

A silent request.

Friedhelm hesitated for only a moment.

Then stepped forward.

He placed two fingers lightly against Tsukihiko’s wrist.

And murmured something under his breath—old, soft, almost absent-minded.

Then he whistled.

Not loud.

But precise.

Like calling something back into alignment.

The air in the room shifted.

Tsukihiko’s brow twitched.

Then again.

A breath deeper than the others.

His eyes opened.

And Chōbei moved.

It wasn't gentle.

It wasn't careful.

It was immediate—feral in its relief.

He grabbed Tsukihiko like he had been drowning and just found land, pulling him upright, hands at his shoulders, forehead pressing briefly against him as if checking he was still there in every possible way at once.

Tsukihiko made a sound of protest—

but didn't push him away.

Friedhelm looked down at Kohaku, suddenly very interested in the way the child was grasping at his sleeve.

Leora exhaled again.

A little softer this time.

And without a word exchanged between them, she and Friedhelm both understood the same thing.

They should leave.

Not because they weren't needed.

But because, for the first time in days—

someone else was finally allowed to break first.

The Crisis Part XXVI

Sukuna finds her before she speaks.

Not because she calls out.

Because the air shifts—subtle, familiar. The world around him adjusts like it has been waiting for her to re-enter it.

Leora crosses the distance immediately.

No hesitation.

No checking the room.

She reaches him and simply takes him as if there had never been a question of permission.

Her arms loop around his neck, firm and exact, and she presses her face into the side of his throat.

Not frantic.

Not collapsing.

Claiming contact like it is a known fact of existence.

Sukuna's body stills under her for a fraction of a second.

Then his hand comes up and settles at her back.

Not gripping.

Not pulling.

Just holding her there like a confirmation that she is still in the world.

Leora exhales once—long, controlled—and the tension drains out of her body in a way that is almost disconcerting in its certainty. Like she has already decided what she is, and what happened, and what it costs.

Her fingers slide through his hair with quiet familiarity. She presses a kiss to his jaw, then another at his neck, each one grounding rather than searching. She kisses him consistently, involuntary sounds escaping that make his chest clench. He can feel her moving closer even when there already feels like there's no distance.

Sukuna watches her closely.

Noticing something he had already seen once before—

when she was on the ground, broken and still looking at the world as if it had not successfully defeated her.

That same clarity is here now.

Not softness.

Not sorrow.

Clarity.

Defiance, sharpened into something practiced.

He speaks first.

> “What happened?”

Leora doesn't lift her head immediately.

There is no trembling in her pause.

No unraveling.

Just a short silence, like she is choosing whether this is worth saying out loud again.

Then she pulls back just enough to look at him.

Her expression is steady.

Not pleading.

Not lost.

Set.

And she says it without hesitation:

> “It's my fault.”

Sukuna's eyes narrow slightly.

But she continues before he can press further.

Not rushing.

Not emotional.

Simply stating it as something already concluded long before now.

> “There's nothing to discuss right now.”

A beat.

Her gaze flicks past him briefly, like she is already orienting toward movement again.

> “It's my issue. My shortcomings. My ignorance.”

The words are not self-pity.

They are inventory.

Measured.

Cold in a way that is almost frighteningly familiar.

> “That's what led to everything happening. Tsukihiko. The others.”

She adjusts her grip on him—then, as if the contact itself is now resolved, she begins to step back.

Not dramatically.

Not emotionally.

Just... disengaging.

Creating space between them so she can move again.

"I'll deal with it," she adds simply, already turning slightly as if to leave him with that answer and nothing else.

That is when Sukuna stops her.

Not with force.

With presence.

His hand tightens at her back—not restraining, but anchoring—and the space she is trying to create collapses under it.

Leora pauses.

Sukuna's voice drops.

> "Don't."

Just that.

Because something in him reacts violently to the idea of her leaving the space between them again.

Not abstractly.

Not philosophically.

Viscerally.

He has already seen what absence looks like when it wears her face.

He has already stood in a world where she did not respond.

Where she did not exist in reach.

He does not want to repeat the experience, even in smaller form.

Leora stills.

Not surprised.

Just assessing.

Like she is recalculating him.

Sukuna's grip shifts slightly—more deliberate now, his hand firm at her back as he pulls her just enough that she cannot fully step away.

Not possessive.

Not aggressive.

Refusal of distance.

> “You don't leave after saying that,” he says quietly.

Leora exhales through her nose.

A small sound.

Almost impatient.

Almost amused.

But she doesn't pull away again.

Not yet.

And Sukuna realizes, with a clarity that sits uncomfortably in his chest, that this is what he cannot tolerate now:

Not losing her.

Not even for a moment that feels like one.

The Crisis Part XXVI - No Distance

Sukuna does not permit distance anymore.

Not even small amounts.

Every time Leora drifts more than a few steps away, his hand closes around her wrist, her waist, the sleeve of her robes—anything—and he pulls her back toward him with increasing impatience.

She notices.

Of course she notices.

But she does not resist him once.

By the third time he redirects her away from hallways, servants, responsibilities, and conversations, she finally laughs softly under her breath.

Not mocking.

Just tired and fond.

And she lets him steer her wherever he wants.

Which is, inevitably, their chambers.

The moment the doors close behind them, Sukuna's restraint disappears entirely.

Not violently.

Desperately.

He pulls her against him and keeps her there like separation itself has become intolerable to his nervous system.

Leora exhales softly and simply melts.

Her weight settles fully into him.

Limbs loose.

Trusting.

As though she has already decided there is nowhere else she needs to be.

Sukuna sits with her half in his lap, half against his chest, one arm wrapped around her waist while the other keeps touching her compulsively.

Her hair.

Her shoulder.

The side of her neck.

Her hands.

Anywhere.

Every few seconds he checks again without realizing he is doing it.

Leora watches him quietly for a long while.

Then, with sleepy confusion:

> “I’m surprised you’re still looking at me like that.”

Sukuna’s hand pauses briefly against her jaw.

Leora smiles faintly.

Soft.

Certain.

> “You came all the way into death to get us.”

The words hit him wrong immediately.

His eyes narrow slightly.

But she continues before he interrupts.

> “You found us in Helheim.”

A pause.

Then she tilts her head against him comfortably.

> “And every time I searched for you...”

Her fingers slide lazily through the fabric over his chest.

> “You touched my face.”

Sukuna goes completely still.

Leora’s expression remains peaceful as she remembers it.

Not doubtful.

Not uncertain.

Certain.

> “You kept letting me know you were there.”

The look in her eyes when she says it nearly makes him sick.

Not because it is too intense.

Because it is full of love directed at him for something he did not do.

Something he cannot claim.

Eirvorr.

That thing wearing familiarity like skin.

Sukuna suddenly understands exactly what the god meant when he said:

> *My bride and yours.*

His stomach twists.

Because Leora does not even question it.

Not once.

To her, of course it was Sukuna.

Of course he came for her.

Of course he would reach into death and touch her face until she found him again.

The faith in that assumption feels unbearable.

Undeserved.

Sukuna looks away sharply.

And Leora notices immediately.

Her brow furrows slightly.

> "What?"

He cannot answer right away.

Because for the first time in a very long time, Sukuna feels something dangerously close to shame.

Not weakness.

Not embarrassment.

Something heavier.

He thinks about her broken body dragging itself through the forest trying to reach him.

About how he looked directly at her and failed to know her.

And somewhere in death, something else wore enough of him that Leora reached toward it instinctively.

Trusted it instinctively.

Loved it instinctively.

Because she loves *him* that completely.

Sukuna's hand tightens slightly where it rests against her waist.

Leora studies him quietly now.

More alert.

Then she reaches up and touches his face gently.

The exact gesture she described.

And Sukuna almost recoils from the tenderness of it.

Not because he dislikes it.

Because he feels he has not earned it.

Leora watches him for another long moment.

Then, softer:

> "You really scared yourself, didn't you?"

Sukuna closes his eyes briefly.

And that is answer enough.

The Crisis Part XXVII

Sukuna doesn't notice the change at first.

It's subtle.

Like something inside him loosening without permission.

Leora is still in his arms.

Warm.

Present.

Real enough that his hand can feel the weight of her spine beneath fabric, the steady rise and fall of her breathing against his chest.

And yet—

his mind does not stay still.

It slips.

Not into memory alone, but into **absence**.

Two days.

An empty side of the bed.

No sound shifting in the room at night.

No footsteps in the morning.

No hands pulling him back into something familiar.

Just silence where she should have been.

And then—

the image intrudes again.

Not softened by time.

Not dulled by distance.

Leora on the ground.

Broken.

Unrecognizable.

Mizuki's voice—flat with certainty.

She's going to die.

Mizuki's face—too still, too young in the wrong way.

Chōbei's silence that said more than words ever could.

Tsukihiko and Kurohiko's absences in the same breath as her collapse.

Everything stacking at once.

Too many truths that do not align.

Sukuna's grip tightens.

Not intentionally.

Leora shifts slightly against him, and the sensation does not resolve the contradiction—it sharpens it.

Because she **moves.**

Because she is **here.**

But his mind refuses to stop replaying the alternative.

His breathing changes.

Shortens.

Not obvious at first.

Then uneven.

He looks down at her like he is trying to confirm a fact that keeps changing shape.

Leora is still watching him.

Not alarmed.

Not startled.

Just aware.

That clarity in her eyes again—the same one he saw even when she was on the ground, even when everything around her said she should have already been gone.

Sukuna's voice comes out lower than he intends.

Unsteady in a way that doesn't belong to him.

> "You were gone."

A pause.

Then sharper, like he's trying to force logic back into place.

> "I saw you."

His hand shifts slightly at her back, as if anchoring her is the only thing preventing the world from correcting itself.

But the correction feels closer now.

Like it's waiting.

His gaze flicks briefly past her shoulder—empty air, corridor, nothing—but for a moment it does not register as solid.

His mind supplies the missing image too easily.

Her not there.

Again.

Sukuna exhales once, but it catches halfway, breaking the rhythm.

And then, quieter—almost disbelieving:

> “Is this... real?”

The question is not philosophical.

It is immediate.

Raw.

Because his body remembers what absence felt like.

And now that she is back in his arms, his instincts do not trust the return.

Leora doesn't move away.

Instead, she adjusts slightly—closing the distance that he instinctively tried to secure without realizing.

Her hand comes up to his jaw.

Steady.

Not soothing in a fragile way.

Grounding in a decisive one.

Her thumb presses once against his cheekbone, as if confirming structure.

That he is here too.

Then she speaks, calm and matter-of-fact.

Not soft.

Not shaken.

> “It’s real. I’m here.”

A beat.

> “You’re holding me.”

Her eyes do not waver.

> “This didn’t change.”

Sukuna stares at her.

Still not fully stable.

Still not convinced the world is not going to slip again.

His grip tightens once more—not enough to hurt, but enough to prove something to himself through sensation.

Leora remains exactly where she is.

Not resisting.

Not fading.

Just present.

And slowly—very slowly—the panic does not disappear.

But it stops escalating.

Because if this is real, then she is here.

And if she is here—

then he refuses to let the space between them exist long enough for reality to take her again.

The Crisis Part XXVIII

Friedhelm knocks softly before entering.

Not because he truly waits for permission.

Because he is trying to be gentle with them.

With *him.*

The door slides open quietly.

And immediately Friedhelm's eyes find Sukuna.

That same look.

That same unbearable certainty Leora had moments ago.

Trust.

Relief.

Love so complete it assumes impossibilities as naturally as breathing.

And Sukuna feels shame curl deeper beneath his ribs.

Friedhelm crosses the room without hesitation.

Still bruised beneath the collar of his robes.

Still moving carefully from the damage his body absorbed for Leora.

But he comes anyway.

Straight to Sukuna.

Then simply folds himself into Sukuna's other side like there was never another place intended for him.

His fingers clutch lightly into Sukuna's robes as he settles there.

Warm.

Real.

Alive.

Friedhelm exhales softly once he's pressed against him properly.

Like his body had been searching for this exact position since waking.

Then quietly:

> "I still don't understand how you did it."

Sukuna's stomach twists immediately.

Friedhelm continues before he can interrupt.

> “How you entered Helheim.”

His voice is soft with genuine wonder.

Not suspicion.

Not doubt.

Wonder.

> “How you found us that deep.”

Leora smiles sleepily against Sukuna’s shoulder, eyes half closed as she listens.

Friedhelm’s hand smooths unconsciously over Sukuna’s chest.

> “And the river...”

He frowns faintly as if trying to solve something impossible.

> “I don’t understand how you placed us there.”

A small laugh leaves him.

Tired.

Fond.

> “But I suppose I shouldn’t be surprised.”

Sukuna cannot breathe correctly anymore.

Because Friedhelm sounds so sincere.

So certain.

Friedhelm tilts his head slightly against him.

> “You learned how to walk in death for Leora.”

His lips brush softly against Sukuna’s jaw.

Affectionate.

Instinctive.

> “Of course you would learn how to enter Helheim and act like it was nothing.”

Then another kiss against the edge of his neck.

And Friedhelm relaxes further into him.

Completely trusting.

Completely safe.

Leora shifts closer too, nearly climbing fully into Sukuna now just to fit beside Friedhelm.

She smiles at him with exhausted softness.

> “I love you so much.”

Simple.

Certain.

Friedhelm nuzzles lightly against Sukuna’s shoulder.

And suddenly Sukuna is hit by the full magnitude of them.

Not their devotion.

Their *orbit.*

Leora.

Friedhelm.

Both of them re-arranging themselves around him so naturally they no longer even question it.

They believe he crossed worlds for them because to them there is no reality where he wouldn’t.

No hesitation.

No limit.

And Sukuna—

who had spent two days unable to survive the emptiness of their absence—

suddenly understands something horrifying.

Eirvorr had not misunderstood him.

Not even slightly.

The god had looked at Sukuna once and known immediately:

> this creature will tear through existence itself before allowing these two to disappear from him.

And worse—

Sukuna realizes the terrifying part is that it's true.

Even now, holding them both against him, he can still feel the panic lurking underneath his skin.

That empty bed.

That silence.

The knowledge that somewhere in the world Leora had dragged herself across the forest in pieces trying to reach him.

That Friedhelm had broken himself apart to keep her alive.

And for a brief moment—

a terrible moment—

Sukuna wraps both arms around them more tightly and thinks:

> I would destroy anything before I lose them again.

The Crisis Part XXVIII - Kurohiko and Chobei

Tsukihiko had finally recovered enough to sit upright against the pillows.

Barely.

The movement alone left him pale beneath the bruising still lingering along his throat and collarbone.

But he was awake.

Awake enough to track everything around him with those sharp silver eyes.

Chōbei had not left his side properly in days.

And it showed.

He looked terrible.

Hair unwashed and half tied back badly.

Eyes bloodshot.

Clothes wrinkled from sleeping in chairs and on floors beside the bed.

Kohaku rested against his chest while Higan slept bundled beside Tsukihiko's hip in a nest of blankets Chōbei had clearly arranged himself.

Like he refused to let either child out of reach.

The room smelled faintly of medicine, warm milk, and exhaustion.

Then the door slid open.

Kurohiko entered quietly with Sieg clinging stubbornly to one leg.

Kiyomi had finally fallen asleep in another room after days of fever and soul-drain exhaustion.

Kurohiko took one look at Chōbei and exhaled slowly through his nose.

Then crossed the room.

Without asking, he gently lifted Higan first.

Then carefully took Kohaku from Chōbei's arms.

Kohaku made a sleepy protesting noise before settling against Kurohiko immediately.

Sieg stared at both babies solemnly like they were sacred objects.

Kurohiko adjusted Kohaku against his shoulder and said softly:

> "I think they need some air."

Chōbei looked up slowly.

Exhausted enough not to argue immediately.

Then muttered:

> "You openin' a daycare for little monsters?"

Kurohiko smiled.

Small.

Fond.

Real.

> "Maybe."

Sieg tightened his grip on Kurohiko's clothes proudly like this confirmed something important.

The moment softened briefly.

Then Kurohiko looked back at Chōbei properly.

Not casually.

Really looked at him.

And Chōbei immediately became uncomfortable.

Because there was something unusually direct in Kurohiko's expression.

Something thoughtful.

Heavy.

Tsukihiko appeared asleep beside them.

Breathing slow.

Eyes closed.

Kurohiko sighed quietly.

Then said:

> "Ever since you came into our lives... everything changed."

Chōbei clicked his tongue lightly.

Deflective already.

But Kurohiko kept going.

> "At first I hated you."

That pulled Chōbei's attention fully.

Kurohiko adjusted Kohaku absently against his shoulder.

Sieg leaned sleepily against his leg.

> "I thought you'd hurt Tsukihiko."

His voice remained calm.

Matter-of-fact.

> "I thought you'd destroy him."

Chōbei looked away immediately after that.

Jaw tightening.

As if he couldn't decide whether to laugh at the statement or agree with it.

Before either of them could continue—

a servant knocked hurriedly at the door.

The servant bowed so quickly she nearly lost balance.

> “Lady Leora has requested Lord Chōbei come to her private chambers when he can.”

Silence.

Chōbei stared at her.

Kurohiko stared at her.

Even Sieg looked up.

The servant immediately panicked under the combined force of both expressions.

> “I-I mean—”

>

> “I was instructed—”

>

> “Lady Leora specifically said—”

Chōbei finally barked:

> “Why the fuck are you calling me *Lord Chōbei?*

The poor woman looked moments from death.

Kurohiko pinched the bridge of his nose.

> “You may go before he accidentally kills you.”

The servant fled instantly.

The room remained quiet for another moment.

Then Chōbei muttered:

> “What the fuck is happening to this estate...”

Kurohiko smiled faintly again.

Then the smile faded.

And he continued.

> “I hated you at first.”

Chōbei glanced sideways at him.

Kurohiko adjusted Kohaku against his shoulder carefully before continuing.

> “Because Tsukihiko loved you immediately.”

His tone remained calm.

Measured.

> “And that terrified me.”

Sieg had wandered toward the crib now, dangling a piece of cloth over Higan with absolute seriousness.

Kurohiko watched him for a second before speaking again.

> “I always thought Tsukihiko would marry some soft-spoken noble girl.”

A pause.

> “Beautiful.”

>

> “Quiet.”

>

> “Timid.”

Chōbei snorted.

Kurohiko grimaced slightly.

> “I would’ve hated her.”

That startled an actual laugh out of Chōbei.

Kurohiko continued:

> “Otosan would’ve hated her too.”

Now even Chōbei looked interested.

> “He would’ve pretended not to.”

>

> “Because politically it would’ve been useful.”

>

> “And because Tsukihiko is the heir.”

Kurohiko’s mouth tightened faintly.

> “But he would’ve despised watching Tsukihiko hold himself back to protect somebody fragile.”

Chōbei leaned back slowly in the chair.

Kurohiko looked toward the sleeping Tsukihiko.

And his voice changed slightly.

More thoughtful.

More personal.

> “Then you arrived.”

>

> “And mama looked at you like she’d found something she recognized.”

Chōbei’s expression shifted immediately.

Guarded.

Kurohiko saw it and continued anyway.

> “At first I hated that too.”

His voice roughened slightly.

> “Because suddenly there was this side of mama we’d only seen in fragments...”

A pause.

> “...and you brought it out completely.”

Chōbei looked away first.

Kurohiko exhaled through his nose.

> “I knew immediately Ootosan wasn’t saying what he should’ve been saying to her.”

That made Chōbei look back sharply.

Kurohiko met his eyes evenly.

> “I could tell how much he loved her.”

>

> “But I could also tell something in him kept pulling back from admitting how hopeless he’d be without her.”

His eyes lowered briefly.

> “I think I understand why.”

Another pause.

> “Someone like him rearranging his existence around someone like mama...”

A faint shake of the head.

> “...after centuries of being the King of Curses?”

He smiled faintly.

Sad almost.

> “That’s a difficult thing to survive admitting.”

The infirmary remained quiet except for Kohaku’s small sleepy noises.

Then Kurohiko looked back at Chōbei fully.

> “And then you gave mama something he didn’t.”

Chōbei’s jaw tightened.

> “At the exact moment she would’ve broken without it.”

Kurohiko laughed once under his breath.

> “And she *blossomed.*”

The word sounded almost accusing.

> “I hated you for that too.”

Chōbei opened his mouth.

Kurohiko cut him off immediately.

> “Because I thought she’d leave him.”

That landed heavily.

> “And then what would happen to Tsukihiko?”

His eyes narrowed slightly.

> “Honestly?”

>

> “I assumed eventually it would just become mama and Tsukihiko sharing you.”

Chōbei choked violently.

Kurohiko remained perfectly serious.

> “That made me deeply uncomfortable.”

Even Sieg stopped to stare at him.

Then Kurohiko sighed.

And something softened in him.

> “But then something else happened.”

He looked toward the hallway absently.

Toward where Sukuna likely was somewhere inside the estate.

> “You became Ootosan’s mirror.”

Chōbei went still.

Kurohiko nodded slowly.

> “And that was probably the best thing that ever happened to this family.”

His voice steadied.

> “Because suddenly Ootosan learned what love actually looked like.”

Another pause.

> “He identified it in himself.”

>

> “Then he took control of repairing everything.”

His expression softened faintly.

> “Especially with Tsukihiko.”

Chōbei looked toward the sleeping man instinctively.

Kurohiko smiled.

Small.

Fond.

> “And now mama and Otosan are happier than I’ve ever seen them.”

>

> “Except maybe when we were all very little.”

Silence settled briefly.

Then Kurohiko adjusted Kohaku again and said quietly:

> “Tsukihiko is my hero.”

That startled Chōbei more than anything else had.

Kurohiko continued before he could react.

> “Mine and Mizuki’s.”

His eyes lowered.

> “Sometimes I think both of us feel inadequate standing beside him.”

A beat.

> “But the burden he carries was never meant for us.”

>

> “And nobody else could carry it better.”

He looked directly at Chōbei then.

Completely earnest.

> “I love you because you love him the way he deserves.”

Chōbei froze.

Kurohiko continued steadily:

> “I love you because you love mama in a way that makes her lighter.”

>

> “Healthier.”

>

> “More healed.”

Then softer:

> “I love you like a brother.”

A faint smile.

> “And I love you like something else there isn’t really a word for.”

Chōbei looked visibly overwhelmed now.

Kurohiko noticed.

Ignored it.

> “And honestly?”

Another glance toward the hall.

> “You became Otosan’s first real friend.”

Chōbei barked a startled laugh.

Kurohiko shrugged.

> “Uncle Friedhelm never really fit that role.”

A pause.

Then very seriously:

> “Especially now that he sleeps with Otosan too.”

Chōbei made a noise like he’d been punched in the throat.

Sieg looked delighted by the reaction despite understanding absolutely nothing.

Then Kurohiko’s expression became grave.

Deadly serious.

> “Please don’t start sleeping with Otosan.”

Chōbei stared at him in total disbelief.

Kurohiko held eye contact.

Absolutely sincere.

Then added:

> “Tsukihiko has Kohaku because of you.”

Chōbei blinked slowly.

Kurohiko looked toward the sleeping heir.

Lowered his voice.

> “That deity noticed you and decided that Kohaku was going to be the most marvelous creation it ever made.”

The room went still.

“What?” Chobei sounded winded, “What diety?”
And from the bed—

Tsukihiko’s fingers twitched once against the blankets.

The Crisis Part XXX

The infirmary was quiet in a way that didn’t feel like rest.

It felt held.

Like the air itself had been told not to move too loudly.

Tsukihiko sat propped up against the pillows, one hand loosely wrapped in bandages, the other resting near his lap. The exhaustion in him wasn’t just physical anymore—it had settled into something deeper, something that made even blinking look like effort.

Chōbei sat beside him in the chair that had long since stopped being comfortable.

Neither of them had moved for a while.

Then Tsukihiko finally spoke.

> “I met him.”

Chōbei didn’t react immediately.

That alone made Tsukihiko glance at him.

> “In Death.”

A pause.

Then, quieter:

> “The fox god.”

Chōbei’s eyes narrowed slightly.

Tsukihiko’s gaze drifted, unfocused for a moment, like he was still standing in that place rather than here.

> “Skugga.”

The name didn’t feel learned.

It felt remembered.

Chōbei exhaled slowly through his nose.

> “And?”

Tsukihiko’s expression tightened slightly, as if trying to arrange something too large for language.

> “He looks like Friedhelm.”

That made Chōbei still.

Tsukihiko nodded once, confirming it to himself as much as anyone else.

> “Not just looks.”

>

> “The way he smiles. The way he watches things.”

>

> “It’s the same.”

A pause.

> “He was surrounded by foxes.”

That landed heavier.

Tsukihiko shifted slightly in the bed, gaze sharpening as memory anchored itself properly.

> “It reminded me of the story Mama told us.”

Chōbei’s brow furrowed.

Tsukihiko continued:

> “The fox and the wolf moon tale.”

>

> “When Kohaku was born.”

His voice softened slightly at that.

> “She said sometimes children come back wrong from Death rituals.”

>

> “Not broken.”

>

> “Just... *different.*”

Chōbei's hand tightened faintly on the edge of the chair.

Tsukihiko looked at him directly now.

> "I think this is one of those."

Chōbei finally spoke, low.

> "What are you talking about?"

Tsukihiko didn't answer immediately.

Like he was deciding how much truth Chōbei was allowed to survive hearing.

Then:

> "Skugga asked if I brought 'One-Eye.'"

Chōbei blinked.

> "...what?"

Tsukihiko's eyes flickered faintly.

> "You."

Silence hit the room hard.

Then Tsukihiko continued, quieter:

> "He already knew Kohaku."

>

> "He called him 'Kiba.'"

>

> "Said he was getting bigger."

A pause.

His expression shifted slightly—something almost unsettled, almost reverent in spite of himself.

> "And then he told me I was a good father."

Chōbei stared at him.

For once, completely without words.

Tsukihiko glanced at him.

> "That part... was the strangest."

Chōbei let out a rough breath.

> “Is that normal?”

Tsukihiko’s answer was immediate.

Flat.

Honest.

> “Nothing about him is normal.”

A beat.

Then Tsukihiko’s gaze lowered slightly.

> “But Kohaku...”

He hesitated.

Something in him clearly resisting how to phrase it.

> “He wasn’t only born from us.”

Chōbei’s eyes sharpened instantly.

Tsukihiko continued:

> “Skugga crafted him.”

That word made the air feel thinner.

> “Not his body alone. His nature.”

>

> “Like a fox pup. Like something... designed.”

Chōbei went still.

Tsukihiko’s voice softened, almost clinical now in its clarity.

> “That’s why he behaves the way he does.”

>

> “The animal sounds. The instinct responses. The way he reacts to us.”

>

> “It isn’t just genetics.”

A pause.

> “It’s intent.”

Chōbei looked down slowly, as if trying to see Kohaku through new eyes.

Tsukihiko added, quieter:

> “And the crescent mark.”

>

> “The cheek markings.”

His jaw tightened faintly.

> “That wasn’t accidental either.”

Chōbei’s voice came out rough.

> “So someone *decorated* our child?”

Tsukihiko didn’t correct him.

Just nodded once.

> “Skugga is... attentive to you.”

That made Chōbei look up sharply.

Tsukihiko’s expression shifted slightly—annoyance creeping in at the edges now, as if he disliked saying the next part out loud.

> “He thinks your scars are art.”

Chōbei let out something between a scoff and disbelief.

Tsukihiko continued anyway.

> “He used them as reference.”

>

> “For Kohaku.”

A pause.

> “The eye color. The markings. Even the way he moves.”

Chōbei went very still.

Tsukihiko clicked his tongue faintly.

> “I told you before—someone put those marks on him because they *admire* you.”

His gaze flicked toward Chōbei.

> “I know I was right.”

Silence stretched.

Then Tsukihiko added, almost reluctantly:

> “He’s obsessed with continuation.”

>

> “With things that refuse to end properly.”

A breath.

Then:

> “And apparently... with you.”

Chōbei stared at him.

> “That’s not comforting.”

Tsukihiko huffed faintly.

> “No.”

>

> “It isn’t.”

Then, after a pause—more honest than he seemed to want to be:

> “And yet I understand him.”

Chōbei frowned.

Tsukihiko looked at him properly now.

> “Because I understand you.”

That made Chōbei still.

Tsukihiko’s voice lowered slightly.

> “You are not something that should exist the way you do.”

>

> “You carry things that should have ended you.”

A faint pause.

> “That’s what he sees.”

Chōbei rubbed a hand over his face slowly.

> “So this god just... decided to build a child around my scars?”

Tsukihiko nodded.

> “Yes and my likeness and connection to Friedhelm..”

A beat.

Then Tsukihiko's expression twisted slightly, something sharper surfacing.

> "And gave him *your* eye color."

That last part landed differently.

More intimate.

More invasive.

Tsukihiko clicked his tongue again.

> "He's either a visionary or completely unwell."

Then, quieter—almost like an afterthought he didn't mean to admit:

> "Maybe both."

> "Visionary is what I personally believe because when I look at you I can't even breathe properly sometimes."

Chōbei let out a short breath.

> "So what do we do about it?"

Tsukihiko opened his mouth—

But stopped.

Because before either of them could answer—

The fox bell chimed.

Once.

Soft.

Too close.

Neither of them had seen it in the room a moment ago.

But now it was there.

And in that same instant—

the air changed.

Something in the corner of the infirmary shifted slightly, as if the world had been adjusted by a hand neither of them could see.

The room did not change the way violence changes a place.

It changed the way *winter* changes it.

Quietly.

Without permission.

The fox bell on the table chimed once on its own.

Not struck.

Not moved.

Just... acknowledging something that had decided it was already inside.

Tsukihiko stopped mid-breath.

Chōbei's hand, still half raised from his last gesture, froze in the air.

And then the scars reacted.

Not pain.

Recognition.

Chōbei's body went rigid as something *under* the healed wounds stirred—beneath the eye, along the mouth, across old knife cuts that had long since stopped meaning anything.

Silver light surfaced under the skin like trapped moonfire finally remembering it had a direction.

Foxfire-thread.

Not burning out.

answering.

Tsukihiko didn't speak.

He couldn't.

Because he understood what it meant faster than he understood how he understood it.

Something was touching Chōbei.

Directly.

Across distance that should not have allowed contact.

The fox bell chimed again.

Once.

Twice.

A third time—but softer, like hesitation.

Then—

something appeared on the infirmary bed behind them.

Neither of them saw it arrive.

They only noticed the absence of sound where it should have been.

Braided cords lay coiled neatly against the sheets.

Black as river silt.

Interrupted by silver beads that caught the dim light and refused to release it.

Tiny fox teeth threaded between them like careful punctuation.

Tsukihiko turned first.

Slowly.

Like moving his head too quickly might make the world notice him noticing.

He reached out.

Stopped just before touching.

Then touched anyway.

One bead.

Cold.

Precise.

And the moment his finger made contact, his expression changed.

Not fear.

Not awe.

Something sharper.

Disbelief edged with comprehension.

Because the placement of the beads was not symbolic.

It was *observational*.

Each one corresponded to a scar on Chōbei's body.

Even the ones no one had ever seen.

Even the ones Chōbei himself had stopped remembering.

Tsukihiko's voice came out low.

Careful.

> "It knows them."

Chōbei didn't answer.

He couldn't look away from the cords.

Because the foxfire under his skin was responding—quietly brightening under healed wounds like something inside him had been named correctly for the first time in years.

Tsukihiko's hand moved again.

Faster this time.

Tracing the line of beads.

He stopped abruptly.

There was space.

An empty interval in the braid.

A deliberate gap.

Waiting.

Tsukihiko stared at it.

Then, very quietly:

> "That isn't decoration."

Chōbei's throat worked once.

> "No."

The word came out rough.

Tsukihiko finally looked back at him.

And there was something in his expression now—cold understanding layered over something far less comfortable.

> “It mapped you.”

Silence.

Outside, snow began to fall against the estate windows.

Wrong direction.

Upward.

Chōbei’s fingers twitched slightly, but he didn’t reach for the cord.

He didn’t trust what it would feel like if he did.

Tsukihiko exhaled through his nose, almost a laugh—but it didn’t carry warmth.

> “This is not worship.”

A pause.

His eyes flicked once more to the empty space in the braid.

> “It’s attention.”

That word landed heavier than the rest.

Because attention from gods was never passive.

It was structural.

Chōbei finally spoke, quieter than before:

> “Is that supposed to be comforting?”

Tsukihiko looked at him for a long moment.

Then, honestly:

> “No.”

Another silence.

The fox bell gave a single, soft chime again.

And somewhere beyond the infirmary walls—beyond Life as it should have understood itself—something unseen continued watching the exact shape of Chōbei’s survival with patient, deliberate interest.

The Crisis Part XXXI

The doors to Leora’s chambers open with a soft, reluctant creak.

Chōbei stops in the threshold.

For a fraction of a second, he doesn’t move at all.

Not because of Sukuna.

Not because of Friedhelm.

But because of her.

Leora is standing there—alive, upright, **here**—and still somehow not fully held together by anything that looks like certainty.

Even healed, she looks wrong in the way aftermaths look wrong.

Bruises still ghost across her skin beneath carefully adjusted fabric. Bandages are hidden too well to be comforting. Her hair is uneven in places where moonlight had once tried to mend it back into place. And her eyes—

Her eyes brighten the moment she sees him.

Like she has been waiting for something solid to orient herself to.

> “Chōbei.”

Sukuna is already there.

Of course he is.

He has Leora’s arm in a grip so tight it’s not affectionate anymore—it’s **refusal**. Possession edged with fear. Not fear of Chōbei.

Fear of what happens if he lets go.

Friedhelm sits slightly behind them on the bed, watching Sukuna like he’s watching a storm he already survived once and doesn’t want repeated.

Leora tries to step forward.

Sukuna tightens instantly.

The fabric of her sleeve creases under his grip. It is going to bruise again.

Chōbei sees it clearly.

And something in him goes cold.

Leora notices his expression change immediately and turns her face slightly toward Sukuna, voice soft but firm in a way only she can manage when she decides reality needs correcting.

> “Sukuna... I’m fine. If I’m with Chōbei, it’ll be fine.”

That word—*okay*—does not reach him.

Sukuna’s eyes flick to Chōbei.

There is no accusation there.

Just terror disguised as control.

Chōbei exhales once through his nose, sharp.

> “You’re insane if you think she’ll leave my sight for even a second. It’s my time. My day. She’s mine, too.”

It’s blunt.

But it lands.

Sukuna doesn’t relax.

Not fully.

But something in him stops escalating.

Leora shifts again, instinctively moving toward Chōbei now that the pressure has eased.

Sukuna’s grip tightens reflexively—

Chōbei steps forward immediately and takes Sukuna’s hand off of her harshly, before he can hurt her further.

No hesitation.

He pulls her into his side like it is the most natural thing in the world for her to be anchored there. One arm around her shoulders and back, firm but careful. His other hand steady at her neck and jaw like he’s checking without looking.

Leora exhales into him like her body remembers the shape of that safety before her mind does.

Sukuna looks away.

Not angry.

Worse.

Like he can't bear to look at what he is afraid to lose again.

Chōbei's voice drops slightly.

> "I've got her."

It isn't reassurance.

It's declaration.

Sukuna still doesn't answer.

Friedhelm, quietly watching the unraveling edges of Sukuna's control, shifts on the bed.

Then he does something simple.

He reaches out and gently takes Sukuna's arm in both hands.

Not restraining.

Not forcing.

Just holding.

His expression is soft in a way that feels unfairly disarming.

> "Stay with me?"

Sukuna freezes.

It hits him like impact without motion.

For a moment, Chōbei genuinely thinks Sukuna might collapse on the spot.

Friedhelm doesn't move his gaze.

Just waits.

And somehow, that patience is what breaks the tension.

Sukuna lowers himself slowly onto the edge of the bed beside him, as if the act of sitting is something he has to relearn under weight.

Leora watches him for a heartbeat longer.

Then lets herself fully lean into Chōbei.

> “It won’t be long,” she says softly.

Sukuna doesn’t respond.

But he doesn’t stop her.

That is the closest thing to permission he can give right now.

Chōbei adjusts his hold slightly and turns toward the door.

As they leave, Leora pauses just once—glancing back over her shoulder.

Sukuna is still there.

Friedhelm is still beside him.

And for a moment, all of them look like they are trying not to break in different directions at once.

-

Outside, the air is cooler.

Quieter.

Leora walks close to Chōbei, slower than usual, her hand brushing his sleeve like she needs to confirm he is still real.

Then she notices something—his posture, the tension under it, the exhaustion he hasn’t even tried to hide.

Her brows knit slightly.

> “You haven’t been taking care of yourself.”

It isn’t a question.

It’s immediate assessment.

Chōbei huffs under his breath, almost a laugh, almost not.

> “Neither have you.”

That makes her pause.

Then, unexpectedly, she tugs lightly at his sleeve.

> “Come on.”

He glances at her.

> “Where?”

Leora looks forward again, already deciding.

> “The onsen.”

Chōbei exhales, something like disbelief and relief tangled together in the same breath.

Despite everything—despite the ruin still hanging over them, despite the missing time, despite the way the world still feels like it hasn’t fully settled back into place—

He smiles faintly.

And follows her anyway.

The Crisis Part XXXII - Onsen

Steam curls softly through the air.

The onsen water laps quietly against stone.

And Chōbei cannot stop staring at her.

It keeps happening.

Every few minutes he looks at Leora and something inside him twists so violently he has to look away or he starts tearing up again.

Leora notices every single time.

She pretends she doesn’t.

Instead she reaches for another oil bottle Sukuna bought from the city and pours some into her hands, making a show of sniffing it critically.

> “This one smells ridiculous.”

Chōbei snorts quietly despite himself.

> “You used half the bottle.”

> “That’s because I needed to fully understand how ridiculous it was to give him my notes on the subject.”

Her voice is light.

Deliberately light.

Everything she does now is deliberate.

She keeps trying to pull him upward away from the edge he's standing on.

The shelf beside the bath catches his eye.

Hair comb.

Oils.

Folded cloth.

And beside them—

the little wooden cat.

Small enough to fit in a palm.

Rounded from years of handling.

Sukuna's gift.

Chōbei remembers asking about it once when Tsukihiko was half asleep and unusually affectionate after Kohaku's birth.

Tsukihiko had smiled faintly and said:

> "Mama used to let me play with it during baths."

Then after a pause:

> "Otosan bought it because Mama said once she liked cats."

That was all.

No grand declaration.

No ceremony.

Leora liked cats.

So Sukuna had apparently searched until he found someone to carve one for her that he deemed worthy of her and perfect in quality and form.

And then it simply became part of her life forever.

Chōbei thinks about Sukuna in the bedroom again.

About the way he looked when Leora stepped away from him.

Not angry.

Not possessive.

Hollowed out.

Like losing her had removed structural support from inside him.

And Chōbei realizes with deep certainty:

it is only going to get worse now.

Sukuna is going to become restrictive again.

Overprotective.

Controlling.

Because now he knows exactly what the world looks like without her in it.

Leora wipes water gently from Chōbei's face with a cloth.

Then stills.

Her gaze fixes on his scars.

The foxfire beneath them glows faintly silver beneath ruined flesh.

Not imagined.

Not metaphorical.

Visible.

Alive.

Leora goes quiet instantly.

Actually quiet.

Chōbei notices the shift immediately.

> "What?"

She touches the scar beneath his eye carefully.

The silver beneath the skin flickers softly against her fingertips.

And Leora understands at once.

Not partially.

Fully.

The implications settle over her like ice water.

Divine favoritism at this level is catastrophic.

Especially from something tied to:

continuation.

lineage.

survival through attachment.

Skugga is not merely watching Chōbei.

He has become emotionally invested in him specifically.

In his scars.

His survival.

His continuance.

And gods who loved things too personally eventually distorted the world around them.

Leora's expression darkens slightly.

Disturbed in a way Chōbei rarely sees.

> "That's bad, isn't it?"

She exhales slowly.

Carefully.

> "Potentially."

Her fingers brush another scar.

Silver threads answer beneath his skin.

Leora closes her eyes briefly.

Then Chōbei suddenly grabs her.

Pulls her directly into his lap.

The movement startles a small breath out of her.

And then he kisses her.

Not gently.

Desperately.

Like he's trying to force himself to believe she's alive through contact alone.

Leora kisses him back immediately.

Heat.

Water.

Steam.

For one small moment there is nothing else.

No gods.

No death.

No mutilation.

No fear.

Just Chōbei's hands on her waist and her fingers threading into damp hair. She touches the spot on his ribs that always makes him lose his mind. He makes a sound she knows well at this point. She knows he's solely focused on her. Focused only on how they're moving together, kissing, touching, and feeling. She touches it again and he keens, pulling her even closer so he can consume her. Just as she's about to empty her mind—

the guilt comes back.

Violent.

Instant.

Because this is her fault.

All of it.

Tsukihiko.

Kiyomi.

The estate.

Sukuna unraveling.

Chōbei crying beside hospital beds.

Children asking if their mother died.

Her chest tightens.

Chōbei notices immediately.

Of course he does.

He always notices.

He stops immediately.

He pulls back to look at her,

He says nothing.

Just stands, lifting her effortlessly from the water when her legs weaken slightly.

Leora clings tighter automatically.

One arm around his shoulders.

Face pressed against his neck.

Chōbei grabs towels and robes with his free hand and carries both of them from the baths.

The room beside the onsen is warm and dimly lit.

Built for resting afterward.

Safe.

Quiet.

Private.

The door slides shut behind them softly.

Chōbei dries her carefully.

Too carefully.

Like if he presses too hard she will come apart again in his hands.

The towel moves over bruised skin and every mark sends something poisonous through him.

Finger marks.

Dark bruising around her wrists.

Along her ribs.

Her thighs.

Her jaw.

Violence still written across her body in unmistakable language.

It makes him feel feral.

Not angry.

Past anger.

Something uglier.

Something that wants to find every man who touched her and reduce them to screaming ruin so complete even death would reject them afterward.

Leora watches him from the mats quietly.

Guilt shadows every movement she makes.

And Chōbei cannot stand that expression anymore.

Not on her.

Not after what she survived.

She shifts slightly beneath the robe.

Then he notices it.

The look in her eyes.

Not sadness.

Not fear.

Something warmer.

Hungrier.

But vulnerable underneath it.

She reaches out slowly and touches his ankle.

Her fingertips slide upward along his calf.

His breathing stops immediately.

Leora looks up at him softly.

> “Do you remember after I returned from the threads?”

Of course he remembers.

The memory lives under his skin like rot.

Leora trembling on wet river stones.

Eight days dead.

Terrified of touch.

Terrified of people.

Terrified of him.

He remembers the way she flinched when Sukuna moved too quickly near her.

The way she looked at all of them like she expected something horrible to happen at any second. Like she expected the only man she'd ever known intimately to hurt her in a way so disgusting it made him want to kill him himself.

Broken open from violation after violation until even affection frightened her.

Her hand moves higher.

Over his knee.

Onto his thigh.

And her voice grows quieter.

> “Do you remember when I asked if I was broken?”

Chōbei feels like the room caves inward.

Because he remembers that too.

Her voice shaking.

Her eyes empty and horrified.

Asking him if something inside her had been ruined permanently.

Asking him like he might know how to put her back together.

And now she's looking at him again.

Not afraid.

Sweet.

Open.

Wanting.

> “Will you sleep with me now?”

Chōbei stares at her.

And the question tears straight through him.

Because what he hears is not just the question.

He hears:

Why you?

Why would someone like her choose him?

Why would Leora ever want him unless it was pity?

Unless she was hurting?

Unless he was simply useful?

The memory hits him suddenly—

Tsukihiko sitting beside the screen door in dawnlight after their first time together.

So beautiful Chōbei could barely stand looking at him.

And Chōbei asking in that awful half-joking voice:

> “You do this stuff all the time or’d you just do me a favor?”

As if Tsukihiko might have slept with him out of kindness.

Out of pity.

Because how could someone like Tsukihiko ever truly want someone like him?

Leora doesn’t understand that this is what Chōbei is asking now.

So she answers honestly.

Matter-of-fact.

Earnest.

> “Because my body doesn’t feel like mine.”

Her fingers tighten slightly against his leg.

> “I know it’s technically healed... but where everything was severed... where the bones and joints had to be put back together...”

She swallows.

> “It feels wrong.”

Then quieter:

> “I want to feel like myself again.”

Her gaze lifts to his.

Soft.

Hungry.

Trusting in a way that nearly destroys him.

> “Please?”

Chōbei opens his mouth.

Nothing comes out.

He actually stammers.

Face flushing hard enough it almost hurts.

Because she is looking at him like she wants him.

Not tolerates him.

Not uses him.

Wants him.

And he has to physically look away for a second just to get control of himself again before he completely falls apart in front of her.

Leora moves into his arms before he can recover.

Just folds herself against him.

Like she belongs there.

Chōbei catches her automatically, one arm around her waist while the other braces against the floor behind him.

She presses her face into his neck.

And quietly says:

> “I’m afraid to figure it out with Sukuna.”

Chōbei stills.

Her fingers clutch tighter into his robe.

> “It gives me anxiety.”

She exhales shakily.

> “Because if anything feels wrong... if something is different...”

Her voice gets smaller.

> “It’ll upset him. It’ll...”

Chōbei closes his eyes immediately.

Because he doesn’t hear upset.

He hears the truth beneath it.

It will destroy him.

He saw Sukuna without her.

Saw what remained after only two days.

The hollow look.

The panic.

And now —

The inability to let her out of sight even for moments.

Sukuna wasn’t merely attached anymore.

He was anchored.

And anchors do not survive losing the thing they hold to.

Leora shifts suddenly.

Tightens hard against him.

Then says in a rush:

> “I understand if you feel used.”

Chōbei’s eyes snap open.

She sounds distressed now.

Like the realization genuinely hurts her.

> “Now that I hear it out loud it sounds terrible.”

Her hands grip at him desperately.

> “I didn’t mean—”

She stops herself.

Tries again.

More honestly this time.

> “You just...”

Her voice trembles.

> “You make me feel like if something *was* wrong with me...”

She swallows hard.

> “If I really was broken...”

Then quieter:

> “You wouldn’t make it about yourself.”

That hits him so hard he almost recoils.

Because she’s right.

Sukuna would blame himself.

Friedhelm would blame himself.

Tsukihiko would blame himself.

The whole household would begin carving themselves apart searching for fault.

But Chōbei...

Chōbei would simply hold her.

No conditions.

No panic over what it meant.

No fear of imperfection.

Just hold her until the shaking stopped.

Leora suddenly clings tighter.

Like she's trying to crawl inside his ribs.

And in a small wrecked voice says:

> "I love you."

Then she breaks.

Not graceful tears.

Not quiet crying.

It comes out ugly.

Raw.

Like something ripped open.

She sobs against him hard enough her whole body shakes.

And Chōbei realizes with horror she's been holding this in since she woke up.

The guilt.

The fear.

The violation.

The sight of everyone broken around her because she came back in pieces.

She cries like she's ashamed to exist this way.

And Chōbei feels something inside himself tear violently.

He pulls her fully into his lap.

One hand cradling the back of her head.

The other gripping her so tightly it borders on desperate.

> “Don’t do that.”

His voice breaks immediately.

> “Don’t you ever think I’d feel used by you.”

He presses his face into her hair.

Breathing hard.

Almost shaking himself now.

> “Leora... you could ask me for anything.”

His arms tighten harder.

> “Anything.”

She sobs harder at that.

And Chōbei finally understands something horrible:

Leora genuinely believed she might disgust him now.

After everything done to her.

After all the violence.

She thought he might look at her differently.

The realization makes him feel sick.

So he cups her face hard enough to force her to look at him.

Tears standing openly in his own eyes now.

> “Listen to me.”

His voice is rough.

Uneven.

> “You and Tsukihiko are the most beautiful things I’ve ever touched.”

Her crying falters.

And he says it again immediately.

Like she *needs* it understood.

> “Nothing could happen to you that would make me stop wanting you.”

He kisses her forehead.

Then her cheek.

Then the corner of her mouth.

Tender.

Reverent.

Like he’s trying to undo every horrible hand that ever touched her.

> “Nothing.”

Leora presses closer to him.

Not hungry now.

Not desperate.

Just needing.

Needing warmth.

Weight.

Presence.

Chōbei guides her down slowly onto the mats and blankets with impossible care.

Every movement measured.

Every touch cautious.

He watches her face constantly.

Her breathing.

Her eyes.

The slightest hesitation.

Like he’s learning her body all over again after someone tried to destroy it.

And through it all he keeps touching her gently.

Grounding her.

Hands smoothing over her arms.
Her waist.
Her hair.

Kissing her forehead.
Her throat.
Her shoulder.

Not taking.

Reassuring.

As if every touch says:

- > You are loved.
- > You are wanted.
- > You are still yourself.
- > You survived.

And Leora slowly relaxes beneath him.

The tension leaves her inch by inch.

Until finally she clings to him instead of bracing against herself.

Afterward, they stay tangled together quietly.

Chōbei half over her, breathing unevenly while she strokes her fingers through his hair.

Then her hand drifts lower.

To his scars.

The foxfire beneath them immediately brightens.

Silver threads illuminating softly beneath damaged flesh.

Across his mouth.
His neck.
Beneath his ruined eye.

The glow pulses warmly under her fingertips.

Leora stills instantly.

Concern floods her expression so quickly it hurts to see.

Chōbei notices immediately.

Before she can pull away, he catches her hand and presses kisses all over her knuckles and wrist.

Trying to distract her.

Trying to stop that look.

But she whispers softly:

> “I’m worried.”

Chōbei sighs quietly against her skin.

Of course she is.

Leora touches one glowing scar carefully.

The silver light follows her fingertip beneath his flesh.

Too alive.

Too aware.

And she looks genuinely disturbed now.

> “A deity should not be this invested in a person.”

Her voice lowers further.

Thoughtful.

Troubled.

> “Not like this.”

Chōbei watches her.

The moonlight catches bruises still lingering along her throat and jaw.

And suddenly he understands something terrible:

Leora isn’t frightened for herself.

She’s frightened for him.

Because she understands gods.

She understands what it means when something ancient begins choosing favorites.

Her fingers tighten slightly against his chest.

> “Attachment from beings like that always costs something eventually.”

Chōbei leans down and kisses her again before she can spiral deeper into the thought.

Slow.
Careful.

Then presses his forehead to hers.

> “Yeah?”

His voice is rough with exhaustion and affection.

> “Well maybe he’s got shit taste and I’ll disappoint him soon and he’ll give me up.”

Leora actually huffs out a tiny laugh despite herself.

> “He has excellent tastes. I would.... Oh Chobei, if I was a goddess... it would be worse.”

But the worry remains in her eyes.

And Chōbei realizes she’s truly afraid that Skugga’s attention may one day demand something from him.

Or worse—

change him.

So he pulls her tighter against him.

Scarred fingers threading through her hair.

> “I’m not goin’ anywhere, pretty thing.”

Simple.

Solid.

Certain.

> “And if some fox god wants to stare at me survivein’, then he can get in line.”

The Crisis Part XXXIII

When Chōbei returned Leora to the chambers, it felt exactly like that.

Returning her.

The realization soured something inside him immediately.

Because he had fought for his place with her.

Not stolen.

Not borrowed.

Not temporary.

His.

Separate from Tsukihiko.

Separate from Sukuna.

Separate from anyone else.

And yet the moment he crossed the threshold carrying the warmth of her still lingering against him, it felt like he was handing her back over.

He hated that feeling more than he wanted to admit.

Inside, Sukuna was half reclined against the headboard while Friedhelm rested nearly naked against him with complete shamelessness, head in his lap like some enormous dangerous cat that had decided the angry human it found belonged to it now.

Friedhelm looked peaceful for the first time in days.

Sukuna did not.

The moment Leora entered, Sukuna's attention locked onto her so intensely it almost felt physical.

Leora softened immediately.

> "I had a nice time with Chobei and I came back. I think he did a good job."

Then before leaving Chōbei's side completely, she reached up and touched his face fondly.

Her fingers brushed one glowing scar.

The foxfire beneath his skin shifted instantly.

Silver light unfurled beneath damaged flesh.

And then—

Sukuna was suddenly in front of him.

Fast enough Chōbei barely tracked it.

A large hand grabbed his jaw hard and turned his face toward the light.

Chōbei stiffened.

Sukuna stared.

Sharp irritation flickered across his face first.

Then fascination.

Because the markings were beautiful.

Infuriatingly so.

The silver foxfire threading beneath ruined flesh made Chōbei look less human in a way Sukuna immediately recognized as dangerous.

Not because of power.

Because of attention.

Possession.

Admiration.

Sukuna knew possessiveness when he saw it.

This was not a blessing.

This was a god publicly admiring someone.

Claiming interest openly.

And worse—

Chōbei visibly hated being perceived this intimately.

Which somehow made Sukuna even angrier.

Because now something ancient had looked at Chōbei closely enough to recreate every scar on his body bead by bead.

Something about that thought made Sukuna's expression darken immediately.

And Chōbei noticed with horrifying clarity—

Sukuna was considering him differently now.

Not stray dog.

Not nuisance.

Not irritating adopted disaster.

Not merely Tsukihiko's lover.

Not merely Leora's.

Something else.

Something Sukuna suddenly wanted nowhere near the rest of the world.

The realization nearly made Chōbei nauseous.

Kurohiko's words echoed violently in his head.

> "You're Otosan's first real friend."

Then:

> "Please don't start sleeping with him."

The thought alone made Chōbei want to throw up.

Which honestly reassured him enormously.

Maybe Sukuna had some kind of cursed technique that made everyone eventually end up in his bed. He's insufferable, a bastard, and then suddenly tender and extremely protective.

At this point it seemed statistically possible.

Chōbei grabbed Sukuna's wrist and tried pulling away.

Sukuna didn't let go.

Instead his thumb dragged once across the glowing scar beneath Chōbei's ruined eye.

The foxfire reacted immediately.

Brightening.

That made Sukuna's eyes narrow dangerously.

> "When did this happen?"

Before Chōbei could answer, Leora stepped back toward them.

She reached out and took Sukuna's wrist.

Not frightened.

Not soft about it either.

Firm.

Certain.

> “It’s one thing to grab me.”

Sukuna looked at her immediately.

And Leora’s voice lowered in a way that made the room sharpen.

> “Don’t grab Chōbei.”

Silence.

Heavy silence.

Because this wasn’t teasing.

Wasn’t negotiation.

It was a boundary.

A serious one.

Even Friedhelm lifted his head slightly at the tone.

Chōbei felt Sukuna’s grip loosen almost immediately.

Not because he wanted to release him.

Because Leora asked.

And that somehow felt worse.

Sukuna slowly let go of Chōbei’s face.

But his eyes stayed fixed on the glowing scars.

Cold.

Thoughtful.

Possessive in a way Chōbei deeply disliked recognizing.

Then Sukuna finally spoke.

Quietly.

Disgusted.

> “That thing likes you too much.”

Chōbei barked out a rough laugh immediately.

> “Yeah? You sound personally offended by that.”

Friedhelm made a startled choking sound.

Leora's mouth twitched.

And for one brief second—

something almost normal returned to the room.

The Crisis Part XXXIV

The next few nights became something strange.

Not peaceful.

Not normal.

Possessive.

Sukuna kept both Leora and Friedhelm in his chambers constantly.

If Leora stood, he stood.

If Friedhelm moved, Sukuna's eyes followed instantly.

He never allowed distance anymore.

Never.

His hand was always on Leora somewhere.

Fisted tightly into fabric.

Wrapped around her wrist.

Resting heavy over her ankle beneath blankets.

Curled possessively into her hair while she rested against him.

Sometimes he held on so tightly she would look down at his hand with that soft aching expression that made something inside him twist violently.

But she never asked him to let go.

Not once.

When she went to bathe, Sukuna waited directly outside the door or came with her and sat next to the water or in the water with her.

When she walked the estate, he followed close enough their sleeves brushed constantly.

And Friedhelm—

Friedhelm was never allowed farther than arm's reach either.

It became almost absurd.

If Friedhelm so much as mentioned needing thread, Sukuna returned with entire sewing baskets.

Paints.

Brushes.

Paper.

Rare herbs.

Dried flowers.

Books.

Books that Leora swore had not been seen in centuries.

Some hidden impossible library Sukuna apparently kept buried away solely to occasionally satisfy the people he cared for.

The servants stopped reacting eventually.

Though many stared in open disbelief the first time Sukuna personally arranged blankets around Friedhelm because he looked cold.

At night it became worse.

Leora would curl into Sukuna's chest and he would slowly stroke his fingers through her repaired hair for hours at a time.

Sometimes he would pause suddenly—

as if checking she was still there.

Still breathing.

Still warm.

And when he kissed her, she made soft pleased sounds and tucked herself impossibly closer against him.

Not frightened.

Not burdened.

Safe.

That nearly destroyed him more than her absence had.

Because she trusted him completely after everything.

Friedhelm was quieter about it.

But Sukuna could feel the trembling in him whenever he leaned close.

The slight shake of his lips during kisses.

The way he pressed nearer afterward like he could not help himself.

Like he still expected to wake up alone in Helheim.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna did not know how he had arrived here.

Did not know when his chambers had stopped belonging solely to him and Leora.

When Friedhelm's robes began hanging near the doors.

When the bed no longer felt survivable empty.

He only knew one thing with unbearable certainty now:

He would never survive losing them again.

Never.

The world had already shown him what existence without Leora felt like.

Silence.

Emptiness.

Children asking for their mother.

An untouched side of the bed.

And Friedhelm—

Friedhelm disappearing with her had carved out something equally catastrophic.

Because Sukuna had realized too late that Friedhelm had quietly threaded himself through every corner of their lives until his absence became horrifying too.

So now Sukuna held on.

Constantly.

Relentlessly.

Like a starving creature finally understanding hunger after centuries of never needing anything.

And some nights, when Leora slept against his chest and Friedhelm rested tucked into his side, Sukuna stayed awake simply listening to them breathe.

Counting each breath unconsciously.

As though vigilance alone could keep death from ever touching them again.

The Crisis Part XXXV - Eirvorr Returns

The room changed so suddenly Sukuna knew immediately it was not human.

Not cursed energy.

Not death.

Something older.

The shadows stopped moving first.

Then the warmth drained slowly from the chambers until frost traced silver patterns across the wooden floorboards.

The candles dimmed.

Not extinguished.

Subdued.

Like lesser flames bowing instinctively to something greater.

Sukuna's eyes opened instantly.

Beside him, Leora remained asleep curled against his chest, fingers loosely wrapped around his wrist beneath the blankets.

Friedhelm slept against his side similarly tangled around his other arm.

Neither stirred.

That alone disturbed Sukuna.

Because both of them woke at the slightest shift lately.

Especially Leora.

Yet now—

nothing.

Sukuna looked up.

And saw four pale flames staring back at him from the darkness.

Eirvorr stood at the edge of the bed like he had always been there.

Massive.

Still.

Black antlers nearly disappearing into shadow above him.

The four burning eyes drifted slowly across the three of them.

Watching.

Assessing.

Satisfied.

Sukuna immediately reached for Leora tighter.

Eirvorr noticed.

Of course he noticed.

One of the pale flames tilted slightly toward Sukuna.

Then the god extended a blood-stained hand toward the bed.

> “How does it feel,” Eirvorr asked quietly, “to have Vetrbríð and Heilsundr returned to you?”

His hand brushed over Leora’s head gently.

She sighed softly in her sleep and unconsciously pressed closer toward the touch.

Eirvorr was intensely pleased by it.

He dared to even caress her cheek with the back of one finger.

Sukuna’s expression darkened instantly.

He would remove the finger.

> “What are you doing.”

Eirvorr looked genuinely puzzled by the hostility.

> “Correcting something unpleasant.”

His gaze drifted slowly over the bruises still faintly shadowing Leora's skin.

The handprints.

Finger marks.

Lingering signs of violence.

Something cold entered his voice.

> "I cannot stand looking at her covered by them anymore."

Then he touched her more firmly.

Sukuna moved immediately.

Violence sharpened through the room so fast frost burst outward beneath the bed.

But Eirvorr only looked at him calmly.

> "Your instincts are sharper now that she is back."

Not mocking.

Observing.

Like discussing weather.

Sukuna hated how accurate it was.

Eirvorr's hand passed once through Leora's hair.

Moonlight spilled between his fingers.

The damaged uneven strands immediately began lengthening.

Silver-white hair threaded itself back together impossibly fast.

Smooth.

Whole.

Shimmering exactly as it had before the clearing.

Sukuna stared.

Leora made another soft pleased sound in her sleep.

Sukuna felt betrayed; she made such sounds for Eirvorr to hear.

Eirvorr savored them.

Then Eirvorr turned toward Friedhelm.

Friedhelm twitched faintly as cold fingers brushed through pale hair.

The deep bruising scattered across his throat and shoulders slowly disappeared beneath moonlit frost.

Bone settled correctly.

Damaged flesh restored itself.

Even the exhaustion etched into him softened slightly.

Sukuna watched silently.

Unable to reconcile fury with gratitude.

Eirvorr studied them both afterward with visible satisfaction.

Then one pale flame drifted toward Chōbei's absent place in the room.

Thoughtful.

> "Skugga's markings suit One-Eye beautifully."

Sukuna immediately disliked where this was going.

Eirvorr tilted his head slowly.

Actually considering something.

> "Perhaps Vetrbríð and Heilsundr should also be marked properly."

The temperature in the room dropped violently.

Sukuna's cursed energy surged instantly.

Pure instinct.

Possessive.

Territorial.

Dangerous.

Eirvorr looked delighted.

Actually delighted.

> "There it is."

One flaming eye narrowed slightly.

> “The permanence.”

Sukuna’s voice came out low and lethal.

> “Don’t touch them further. Do not lay marks upon them. They are perfect as they are.”

Silence followed.

Then Eirvorr looked down at the sleeping siblings still wrapped around Sukuna’s wrists.

Leora breathing softly against his chest.

Friedhelm tucked against his side.

Held instinctively even in sleep.

And something ancient shifted behind the god’s burning eyes.

Recognition.

Not of love.

Of inevitability.

> “You truly believe they are yours,” Eirvorr murmured.

Sukuna answered immediately.

Without hesitation.

> “They are.”

The frost spreading through the room stopped entirely.

Then Eirvorr smiled.

Slowly.

Terribly.

Like a god witnessing prophecy unfold exactly as expected.

The Crisis Part XXXVI - Eirvorr Returns

Part II - Prophecy

Eirvorr's four pale flames remained fixed on Sukuna as though he were studying the shape of something inevitable.

Then his gaze lowered toward Leora sleeping peacefully against Sukuna's chest.

> "I warned you," Eirvorr said quietly. "Men who believe they own her will come."

Sukuna's grip tightened instinctively around Leora beneath the blankets.

But Eirvorr continued.

> "Yet those are not the ones you should fear most."

The room had become utterly silent now.

Even the candles no longer flickered.

> "There will also come those who seek only her approval."

One pale flame drifted slowly downward toward Leora's hand curled against Sukuna's robes.

> "Those who would devote themselves entirely to her judgment. To her mercy. To her disappointment."

His voice lowered slightly.

Something ***prophetic*** enters his voice again:

> "They will abandon one life willingly for another if she asks it."

Sukuna did not like where this was going.

At all.

> "True humility," Eirvorr murmured. "True sacrifice."

Then:

> "But they are few. There will be blood. You must defer to her judgement of who lives and who dies."

Sukuna stared at him.

The god's attention shifted abruptly.

> “What of Linnea?”

Instant hostility sharpened through Sukuna.

> “What about her.”

Eirvorr ignored the threat in his tone.

> “Have the flowers begun growing yet?”

Sukuna frowned immediately.

He pulled Leora and Friedhelm closer unconsciously.

> “I don’t know what you mean.”

Eirvorr sighed softly.

Then looked openly at Leora again.

Not lustfully.

Not gently.

Reverently.

Like observing a sacred thing damaged by lesser hands.

> “Have you told her yet,” he asked Sukuna, “that you were not the one who retrieved them from Helheim?”

Sukuna’s jaw tightened instantly.

He immediately felt it.

Shame.

Hot.

Wickedly painful.

> “No.”

> “What exactly did you do?”

Eirvorr grew still.

And when he answered, his voice sounded older than the room itself.

> “Helheim is not merely death.”

Frost crept slowly over the bedframe.

> “It is continuation after conclusion. A place where endings are preserved rather than erased.”

One pale flame shifted toward Friedhelm.

> “Heilsundr understood this.”

Sukuna looked down at Friedhelm sleeping beside him.

> “Taking her there was the final method available to him.”

Eirvorr’s gaze lowered.

> “He split her injuries between them.”

Sukuna’s stomach twisted immediately.

Because now—

now he understood why Friedhelm had returned ruined too.

Why the bruising mirrored hers.

Why his body looked partially destroyed despite not being present in the clearing.

> “But there were too many wounds,” Eirvorr continued. “Too much damage.”

His expression darkened faintly.

> “The deity of Helheim left them upon the road.”

A pause.

Then:

> “Dismembered. Breathing. Still reaching for one another.”

Sukuna went cold.

Eirvorr continued more quietly now.

> “Because they crossed too deeply into Helheim...”

He stopped.

Actually stopped.

Sukuna’s voice sharpened immediately.

> “Why did you stop speaking.”

For the first time, something almost amused appeared across Eirvorr’s face.

Not mockery.

Recognition.

He reached down absentmindedly and touched across Leora's outer thigh over the blankets and then downward into her inner thigh.

Sukuna reacted instantly.

Violence exploded through the room so fast the walls cracked with cursed pressure.

Eirvorr merely smoothed his hand calmly downward along her leg to her foot as though Sukuna's reaction had been expected.

Which made it worse.

> "They had gone too deep to return naturally," Eirvorr said.

Sukuna forced himself still through sheer effort.

> "Explain."

> "They would have survived."

The god's burning eyes dimmed slightly.

> "Eventually."

Then:

> "Centuries from now."

Sukuna stared at him.

Eirvorr's voice became colder.

> "Helheim had already begun keeping them."

One pale flame flickered softly toward Friedhelm.

> "Especially Vetrbríð."

A pause.

> "The deity there would not have relinquished her willingly."

Leora shifted faintly in her sleep at those words.

Sukuna held her tighter immediately.

Then Eirvorr said:

> “So I removed them.”

Silence.

> “I brought them out of Helheim to the deepest edge of death.”

His gaze lowered toward Leora’s restored hair spread across Sukuna’s chest.

> “To the river beneath the moon I made for Vetrbríð.”

Sukuna went perfectly still.

Actually still.

Then slowly:

> “What do you mean...”

His voice sounded wrong even to himself.

> “You made her a moon?”

Eirvorr looked genuinely perplexed by the question.

Not offended.

Confused.

As though Sukuna had failed to understand something obvious.

The four pale flames watched him steadily.

Then Eirvorr asked quietly:

> “Would you not create a moon for her if you could?”

The question struck Sukuna harder than expected.

Because the answer came immediately.

Without thought.

Without hesitation.

Yes.

Of course he would.

He would split apart worlds for her if necessary.

Would drag stars down into her hands if she desired them.

Would rebuild reality itself around her comfort if given enough strength.

And Eirvorr knew it from the look on his face alone.

The god's expression softened into something almost satisfied.

> "Exactly."

Frost drifted slowly across the blankets near Leora's sleeping form.

Eirvorr looked at her the way ancient things looked at sacred places.

> "So I made one."

His voice lowered slightly.

> "A moon untouched by mortal skies."

The pale flames dimmed softly.

> "And the deepest portion of death beneath it."

Sukuna listened in silence now.

Because Eirvorr did not sound delusional.

Or metaphorical.

He sounded practical.

Like an architect describing a completed structure.

> "I wished for Vetrbríð to have a place worthy of her."

His gaze traced Leora's restored hair.

> "A place that belonged solely to her."

Then:

> "A place worthy of her glory."

Sukuna hated how sincere the god sounded.

No obsession.

No madness.

Only certainty.

Like Leora's magnificence was simply a fact universally acknowledged by powerful things.

Eirvorr continued calmly:

> "Heilsundr already possesses a place beside Skugga."

One pale flame shifted toward Friedhelm sleeping peacefully tucked against Sukuna's side.

> "He has a sun. Open fields of wheat and trees for shade. The foxes run wild and there are plenty of places to paint and swim. Skugga has been crafting it for over a thousand years waiting for Heilsundr's birth."

A pause.

> "And for her, she has a moon, endless moving water, flower beds to lay down and rest in. She has..."

Eirvorr seems lost in his own thoughts.

Another pause.

> "They will remain connected regardless."

The way he spoke made Sukuna's skin crawl slightly.

Not because it sounded threatening.

Because it sounded decided.

Absolute.

Like Eirvorr was not predicting a future—

he was recalling one.

A book already read countless times.

Sukuna realized suddenly that Eirvorr spoke about eternity the way humans spoke about tomorrow.

Then Eirvorr said quietly:

> "I could have kept them."

Sukuna's entire body tightened instantly.

The god looked entirely unbothered by the reaction.

> "They were damaged enough."

His gaze lowered toward Leora.

> “Especially her.”

The room became colder.

> “It would have been easy to let Helheim close around them fully. But, I wouldn’t have done that. They deserve the places Skugga and I created for them.”

Sukuna’s fingers tightened instinctively against Leora’s back beneath the blankets.

Eirvorr watched the motion.

Interested.

> “But then,” he said slowly, “I thought of her children.”

For the first time, something resembling reluctant understanding entered his voice.

> “How distressed she would become separated from them.”

Leora shifted faintly in her sleep as if hearing him distantly.

Sukuna felt her press unconsciously closer against him.

Then Eirvorr added:

> “And she chose you.”

Sukuna looked up sharply.

Eirvorr met his stare directly now.

All four pale flames focused entirely upon him.

> “If she had not been allowed to say goodbye on her own terms...”

A faint pause.

Then something almost amused crossed the god’s face.

> “She would have become troublesome.”

Sukuna stared at him.

And suddenly—

suddenly he could picture it perfectly.

Leora in death.

Refusing permanence itself.
Refusing gods.
Refusing endings.

Demanding her children.
Demanding Sukuna.
Demanding Friedhelm.

Demanding to return.

Eirvorr seemed to see the realization settle into him.

> “Vetrbríð does not yield gracefully,” he said quietly.

Then one pale flame drifted slowly toward Leora’s sleeping face again.

Fondly.

> “It is one of the reasons she interests me so deeply.”

Eirvorr stood motionless beside the bed while frost spread in slow delicate patterns beneath his feet.

The four pale flames remained fixed on Sukuna now.

Studying him.

Not casually.

Intimately.

Like something ancient attempting to understand another ancient thing.

Then Eirvorr asked quietly:

> “Why does Vetrbríð interest you?”

Sukuna frowned immediately.

But the god continued before he could answer.

> “Why did you choose her?”

One pale flame drifted toward Leora sleeping peacefully against Sukuna’s chest.

> “Why choose her over chaos?”

Another flame.

> “Over genocide?”

Another.

> “Over power?”

The last remained fixed directly on Sukuna.

> “Why remain here in this place with their children?”

His voice lowered further.

> “Why care for their children?”

Sukuna felt something uncomfortable move beneath the questions.

Because Eirvorr was not mocking him.

He genuinely wanted to know.

As if Sukuna himself had become something fascinating.

Sukuna’s hand tightened slightly in Leora’s hair.

> “They’re mine.”

The answer came immediately.

Instinctively.

Eirvorr went still.

Then:

> “Yes.”

Something almost approving entered his tone.

> “They are.”

The god tilted his head slightly.

> “Would you like more power to ensure they remain safe?”

Sukuna’s eyes sharpened instantly.

Dangerously.

Eirvorr looked unsurprised.

> “You are already considering it.”

Not a question.

An observation.

Then the god spoke again.

And this time the room itself seemed to narrow around the words.

> “What of Heilsundr’s song this year?”

Sukuna froze.

Eirvorr’s gaze remained steady.

> “The one where he tells Vetrbríð that you will eventually be split into ten pieces.”

A pause.

Then calmly:

> “How have you begun planning for this?”

Something cold entered Sukuna’s spine immediately.

Not fear.

Something worse.

Recognition.

Because Eirvorr had not asked if it would happen.

Only how Sukuna intended to prepare.

Begun to plan.

As though the future already existed somewhere fixed and waiting.

Sukuna’s cursed energy shifted sharply through the room.

Eirvorr ignored it completely.

> “Do you wear the bracelet?”

Sukuna’s gaze dropped instinctively toward his wrist.

The oath band rested there quietly beneath the blankets.

Eirvorr noticed immediately.

Then the god smiled faintly.

Not kindly.

Curiously.

> “Vetrbríð went to extraordinary lengths improving that protection for you.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed.

> “What do you mean.”

Eirvorr’s pale flames brightened softly.

> “Her blood is within it.”

A pause.

> “Her blood and the blood of countless others.”

Sukuna stared at him.

Actually stared.

Because—

no.

Leora had never said—

Eirvorr noticed instantly.

And something deeply amused entered his expression.

> “So,” he murmured, “you did not know.”

His gaze lowered briefly toward the bracelet.

> “She slaughtered over one thousand innocent souls to forge your protection.”

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Sukuna felt Leora breathing softly against him.

Friedhelm sleeping beside him.

Warm.

Alive.

And suddenly—

suddenly the bracelet around his wrist felt impossibly heavy.

Eirvorr continued softly:

> “Curious.”

One pale flame tilted slightly.

> “She did not hesitate even once.”

Sukuna’s throat tightened unexpectedly.

Because he believed it instantly.

Of course she would.

Of course she had.

The god watched realization settle into him slowly.

> “Vetrbríð has always understood something important about love.”

Frost spread slowly over the edge of the bedframe.

> “Protection is rarely clean.”

Then Eirvorr’s gaze sharpened slightly.

> “You slaughter openly.”

A pale flame drifted toward Leora.

> “She slaughters quietly.”

Another pause.

> “But she is far crueler when she chooses to be.”

And somehow—

somehow—

that unsettled Sukuna more than the number itself.

The room remained deathly still after Eirvorr’s revelation.

Leora slept peacefully against Sukuna’s chest.

Unaware.

Friedhelm’s breathing remained soft against his side.

And Sukuna sat between them feeling the weight of the bracelet around his wrist like something newly alive.

One thousand souls.

For him.

Not for power.
Not for immortality.
Not for herself.

For him.

Eirvorr watched the realization settle into him with quiet fascination.

Then he asked again:

> “Why do you love Vetrbríð?”

The question landed differently this time.

Heavier.

Closer.

Sukuna stared down at Leora’s sleeping face.

At her restored hair spread across him like moonlight.

At the faint exhaustion still shadowing her despite Eirvorr’s healing.

At the way even unconscious she remained wrapped around him instinctively.

His hand moved through her hair slowly.

Carefully.

And for once—

for once Sukuna did not answer immediately.

Because the answer felt too large now.

Too enormous to fit into simple words.

Finally:

> “Because she remained.”

Eirvorr went still.

Sukuna's voice lowered.

> "Everyone feared me. Worshipped me. Wanted something from me."

His fingers tightened slightly in Leora's hair.

> "She didn't."

Another pause.

> "She saw me completely."

The room grew colder.

> "And she stayed anyway."

Eirvorr's pale flames dimmed slightly.

Listening.

Actually listening.

Sukuna looked down at Friedhelm next.

At the way he slept curled instinctively toward both of them.

Fragile looking.

Unbelievably devoted.

> "Then she made this."

His voice sounded rougher now.

More honest than he intended.

> "A home."

The word itself felt strange leaving his mouth.

But true.

Painfully true.

> "Children."

A pause.

> "People who wait for me to return."

His gaze sharpened slightly.

> “People I would kill gods for.”

Silence followed.

Then Eirvorr asked softly:

> “And if they die?”

Sukuna answered instantly.

> “Then the world dies after them.”

The frost in the room surged violently outward.

Not from Sukuna.

From Eirvorr.

The god stared at him now with unmistakable interest.

Not casual fascination anymore.

Recognition.

Like something fundamental had just confirmed itself.

Then slowly—

very slowly—

Eirvorr smiled.

Terribly.

Beautifully.

> “Yes.”

One pale flame drifted closer toward Sukuna.

> “There it is.”

The pressure in the room deepened suddenly.

Reality itself tightening.

Sukuna’s instincts screamed immediately.

Eirvorr had decided something.

> “I understand now.”

The god’s voice echoed strangely.

Too deep.

Too vast.

> “You love her as permanence loves existence.”

Sukuna’s cursed energy sharpened instantly.

> “What are you doing.”

Eirvorr ignored the question entirely.

> “You require more power.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed dangerously.

> “I didn’t ask you for anything.”

> “No,” Eirvorr agreed calmly. “But I have decided.”

The four pale flames brightened.

The frost reached the ceiling now.

Cracks spread silently across the walls.

And for the first time since appearing—

Eirvorr’s presence became truly overwhelming.

Ancient.

Inevitable.

Godlike in a way Sukuna hated instinctively.

> “You will not survive what approaches as you are now.”

Leora shifted faintly in her sleep.

Sukuna immediately tightened around her protectively.

Eirvorr watched the motion with visible satisfaction.

> “Good.”

Then the god stepped closer to the bed.

Too close.

> “So I will strengthen you.”

Sukuna’s entire body tensed.

Violence exploded through his instincts instantly.

But Eirvorr only looked at him steadily.

> “Because Vetrbríð chose you.”

A pause.

Then softly:

> “And I would prefer not to watch her suffer your absence.”

The Crisis Part XXXVII - Eirvorr Returns Part III - Fight

The transition into Death was instantaneous.

No tearing.

No falling.

One moment Sukuna was in bed holding Leora and Friedhelm—

the next he stood upon a silent plain beneath a black sky full of unmoving stars.

Cold silver grass stretched endlessly around him.

No wind.

No sound.

Only Eirvorr.

The god stood some distance away, massive and motionless beneath the endless dark.

And above them—

the sky moved.

Not clouds.

Memories.

Leora.

Sukuna looked up immediately.

He saw her as a child wandering winter forests wrapped in fur too large for her shoulders.

Saw her kneeling beside dying animals trying to save them.

Saw her bloodied hands learning rituals.

Saw loneliness.

Saw fury.

Saw devotion.

Saw her laughing for the first time beside Friedhelm near a frozen river.

Eirvorr paused there longer than necessary.

Affectionately.

Then another moment.

Leora younger still.

Sleeping beside stacks of books with moonlight across her face.

Paused longer.

Another.

Leora weeping silently while stitching together wounds no child should understand.

Paused.

Affection.

Recognition.

The god was not merely observing her life.

He cherished parts of it.

Sukuna's jaw tightened.

Then—

there he was.

The first moment she saw him.

The moment her existence bent irreversibly toward him.

Eirvorr let that memory linger longest of all.

Then finally the god looked at Sukuna.

> “Fight me.”

The plain darkened slightly.

Sukuna flexed his hand instinctively.

And immediately—

immediately—

he missed the warmth against him.

Leora.

The weight of her.

Friedhelm curled nearby.

Their breathing.

Gone.

Eirvorr noticed instantly.

And smiled.

Then he lifted one hand.

The silver grass parted behind him.

Revealing a bed of pale flowers growing impossibly from the black earth.

Leora and Friedhelm slept there peacefully together.

Unharmmed.

Leora curled toward Friedhelm instinctively.

Friedhelm’s hand tangled loosely in her hair.

Safe.

Eirvorr's voice lowered slightly.

> "No matter how intensely we fight, they will remain untouched."

One pale flame shifted toward the sleeping pair.

> "Neither of us would focus otherwise."

Sukuna exhaled slowly through his nose.

Because the god was correct.

Eirvorr stepped closer.

> "Remove it."

Sukuna's gaze sharpened.

> "What."

> "The construct."

The pale flames watched him steadily.

> "The shape you wear to resemble something smaller. More human."

A pause.

Then:

> "I wish to fight you honestly."

The frost beneath Eirvorr's feet deepened.

> "As the man Vetrbríð loves."

His voice became quieter.

More intimate.

> "Nothing more."

A pause.

> "Nothing less."

Sukuna stared at him for a long moment.

Then slowly—

his body shifted.

The illusion peeled away.

Extra arms.

Extra eyes.

The full monstrous reality of him emerging beneath the silent sky.

The plain itself reacted.

Silver grass bent outward violently.

Eirvorr looked pleased.

Not disturbed.

Pleased.

Then something above caught Sukuna's attention.

The sky had changed again.

Another memory.

No—

not memory.

Something else.

Leora knelt crying upon a dark floor.

The floor of the estate.

Broken.

Older somehow.

She clutched an older, thin silver band in trembling fingers.

Her voice echoed faintly across the plain.

> "I'm sorry."

She looked toward someone absent.

> "Friedhelm..."

Then again—

softer.

More devastated.

> “Wulf... Woeflchen, please, please forgive me.”

Sukuna froze instantly.

Leora’s shoulders shook violently.

Then:

> “Thank you.”

Eirvorr lifted one hand.

The vision stopped immediately.

Frozen.

Sukuna’s voice came out dangerous.

> “What is that.”

Eirvorr looked up at the halted image.

Then back toward Sukuna.

> “A possible continuation.”

Not prophecy.

Not warning.

Continuation.

The distinction unsettled Sukuna deeply.

Then Eirvorr smiled slightly.

> “Impress me.”

The black sky cracked faintly with pale light.

> “And I will show you what happens next.”

The Crisis Part XXXVIII - Eirvorr Returns

Part IV - Fight

The plain changed the moment Sukuna accepted the fight.

Silver grass blackened.

Snow began falling upward.

And the distant forest surrounding them froze solid beneath moonlight that did not belong to any human sky.

Eirvorr stood motionless across from him.

At first—

still comprehensible.

Humanoid.

Black skin smooth as polished obsidian.
Towering stag antlers branching endlessly upward.
Four pale flames burning where eyes should exist.
Blood dripping steadily from both hands into the snow.

But the longer Sukuna looked—

the less stable the shape became.

Too many joints.

Limbs slightly too long.

Movements delayed strangely.

As though reality itself needed time to understand where Eirvorr had already moved.

And once—

only once—

Sukuna realized with sudden instinctive revulsion that Eirvorr had stepped forward before his body visually followed.

That alone was horrifying.

Then Sukuna attacked.

Of course he did.

Because Sukuna refused—
absolutely refused—
to allow himself to become psychologically cornered first.

Cleave erupted outward instantly.

The frozen forest split apart.

Entire trees collapsed in razor-fine pieces.
The ground ruptured open beneath the snow.
Black fissures screamed through the plain.

And Eirvorr simply walked through it.

The cuts landed.

Sukuna saw them clearly.

Black blood spilled steaming into the snow.

One shoulder split open.
Ribcage exposed beneath obsidian flesh.

But Eirvorr did not slow.

Did not react.

Instead—

he looked pleased.

The god's distorted body continued forward with impossible calm.

And Sukuna understood immediately:

this would not be a battle of speed.

Neither of them wasted movement.

No screaming.
No grand displays.

Every motion carried certainty.

Every strike intended death.

Eirvorr moved like inevitability itself.

Not overwhelming.

Closing.

Every time Sukuna shifted position—

Eirvorr already occupied the next logical space.

Like winter consuming roads one by one.

Like hunting.

Like death quietly reducing options.

Sukuna adapted instantly, changing angles, trajectories, attack patterns.

It did not matter.

Eirvorr remained there.

Waiting.

Watching.

Then the god spoke while black blood dripped slowly from his split torso.

> “You fear absence more than pain now.”

Sukuna’s cursed energy sharpened violently.

Another strike.

Another catastrophic rupture through the forest.

Eirvorr avoided it before Sukuna consciously finished deciding the attack.

> “You already know what her silence would do to you.”

That landed worse.

Because it was true.

Two days.

Only two days without Leora and Sukuna had nearly unraveled completely.

Eirvorr continued advancing.

Not hurried.

Never hurried.

> “You have finally learned why gods become cruel.”

That one struck deepest of all.

Because Sukuna understood instantly.

Perfectly.

Power meant nothing once something irreplaceable existed.

Cruelty became preservation.

Possession became protection.

The forest stopped surviving around them entirely.

Not from destruction.

From rejection.

Reality itself began failing.

Snow evaporated midair.

Trees split apart internally without being touched.

The false moon overhead flickered wrong.

Sukuna attacked harder.

Faster.

More violently.

And finally—

finally—

he landed a strike that tore Eirvorr nearly in half from shoulder to ribs.

The god staggered.

Black blood exploded across the snow.

And Eirvorr laughed.

Not mockingly.

Delighted.

Because Sukuna had stopped holding back.

The sound echoed wrong through the dead forest.

Then suddenly—

Sukuna couldn't move correctly.

Not physically.

Strategically.

Every route closed.

Advance—
death.

Retreat—
death.

Attack—
already countered.

And for one impossible second—

Sukuna felt helpless.

The dream returned instantly.

Leora screaming.

Broken.

Unable to reach her.

Unable to save her.

Eirvorr sensed it immediately.

And pressed harder.

The distorted body shifted strangely through space.

Not fast.

Worse than fast.

Certain.

And Sukuna realized the truth all at once:

power meant nothing if fear controlled the next decision.

That was the lesson.

Not strength.

Not destruction.

Fear.

Then—

Sukuna became still.

Completely still.

The panic vanished.

The desperation vanished.

He stopped chasing openings.

Stopped resisting inevitability emotionally.

And instead—

he accepted certainty.

The exact same terrible stillness Eirvorr possessed.

For the first time—

the god smiled genuinely.

Beautiful.

Monstrous.

Proud.

Because Sukuna finally understood.

Inevitability does not rush.

From that moment onward—

the fight changed.

Now Sukuna moved differently.

Quieter.

He no longer attacked movements.

He attacked futures.

Positioning.

Outcome.

Eirvorr stepped somewhere—

and Sukuna was already destroying the next space before arrival became possible.

The god's pale flames brightened.

Interest deepening visibly.

Because Sukuna was evolving mid-fight again.

Like something monstrous refining itself through adaptation alone.

Exactly what had fascinated Eirvorr from the beginning.

Then finally—

Sukuna landed the strike.

Not flashy.

Not explosive.

Precise.

Perfect.

A killing blow directly through Eirvorr's chest.

The world split silently around the impact.

Black blood poured heavily across the snow.

And Eirvorr let it happen.

Because victory had never mattered.

The god looked down slowly at the wound.

Then laughed softly.

> "There you are."

He reached upward.

Bloody fingers pressed against Sukuna's chest directly over his heart.

And something entered him.

Not cursed energy.

Older.

Colder.

Heavier.

A piece of inevitability itself.

Recognition.

The plain shuddered violently.

Winter bent around Sukuna instinctively afterward.

Not obeying.

Acknowledging.

When Eirvorr finally stepped back, Sukuna felt different immediately.

Not stronger in any simple way.

Worse.

Quieter.

Heavier.

Like the world itself now expected certain outcomes from him.

Like winter had learned his name.

Then the shattered forest vanished.

The plain returned.

Leora and Friedhelm still sleeping peacefully among pale flowers.

Untouched.

Safe.

Eirvorr stood beside them once more, black blood slowly vanishing from his body.

Then he looked toward the frozen vision hanging in the sky—

Leora crying with the silver band in her hands.

And said calmly:

> “Now.”

> “I will show you what happened next.”

The Crisis Part XXXVIII - Eirvorr Returns Part V - Fight

The world did not return gently.

It snapped back into place like something forcibly stitched over a wound that refused to close.

Snow drifted through broken black branches.

The forest beyond Eirvorr and Sukuna was silent in the way things only became after violence stopped being fresh and started becoming permanent.

No wind.

No birds.

Only the faint hiss of silver fire burning where orange should have been.

A dead campfire sat between them—pale wood stacked in a careful ring, burning without heat. The flames moved like liquid moonlight, casting no warmth, only clarity.

Sukuna sat across from Eirvorr.

Still injured.

Still upright.

Still watching.

Eirvorr hadn't moved since the fight ended.

Not truly.

Only his gaze had shifted.

It stayed locked on Sukuna's wrist.

On the bracelet.

Like it was the only thing in existence that mattered.

Finally—

> “You still wear it.”

Sukuna glanced down once.

The band circled his wrist like it had always belonged there.

> “She told me not to remove it.”

Eirvorr’s smile was slow.

Dangerous in a way Sukuna now understood meant *interest* rather than threat.

> “Of course she did.”

Silence stretched.

Then Eirvorr moved.

So fast it was almost unperceived—his hand closing around Sukuna’s wrist.

Not an attack.

A claim of attention.

The bracelet flared instantly.

Silver runes beneath its surface igniting like a living breath.

The forest recoiled.

Snow turned to steam midair.

Even the pale fire shuddered.

Eirvorr’s expression changed.

For the first time since Sukuna had met him—

he looked unsettled.

Quietly, almost to himself:

> “She used Návsmiðr.”

Sukuna's eyes narrowed slightly.

> "What is that?"

Eirvorr did not answer immediately.

His fingers tightened once.

Not enough to hurt.

Enough to listen.

Then:

> "A place gods prefer forgotten."

And the world dropped.

● THE DESCENT

There was no transition.

No passage.

Only loss.

Cold black water swallowed everything.

The sky vanished first—replaced by dead stars pinned into a ceiling of ice.

Then the ground stopped being ground.

Chains hung beneath it instead.

Massive bone arches rose from the abyss like the ribs of something that had died too large for any world to contain it.

And beneath it all—

a forge burned.

Not with flame.

With memory.

With name.

With things that should have never been allowed to persist.

Sukuna stood inside it before he realized he had moved.

The bracelet at his wrist felt like a hook dragging him downward.

Eirvorr's voice followed him through the void:

> "Návsmiðr."

The word echoed differently here.

Like the forge itself recognized it.

> "The Corpse-Smithy."

● THE FORGE

The structure was not built.

It had *grown*.

Cathedral ribs of something ancient enough that even gods hesitated to define it.

Spine-like columns burned beneath black ice.

Hundreds—thousands—of bells hung from chains overhead.

Each one moved without wind.

Each one sounded without being struck.

Soft tones.

Breathing tones.

Human tones.

Sukuna's instincts sharpened instantly.

Because each bell did not simply make sound.

It contained a *finality*.

A name that had been removed from the world so completely even memory could not retain it.

Eirvorr watched him notice.

> "Every binding begins here."

A pause.

> “Or did.”

The forge responded to Sukuna’s presence.

Not physically.

Conceptually.

Like something recognizing a tool it once knew how to break.

THE CORPSE-SMITHS

They emerged from the dark water beneath the forge like mistakes remembering themselves into existence.

Ash-gray skin split with veins of molten silver.

Mouths sewn shut with rune-wire that pulsed faintly as if breathing was still remembered pain.

Iron antlers erupted from shoulders and backs like growths that refused correction.

They did not walk.

They *arranged themselves into position*.

One tilted its head toward Sukuna.

Its voice came from within bone, not throat.

> “A living thing enters willingly.”

Another followed.

> “Carrying attachment.”

A third—slower, heavier:

> “Carrying prophecy.”

That word struck something in Sukuna.

Not because of meaning.

Because of timing.

Before the songs.

Before confirmation.

Before inevitability had ever been spoken aloud.

Meaning Leora had already known.

Already feared.

Already acted.

● LEORA ARRIVES

She walked into the forge alone.

No hesitation.

No ceremony.

Just the quiet inevitability of someone who had already made peace with the cost.

But Sukuna noticed immediately—

she looked exhausted in a way that was not physical.

It was decision-weight.

Like she had been standing at this threshold for far too long before stepping forward.

In her hands, carefully wrapped:

a broken oath band.

Sukuna felt Eirvorr's attention sharpen beside him.

> "That band belonged to the strongest binder the Gegner line ever produced."

A pause.

> "She destroyed it for you."

Leora stepped closer to the forge.

The smiths did not stop her.

They simply watched her like something being measured.

One of them touched the band.

And the forge reacted.

● WHAT THE FORGE SHOWED

Reality fractured.

Not visually—

conceptually.

Sukuna saw flashes that did not belong to time:

Shrines collapsing under unseen pressure.

Bodies reduced to names before they were even born.

A future where he existed in pieces, arranged like currency.

Hands praying over severed remains that still *moved*.

Then silence.

The forge withdrew.

One smith spoke:

> “This one ends partitioned.”

Another corrected:

> “Not killed.”

A pause.

> “Separated.”

The implication was worse than death.

Then:

> “The world will fear him too greatly to leave him whole.”

Leora answered immediately.

No hesitation.

No tremor.

> “Then make separation impossible.”

🩸 THE PRICE

The smiths did not look at each other.

They did not need to.

The answer was already known.

> “Mass life force.”

> “Innocence.”

> “Identity anchor.”

One bell overhead chimed softly.

Another followed.

The forge was counting something unseen.

> “A thousand undeserving lives.”

Leora did not react.

> “And more.”

A pause.

> “How much more?”

The answer came without cruelty.

Only structure.

> “Part of the soul that loves him.”

Silence.

Even Sukuna felt something inside him go very still.

Leora finally paused.

Not in refusal.

In understanding.

Then—

> “How much?”

The smith answered:

> “Enough that you will recognize loss every time he breathes.”

● THE WALK THROUGH BELLS

Leora descended.

Not into fire.

Into layers beneath it.

The bells followed her path.

Each one ringing once as she passed.

Soft.

Wet.

Human.

Sukuna understood too late what he was hearing.

Not sound.

Lives.

Each bell was a surrendered existence.

Each tone was a choice she did not delegate.

She walked through them without stopping.

Without breaking stride.

Like a woman crossing a river she had already decided would cost her everything she had.

Eirvorr's voice lowered:

> “She feared your future more than your present.”

● THE SOUL OFFERING

At the heart of the forge, silver-white metal burned.

It did not glow.

It *listened*.

Leora placed the oath band into it.

Then her rune mark.

Then her blood.

The forge rejected it once.

Then again.

A smith murmured:

> “It does not recognize him completely.”

Leora went still.

Sukuna felt it before he saw it—

the moment she understood what was missing.

The forge required *her*.

Not metaphorically.

Not symbolically.

Literally.

Leora pressed her hand to her own chest.

Paused.

Then cut.

Not violently.

Precisely.

Like opening a sealed document.

Soul-thread spilled out.

Silver.

Blue.

Alive.

The smiths recoiled.

One whispered:

> “She remains conscious...”

Another:

> “That is not permitted.”

Leora’s voice did not waver.

> “He will remain whole.”

● THE FINAL AGREEMENT

The forge spoke one last time:

> “Fate has already touched him.”

Leora stepped closer to the flame.

Eyes steady.

> “Then I will touch him harder.”

Silence followed.

Not rejection.

Recognition.

The forge accepted.

🔴 THE BRACELET IS BORN

Silver-black metal rose from the fire.

It did not cool.

It *settled*.

Like something deciding its shape.

Inside it—

something alive.

Something anchored.

Something impossible.

The smiths spoke softly:

> “It will not stop division.”

> “Only resist it.”

A pause.

> “He may still be separated.”

For the first time—

Leora faltered.

Not outwardly.

Just a breath that caught for half a moment too long.

Then she steadied herself again.

> “Then let him feel me fighting for him when it happens.”

The forge went silent.

And accepted that too.

● RETURN

The memory shattered.

Sukuna was back in the frozen forest.

Snow falling gently now, as if nothing had occurred.

Eirvorr still sat across from him.

Watching.

Waiting.

The bracelet on Sukuna’s wrist suddenly felt heavier than anything he had ever worn.

Not physically.

Historically.

Eirvorr spoke quietly:

> “She walked beneath Death itself to keep the world from owning you.”

A pause.

Then, almost gently:

> “And still you wonder why gods became interested in her.”

The Crisis Part XI - Eirvorr Returns Part VI - Fight

The forest remained silent after the memory ended.

Not ordinary silence.

The kind that follows catastrophe.

Black snow drifted slowly through the shattered trees. Pale embers hissed beneath ruined frost. Somewhere far away, something enormous groaned beneath the ice of Death itself.

Sukuna did not move.

The bracelet around his wrist felt unbearable now.

Heavy.

Alive.

He stared at it without blinking.

Her.

Her blood.

Her soul.

A thousand lives.

That forge.

Those bells.

Those things speaking about him like a future corpse already laid upon an altar.

And Leora—

walking willingly into the deepest part of Death to fight fate with her bare hands.

Alone.

Eirvorr watched him quietly from across the pale fire.

The deity's four burning eyes reflected silver against the snow.

Sukuna finally spoke.

His voice came out low and rough.

> "She knew."

Eirvorr tilted his head slightly.

> "Of course she knew."

Sukuna's fingers tightened slowly against the bracelet.

Too tight.

The metal groaned.

> "She knew they would split me apart."

Images still ruptured behind his eyes.

Shrines.

Prayers.

Fingers laid out like relics.

His soul partitioned.

Not killed.

Separated.

And somehow the worst part was not the inevitability itself—

it was that Leora had carried the knowledge alone.

For years.

Maybe decades.

Sleeping beside him.

Touching him.

Smiling at him.

Bearing his children.

All while knowing someday the world would try to tear him into pieces and worship what remained.

His breathing deepened once.

Controlled.

Dangerously controlled.

> “And she never told me.”

Eirvorr’s expression did not change.

> “Would you have allowed her to do it?”

Sukuna immediately answered:

> “No.”

The word cracked through the forest instantly.

Absolute.

Eirvorr nodded once.

> “Exactly.”

That made something in Sukuna twist violently.

Because he understood immediately.

Leora had hidden it because she knew him too well.

Knew he would have stopped her.

Knew he would rather face fate unprotected than allow her to mutilate her own soul for him.

And still—

she had done it anyway.

Sukuna looked down at his hand again.

At the bracelet she had forged from death and sacrifice and stolen permanence.

He remembered her fastening it around his wrist.

Her fingers lingering.

That strange look in her eyes he had not understood at the time.

The way she had said:

> "Do not remove it."

Not asking.

Terrified.

Gods.

She had been terrified.

Not of him.

For him.

Something inside Sukuna suddenly lurched so hard it almost became nausea.

Eirvorr watched the realization settle deeper and deeper into him.

Then quietly:

> "She walked beneath the Corpse-Smithy willingly."

Sukuna shut his eyes once.

Immediately saw her again.

Silver soul-thread spilling from her chest.

Those bells ringing.

The forge asking if she would cripple herself for a future not yet written.

And her answering without hesitation.

> *Then I will touch him harder.*

His throat tightened violently.

Eirvorr continued softly:

> “Most beings claim devotion.”
> “Very few rewrite themselves for another existence.”

Sukuna opened his eyes again.

Something darker lived in them now.

Not rage.

Not exactly.

Something heavier.

Ancient.

He touched the bracelet carefully this time.

Almost reverently.

As if he now understood he was touching part of her actual soul.

And suddenly—

horribly—

he understood why he had panicked so violently after losing her.

Why the absence had felt physically wrong.

Why breathing without her nearby had become unbearable.

She had embedded herself into him.

Literally.

Spiritually.

Cosmically.

Leora had tied herself to his existence so completely that separation itself now resisted.

The realization nearly destroyed him.

Eirvorr’s voice cut through the silence again.

> “And still you wonder why gods became interested in her.”

Sukuna looked up slowly.

For the first time since the memory ended, there was genuine hostility in his face again.

Not toward the memory.

Toward Eirvorr.

> “You speak about her like she already belongs to you.”

The pale flames in Eirvorr’s eyes flickered softly.

Not offended.

Almost thoughtful.

> “No.”

Then after a pause:

> “I speak about inevitability.”

Sukuna hated that answer instantly.

Eirvorr rose slowly from beside the silver fire.

Towering antlers disappearing partially into drifting black snow.

> “She chooses.”

> “That is why she matters.”

Then quieter:

> “She chose you over power.”

> “Over gods.”

> “Over safety.”

> “Over eternity.”

Sukuna’s jaw tightened.

Because hearing it spoken aloud made the truth unbearable.

Leora had not drifted toward him accidentally.

She had chosen him repeatedly.

Knowingly.

Even understanding exactly what he was.

Exactly what would happen to him.

Exactly what it would cost her.

Eirvorr studied him one last time.

Then said the thing that finally hollowed Sukuna completely:

> “You are loved in a way that terrifies even Death.”

The forest went still again.

And Sukuna realized—

with sudden horrible clarity—

that he did not know how to survive the weight of that love if he ever lost it again.

Chapter XLI

Morning came slowly to the estate.

Not peacefully.

Never peacefully anymore.

The room was warm in the heavy way it only became when too many bodies had slept in the same bed for too many nights. The brazier crackled softly somewhere nearby. Snowlight filtered pale through the paper screens.

Leora woke first.

For one brief second, before memory returned, she only registered warmth.

Friedhelm pressed along her back.
Sukuna’s scent still soaked into the bedding.
A hand no longer holding onto her.

Her eyes opened immediately.

Empty space.

She turned sharply.

Sukuna was gone.

The absence hit instantly now. Immediate. Physical. Wrong.

Friedhelm made a sleepy sound behind her as she carefully untangled herself from the blankets. He curled instinctively toward the warmth she left behind.

Leora dressed slowly, still sore in ways she disliked acknowledging. Her body had technically healed. Technically.

But sometimes when she moved too quickly she still felt phantom seams beneath skin and bone.

She reached the door and slid it open—

Nothing happened.

Her brows pulled together.

She tried again.

The paper screens trembled faintly beneath an invisible pressure.

Locked.

Not physically.

Warded.

Leora stared at it for a long moment before walking to the windows.

The same thing.

Sealed.

Completely.

She sighed.

Behind her Friedhelm stirred awake properly this time, silver hair tangled wildly as he pushed himself upright. He blinked at her slowly.

“What’s wrong?”

Leora crossed her arms.

“Sukuna locked us up.”

Friedhelm was quiet.

Then:

“Oh.”

Not shocked.

Just mildly disappointed.

Leora looked over at him suspiciously.

“You’re not surprised?”

Friedhelm rubbed one eye.

“He looked like he was going insane.”

Fair.

Leora exhaled through her nose before pausing suddenly.

“...Where are your bruises?”

Friedhelm looked down at himself.

The deep violet marks that had once covered him were gone entirely.

Smooth skin.

Whole.

His expression changed immediately.

He looked toward her.

“Yours too.”

Leora went still.

Her hand rose slowly to her neck.

Nothing.

No finger marks.

No handprints.

No dark bruising.

Gone.

Completely.

Her stomach dropped instantly.

“...Sukuna.”

Friedhelm looked toward the sealed door.

“...Or the antler one.”

Leora closed her eyes briefly.

“That is not reassuring.”

—

Meanwhile, the dining hall had become loud enough to resemble organized suffering.

Sukuna stood near the head of the long table while servants moved around carrying trays of food.

He had called everyone.

No excuses.

No wandering.

No exceptions.

Tsukihiko sat carefully propped upright with Kohaku balanced against his chest. The fox-child gnawed happily on one of Tsukihiko's sleeves while tiny fox ears twitched beneath white hair.

Chōbei lounged beside him looking deeply exhausted while dangling Higan upside down over one arm.

Higan loved it.

Unfortunately.

The child shrieked with delighted laughter every time Chōbei bounced him slightly.

“If he throws up on me,” Chōbei complained, “I’m givin’ him to Sukuna permanently.”

Then, Sukuna entered.

Higan spotted Sukuna immediately and smiled brightly, squealing and reaching for him.

Traitor.

Kurohiko carefully helped Kiyomi into her chair beside him. She looked fragile now in a way that unsettled the room whenever anyone stared too long. Pale skin. Exhaustion carved beneath her eyes.

Several streaks of white now threaded through her black hair permanently.

Soul damage.

Irreversible.

Sieg stumbled sleepily into the room next, immediately veering toward the fire like a dying moth seeking warmth.

Mizuki caught him before he collapsed face-first onto the floor.

“You are unbelievable,” Mizuki muttered fondly.

He tucked a blanket around Sieg after depositing him near the fire.

Tōma entered last with Kaguya.

Linnea slept peacefully in Kaguya’s arms.

Sukuna’s attention sharpened immediately.

Flowers.

Tiny pale flowers woven through the infant’s dark hair.

Not decorative.

Growing.

He stepped closer.

Kaguya immediately shifted away from him protectively.

Sukuna stilled.

Tōma noticed immediately.

“They started appearing yesterday,” he explained quietly. “Under her crib.”

Kaguya looked exhausted.

“When she cries they bloom.”

The room went quieter.

Sukuna remembered Eirvorr’s question instantly.

Have the flowers begun?

His chest tightened unpleasantly.

Chōbei finally looked around.

“Where’re Leora and Friedhelm?”

Sukuna’s eyes landed on him fully then.

The foxfire beneath Chōbei’s scars had become brighter overnight.

Silver glimmered beneath ruined flesh like moonlight trapped under skin.

Possessive.

Beautiful.

Infuriating.

Chōbei noticed the stare instantly and scowled.

“I can’t help it if some fox god’s obsessed with me.”

Kurohiko immediately looked away to hide a smile.

Sukuna stepped toward Chōbei before he could react.

His fingers brushed carefully against the scar beneath Chōbei’s eye.

Gentle.

Too gentle.

Chōbei slapped his hand away instantly.

Red spread violently across his face.

Absolutely not.

No.

He already understood far too much now about how people ended up tangled around Sukuna and the Ten Brinken siblings like doomed pilgrims orbiting moonlight.

He refused to become the next victim.

Kurohiko, meanwhile, silently agreed.

Absolutely not.

Sukuna looked faintly irritated by the rejection.

Then thoughtful.

Then somehow softer.

Which was worse.

Chōbei pointed at him accusingly.

“Stop lookin’ at me like that.”

Sukuna ignored him completely.

Instead he said calmly:

“Sit. Eat.”

“And mama and uncle Friedhelm?” Tsukihiko asked quietly.

Sukuna paused.

“...I’ll bring them.”

Everyone knew he didn’t want to but only for Tsukihiko he would.

Then he turned and left the dining hall.

Fast enough that it was obvious he had no intention of allowing either sibling unsupervised freedom for the foreseeable future.

Chapter XLII

The halls were already warm with food smoke and low voices by the time Sukuna returned to the sealed chambers.

He opened the doors without speaking.

Leora immediately looked up from where she sat brushing out her hair.

“You locked the windows too,” she said flatly.

Sukuna ignored the accusation entirely.

“Come eat.”

Leora narrowed her eyes at him.

“I asked to go to the onsen.”

A pause.

He stared, “And I remember not allowing that.”

Then:

“You would not have had to ‘allow’ anything if I had simply been permitted to leave when I woke.”

Sukuna visibly tightened.

But after several long seconds:

“Fine.”

Friedhelm sighed softly in relief from the bedding.

Leora stood slowly, still healing despite how much better she looked now that the bruising and mutilation had vanished. Friedhelm followed after her wordlessly, silver hair loose and unstyled.

Very unlike him and, due to the sight, potentially dangerous for onlookers.

Sukuna stayed with them the entire walk.

Of course he did.

At the onsen, Leora disappeared behind the screen walls to wash properly while Sukuna remained in one of the side rooms pretending not to listen for movement every second.

Friedhelm emerged first.

Freshly bathed.

Hair damp.

Face soft with lingering sleep.

Sukuna looked up briefly.

Then froze slightly when Friedhelm crossed the room without hesitation and settled directly into his lap.

The movement was natural.

Easy.

Like he had done it a hundred times before.

Friedhelm reached up immediately and threaded slender fingers into Sukuna's hair near the roots. He pressed his face against Sukuna's neck, softening himself in a certain way that he knew Sukuna couldn't resist. A way that Sukuna found intoxicating when presented with it.

Sukuna exhaled once through his nose.

Dangerous mistake.

Friedhelm smiled faintly against his throat.

Then kissed the side of his neck.

Sukuna's shoulders tightened instantly.

Another kiss.

Then another lower against his collarbone while his fingers gently tugged at Sukuna's hair in a way that made the curse visibly fight not to react.

"You're doing that on purpose," Sukuna muttered.

"Yes."

Friedhelm sounded pleased with himself.

His hand drifted lazily down Sukuna's shoulder before pressing directly against one of the few sensitive points on his body.

Sukuna jerked slightly.

Friedhelm's eyes brightened immediately.

"Oh."

Sukuna grabbed his wrist.

Friedhelm only leaned closer. Sinful mouth continuing to deal damage to Sukuna's skin and resolve.

His voice was rough, "Are you going to keep locking us up?"

"Yes."

No hesitation.

Friedhelm considered this thoughtfully.

Then:

"That's fine."

Sukuna narrowed his eyes suspiciously.

Friedhelm kissed his jaw softly.

"Just keep me happy and satisfied and I'll stay quiet about it. I'll even help you maintain control."

Sukuna nearly choked.

Actually choked.

Friedhelm looked delighted.

By the time Leora entered the room, Sukuna's neck was flushed dark red and a distinct purple mark bloomed beneath his collarbone.

Leora stopped immediately.

Then slowly smiled despite herself.

"Traitor."

Friedhelm looked entirely unashamed.

"It's a fair deal. I get what I want and he gets what he wants. I think you find it also agreeable."

Leora laughed softly under her breath.

Sukuna looked murderous.

Embarrassed.

And strangely calmer than he had been in days.

Leora crossed the room and took Sukuna's hand before he could retreat behind irritation.

Friedhelm slipped easily into step beside them as they left the onsen together.

When they entered the dining hall, conversation stalled almost immediately.

Not because of Leora or Friedhelm.

Because Sukuna still looked like he was actively losing a war against emotional instability.

Tsukihiko noticed first from his place near the head of the table with Kohaku in his lap.

"Mama," he said immediately, visibly relieved.

Leora smiled softly at him.

Kohaku made excited chirping noises and reached toward Friedhelm, who immediately abandoned Sukuna long enough to take him.

Sukuna looked personally betrayed.

Chōbei noticed the mark on Sukuna's collarbone instantly.

A pang of jealousy was quickly replaced with understanding when he saw how Friedhelm touched Sukuna's arm slightly.

Sure, Leora wasn't solely his but he didn't necessarily like seeing Sukuna covered in her handiwork.

He was sure the feeling was mutual.

Friedhelm sat down calmly with Kohaku in his arms while Leora moved toward Kaguya and Linnea.

Tiny pale flowers were indeed tangled through the infant's dark hair.

Sukuna noticed Leora noticing them too.

Something uneasy passed silently between them.

Then Chōbei looked at Sukuna again suspiciously.

“...Why do you look like you lost a fight to affection?”

Sukuna glared at him.

Friedhelm answered for him.

“He's very sensitive there.”

And immediately touched the exact weak spot on Sukuna's shoulder again.

Sukuna looked ready to split reality open.

Chapter XLIII

The dining hall had settled into something almost peaceful.

Almost.

Rain tapped softly against the estate windows. Steam curled from untouched tea. The fire crackled low beneath the scent of rice, herbs, and damp earth carried in from the storm outside.

But underneath it all sat tension.

The kind that no one named.

Kohaku rested in Tsukihiko's arms again, small fox tail lazily wrapped around Friedhelm's wrist as if refusing separation even over distance. Friedhelm absently stroked the tail with two fingers while leaning against Sukuna's shoulder.

Chōbei sat close enough to Tsukihiko that their knees remained pressed together beneath the table. His arm rested behind Tsukihiko's chair possessively, unconsciously. Every few seconds his thumb brushed against Tsukihiko's pulse at the side of his throat like he still needed proof he was alive.

Leora remained tucked firmly into Sukuna's side.

Not trapped.

Not exactly.

But Sukuna's hand never loosened from her waist.

Not once.

Kurohiko noticed the way Leora looked toward Kiyomi sometimes.

Small glances.

Guilt-ridden ones.

Kiyomi sat pale beside him, strands of white still threaded through her dark hair from the soul leeching. She looked exhausted but calm, leaning faintly against him while sipping tea with both hands.

She never noticed Leora staring.

Kurohiko was grateful.

Because Kiyomi adored her.

Absolutely adored her.

And if she realized Leora blamed herself for what happened to her, it would shatter something delicate inside her immediately.

So he quietly reached over and adjusted Kiyomi's sleeve higher around her shoulders, drawing her attention away before Leora could spiral further.

Across the hall, Tōma laughed softly under his breath.

Linnea had wrapped tiny fingers into his hair.

Kaguya leaned over and kissed his cheek.

Tōma smiled instantly.

Mizuki rose to check on Sieg where he'd nearly fallen asleep beside the fire. The boy blinked blearily as Mizuki scooped him up with practiced ease and carried him back toward the table wrapped in blankets.

Higan, meanwhile, had begun fussing.

Small unhappy noises.

Restless.

One of the servants carefully handed him toward Sukuna.

Immediately—

the toddler quieted.

Tiny hands latched onto Sukuna's robes.

Contentment replaced distress so completely it startled even the servants.

Leora smiled softly beside him.

"Someone really loves his Otōsan."

Higan laughed.

Actually laughed.

Like this was the happiest truth in existence.

Sukuna felt something inside his chest tighten painfully.

Then—

small fingers grabbed the bracelet around his wrist.

Everything stopped.

Not physically.

But inside him.

The metal touched Higan's skin.

And suddenly—

black oceans.

Silver bells.

Molten ribs beneath dead ice.

Leora cutting open her chest with steady hands.

A thousand extinguished lives.

Her soul-thread unraveling into the forge.

> Then I will touch him harder.

His breathing vanished.

The dining hall blurred around the edges.

Higan tugged curiously at the bracelet again, fascinated by the silver runes hidden beneath the blackened metal.

Sukuna stared at it.

At the thing he had worn carelessly for months now and never questioned.

The thing she had bled herself apart to create.

One thousand innocent souls.

Her blood.

Her soul.

For him.

For his future.

For a fate she had feared long before anyone else understood it was coming.

The memory of Eirvorr's voice slid through him like winter.

> "She walked beneath Death itself to keep the world from owning you."

Sukuna suddenly could not breathe correctly.

Leora noticed immediately.

Her hand moved to his arm.

"Sukuna?"

Soft.

Concerned.

Immediate.

The exact same way she always said his name.

The exact same way she had before the world tried to tear her apart.

Sukuna looked at her.

Really looked at her.

The woman who had mutilated her own soul for him.

Who had carried his children.

Who had crawled through the forest dismembered trying to reach home.

Who smiled at him now with gentle concern despite everything done to her.

And something inside him began unraveling all over again.

Because he finally understood something unbearable:

Leora had never once loved him cautiously.

Never strategically.

Never partially.

She had loved him with catastrophic completeness.

The kind that gods noticed.

The kind that altered fate.

The kind that descended beneath death itself and demanded more time from inevitability.

Higan made another happy noise and pressed his face against Sukuna's chest.

Sukuna closed his hand around the bracelet suddenly.

Hard enough his knuckles whitened.

Leora frowned slightly.

"Sukuna?"

He looked at her for a long moment.

Then silently pulled her closer against him until she was nearly sitting in his lap.

Like he could somehow keep her there permanently if he held tightly enough.

And for once—

no one at the table teased him for it.

Chapter XLIV

The room shifted the moment Leora spoke.

Not loudly. Not sharply.

Just decisively.

> “After this meal... everyone please stay.”

Forks paused mid-air. Conversations thinned out like breath caught in cold air.

Leora’s gaze moved across the table, steady but softened at the edges.

> “This is about what happened.”

Friedhelm didn’t speak yet, but he sat a fraction straighter beside her, already aware of what she meant.

Then Leora’s eyes lowered slightly.

> “And the children should be taken elsewhere. Kiyomi should go with Sieg.”

A beat.

Kiyomi’s reaction was immediate—too immediate. Her fingers tightened around her sleeve, knuckles paling.

> “I can stay.”

It wasn’t defiance so much as refusal to be excluded.

Leora turned toward her.

The expression on her face changed—subtle, almost imperceptible—but something in it softened in a way that hurt more than rejection would have.

> “Kiyomi...”

A pause.

Not distance. Not dismissal.

Care.

> “That’s fine.”

Then, quieter:

> “I just worry. You’re still weak.”

Kiyomi’s mouth opened like she wanted to argue, but nothing came out.

Because Leora hadn’t told her to leave.

She had simply told her the truth as she saw it.

That was worse.

Across the table, Kohaku shifted.

His tail curled tighter around Friedhelm’s wrist, as if anchoring him there.

Chōbei had Tsukihiko pulled so close it was almost unnatural—his hand pressed against Tsukihiko’s side as if confirming, over and over, that he was still warm. Still real.

Mizuki noticed it again.

The way Chōbei held him wasn’t protective.

It was **refusal of loss**.

Tōma let out a small, almost disbelieving laugh at something Linnea did, and Kaguya leaned in to kiss again him without thinking—automatic, familiar, grounding.

Sieg was half-asleep already, leaning into Mizuki’s arm as he adjusted him closer to the table.

And then—

Higan.

He broke the atmosphere entirely without meaning to.

He reached up, small hands grabbing Sukuna’s face with complete trust, patting him as if confirming his existence.

Then, as if deciding Sukuna was now his entire world, he wrapped his arms around his neck and nestled in.

> “Higan...” Leora’s voice softened instinctively.

Sukuna didn’t stop him.

He just... held him.

Both arms came up around the child without hesitation, pulling him in as though it was the only stable thing in the room.

For a moment, Sukuna looked worse than before.

Not angry.

Not distant.

Just—

empty in a way that made Mizuki's attention sharpen for the first time.

Noticing it clearly now:

Something like dread sitting behind his father's eyes.

Leora reached out without thinking and touched Sukuna's face gently, thumb brushing near his cheekbone.

Friedhelm did the same a second later—quiet, steady contact on his arm, grounding him without asking anything.

The servants moved to collect the children.

Higan immediately protested—small, sharp cries that cut through the room.

Sukuna's energy flared instantly.

The servant stumbled back as pressure hit the space between them.

> "I'll keep him."

The words came out flat.

Final.

Leora paused.

Then she stood, stepped forward, and took Higan back into her arms.

She didn't argue.

She just held him.

And whistled once—soft, familiar.

Higan's body slackened immediately, the resistance dissolving as sleep took him again mid-breath.

The servant stepped in quickly and took him this time without interruption.

Leora watched him go for a second longer than necessary.

Then she looked back at the table.

Her expression returned to focus.

Serious again.

Unyielding in a quieter way.

> “Again,” she said softly, “this is serious.”

And this time, no one mistook what she meant.

Chapter XLV - What Happened Part I - Lieders

The dining hall felt different once the children were gone.

Too large.

Too quiet.

Rain whispered softly against the estate walls while servants retreated one by one until only family remained seated around the low table.

No one touched their food anymore.

Leora sat very still beside Sukuna.

Friedhelm beside her.

Both of them looked—

not nervous.

Not frightened.

Something worse.

Like people preparing to exhume their own graves.

Leora reached for Friedhelm’s hand beneath the table first.

Their fingers intertwined automatically.

Then she looked at him.

Actually looked at him.

Pain moved openly across her face for the first time that morning.

> “Do we really do this?”

Friedhelm held her gaze.

Then nodded once.

> “We have to.”

His voice was quiet.

Steady.

> “We did them an injustice keeping it from them.”

A pause.

Then softer:

> “At least... that’s what we agreed.”

He tilted his head slightly.

> “Do you not agree anymore?”

Leora looked down briefly.

Thinking.

Not avoiding.

Just weighing the damage before it happened.

Finally she sighed through her nose.

> “I agree.”

The words settled heavily across the table.

Leora looked at all of them.

Sukuna.

Tsukihiko.

Chōbei.

Kurohiko.

Mizuki.

Kiyomi.

Tōma.

Kaguya.

And for one strange moment—

the words failed her completely.

Friedhelm spoke instead.

> “We’ve been lying to all of you for years.”

Silence.

Not shock yet.

Just stillness.

Friedhelm continued carefully.

> “Much of what you know about us is either lie, legend, myth... or half-truth.”

Leora winced immediately.

> “Not everything has been a lie.”

> “No,” Friedhelm agreed gently. “But enough has been to matter.”

Sukuna remained unreadable.

Too unreadable.

That frightened Mizuki more than anger would have.

Leora nodded once.

Accepting it.

Then said quietly:

> “True.”

A pause.

Then:

> “First, let me say that this is my fault.”

Every eye sharpened instantly.

Leora did not look away.

> “That everyone was hurt or killed.”

Her voice did not shake.

> “The blame lays fully on me.”

Chōbei immediately tightened beside Tsukihiko.

Tsukihiko felt it all through him—the sudden violence of emotion restrained by force alone.

Leora continued anyway.

> “It’s not something any amount of shifting can change.”

Then flatter:

> “I just have to take it and eat it.”

Chōbei visibly hated that sentence.

Violently.

Leora turned toward Kurohiko then.

And something in her expression changed entirely.

Not weakness.

Never weakness.

But something stripped painfully bare.

> “I will spend the rest of my life trying to apologize to you for what you saw.”

Kurohiko immediately looked down.

Couldn’t look at her.

Couldn’t.

Leora’s voice sharpened slightly.

Not emotionally.

Clearly.

Terribly clearly.

> “How you found me lying there in the mud drowning on my own blood.”

Kurohiko’s jaw tightened.

Across the table Mizuki went still too.

Because she wasn't exhausted now.

Wasn't drifting.

Wasn't softening what happened.

She was *clear.*

And somehow that made it worse.

> "I was taught never to allow someone I love to find me like that."

The room felt colder suddenly.

> "I should have stayed in the clearing."

A breath.

Then:

> "But selfishly... I wanted to see your Otōsan one last time before I died."

Sukuna's entire body locked.

> "So I crawled toward him."

The words landed like iron.

Heavy.

Hot.

Unavoidable.

> "You were never meant to find me."

Kurohiko's hand tightened hard enough around Kiyomi's sleeve that she looked at him finally.

Leora lowered her gaze slightly.

> "I am ashamed that you and Mizuki will carry that with you for the rest of your lives."

Then quieter:

> "I have shamed myself and those who taught me better."

No one breathed properly after that.

Friedhelm squeezed her hand.

> "But it's understandable what you did."

Leora shrugged faintly.

> “And yet the cost was too high.”

Friedhelm exhaled softly.

His eyes distant now.

Old.

Older than anyone at the table had ever truly seen him look.

> “It has always been too high.”

Then:

> “Remember how sad we were when we never got to say goodbye to them?”

Leora didn’t look at him.

> “It was better.”

The answer came too quickly.

Too practiced.

> “I don’t remember any of them dismembered.”

A pause.

Then flatter:

> “And I don’t hear the sound of blood filling their lungs.”

Friedhelm interrupted immediately.

Firmly.

> “Not true.”

Leora barked out a sharp laugh.

Humorless.

> “You know what I meant.”

Friedhelm turned fully toward her.

And for the first time since this conversation began, something openly painful crossed his face.

> “Yes.”

Then quieter:

> “But it’s best we don’t pretend the sound of people drowning on blood wasn’t our lullaby.”

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Kaguya’s face had gone pale.

Tōma stared openly now.

Mizuki looked like something inside him had begun rearranging itself violently.

Kiyomi covered her mouth slowly with one hand.

Tsukihiko sat perfectly still.

Too still.

Because suddenly pieces were clicking together in horrifying ways.

The stories.

The gaps.

The impossible reactions to violence.

The way Leora and Friedhelm spoke about death like weather.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna looked at them both with something almost terrible in its intensity.

Not revulsion.

Not fear.

Recognition.

Because for the first time—

he was beginning to understand what kind of world had created them.

No one spoke after Friedhelm’s last sentence.

The silence in the hall had become something dense now.

Not discomfort.

Weight.

Friedhelm looked around the table slowly before continuing.

> “Tribes consist of seven families.”

His voice had returned to calm explanation now, though the calm itself felt unsettling.

> “And within some of those families... there are people called Lieders.”

Leora immediately cut across him.

Sharp.

> “I didn’t want to jump into that.”

Friedhelm sighed softly.

Not irritated.

Almost fondly exhausted.

> “Where would you like to jump in then?”

He tilted his head slightly.

> “There or Blood Eagles?”

Leora’s face drained instantly of color.

Actually drained.

Even Sukuna turned toward her sharply at the reaction.

> “I would not wish to immediately jump into the Blood Eagle.”

Friedhelm smiled softly at that.

Far too softly for the subject.

> “Why not?”

Then gently:

> “Too graphic?”

A beat.

Then the killing line:

> “Says the woman who had to be carried in pieces.”

The room froze.

Completely.

Kiyomi inhaled sharply.

Tōma looked sick.

Kaguya's hands tightened protectively around Linnea even though the child was gone from the room already.

Mizuki shut his eyes briefly.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna looked like he might actually tear reality apart.

Leora inhaled slowly through her nose.

When she spoke again, she sounded controlled.

Too controlled.

> “On the day everything happened... I wasn't paying attention.”

No one interrupted her.

> “I wasn't prepared like I should have been.”

Her gaze lowered slightly.

> “Like I have been trained my entire life to be.”

There was no self-pity in it.

That made it worse.

> “I have grown unbearably soft these years.”

Sukuna's jaw tightened immediately.

Leora continued before he could speak.

> “Because with Sukuna around, nothing can touch me.”

The words hit him visibly.

> “I gave in to comfort and safety like a naïve and foolish lovesick girl.”

Chōbei looked furious at that description of her.

Tsukihiko noticed instantly.

Leora didn't.

Or pretended not to.

> "It isn't important how I got so deep into the woods."

Her fingers tightened once around the fabric near her knee.

> "Just that when I did... I lost the chance to control the battle because of carelessness."

Her voice sharpened slightly.

Angry now.

At herself.

> "The Todkriegers drew my focus too fully."

Mizuki frowned immediately at the unfamiliar word.

But before anyone could ask—

Leora continued.

> "And by the time I realized what they were and what that meant..."

She paused.

Actually paused.

Upset finally surfacing visibly.

> "...the Lieder was already singing."

The room felt colder somehow.

Friedhelm had gone completely still beside her.

Not frozen.

Listening.

Leora let out a rough huff of breath.

Then muttered bitterly:

> "You should have just let me die."

Every head snapped toward her.

> “I earned it by being that stupid.”

Sukuna moved instantly.

Not visibly aggressive.

But something dark shifted violently through the room anyway.

Friedhelm sighed before anyone else could react.

Then said simply:

> “I am not our father.”

The sentence landed harder than almost anything else that evening.

Because of the silence after it.

Because of the way both of them looked away afterward.

And because suddenly everyone at the table understood something horrifying without needing it explained:

Whatever raised Leora and Friedhelm—

it had not been mercy.

Chapter XLVI - What Happened Part II

The silence after Leora’s final words did not feel natural.

It felt arranged.

Like even the room itself had settled carefully around the weight of what they had just revealed.

Snow moved softly beyond the screens.

Nobody at the table spoke.

Nobody seemed entirely certain how to.

Sukuna sat motionless beside Leora.

One arm remained around her waist beneath the table.

Not possessive now.

Anchoring.

His gaze rested on Friedhelm and Leora with a new kind of attention entirely.

Not surprise.

Calculation.

Understanding.

And something colder beneath it.

Tsukihiko was still staring.

Not frightened.

Overwhelmed.

Because suddenly dozens of moments across his entire life had rearranged themselves into horrifying clarity.

The whistles.

The bells.

The way Friedhelm could calm rooms without speaking.

The way Leora sometimes hummed under her breath while treating injuries.

The way arguments seemed to dissolve around them before fully escalating.

The birthday songs.

The runes.

The feeling of pressure before either sibling ever raised their voice.

It had all been there the entire time.

Kurohiko spoke first.

Quietly.

“So your songs aren’t metaphorical.”

Leora looked tired suddenly.

“No.”

Mizuki rubbed both hands down his face.

“That means when mama says somebody’s voice is dangerous she means literally dangerous.”

“Yes,” Friedhelm answered.

Simple.

Immediate.

Chōbei leaned back slightly, arms crossed.

“And this whole time you both were pretending whistles and little songs were normal?”

Leora looked at him flatly.

“They are normal.”

“For you,” Chōbei muttered.

Friedhelm tilted his head slightly.

“Yes.”

That somehow made it worse.

Kiyomi sat very still.

Her pale fingers tightened slowly together in her lap.

Leora noticed immediately.

Of course she did.

“Kiyomi,” she said softly.

Kiyomi looked up quickly.

Leora’s expression gentled.

“The handpipes helped you because they gave your breathing structure. That was all.”

Kiyomi swallowed.

“But the sound mattered.”

Leora hesitated.

Then nodded once.

“Yes.”

Kiyomi looked faintly ill now.

Sukuna watched this entire exchange carefully.

Then finally spoke.

“When you say memories can be externalized...”

The entire table looked toward him instantly.

Because Sukuna almost never interrupted explanations unless something truly interested him.

Friedhelm answered carefully.

“A memory is structure.”

Leora continued softly:

“Strong emotion leaves deep impressions.”

“Songs can reach them.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed slightly.

“Can they be altered?”

That question changed the atmosphere immediately.

Friedhelm answered first.

“Yes.”

Leora answered second.

“But not cleanly.”

Sukuna kept staring.

Leora sighed softly before explaining further.

“A fabricated memory lacks weight.”

“Reality resists false structure.”

Friedhelm added:

“And living witnesses destabilize lies.”

Chōbei frowned.

“So people can tell?”

Leora looked at him.

“If they survive long enough.”

That landed badly.

Tsukihiko exhaled sharply through his nose.

“Okay. I officially hate all of this.”

Chōbei immediately pointed at him.

“No, see, I think this is incredible.”

Tsukihiko stared.

“You think everything is incredible.”

“Yes.”

“That’s the problem.”

Kurohiko suddenly spoke again.

Quietly.

“The man in the forest...”

Leora stilled immediately.

Everyone did.

Kurohiko looked at the table instead of her.

“You said his note entered you before you recognized him.”

Leora’s expression hardened with visible disgust toward herself.

“Yes.”

“And that was enough?”

Friedhelm answered this time.

“For someone at that level? Yes.”

Sukuna’s fingers tightened slightly against Leora’s waist.

Friedhelm noticed.

So did Leora.

Leora inhaled once before continuing.

“A battlefield between Lieders begins before violence.”

She looked toward Sukuna briefly.

“Awareness matters more than power initially.”

That irritated Sukuna immediately.

Not visibly.

But Chōbei felt Tsukihiko tense because Sukuna’s cursed energy shifted almost imperceptibly.

Leora noticed too.

“Which is why I failed.”

Sukuna’s gaze snapped toward her instantly.

Sharp.

Dangerous.

But Leora continued anyway.

“I was distracted.”

“You were ambushed,” Tsukihiko said immediately.

Leora ignored him.

“I relaxed.”

“Mama—”

“I stopped listening,” she said flatly.

The room went quiet again.

Because her tone had changed.

Not emotional.

Condemning.

Toward herself.

Friedhelm watched her carefully.

Then sighed.

“You are impossible.”

Leora laughed once.

Dry.

“And yet correct.”

“No,” Friedhelm replied calmly. “Only self-destructive.”

That startled everyone.

Because Friedhelm almost never openly contradicted her.

Leora looked at him.

He looked back steadily.

Then said:

“You survived.”

The room stilled.

Friedhelm’s pale eyes remained fixed on her.

“You survived,” he repeated quietly. “And now you are trying to make survival shameful because you cannot tolerate failure.”

Leora looked away first.

That alone unsettled the table.

Because Leora almost never yielded ground once she committed to something.

Sukuna watched Friedhelm carefully now too.

Watching the strange sharpness beneath his gentleness.

Watching the absolute refusal to let her devour herself alive.

Chōbei suddenly spoke.

Softly.

“You two talk like this all the time?”

Friedhelm blinked once.

In unison they answered, "Yes."

Chōbei looked horrified.

Tsukihiko looked exhausted.

Kurohiko looked like he suddenly understood at least twenty years of strange interactions between them.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna finally understood why nobody else in the world could truly separate the two siblings.

Not even themselves.

Because they did not merely share history.

They shared structure.

Meaning.

Rhythm.

Like two parts of the same unfinished song.

Chapter XLVII- What Happened Part III

The room had gone too quiet.

Not tense.

Not angry.

Something worse.

Like everyone present had realized simultaneously that the world was much larger, older, and more dangerous than they had understood an hour ago.

Leora sat upright despite the bruising still shadowed faintly beneath her restored skin. Her posture remained perfect. Controlled.

Too controlled.

Sukuna knew that posture now.

It was the same posture she had possessed while dragging herself through mud with half her body severed away.

The posture of someone enduring something already accepted.

Leora shifted slightly and spoke with frightening clarity.

“It is shameful I failed.”

The words landed flatly.

No plea for reassurance.

No invitation for comfort.

Just fact.

Her silver eyes moved toward Friedhelm.

“I do not know why all of you are going soft about this.”

Tsukihiko visibly disliked that sentence.

Chōbei even more.

But Leora continued before anyone could interrupt.

“If I had failed before, I would not be here today.” Her voice sharpened slightly. “Failure was never tolerable. It was never survivable. You know that better than anyone, Friedhelm.”

Friedhelm did not answer immediately.

Which was answer enough.

Leora looked almost cold now.

“I am the Alraune.” Her fingers tightened once against the table. “There should be no Lieder stronger than us.”

Silence.

Then quieter:

“If there is... then our time in the sun is over.”

Nobody moved.

Friedhelm did not contradict her.

That terrified Sukuna more than if he had.

Because Friedhelm remembered everything.

And if he was thinking instead of correcting—
then part of him agreed.

Leora looked downward briefly.

Then spoke again.

“I am the Sun,” she said quietly, “and you are the Moon.”

Her eyes lifted toward Friedhelm.

“The wolves have always chased us.”

Something uncomfortable moved through the room.

Old.

Ancient.

Friedhelm’s expression tightened immediately.

“Leora.”

But she continued anyway.

“Now,” she said evenly, “one has devoured me.”

Friedhelm became visibly cross for the first time since the conversation began.

“We are not a folk tale.”

“Are we not?”

The words came immediately.

Too immediately.

Like she had already argued this with herself a hundred times.

“Hati and Sköll have always chased after us.”

Mizuki frowned slightly.

“Who are Hati and Sköll?”

Leora finally looked away from Friedhelm and toward the others again.

“Hati Hróðvitnisson,” she explained softly. “One Who Hates. The Enemy.”

Then:

“Sköll. Mockery. Treachery. The Pursuer.”

Outside, wind moved softly through the snowy gardens.

“In the old stories,” Leora continued, “the wolves chase the sun and moon from the beginning of time.”

Friedhelm leaned back slightly now.

Avoiding her gaze.

Still irritated.

Still listening.

“The important part,” Leora said, “is that the celestial bodies are already living inside a countdown.”

Her fingers tapped once softly against the wood.

“That is us.”

Now the room truly understood she was not speaking metaphorically.

Not fully.

“As Lieders,” she continued, “we establish first structure. We dominate rhythm. We dictate engagement.”

Each phrase sounded less like explanation and more like doctrine.

“If another Lieders reaches us first...”

Her jaw tightened.

“...then the sky has already been touched.”

Silence.

Heavy silence.

Sukuna watched her carefully.

And finally understood what she truly feared.

Not death.

Not pain.

Replacement.

Loss of inevitability.

Loss of dominance.

Loss of structure.

Leora inhaled slowly.

“When his note entered me before I recognized him...” Her eyes unfocused slightly. “I ceased being the sun.”

The statement hit the room like a physical strike.

Kurohiko looked disturbed.

Mizuki looked confused and horrified simultaneously.

Tsukihiko’s grip tightened unconsciously around Chōbei.

And Chōbei—

Chōbei looked furious.

Not at her.

At the idea itself.

Friedhelm finally spoke.

Quietly.

“Leora measures herself against absolute control.”

No one interrupted him.

“If she loses initiative once...” His pale eyes lowered slightly. “Then in her mind, decay has already begun.”

Leora gave one tiny nod.

As if confirming diagnosis.

“In the stories,” she said softly, “once the wolves finally catch the sun and moon...”

Her voice thinned slightly.

“...the world ends shortly afterward.”

Kiyomi stared at her.

“No.”

The word escaped before she could stop it.

Leora looked at her gently.

Not dismissive.

Almost sad.

“You asked what happened,” she said quietly. “This happened.”

Sukuna sat perfectly still.

But inwardly—

something vicious had begun moving.

Because he understood now.

Leora believed this logically.

Not emotionally.

To her, this was not insecurity.

Not shame.

Not panic.

It was structural inevitability.

She had been reached first.

Therefore someday she could be reached again.

And if that happened—

the household could fall.

The children could die.

Friedhelm could die.

Sukuna could be controlled.

So naturally, in her mind:

Ragnarök had already begun quietly.

And then—

Sukuna spoke.

Finally.

Cold.

Certain.

“So kill the wolves.”

The room went still.

Leora looked at him.

Actually looked at him.

And Sukuna’s eyes narrowed slightly.

“There is no fate in existence I accept simply because it arrived.”

His voice had gone frighteningly calm.

“If something reached you once, then next time we destroy it before it breathes.”

Leora stared at him.

Not softened.

Not reassured.

Something stranger.

Like she had forgotten there were people in existence capable of rejecting inevitability itself.

Friedhelm looked at Sukuna next.

Long.

Thoughtful.

And somewhere very deep beneath his exhaustion—

something eased slightly.

Because Sukuna did not think like a Liedr.

Leora saw cycles.

Decline.

Structure.

Collapse.

But Sukuna?

Sukuna looked at apocalypse itself—

and treated it like an opponent that simply had not been killed yet.

Chapter XLVIII - What Happened Part IV

The silence after Sukuna's words lingered heavily across the table.

Not fearful.

Thinking.

Leora stared at him openly now.

Friedhelm too.

And then, at the exact same moment, both of them spoke.

"You're different."

"What happened to you?"

The synchronization made Tsukihiko glance between them immediately.

Sukuna did not answer.

But inwardly—

he remembered.

The ruined forest.

Black snow.

Eirvorr's blood steaming across frozen ground.

The impossible stillness.

And finally—

those burning fingers pressing into his chest.

A piece of inevitability itself forced into him.

Something old.

Something that had changed the shape of his existence quietly.

He could still feel it.

Not power.

Not cursed energy.

Something heavier.

Something patient.

Leora watched him carefully.

Too carefully.

And Sukuna realized she could feel it too.

Not consciously perhaps.

But Lieders understood structure.

And his had changed.

Friedhelm tilted his head slightly.

Then asked quietly:

“How did you get to Helheim?”

The room stilled again.

Sukuna’s gaze shifted toward him.

Friedhelm’s expression remained calm but intent.

“How did you retrieve us?”

Leora softened beside him instantly.

It was subtle.

But Sukuna saw it.

Saw the expectation already forming in her eyes.

Not arrogance.

Not assumption.

Something simpler.

Trust.

The belief that of course Sukuna had done something impossible.

Because Sukuna always tore through impossibility eventually.

And worse—

she looked pleased by it.

Curious.

Fond.

Like she expected him to answer:

> I just did.

But Sukuna remembered the truth.

He remembered collapsing.

The empty side of the bed.

The silence.

Mizuki's face.

Kurohiko saying they had not recognized her body.

He remembered panic.

Real panic.

He remembered becoming something ugly and desperate enough that even Eirvorr had smiled at him like a starving animal finally baring its teeth.

And he remembered this most clearly of all:

He had not brought them back.

Eirvorr had.

Sukuna's hand tightened once beneath the table.

Leora noticed immediately.

Of course she did.

Her expression softened further.

Gentler now.

As if she mistook the hesitation for exhaustion.

And suddenly—

Sukuna understood something horrible.

Neither of them had ever questioned it.

Not once.

Not even slightly.

They loved him enough that the impossible simply became believable.

Friedhelm waited quietly.

The others watched too now.

Tsukihiko especially attentive.

Chōbei narrowing his eyes slightly.

Sukuna could lie.

It would be easy.

One sentence.

One omission.

And they would believe it completely.

But then—

he remembered the forge.

The bells.

Leora tearing apart her own soul so he would remain whole.

And something inside him rejected dishonesty immediately.

Sukuna exhaled once.

Slowly.

Then finally spoke.

“I did not retrieve you.”

The room went still.

Leora blinked once.

Friedhelm’s expression sharpened.

Sukuna continued before anyone could interrupt.

“I tried.”

His voice remained calm.

But something in it felt heavier now.

“I would have torn apart whatever existed between worlds to reach you.”

Leora’s eyes softened painfully at that.

“But I failed.”

The word landed like iron.

Because Sukuna did not use that word lightly.

Ever.

“I found...” He paused once. “Something else.”

Not a lie.

Not fully truth either.

Eirvorr did not belong at this table yet.

Friedhelm watched him with growing intensity now.

And Sukuna continued.

“You had gone too deep.”

Leora's expression changed instantly.

Recognition.

Fear.

Understanding.

Sukuna saw the exact moment she realized what that implied.

His gaze shifted toward her.

"I did not know what Helheim was," he admitted flatly. "I did not know where you were."

The shame tasted foul in his mouth.

Because now that he had seen it—

now that he understood—

he hated that there had been somewhere beyond his reach.

Leora moved before thinking.

Her fingers wrapped around his wrist immediately.

Not comforting.

Anchoring.

"You came anyway," she said quietly.

Sukuna looked at her.

And suddenly remembered her words in the forge:

> Then I will touch him harder.

His chest tightened sharply.

Friedhelm was still watching him.

Then quietly—

very quietly—

he asked:

"Who brought us back?"

The room became silent enough to hear breathing.

Sukuna thought of Eirvorr standing beneath dead stars.

Thought of him touching Leora's hair like moonlight belonged to him.

Thought of the fight.

The forest.

The inevitability forced into his chest.

And finally Sukuna answered:

"...someone interested in her."

Leora went completely still beside him.

Friedhelm's pale eyes widened slightly.

Not shocked.

Worse.

Recognizing.

And Sukuna suddenly realized both of them already knew exactly the kind of beings capable of walking into Helheim and returning with the dead.

Which meant—

this terrified them far more than if he had lied.

Chapter XLVIII - What Happened Part IV

The room changed instantly.

Not emotionally.

Structurally.

Like something underneath reality itself had shifted out of place.

Leora folded forward suddenly, elbows braced against the table so hard the wood creaked faintly beneath the pressure.

Her pale hair spilled down, obscuring her face completely.

But everyone could see her hands shaking.

Violently.

White-knuckled.

Friedhelm stared at Sukuna.

Just stared at him.

As if waiting for the rest of the sentence.

Waiting for the correction.

The lie.

Something.

Anything.

But Sukuna said nothing.

And Friedhelm slowly turned his head.

Across the table.

Toward Tsukihiko.

Toward Chōbei.

And then—

he saw it.

The foxfire beneath Chōbei's scars.

Silver light moving quietly beneath damaged flesh.

Recognition flashed across Friedhelm's face so violently it almost looked like pain.

Then he made a sound.

A horrible sound.

Not human.

Thin.

Broken.

Like something inside him had split open.

Leora flinched sharply beside Sukuna.

Sukuna moved instantly.

One hand caught Leora's shoulder.

The other reached toward Friedhelm automatically.

Protective.

Instinctive.

But neither sibling seemed fully aware of the room anymore.

Leora's voice came out barely above a whisper.

"They won't let us die."

Silence.

Friedhelm was shaking now too.

Hard enough the table trembled faintly beneath his hands.

Leora's fingers curled into her own sleeves.

Eyes unfocused.

"After we..." Her voice caught. "They won't let us die."

Friedhelm suddenly looked toward Tsukihiko again.

And the expression on his face made Chōbei's stomach turn.

Because for one terrible second—

it looked like Friedhelm wanted to grab Tsukihiko and run.

Run where, Chōbei didn't know.

Somewhere unreachable.

Somewhere hidden.

Leora looked corpse-pale now.

Shaking visibly.

Friedhelm swallowed hard enough everyone heard it.

Then asked quietly—

too quietly—

“Has something spoken to either of you?”

His eyes moved between Tsukihiko and Chōbei.

“Taken interest in you?”

Tsukihiko exchanged a glance with Chōbei.

Then answered carefully.

“Yes.”

Friedhelm closed his eyes.

Tsukihiko continued:

“In death. I met someone.”

His brows knit slightly as he remembered.

“He reminded me of uncle Friedhelm.”

Friedhelm made another small sound.

Almost a whimper this time.

Leora folded further into herself.

Tsukihiko continued slowly:

“He was surrounded by foxes.”

Friedhelm looked physically ill now.

Leora’s breathing had become uneven.

Then quietly—

very quietly—

she asked Sukuna:

“Are you sure?”

Her voice shook.

“Are you absolutely sure you did not come retrieve us?”

Sukuna frowned.

Leora lifted her head finally.

Her face looked stricken.

“Are you sure you did not touch me in the water?”

The silence afterward was unbearable.

Chōbei looked between them all and suddenly realized he had never seen Sukuna look like this before.

Not rage.

Not violence.

Not grief.

Something far worse.

The expression of a man realizing the shape of something enormous standing behind him.

Sukuna answered slowly.

“No.”

Leora made a sharp sound in the back of her throat.

Terror.

Real terror.

Then she whispered again:

“They won’t ever let us die.”

Her breathing hitched.

“They won’t let us go.”

“If we want to die, they won’t let us, Friedhelm. We can’t run or hide anywhere-”

Friedhelm snapped immediately:

“Be quiet.”

Too fast.

Too harsh.

Fear.

Pure fear.

The entire room had gone motionless now.

Then—

quietly—

Kurohiko spoke.

His eyes remained fixed on Sukuna.

“The deity who brought mama and uncle Friedhelm back...”

He hesitated.

“...was he black? With stag antlers?”

Leora’s head jerked upward instantly.

Sukuna looked at Kurohiko sharply.

Then nodded once.

Leora grabbed Sukuna’s arm so hard her nails bit through fabric.

She opened her mouth—

Closed it.

Tried again.

Nothing came out.

Time passed strangely after that.

Nobody spoke.

Friedhelm’s shaking slowly eased.

Leora’s breathing steadied little by little.

But neither looked normal anymore.

Finally Leora asked quietly:

“Did he say why?”

Sukuna looked down at her.

“Why he didn’t keep me.”

The words twisted something ugly inside Sukuna immediately.

Possessive.

Violent.

He answered anyway.

“He said you would miss the children too much.”

Leora shut her eyes.

Sukuna continued flatly:

“And that if you could not say goodbye to me properly...”

His jaw tightened.

“...you would become troublesome.”

Leora laughed.

Sharp.

Disbelieving.

Almost offended.

The sound echoed strangely through the room.

Sukuna’s hand moved unconsciously toward the bracelet.

Heavy against his wrist.

Warm.

Kaguya finally spoke softly from beside Tōma.

“Why are deities suddenly interested in this family?”

Leora’s smile vanished instantly.

She looked exhausted suddenly.

Ancient.

Her answer came quietly.

“Because I should have died a long time ago.”

Silence.

Then:

“And Friedhelm should have too.”

Friedhelm lowered his gaze.

And nobody at the table missed the way both siblings spoke not like survivors—
but like people who had once escaped something that had finally found them again.

Chapter L - What Happened Part V

Leora and Friedhelm did not look up for a long moment.

The silence at the table had become unnatural.

Not calm.

Not settled.

Just... suspended.

Like everyone was waiting for something to break.

Then Mizuki shifted.

Carefully.

Uncertainly.

“Mama...”

Leora’s head lifted slightly.

Not fully.

Just enough to acknowledge him.

Mizuki swallowed.

“Why do you have marks on your body?”

That was when everything stopped.

Completely.

Leora froze.

Not in shock.

In control.

Too much control.

Her fingers tightened against the edge of the table until her knuckles went white.

And then—

slowly—

her gaze lifted fully to Mizuki.

The air changed immediately.

Tsukihiko felt it first.

Something in her focus sharpening into something dangerous.

Mizuki’s voice faltered.

“I— I saw them. On your wrists. And your arms. And—”

“Stop.”

Chōbei’s voice cut through instantly.

Not loud.

But final.

Mizuki obeyed immediately, going rigid.

Because Chōbei wasn’t looking at him.

He was looking at Leora.

And there was something deeply unsettled in his expression.

Not fear.

Recognition.

Friedhelm exhaled slowly through his nose.

Like he already knew where this was going.

Leora's gaze remained on Mizuki for a long moment.

Then she asked, very quietly:

"Where else did you see them?"

Mizuki didn't answer right away.

Then reluctantly:

"...your legs."

A pause.

Leora's jaw tightened.

Another breath.

"Mama," Tsukihiko said carefully, "what are they—"

Leora raised a hand.

Not sharply.

But enough.

Enough that Tsukihiko stopped speaking mid-sentence.

She did not look at him yet.

Not at any of them.

Her eyes stayed on Mizuki.

Waiting.

Measuring.

Like she was deciding whether he should have seen anything at all.

Friedhelm shifted slightly beside her.

A small movement.

Almost like restraint.

The room held.

Leora opened her mouth.

Closed it again.

Her throat moved as if she had something prepared.

Something structured.

But whatever it was—

she didn't say it.

Not yet.

A silence stretched.

Unbearable in its length.

Then Kurohiko spoke quietly from further down the table:

"...why are you shaking?"

Leora blinked once.

As if only now realizing she was.

Her fingers loosened slightly on the table edge.

But she still didn't answer.

Not the marks.

Not the question.

Not anything.

Instead—

she looked down.

And the silence became heavier than explanation ever could have been.

Friedhelm finally exhaled.

Soft.

Almost resigned.

And that was the only sound in the room for a while.

—

Leora didn't speak immediately.

For a long moment, she simply sat there with her hands folded too tightly in front of her.

Not trembling anymore.

Just held.

Contained.

Like she was forcing something inside herself to stay in place.

Then she inhaled.

Slowly.

And began.

"I entered the clearing first."

Her voice was level.

Too level.

"I didn't realize what I was seeing at first."

A pause.

Tsukihiko's brow tightened slightly, but he didn't interrupt.

"There were Todkriegeers."

Another pause.

Her gaze stayed lowered.

"Over one hundred."

A faint shift moved through the room at that number alone.

Chōbei's expression sharpened.

Kurohiko stopped moving entirely.

Leora continued anyway.

“I had seen them before. Once. Twice, maybe. In stories. In remnants.” A small, bitter breath left her. “To see even one in a lifetime is considered... an omen.”

She swallowed.

“And I thought—after Sukuna brought me back from the tribes—after I was taken—” her fingers tightened again, “—I thought things like that were gone.”

A beat.

“I thought I had erased the possibility of their return.”

Her jaw tightened.

“I thought I killed everyone who knew how to make them.”

Silence pressed in.

Then—

“I was wrong.”

The words were flat.

Not emotional.

Just fact.

Leora’s hands shifted slightly.

Not fidgeting.

Re-centering.

“And then the Lieder sang.”

That made Tsukihiko’s eyes sharpen.

Leora’s expression tightened for the first time.

“That wasn’t normal.”

A breath.

“He was talented. He was... **specific**.”

Her gaze flickered, briefly, like something unwanted crossed her memory.

“It was structured in a way that made entry inevitable.”

Her fingers flexed once.

“He used....one of Wulf’s songs... I don’t know how he knew it....”

Tears rolled down Friedhelm’s cheeks.

That landed harder.

Chōbei’s head tilted slightly, tension rising in his shoulders.

Leora continued before anyone could speak.

“It hooked me.”

A pause.

“Exactly the way you want it to when you’re fighting someone like me.”

Her voice stayed calm.

That was the disturbing part.

“The next thing I knew—he was already on me.”

A shift in the room.

Not sound.

Pressure.

“They all were.”

Leora’s throat moved once.

She did not look up.

“I lost control of my body for a crucial few seconds.”

Her voice dipped slightly.

“Enough for them to start.”

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Then she continued.

“He enjoyed it.”

That word made Mizuki visibly tense.

Leora didn't stop.

"He wanted it to last. To be thorough. To ensure there was nowhere left untouched."

Her jaw tightened again.

"But when I regained enough control—he compensated with numbers."

A small exhale through her nose.

"Too many to isolate. Too many to remove cleanly."

Tsukihiko's expression darkened.

"And he was intelligent."

A pause.

"Incredibly intelligent."

Her voice sharpened slightly there.

"He cut my throat early."

That made Chōbei's hand twitch.

Leora continued anyway.

"Not out of panic. Out of efficiency."

A beat.

"It forced compliance."

Her eyes narrowed slightly, almost like she respected it despite herself.

"Then he bound me."

That was said differently.

Lower.

Colder.

"An older chant."

A pause.

"It made direct retaliation against him... repulsive."

That word made Friedhelm's eyes sharpen instantly.

Leora's fingers tightened.

"So I couldn't go for him."

A breath.

"I knew I was too far gone to survive it."

Silence thickened.

"But I also knew I wasn't leaving."

Her voice changed slightly there.

Something quieter.

Final.

"I wanted to see Sukuna."

A pause.

"That was all."

Her gaze flickered once, briefly.

"I had no plan beyond that."

Then—

"I chose mutual destruction."

Chōbei's expression shifted sharply.

Leora continued.

"Shinobi are not the only ones who practice it."

That landed like a blade in the air.

Chōbei exhaled slowly through his nose.

"...Gabimaru," he muttered under his breath.

Leora didn't acknowledge it.

"I developed a technique over years."

A pause.

“One I never intended to use like that.”

Her fingers loosened slightly.

“Sometimes I used to think about showing it to Sukuna.”

A faint shift in her expression.

Almost imperceptible.

“Not... this version.”

A pause.

Her voice dropped slightly.

“Of course, I thought I would be the one choosing when he saw it.”

Silence again.

Then she stopped.

Just stopped.

Like she had reached the edge of something even she didn't want to step fully back into.

The room reacted immediately—but not with words.

With stillness.

With held breath.

With the weight of everything she had just placed on the table without yet finishing the truth.

Chapter LI - What Happened Part VI

Leora didn't let go of Sukuna's hand.

Both of hers stayed wrapped around his.

Not restraining.

Not pleading.

Just holding him there like an anchor point she refused to lose mid-sentence.

Her voice was steadier now.

Clear again.

That same unsettling clarity that had existed even when she was barely alive on the ground.

“I used what ability I had left,” she said, “and whistled one note.”

A pause.

Sukuna didn’t move.

Leora continued.

“It called the hair.”

Her fingers tightened slightly.

“Unending lengths. Razor-sharp. It cut through everything in the clearing.”

A breath.

“Even me.”

That landed in the room like something physical.

She didn’t dramatize it.

Didn’t soften it.

Just stated it.

“As soon as it went quiet,” she said, “I thought about staying there.”

Her eyes lowered briefly.

“Just letting it end.”

Silence.

Then—

“But I thought about you.”

Her gaze lifted back to Sukuna.

Not emotional.

Certain.

“And I knew you wouldn’t accept that.”

A faint shift of breath.

“You wouldn’t just let me disappear somewhere without finding me. Without understanding it.”

Her fingers eased slightly on his hand.

“And I realized...” a pause, “if I was going to die, I wanted you to be the last thing I saw.”

Another breath.

“I wanted to know you were okay.”

Her eyes flickered once, briefly toward the others at the table.

Then back to him.

“I thought you would be,” she added simply. “You had the children. The grandchildren. I thought... you would survive it.”

A pause.

“But I needed to see you anyway.”

No apology.

Just truth.

“Even if it hurt.”

Her grip tightened again.

“Even if it cost everything.”

Then softer, almost like a correction to herself:

“It was worth it.”

Sukuna didn’t respond.

Leora continued, voice shifting slightly now.

“When I reached the training field...” a pause, “I hated that Kurohiko saw me.”

Her eyes flicked briefly toward him.

“I hated that Mizuki saw me.”

Another glance.

“I hated that Chōbei saw me.”

Her jaw tightened.

“None of you should have seen that.”

A breath.

“But then I heard you.”

Her fingers flexed once around Sukuna's hand.

“Your footsteps. Your energy. The sound of your voice in your chest when you called out.”

Her expression changed slightly — not softer, but anchored.

“And it made it worth it.”

A pause.

“I just wanted to stay myself.”

Then, quieter:

“Even like that.”

Her gaze stayed locked on Sukuna now.

“Even dying, I just wanted to remain me long enough to hold onto you. To hold onto them. To hold onto Friedhelm.”

Silence again.

Then her expression softened just slightly — not emotionally, but in intent.

“And I'm glad I got to give you Higan.”

A faint exhale.

“Chōbei helped more than I did,” she added, almost offhand.

Then:

“I wish I could give you more.”

A pause.

“Being your wife... being their mother...”

Her voice steadied again.

“Those were the happiest roles I’ve ever had.”

Then, very quietly:

“If I died... part of me would stay with you.”

That was when Sukuna finally stopped being still in the same way.

His gaze dropped.

Slowly.

To her hands still holding his.

Then further.

To the bracelet on his wrist.

Eirvorr’s words echoed back without sound.

Her soul.

Her blood.

A piece of inevitability.

Sukuna’s fingers tightened once.

Just once.

Not violent.

Not restrained.

Something worse.

Controlled realization.

The shame didn’t come immediately.

It came *after.*

Slow.

Heavy.

Inevitable.

Leora didn’t speak again.

She just watched him.

Because she already knew something had shifted.

And Sukuna, very quietly, understood the final part of it without her saying it:

He had looked at her in the clearing...

and did not recognize the person who had already given him pieces of her soul just to make sure he would keep existing in a world she intended to survive for him.

And that ignorance—

was not something he could undo.

The air doesn't break the way it should.

It *tightens.*

Like the room itself has decided to hold its breath.

Chōbei shifts first, still uneasy from Sukuna's reaction, but trying to explain it in the simplest way he knows how—honesty without cushioning:

> "You were so cut up and covered in mud and blood that I didn't know who you were."

His brows knit, as if he still doesn't like the memory even now.

> "Mizuki was confused, but I think somewhere deep he felt something."

A pause.

> "And then when Sukuna didn't immediately run to you... well, I just kept thinking you were some unfortunate person who was going to die horribly."

He stops there, like that should settle it.

Like that should clarify everything.

Leora exhales sharply through her nose.

Almost a laugh.

Not amused—more like something inside her clicks into place in a way that hurts and makes sense at the same time.

She leans back slightly, eyes drifting as if rearranging the memory.

Then she looks at Sukuna.

Smiles.

Soft.

Strangely gentle.

> “I guess I wasn’t thinking about how you’d not recognize me.”

Her tone is light. Too light for what she’s saying.

Like she’s accepting a fact she should have considered earlier.

Her gaze doesn’t waver from him.

> “Not only did I look horrible, well... you probably thought I was in the estate.”

A faint, almost apologetic tilt of her head.

> “You would have had no idea I left that morning. I didn’t say anything.”

She pauses.

Then, quieter:

> “I’m sorry. That was my fault, too.”

Her hand lifts.

Slowly.

Not cautious.

Just certain.

She touches Sukuna’s face like she’s checking he’s real again.

Like she still doesn’t fully trust the distance between memory and presence.

Her expression softens in a way that makes the room feel colder instead of warmer.

> “I bet that was hard.”

A small, affectionate breath of a smile.

> “I understand better now why you’re not letting us out of your sight.”

That's when the shift happens.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

But Sukuna's hand moves first.

Catching her wrist before it leaves his face.

Not tight enough to hurt.

Tight enough that she cannot continue the gesture.

His eyes don't leave hers.

And for the first time since Chōbei spoke—

he is no longer reacting to the explanation.

He is reacting to the implication underneath it.

Because what Leora just said, casually, softly, almost lovingly, is:

> **"You only failed to recognize me because I was already beyond recognition."**

And Sukuna understands something deeper than anger now.

Something colder.

More structural.

His voice is low when it comes.

Carefully controlled.

> *"You left the estate that morning."*

Not a question.

A confirmation.

Leora's expression flickers.

Just slightly.

Because she realizes, a fraction too late, what he is tracking.

Friedhelm shifts where he sits.

Tsukihiko stops moving entirely.

Chōbei's mouth opens—

then closes again.

Because Sukuna's attention is no longer in the present conversation.

It is assembling a timeline.

A chain.

A gap.

A failure of visibility.

And Leora—still gentle, still calm—tries to answer like it's simple:

> “Yes. I didn't think—”

But Sukuna interrupts her.

Quietly.

Not sharp.

Worse.

Final.

> “You did not tell me.”

Silence drops into the room like something heavy being set down.

Leora blinks once.

Still holding his face.

Still close.

Still trusting the moment.

> “I thought I’d be back before you noticed.”

A pause.

Honest.

Almost innocent.

> “I didn’t expect—”

Sukuna’s grip shifts slightly.

Not tighter.

More precise.

Like locking a mechanism into place.

His eyes finally change—not into rage, but into something far more permanent:

decision.

And very softly, he says:

> “That is not happening again.”

Not directed at her.

Not really.

Directed at the world that allowed this chain of events to exist in the first place.

Leora’s hand remains on his face.

But for the first time—

she hesitates.

Chapter LII - What Happened Part VII

Chōbei knew it was coming.

He could feel it in the way Sukuna's hand had shifted on Leora's wrist—subtle, precise, like a blade deciding where the cut would begin rather than *if* it would.

So Chōbei moves first.

Not aggressively.

Not loudly.

Just firmly enough to interrupt inevitability.

> “No.”

The word lands cleanly.

Sukuna's eyes flick to him.

Chōbei doesn't flinch.

He continues, voice steadier now, anchored in memory rather than fear:

> “You need to remember what we talked about a long time ago.”

A beat.

Then, like he's pulling it out of Sukuna's past on purpose:

> “Do you remember when I asked you if there was a line when it came to Leora?”

Silence tightens.

Chōbei's jaw shifts slightly as he pushes forward anyway.

> “You said no.”

His gaze sharpens.

> “I asked if it meant genociding all of Japan, and you said no. I said what about the world?”

He exhales once through his nose.

And then he repeats it—verbatim, because Sukuna never forgets words once spoken aloud in sincerity:

> “And you said: *‘You are asking if there will ever be a time I do not eliminate threats to Leora’s safety. No.’*”

Leora’s fingers still on Sukuna’s face pause slightly.

Friedhelm’s expression tightens.

Tsukihiko looks down at the table like he’s decided it is safer not to exist.

Chōbei doesn’t stop.

> “And then you continued.”

His voice lowers, but it becomes heavier.

More serious.

> “I will never restrict Leora. I will never reduce her or isolate her. I will simply follow her wherever she goes and make whatever thinks it can touch her regret it.”

A pause.

He watches Sukuna carefully now.

> “I will remove whatever threatens her, but I will never tell her no. I will build taller walls to keep the world out of her spaces. I will prevent the world from reacting to her in a way that she will always have a safe place to exist.”

His breath slows.

> “This is my role, and I will never cease.”

Now Chōbei steps in closer—not invading Sukuna’s space, but refusing to back away from it.

His voice is quieter.

Not softer.

Just real.

> “I fought for my position with her. And you’ve already tested my patience.”

A flicker of something sharp crosses his face.

> “But I will not allow you to forget your own words and put her in a cage.”

Leora’s hand lowers slightly from Sukuna’s face.

Not fully gone.

Just... uncertain now.

Chōbei continues:

> “I will help you keep her safe. I will commit myself to the safety of this family. I will not let you destroy what you clearly love because you and I fell apart completely when she was gone and Tsukihiko unreachable.”

His gaze breaks for the first time—not from weakness, but from memory.

> “I saw you hollowed out.”

A pause.

> “I heard you make noises anyone would have thought impossible for you to make.”

That lands harder than anything else he’s said.

Even Sukuna stills.

Chōbei swallows once.

> “I remember Sukuna without Leora. Without Friedhelm. I will not let you destroy your purpose because of fear.”

Silence.

Not empty.

Loaded.

Leora’s breath catches slightly—but she doesn’t interrupt.

Friedhelm doesn’t move.

Even Sukuna doesn’t speak immediately.

Because something in Chōbei’s words didn’t feel like argument.

It felt like *anchor.*

And then—

The Foxfire flickered on Chobei’s skin.

The foxfire on Chōbei's scars did not fade.

It lingered like an afterimage the world hadn't finished deciding on.

Then the air *folded.*

Not violently.

Precisely.

Something arriving because it was permitted to arrive.

A box appeared on the table.

No sound of placement. No transition. Just presence.

🟦 THE BOX

Chōbei stared at it first, instinctively.

Tsukihiko reached out more cautiously.

Friedhelm didn't move at all.

Sukuna didn't speak.

The box was dark wood bound with thin, pale metal—too old to be decorative, too intact to be natural.

And inside it—

resting like something preserved rather than stored—

was an ancient piece of black antler.

🔴 THE ANTLER

The antler was not plain.

It was carved.

Deeply.

Relentlessly.

The carvings showed:

* a woman unmistakably Leora, standing among foxes
* a man beside her, softened and distant, surrounded by fox shapes—Friedhelm
* between them, Chōbei

But Chōbei was wrong.

No eyes.

No lips.

Only scars where expression should have been.

Not erased.

Reduced.

As if the carving had decided only what could survive definition.

On the opposite side of the antler:

A man with four arms and four eyes.

Reaching toward Leora.

Not striking.

Not claiming.

Just reaching.

Like inevitability given form.

Black bells were tied to the antler's tips.

They chimed softly.

Once.

Then again.

As if acknowledging recognition rather than announcing arrival.

Tsukihiko moved first.

Carefully, he touched the antler.

The moment his fingers made contact—

the box *responded.*

Not opening.

Not breaking.

Producing.

● WHAT APPEARS

Inside the box, something formed.

Dolls.

Three.

Tsukihiko.

Chōbei.

Kohaku.

Made of rich cloth and silk, stitched with unsettling precision.

Tsukihiko and Chōbei were dressed in matching kimonos—visually aligned, structurally mirrored.

Kohaku's doll sat between them.

Designed not as a separate figure, but as a connector.

Ties and bindings sewn into his form, allowing all three to be joined—intentionally, permanently, in every configuration implied by the design.

A family rendered as architecture.

Silence pressed down.

Heavy.

Unnatural in its completeness.

Chōbei stared at it for a long time.

Long enough that his expression stopped changing.

Then he moved.

Slowly.

Deliberately.

He reached into the box.

Closed it.

Carefully sealed the antler and dolls away from sight.

As if refusing to let them continue existing in shared air.

When he finished, his hand lingered on the lid for a moment too long.

Then he stood.

His face was pale.

Not shaken.

Just... unwell in a way that had no immediate outlet.

He turned and left without a word.

Tsukihiko exhaled slowly, gaze still fixed on the closed box.

Friedhelm looked ill—genuinely so, as if something in what they had seen had bypassed interpretation and gone straight to instinct.

Neither of them spoke.

Because anything said now would feel incorrect in the presence of something that already knew them better than they wanted to be known.

Chōbei's footsteps fade completely down the corridor before anyone speaks.

Not because there is nothing left to say—

but because what remains feels like it should not be said in the same breath as ordinary language.

The silence stretches.

Then Tsukihiko finally breaks it, voice low and careful.

> “Friedhelm.”

Friedhelm doesn’t look up immediately.

Tsukihiko continues anyway.

> “How long has Skugga been interested in you?”

That name again.

It lands differently now.

Heavier, stripped of abstraction.

Friedhelm’s jaw tightens slightly.

A long pause.

Then, quietly:

> “Since I was a child.”

Tsukihiko’s expression doesn’t change—but it sharpens.

Leora turns toward him immediately.

Sukuna’s gaze lifts, slow and precise.

Friedhelm exhales through his nose, as if deciding something unpleasant has already become unavoidable.

> “He used to find fragments of me in death.”

A pause.

His fingers curl faintly against his own sleeve.

> “Pieces of consciousness that hadn’t fully returned.”

Tsukihiko’s brow furrows slightly.

Friedhelm’s voice drops lower.

> “Sometimes he would give them back.”

Another pause.

Longer this time.

> “Sometimes, Skugga would—”

He stops.

Not theatrically.

Not for effect.

But like the sentence physically refuses to continue existing in his mouth.

For the first time, Friedhelm looks genuinely unsettled.

Not controlled.

Not composed.

Actually disturbed.

Leora leans forward slightly.

> “Friedhelm?”

His eyes flicker once.

Then, quieter—worse because of how controlled he tries to make it sound:

> “Skugga would hold me.”

Silence snaps tight.

Friedhelm continues, voice strained at the edges now.

> “Hold my consciousness in death while people used my body and there was nothing I could do. He would appear as they started to undress me, caress me, and then he would look so sad and just take me as far as he could into death to lessen it. Not all the time. He risked breaking me each time he did it. I fragmented more and more each time.”

Leora makes a small, involuntary sound—something caught between breath and disbelief.

Friedhelm doesn’t stop.

> “He would run his fingers through my hair and tell me stories.”

His gaze drops slightly, unfocused.

> “He would leave kisses in my hair and tell me one day I would be his.”

A beat.

> “And that I would never experience pain or violation like this again.”

Leora visibly chokes on air.

Tsukihiko goes still.

Sukuna's eyes narrow faintly—not in disbelief, but in calculation.

Friedhelm's expression shifts suddenly—anger rising like something long contained finally cracking through.

Leora began to speak but her words were cut off.

> “And you have no room to judge, Liebchen.”

His voice sharpens.

Sukuna had never heard him call Leora anything let alone that word.

> “You did what no one should do and you caught the attention of the worst ones.”

Leora opens her mouth, but nothing comes out immediately.

Because for once—

there is nothing she can structure into meaning fast enough.

A pause.

Then Sukuna speaks.

Calmly.

Not interrupting the tension, but redirecting it.

> “Eirvorr came to me again.”

That gets everyone's attention immediately.

Friedhelm goes quiet.

Leora's eyes lift.

Tsukihiko's posture tightens.

Sukuna continues.

> “He offered to retrieve you both from Helheim.”

A beat.

> “Vetrbríð. Heilsundr.”

Leora's expression shifts slightly at the names—recognition sharpening into interest.

Sukuna's voice stays even.

> "He brought you back himself."

Silence.

Then—

> "And last night he returned to heal you more and... I fought him."

Friedhelm's gaze snaps to Sukuna immediately.

Tsukihiko straightens slightly.

Leora doesn't move—but her focus becomes absolute.

Sukuna continues, unbothered by the attention.

> "He gave me more power."

A pause.

> "By giving me a piece of inevitability."

That word changes the room again.

Not emotionally.

Structurally.

Like reality briefly re-evaluates its own rules.

Leora's breath catches—but not in fear.

In fascination.

Her eyes sharpen with immediate, dangerous curiosity.

> "...a piece of inevitability?"

Sukuna looks at her.

Then nods once.

> "Yes."

A pause.

> “He did not fight like someone trying to win.”

His gaze lowers slightly.

> “He fought like someone testing what cannot be avoided.”

Leora leans back slowly.

Her expression is no longer shaken.

It is **engaged.**

Almost reverent in a way she doesn't fully realize she's expressing.

> “And he gave that to you?”

Sukuna's hand drifts slightly toward his wrist again.

The bracelet feels heavier than before.

> “He decided I should have it.”

Silence settles.

This one different from the others.

Less fear.

More reassessment.

Leora finally speaks again, softly:

> “That is not gifting power.”

A pause.

> “That is... recognition of trajectory.”

Friedhelm exhales slowly.

> “That is control.”

Tsukihiko doesn't disagree.

Sukuna doesn't correct either of them.

Because none of the words are wrong.

They are just incomplete.

And Leora—

Leora sits very still for a long moment.

Then, quietly:

> “So both of them have been watching us for longer than we thought.”

A pause.

And then, with something like restrained awe:

> “And we are only now being told.”

Chapter LIII - What Happened Part VIII

Kiyomi is the one who finally breaks the tension.

Still pale.

Still visibly weakened.

But her eyes are bright now in a way they haven't been since the incident.

Careful at first, but unable to fully hide her curiosity:

> “Can we see it?”

Everyone looks at her.

Kiyomi flushes slightly but pushes through anyway.

> “The Lieders. I want to see it.”

Leora immediately looks amused.

Not surprised.

Amused in that deeply familiar way reserved for children proving exactly what she expected from them.

> “I'm not surprised.”

Her gaze softens slightly toward Kiyomi.

> “You have a great inclination for it.”

Kiyomi straightens slightly at that praise despite herself.

But Friedhelm immediately sighs.

A long-suffering sound.

> “Demonstration is similar to training.”

Leora’s expression sours instantly.

Visibly.

> “You always ruin things.”

> “You always make them dangerous.”

> “Things *are* dangerous.”

Leora clicks her tongue softly and looks away.

Tsukihiko speaks next, thoughtful rather than excited.

> “If we learn this technique... will it make us stronger?”

The room stills slightly at the question.

Tsukihiko continues quietly:

> “Anything that makes us stronger makes us safer.”

Friedhelm’s expression shifts almost immediately.

Something softer.

Older.

He looks at Tsukihiko for a long moment before speaking.

> “You’re thinking like a father.”

That lands harder than intended.

Tsukihiko goes still.

Beside him, Chōbei’s absence suddenly feels larger.

Sukuna shifts slightly at the head of the table.

Then, calmly:

> “I want to see it.”

Leora glances toward him immediately.

Interested.

Amused again.

Tōma exhales softly beside Kaguya and leans his cheek lightly against his hand.

With complete sincerity:

> “If Kaguya sang to me, I’d lay down my sword immediately.”

Mizuki immediately makes loud gagging noises.

Kurohiko groans.

Deeply.

Spiritually wounded.

Kaguya, meanwhile, looks entirely satisfied with herself.

> “I’ll sing to you whenever you like.”

Both brothers groan louder.

Tōma slowly turns his head toward them.

And smiles.

Sweetly.

Which immediately makes both of them look more alarmed.

> “I find it funny,” Tōma says pleasantly, “that the unmarried one with no prospects whatsoever has teamed up with the one who somehow has a girlfriend but still can’t figure out what to do with her—”

Mizuki straightens immediately.

> “That is—”

Tōma continues smoothly over him.

> “—to gang up on the married father.”

Kurohiko covers his face instantly.

Mizuki looks mortally wounded.

And then Tōma finishes with horrifying efficiency:

> “The only virgins at this table are the two of you.”

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Then—

Sukuna laughs.

Not loudly.

But genuinely enough that everyone notices immediately.

Leora outright laughs.

Friedhelm follows a second later, covering part of his face with one hand as his shoulders shake.

Kaguya looks deeply proud.

Because she has always known Tōma could bite when he wanted to.

Kurohiko looks like he wants to die.

Mizuki’s anger flares.

> “You were supposed to be the *nice* sibling.”

> “I am nice.”

> “NO YOU AREN’T.” Both Ryomen brothers say in unison.

Kiyomi is bright red now from sheer secondhand embarrassment.

She looks like she wants to sink directly into the floorboards.

Tsukihiko quietly hides his face against his hand.

And even Leora’s mood lightens visibly for the first time since the conversation began.

Which Sukuna notices immediately.

Of course he does.

He watches her laughing softly into her hand—

and some part of the crushing tension inside him loosens just enough to let him breathe again.

Chapter LIV

Sukuna finds Chōbei away from the noise of the house.

Not far.

Just far enough.

A corridor opening into a quieter room where the light is softer and the air feels less crowded.

Chōbei is sitting on the floor.

Kohaku is in his lap.

The child is warm in that effortless, inhuman way—small body curled comfortably against him, fox ears twitching slightly as he makes soft, happy chirping noises that don't belong to anything fully human.

Chōbei is speaking to him.

Quietly.

Unashamedly.

> “I love you.”

A pause.

Kohaku chirps again, tail flicking.

Chōbei smiles—genuine, unguarded.

> “You know that? I love you so much.”

He adjusts Kohaku slightly closer, as if the act itself is something grounding.

> “You make everything better. You don't even have to try. You just... exist, and it's enough.”

His voice drops a little, softer now.

> “You made my life better.”

Kohaku presses into him further, utterly content, as if understanding more through tone than words.

Chōbei exhales slowly, and then leans down, pressing a kiss to Kohaku's fox ears.

Careful.

Reverent in a way that doesn't match his usual roughness.

> "My Kiba..."

Another kiss.

> "My son."

Sukuna stops at the doorway.

Doesn't announce himself immediately.

Just watches.

And something in him tightens—not sharply, not violently.

But **deeply familiar.**

Because the scene does not belong to Chōbei alone.

It overlaps.

Uninvited.

Unavoidable.

His mind drifts, unhelpfully, despite himself.

Leora—

Leora laughing breathless against him.

Leora curling inward when she's tired.

Leora holding his wrist like she can anchor reality through contact alone.

Leora carrying life inside her.

Not once.

Not twice.

Five times.

Five.

Something in his chest shifts at the memory—not tenderness alone, but something heavier underneath it.

Possession, yes.

But also something worse:

awareness.

The kind that follows realization instead of emotion.

How did that feel again?

Her stomach full of life.

Carrying his world inside her.

Not metaphorically.

Not symbolically.

Literally.

Sukuna's gaze narrows slightly as Chōbei continues speaking softly to Kohaku, unaware of the shift in the doorway.

And then Sukuna finally interrupts.

Calmly.

> “You are still confessing your love to your son.”

Chōbei freezes for half a second.

Then looks up sharply.

Kohaku chirps again, completely undisturbed, tail flicking as if Sukuna's presence is irrelevant to his current state of happiness.

Chōbei exhales through his nose, embarrassed but not caught off guard for long.

> “He understands.”

Sukuna steps further in.

Eyes flicking briefly to Kohaku again.

Then back to Chōbei.

> “You are kissing his ears.”

Chōbei immediately adjusts Kohaku slightly—still holding him securely, but now looking faintly defensive.

> “He likes it.”

Kohaku chirps in confirmation, completely betraying him.

Chōbei pauses.

Then sighs.

> “See?”

Sukuna doesn’t respond immediately.

Because he is still caught somewhere between observation and memory.

Then, quieter:

> “Leora did the same thing.”

Chōbei blinks.

Sukuna’s gaze stays fixed.

Not on Kohaku now.

Somewhere further away.

> “She spoke like that.”

A pause.

> “When she thought no one was listening.”

Chōbei’s expression shifts slightly—something softer passing through it before he covers it again.

Sukuna finally looks directly at him.

> “It is distracting.”

Chōbei snorts.

> “You mean it makes you uncomfortable.”

Sukuna does not deny it.

That alone is answer enough.

Kohaku chirps again, curling deeper into Chōbei's lap as if deciding this conversation is beneath him.

Chōbei leans back slightly, still holding him securely.

> "He's safe."

A beat.

Then, quieter:

> "That's all I care about right now."

Sukuna watches him for a long moment.

Then, almost absently:

> "Leora says similar things."

Chōbei stiffens slightly at that.

Because that is the real overlap.

Not affection.

Not softness.

But direction.

The way love becomes an axis.

Something everything else starts orbiting whether it wants to or not.

"Kohaku is my favorite."

Chobei stops and stares, "One of your favorites."

Sukuna doesn't correct himself.

He just continues looking at Kohaku as if the thought had already been arranged in his mind long before it reached language.

Chōbei, however, catches it immediately.

His brows lift slightly.

> "You said favorite."

Sukuna hums once.

> "Yes."

A pause.

Chōbei glances down at Kohaku, then back at him.

> “You have two grandchildren.”

Sukuna’s gaze shifts—slowly, as if the correction itself is irrelevant but being processed anyway.

> “Linnea.”

Chōbei nods.

> “From Kaguya and Tōma.”

Sukuna doesn’t deny it.

Doesn’t elaborate.

Just looks back at Kohaku.

And says, simply:

> “He is still my favorite.”

Chōbei makes a low, offended sound.

Not actually offended.

More like emotionally inconvenienced.

> “That is biased.”

Sukuna’s expression barely changes.

> “Yes.”

That alone makes Chōbei pause.

Because there is no defense.

No justification.

Just fact.

Kohaku chirps softly at the attention, tail flicking like he approves of the conversation being about him specifically.

Chōbei exhales through his nose, then leans back slightly.

> “Linnea will hear about this.”

Sukuna doesn't look worried.

> "She will survive it."

That, for some reason, makes Chōbei laugh under his breath.

A short sound.

Then he glances down at Kohaku again, softer now.

> "He's still going to grow up thinking he rules everything."

Sukuna replies without hesitation:

> "He already does."

Chōbei groans slightly.

> "Of course he does."

A pause settles between them again—less tense now, more lived-in.

Kohaku nestles deeper into Chōbei's arms, utterly unbothered by the political implications of being Sukuna's favorite grandchild.

Chōbei adjusts his hold slightly, more secure now.

Then, quieter:

> "You know this is how it starts, right?"

Sukuna tilts his head faintly.

Chōbei nods toward Kohaku.

> "You pick a favorite. Then you justify it. Then the whole house becomes a war about who you look at longer."

A beat.

Sukuna answers calmly:

> "That already happened."

Chōbei stares at him for a second.

Then sighs.

Because he cannot argue with that either.

Kohaku chirps again—bright, content, completely unaware that he has just been declared a political disaster with ears.

And Sukuna, still watching him, adds quietly:

> “It is not his fault.”

Chōbei snorts.

> “No. It’s yours.”

Sukuna doesn’t disagree.

Sukuna speaks as if he is arranging pieces on a board that already exists.

Not speculative.

Not hopeful.

Structured.

> “This is actually the best case scenario.”

Chōbei watches him carefully now.

Sukuna continues, eyes still on Kohaku.

> “Linnea will grow up privileged. Loved.”

A pause.

> “I will kill anyone who looks at her incorrectly.”

Chōbei makes a small sound—half warning, half disbelief—but doesn’t interrupt.

Sukuna doesn’t look at him anyway.

> “Tōma will spoil her. Ruin her standards for any man who survives the first layer of defense.”

A faint exhale through his nose.

> “Kaguya will pass on enough of my traits that Linnea will remain soft—but not defenseless.”

He tilts his head slightly.

> “Balanced.”

Then his gaze shifts back to Kohaku.

It sharpens—not in threat, but in something more focused.

> “And Kohaku...”

A pause.

Chōbei adjusts slightly, instinctively tightening his hold.

Sukuna continues:

> “Kohaku will be the heir’s heir.”

That sentence lands heavier than the rest.

Not because it is dramatic.

Because it is *certain.*

> “A natural favorite due to lineage.”

His eyes narrow slightly.

> “But that is not why it matters.”

Silence settles for a beat.

Sukuna’s voice lowers slightly.

> “In reality, he will be the true favorite.”

Chōbei’s brows draw together.

Sukuna continues without looking away:

> “Because he will become something too interesting for anyone to ignore.”

A pause.

Then—

> “Leora told me that Kohaku will stand beside me one day.”

His hand shifts slightly on his knee.

> “And then surpass me.”

Chōbei stills slightly at that.

Sukuna finally glances at him.

> “I want to see it.”

A beat.

> “A new era.”

His gaze returns to Kohaku.

> “A new king.”

Then, quieter—almost reverent in a way that feels foreign on him:

> “Wearing Friedhelm and Leora’s influence.”

A pause.

> “Raised by the first son of the Ryomen dynasty and the Bandit King of Iyo.”

His eyes flick briefly upward.

> “Grandson of the King of Curses.”

Another beat.

Slightly slower now:

> “Grandson of the Alraune.”

He reaches out then—casually, almost absentmindedly—and touches Kohaku’s tail.

The child immediately reacts with a bright chirp, tail flicking around Sukuna’s fingers.

For a moment—

Sukuna looks almost... pleased.

Not softened.

But visibly entertained in a way that is rare enough to matter.

Chōbei notices it instantly.

And for the first time in the conversation, he doesn’t joke.

Just watches.

Because what Sukuna is describing is not just family.

It is inheritance shaped into inevitability.

And Kohaku, chirping happily in his lap, has no idea he has just been declared a future axis of an entire world.

Sukuna’s hand stays lightly on Kohaku’s tail for a moment longer than necessary.

Then he withdraws it.

Not abruptly.

Just... like he's decided to set something down.

His eyes shift back to Chōbei.

There's a pause before he speaks—noticeably longer than usual for him.

> “What do you think of me?”

Chōbei blinks once.

Sukuna continues, tone flatter now, but not dismissive.

> “Do you hate me.”

A beat.

His gaze doesn't move.

> “Are we... what they say?”

A slight pause, like the word itself is unfamiliar in his mouth.

> “Friends.”

He exhales once through his nose, quieter.

> “I do not understand it.”

Chōbei doesn't answer immediately.

That alone is rare enough to feel heavy.

Kohaku chirps softly, unconcerned, still warm in Chōbei's lap.

Chōbei adjusts him slightly—buying time more than necessity.

Then he finally speaks.

> “You don't know what we are.”

Sukuna's eyes narrow slightly.

Not offended.

Just attentive.

Chōbei continues, more carefully now.

> “You don’t hate me.”

A pause.

> “And I don’t hate you.”

He exhales, leaning back a little.

> “That doesn’t make us friends in the way people mean it.”

Sukuna tilts his head slightly.

Chōbei glances down at Kohaku, then back up.

> “We’re... aligned.”

A beat.

> “On the things that matter.”

Sukuna doesn’t interrupt.

So Chōbei continues, quieter now:

> “Leora.”

That name lands in the center of the conversation like a fixed point.

> “The children.”

Another pause.

> “Keeping the world from getting too close.”

He shifts slightly, expression tightening.

> “And not letting either of us become something she would hate.”

Sukuna listens without blinking.

Then, very simply:

> “So not friends.”

Chōbei snorts softly.

> “No.”

A pause.

Then, more honest:

> “But also not enemies.”

Sukuna considers that.

Slowly.

Like he’s trying to map it onto something he understands.

> “Kurohiko calls it friendship.”

Chōbei gives a tired look.

> “Kurohiko also calls breathing a coping mechanism, so I wouldn’t use him as a reference.”

That earns the smallest shift in Sukuna’s expression—almost amusement, but restrained.

Silence settles again.

Kohaku chirps once, then settles deeper into Chōbei’s hold.

Sukuna watches him for a moment.

Then, quieter than before:

> “I do not know how to be something that is not control or opposition.”

A pause.

His gaze lifts slightly.

> “Leora behaves as if I already am.”

That part sounds more unsettled than anything else he’s said.

Chōbei studies him for a moment.

Then answers simply:

> “She’s not wrong.”

A beat.

Sukuna looks at him.

Chōbei continues, softer now:

> “But she also treats you like you can learn.”

Silence.

Not heavy this time.

Just... open.

Sukuna finally looks away.

Not in retreat.

But in thought.

And for the first time in the conversation, he doesn't immediately define what comes next.

Sukuna's gaze shifts slightly—away from Kohaku, away from Chōbei, toward the middle distance where the conversation has started to feel more difficult than battle ever did.

Then, simply:

> “Is Tsukihiko okay.”

Chōbei blinks once.

Slowly turns his head.

> “What?”

Sukuna repeats it without irritation.

> “Is he happy.”

A pause.

Then, as if clarifying something that matters:

> “You are... active with Leora.”

His eyes narrow slightly, searching for the right phrasing.

> “But I do not see the same with him.”

That lands wrong.

Immediately.

Chōbei's expression shifts—subtle at first, then sharp.

> “What are you implying?”

Sukuna answers too quickly for it to be defensive.

> “Nothing.”

A pause.

Then, more precise:

> “I am asking.”

Chōbei exhales through his nose, harder now.

> “You don’t ask things like that without meaning something.”

Sukuna’s eyes lift.

> “I am trying to understand.”

That doesn’t calm Chōbei down.

It makes it worse, in a different way.

> “Understand *what?*

Sukuna is quiet for a moment.

Kohaku chirps softly, unaware of the tension rising again.

Sukuna finally speaks:

> “If he is being neglected.”

Chōbei’s expression hardens instantly.

> “Neglected?”

His voice rises slightly.

> “Tsukihiko is not a stray dog you assess for feeding schedules.”

Sukuna doesn’t react to the insult.

Just continues, steady:

> “I did not mean it like that.”

A pause.

> “I want to make sure.”

Chōbei leans forward slightly now, Kohaku adjusting in his arms.

> “No. You don’t get to say it like that and then soften it afterward.”

Sukuna watches him.

Unmoving.

Chōbei continues, voice tighter now:

> “You are not evaluating him like one of your territories.”

A beat.

> “And you are not measuring him against Leora like some kind of... balance sheet.”

That finally makes Sukuna’s gaze sharpen slightly.

Not angry.

Focused.

> “That is not what I am doing.”

Chōbei’s jaw clenches.

> “Then what are you doing?”

Silence.

Sukuna looks away briefly.

Then answers, quieter:

> “I care about my son.”

A pause.

That word—*son*—lands differently when he says it.

Not claimed.

Acknowledged.

> “Like you care about Kiba.”

Chōbei stills slightly at that.

Kohaku shifts in his lap, chirping softly again, tail flicking against Sukuna’s earlier touch.

Sukuna continues, steady now:

> “I do not understand how to show it correctly.”

A beat.

> “So I ask.”

Silence returns—but different this time.

Less accusatory.

More exposed.

Chōbei looks at him for a long moment.

Then exhales slowly, some of the heat leaving his expression—not all, but enough.

> “Tsukihiko is fine.”

A pause.

> “He’s not like Leora. He doesn’t need to be constantly held together or... watched.”

His tone softens slightly, reluctantly.

> “He just is.”

Sukuna listens.

Quiet.

Then:

> “And that is enough.”

Chōbei nods once.

> “Yes.”

A beat.

Then, more pointedly:

> “But if you’re asking because you think love has to look the same for everyone, you’re going to keep misunderstanding people.”

Sukuna doesn’t argue.

He only says, after a moment:

> “I am still learning.”

Chōbei snorts softly.

> “Yeah.”

He adjusts Kohaku slightly again, less tense now.

> “We all are.”

Kohaku chirps, pleased at the calmer atmosphere returning, and Sukuna’s hand—almost unconsciously—moves back near the child again.

Not touching this time.

Just there.

Like he doesn’t fully trust distance yet.

Got it—here’s your scene written properly, following your structure and pacing:

Chōbei exhales through his nose slightly, settling Kohaku more comfortably in his arms.

> “Tsukihiko has his own routine.”

He pauses, thinking back.

> “When we first came to the estate, it took some getting used to. That was... over two years ago now.”

Sukuna listens without interruption.

Chōbei continues more evenly now.

> “He misses Friedhelm.”

A beat.

> “Badly. Sometimes he cries.”

Kohaku makes a small chirping sound, shifting his tail against Chōbei’s sleeve.

> “He never wanted to ask to stay with him more,” Chōbei adds, quieter now, “because he thought it might upset me.”

A pause.

> “So I made sure he has at least five nights a month with Friedhelm.”

Sukuna’s gaze flickers slightly—but he says nothing yet.

Chōbei continues, voice steadier.

> “He keeps track of his siblings too. Like I do with Tōma.”

A faint huff.

> “It’s just more work when there’s four of them instead of one.”

Another pause.

> “He has hobbies. He trains at set times.”

His tone shifts slightly.

> “And sometimes... he forgets to eat.”

Chōbei looks at Sukuna more directly now.

> “So I find him. And I make sure he does.”

That finally lands in Sukuna’s expression.

He looks up.

Not sharply—but noticeably.

Chōbei catches it immediately.

Something about that reaction bothers him.

> “What?”

Sukuna is quiet for a moment.

Then:

> “Kiyomi is still underweight.”

A pause.

> “Even after nearly a year here.”

Chōbei blinks.

> “She is?”

Sukuna continues without changing tone.

> “Leora was worse.”

That makes Chōbei visibly stiffen.

> “Leora?”

Sukuna exhales slowly, almost irritated—not at Chōbei, but at memory.

> “When I researched the Alraune...”

A pause.

> “Even with prolonged starvation, they retain enough weight for childbearing.”

His eyes narrow slightly.

> “Her form is meant to attract attention.”

Chōbei looks at him, unsettled now.

Sukuna continues, steady.

> “But she was still too thin.”

A brief pause.

> “It made me annoyed.”

Chōbei’s expression shifts sharply.

> “Annoyed?”

Sukuna doesn’t correct himself immediately.

Instead, he clarifies:

> “Not at her.”

A pause.

> “At the condition.”

Silence settles briefly.

Then Sukuna leans back slightly.

> “I am not stupid.”

A beat.

> “Telling someone they have a food problem makes it worse.”

Chōbei studies him carefully now.

Sukuna continues, more deliberate.

> “So I observed her.”

> “She does not feel hunger anymore.”

A pause.

> “She was taught her body meant nothing.”

Chōbei’s eyes narrow slightly.

Sukuna’s voice stays even.

> “So I changed the environment.”

> “Food is always available.”

> “Schedules are strict.”

> “Meals are communal.”

A beat.

> “She reaches for things without needing to decide.”

Silence.

Then Sukuna looks back at Chōbei.

> “That is why I am asking.”

A pause.

> “Tsukihiko has a similar issue.”

His gaze sharpens slightly.

> “Not identical. But similar outcome.”

Then, more directly:

> “What do I do so he eats?”

Chōbei doesn’t answer immediately.

Because this time, he understands exactly what Sukuna is asking.

Not strategy.

Not theory.

But:

how to make someone stay alive without making them feel controlled.

Kohaku chirps softly between them again, oblivious.

And the question hangs there, heavier than before.

Chōbei is quiet for a moment after Sukuna finishes speaking.

Not because he doesn't understand the question anymore—

but because he does.

And that makes it harder.

He adjusts Kohaku slightly in his arms, the fox cub making a small contented chirp as his tail curls loosely around Chōbei's wrist.

Then Chōbei exhales.

> "You're not as clueless as you think you are."

Sukuna's eyes lift slightly.

Chōbei continues, slower now, choosing his words more carefully.

> "You're already doing the right things."

A pause.

> "You notice. You adjust. You don't ignore patterns when they show up."

His gaze flicks briefly toward Sukuna's face.

> "That's more than most people manage."

Sukuna doesn't respond immediately.

So Chōbei presses on, tone steadier now.

> "With Tsukihiko... just keep doing what you're doing. Talk to him."

A small shrug.

> "Not like an obligation. Just... like he's there. Like he belongs in the same space as you."

A beat.

> "Because he does."

Kohaku chirps again, shifting in response to Chōbei's hand moving slightly.

Chōbei adds, quieter:

> “He’ll eat if he feels like the world isn’t waiting for him to fail.”

A pause.

> “That’s all it is.”

Sukuna’s expression is unreadable for a moment.

Then he gives a single, almost imperceptible nod.

Not agreement.

Acceptance.

Before anything else can settle, the door shifts.

Not loudly.

Just enough.

Kurohiko steps into the space like he owns it despite clearly not asking permission.

His expression is already set.

Annoyed.

> “I hate Tōma.”

He says it immediately, without greeting.

Chōbei sighs through his nose.

Sukuna glances over.

Kurohiko continues, unfazed.

> “Mama and uncle Friedhelm are going to show us what Lieders can do at sundown.”

A beat.

Then, with visible resentment:

> “Apparently it’s ‘educational.’”

Chōbei slowly closes his eyes for a second.

> “...Of course it is.”

Kohaku makes a small excited chirp at the word “sunset,” completely missing the tension in the room.

Sukuna’s gaze shifts slightly—already recalculating what that might mean.

And somewhere in the estate, without anyone speaking it aloud, the entire day starts to feel like it’s quietly narrowing toward evening.

Chapter LV - What Lieders Can Do - Friedhelm’s Song

Night settled heavily over the training grounds.

Not peacefully.

The cold itself felt attentive.

The estate lanterns burned low behind them while wind moved through the dark pines surrounding the field in long, whispering breaths. Guards lingered farther back than normal. Even the moon-kept militia seemed uneasy standing too close.

Everyone had gathered.

Ryomen Sukuna stood near the front with his arms folded loosely inside his robes, gaze fixed on the field.

Aza Chōbei lingered slightly ahead of Tsukihiko, one hand resting behind him almost unconsciously like a barrier.

Aza Tōma stood beside Kaguya.

Mizuki, Kurohiko, and Kiyomi remained farther back together.

And across the field—

Leora and Friedhelm stood apart.

Far apart.

Not facing one another.

Facing outward.

Like executioners preparing opposite ends of a ritual.

No one spoke for a long time.

Finally Kiyomi broke first, voice small against the cold:

> “So... what does it actually look like... to be Lieders?”

Silence answered her.

Then Friedhelm spoke.

Quietly.

> “It doesn’t look like anything.”

His pale eyes never left the dark field ahead.

> “It means something.”

A pause.

> “It means memory survives the body.”

Leora answered from across the grounds.

> “And songs decide what survives with it.”

Then—

the field breathed.

Not metaphorically.

The earth itself exhaled.

A low war drum sounded beneath everyone’s feet.

Not loud.

Deep.

Ancient.

Another answered it farther away beneath the soil.

Then strings.

Not from instruments—

from the wind itself.

Thin vibrating notes hummed through the trees.

Bells followed underneath.

Soft.

Distant.

Wrong.

And beneath everything—

a lullaby.

Barely audible.

Like something buried beneath the music trying to crawl upward.

Kiyomi's breathing changed immediately.

Tsukihiko straightened.

Sukuna's eyes narrowed slightly.

Because everyone present understood at once:

they were already inside the song.

Then the field changed.

A boy appeared.

Young Friedhelm.

Thin.

Bruised.

Standing perfectly upright despite blood drying at the corner of his mouth.

A larger man circled him slowly.

Friedrich.

And when Friedhelm sang—

it did not sound like himself.

It sounded inherited.

Older.

Crueler.

> “Deutsche Jungen weinen nicht.”

The war drum struck.

The sound physically hit the field.

Kiyomi flinched.

Young Friedhelm remained standing.

Leora answered immediately.

Cold.

Precise.

> “Hold still.”

> “Good boys survive longer.”

The memory shifted.

Young Friedhelm swayed but did not collapse as punishment continued.

Another drumbeat.

> “Count the bodies like sheep”

> “To the rhythm of the war drums”

Snow-covered training grounds emerged.

Dead boys.

Children.

Carried away through falling snow.

The rhythm beneath the earth continued steadily.

Leora’s voice cut through again:

> “Don’t cry yet”

> “Tears make the blade slip”

Friedrich gripped the boy’s jaw while cleaning blood from his mouth almost tenderly.

Mizuki visibly recoiled.

The drums softened.

Strings overtook them.

Bells pulsed gently beneath the melody.

Now the field showed hunger.

Young Leora appeared behind Friedhelm.

Too small.

Watching constantly.

Friedhelm hiding food.

Breaking tiny pieces apart carefully between himself, Leora, and Wulf.

Friedhelm's voice lowered.

> "Pay no mind what others say"

> "They do not care for you"

> "Not like I do"

Friedrich isolated him from the others slowly through the memory.

Like fencing livestock away from a herd.

Leora answered immediately:

> "Open your mouth"

> "Even starving dogs learn manners"

Young Friedhelm knelt at a dinner table.

Starving.

Hands shaking.

Forced to maintain posture while eating.

The strings grew tighter.

More suffocating.

> "Your safe from pain"

> "Truth"

> "And choice"

Darkness enclosed the field.

Young Friedhelm locked inside a room.

No windows.

No light.

Only breathing.

Leora's voice came again:

> "Be grateful"

> "Most fathers would have buried weaker sons"

Friedrich discussed succession killings calmly while the boy listened silently beside him.

The field darkened further.

Snow blackened.

The visual focus shifted.

Young Leora now.

Too small.

Nightgown soaked.

Dragged barefoot through snow.

And suddenly everyone watching understood something horrifying all at once:

Friedrich had hated her immediately.

From birth.

Leora's voice rang sharper now.

> "He cut me from my mother"

> "And called it mercy"

The field ruptured into fragmented flashes—

blood

ritual knives

a screaming infant

hands covered red.

Tsukihiko visibly stiffened.

Kurohiko looked ill.

Friedhelm answered softly:

- > “Stay with me”
- > “Safe and ignorant”

Young Friedhelm shielded Leora during punishment.

Taking strikes meant for her.

Leora continued:

- > “Keep smiling”
- > “Pretty things are treated gentler”

Friedrich forced Friedhelm upright while blood ran down his face.

Adjusting posture.

Inspecting him.

Property.

Not child.

Then Friedhelm:

- > “Stay with me”
- > “Stay and bleed”

The war drums intensified suddenly.

The ground itself vibrated now.

And then—

Wulf appeared.

Everything slowed.

Heartbeat percussion replaced the drums.

Young Wulf sat beside Friedhelm quietly after punishment.

Trying gently to comfort him.

The first warmth in the song.

Which made what followed unbearable.

Leora sang softly:

> “Don’t flinch”
> “Wulf is watching you behave”

Friedrich noticed the attachment instantly.

The atmosphere turned poisonous.

Friedhelm’s voice lowered further:

> “Truth is a blade”
> “Choice is a wound”
> “Love is what survives after”

The memory twisted.

Wulf hurt because Friedhelm resisted.

Friedhelm forced to watch.

Kaguya covered her mouth.

Tōma’s expression emptied completely.

Then Leora:

> “Quiet now”
> “Love sounds better without screaming”

Friedrich held Wulf’s face almost gently.

Wulf trembled trying not to cry.

Then Friedhelm:

> “So I learned first”
> “Kill before they touch what is yours”

Young Friedhelm changed.

Not becoming violent—

becoming dangerous.

Because tenderness itself had become punishable.

The accompaniment changed again.

Beautiful now.

That was the worst part.

Soft bells.

Warm strings.

Gentle drums.

Friedrich's lullaby spread across the entire field.

Friedhelm sang almost too quietly to hear:

- > "Don't fret, precious, I'm here"
- > "Lay your head down child"
- > "I won't let the bogeyman come"

Young Friedhelm trembled against Friedrich's chest.

Wulf nearby.

Leora staring in horror.

And everyone watching understood simultaneously:

Friedrich was the bogeyman.

Leora's voice sliced through the lullaby like a knife:

- > "Look at me"
- > "I only hurt what belongs to me"

The entire field froze.

Then:

- > "Kneel properly"
- > "Shame is ugly when it writhes"

Young Friedhelm kneeling injured.

Bleeding through white snow.

- > "Stand straight"
- > "Broken boys invite hungry eyes"

Friedrich adjusted his posture after beating him.

The horror of it became unbearable.

Then:

- > "Breathe slowly"

> “Panic makes the bruises bloom darker”

Young Wulf shaking violently while Friedhelm tried desperately to calm him.

The song began collapsing inward.

Memories overlapping rapidly.

Snow.

Blood.

Children.

Training grounds.

Wulf reaching for Friedhelm.

Leora standing between them and the world.

Friedrich smiling.

The field became emotionally suffocating.

Friedhelm’s voice finally broke through the chaos:

> “I taught myself silence”

> “Before he could carve it deeper”

Leora answered:

> “He taught you suffering”

> “Then called it love”

Then Friedhelm:

> “You’ll thank me”

> “When softer hands finally fail you”

Young Friedhelm finally stared back at Friedrich without fear.

Then the final line came.

Leora’s voice like an execution blade:

> “Good”

> “Now bleed without embarrassing yourself”

War drum.

Silence.

Everything vanished instantly.

No music.

No memories.

No accompaniment.

Only cold night air.

No one moved.

No one spoke.

Because now they understood.

Friedhelm had never been raised to live.

Leora had never been raised to be human.

And Wulf had been destroyed simply for loving them.

The wind moved softly across the empty training field.

Finally Friedhelm spoke.

Quietly.

> “This is what Lieders can do.”

Leora finished:

> “We do not sing stories.”

A long silence followed.

Then:

> “We make people survive them.”

Chapter LVI

● SCENE — AFTER THE SONG (INTEGRATED FINAL)

🔴 IMMEDIATE AFTERMATH — SILENCE

The moment the final resonance of the song collapses—
everything disappears.

Drums vanish.

Memory dissolves.

Snow-vision fractures into nothing.

Friedrich is gone.

The accompaniment is gone.

Even the sensation of rhythm itself is gone, as if the world had briefly forgotten how to continue moving.

Only night remains.

Cold air returns violently, like a lung remembering breath.

No one speaks.

No one moves.

Even breathing feels intrusive.

The training grounds feel hollowed out—
not empty, but *stripped*, as if something enormous passed through and took the meaning with it.

● LEORA & FRIEDHELM

Leora stands perfectly still.

But Sukuna sees it immediately—

not exhaustion of body.

Exhaustion of *structural restraint*.

As if holding herself together after being split open in a place no one else could see.

Friedhelm does not move at all.

But his hands—

are shaking.

Barely.

Barely enough to notice.

And somehow that is worse than trembling.

Because Friedhelm does not shake.

Not unless something inside him has been forced to remember itself.

🩸 CHŌBEI'S REACTION

Chōbei breaks the silence first.

Not with words.

With fury.

A sharp inhale that feels like it cuts the air.

His expression is not grief.

It is recognition.

System recognition.

He understands cruelty in many forms—

violence, hunger, chains, control—

but this was something refined beyond that.

This was:

> cruelty turned into architecture.

And the Wulf section—

that is what ruins his composure.

Because Chōbei understands immediately:

Wulf was not collateral.

Wulf was *leverage.*

Not because he was weak.

Because he was loved.

Chōbei's jaw tightens so hard it trembles.

CHŌBEI — BEAT RESPONSE

During:

> “Pretty things are treated gentler”

His shoulders twitch once.

A contained flinch.

No commentary.

Just understanding.

During Wulf's presence:

His eyes sharpen.

Because he sees it clearly now:

> attachment was weaponized.

Not accidentally.

Not incidentally.

Intentionally.

Afterward:

He does not look at Friedhelm immediately.

Not because he fears him.

Because he suddenly understands him too well.

And that understanding feels like stepping too close to something burning.

Finally, Chōbei speaks.

Quiet.

Flat.

Dangerously honest.

> “I would have killed him.”

Beat.

> “I don’t care if he was my father.”

No exaggeration.

No performance.

Just certainty.

● TSUKIHIKO’S REACTION

Tsukihiko is still.

Then his face changes—slowly.

Not horror first.

Realization.

Because now Friedhelm’s entire existence reorganizes in his mind.

Every habit.

Every silence.

Every overprotective reflex.

Everything makes sense in a way that hurts.

During succession memory:

Tsukihiko goes pale.

Because he understands now:

> children were trained as threats to each other.

During Wulf:

His breath breaks.

Because he realizes:

Friedhelm didn't become protective *despite love.*

He became protective *because love was punishable.*

When Friedhelm says nothing afterward—

Tsukihiko moves.

Immediately.

No hesitation.

He crosses the distance and grabs Friedhelm.

Not gently.

Not politely.

Like anchoring something drifting away.

> “You were just a child...”

Friedhelm freezes completely.

As if the words do not fit into any structure he has ever lived inside.

● MIZUKI & KUROHIKO

Mizuki does not speak at first.

He just looks at Leora.

Then the realization settles in slowly.

Leora did not raise them through control.

She raised them through *prevention.*

Not shaping them.

Protecting them from becoming what this showed.

His voice comes out faint.

> “Mama never let us become this...”

Kurohiko is quieter.

But sharper.

Anger pointed outward—clean and focused.

Not at Friedhelm.

At Friedrich.

At the system.

At the memory itself.

He looks at Leora.

Then says, almost disbelieving:

> “How did he touch her and survive it?”

No one answers.

Because the truth is simple:

> he didn’t.

Not in any way that matters.

● SUKUNA — AFTERMATH STATE

Sukuna has not moved.

But inside him—

something has shifted.

Not emotionally first.

Structurally.

He is thinking in layers now:

- * rhythm
- * dominance
- * memory encoding
- * survival through structure
- * emotional warfare as architecture

And the most dangerous realization:

> he understands Friedhelm now.

Not abstractly.

Not intellectually.

Emotionally.

And that understanding feels like a violation of something he controls.

His hand moves once—barely—to the bracelet.

● EIRVORR ARRIVES

The air changes before anyone sees him.

Cold deepens unnaturally.

Sound compresses.

Even the wind hesitates.

Sukuna notices first.

Because Sukuna always notices inevitability arriving before it is visible.

Then—

Eirvorr manifests.

🔴 EIRVORR APPEARANCE

He stands where absence used to be.

Massive.

Ancient.

Black stag-antlers branching like dead trees under frozen sky.

Four pale flame-eyes burning softly.

Hands marked with something older than blood.

Not human.

Not god in a familiar sense.

Something that remembers systems instead of lives.

He does not announce himself.

He simply exists.

And the space accepts it unwillingly.

● EVERYONE REACTS

Immediate tension fracture.

Tsukihiko stiffens—recognition from death-memory.

Mizuki and Kurohiko shift instinctively toward Leora.

Chōbei steps half in front of Tsukihiko.

Friedhelm does not move.

But his eyes narrow slightly.

Because he recognizes *type.*

Not identity.

Category.

● EIRVORR FOCUS SPLIT

At first—Sukuna.

Observation.

Evaluation.

Recognition of resistance.

Then—

Leora.

And everything changes subtly.

Because Eirvorr's attention sharpens in a way that is not predatory.

It is *measuring inevitability through her refusal.*

Leora notices immediately.

Her expression hardens.

Not fear.

Annoyance.

Like being studied incorrectly.

She clicks her tongue.

Steps forward slightly.

Not defensive.

Not submissive.

Corrective.

🩸 LEORA — DEFIANT CLARITY

Her voice cuts clean.

> “Stop looking at me like I already belong somewhere I didn’t choose.”

Beat.

Her eyes narrow.

> “I chose him.”

She tilts her head toward Sukuna.

No hesitation.

No emotional softness.

Only declaration.

🩸 EIRVORR RESPONSE

A pause.

Then—

a faint reaction that resembles recognition.

> “Good.”

That single word lands heavier than hostility.

Because it implies:

> resistance is expected.

> resistance is accounted for.

> resistance is part of the structure.

● SUKUNA REACTION

Instant pressure shift.

Cold.

Controlled.

Dangerous.

> “You’re getting familiar with something that isn’t yours.”

Eirvorr does not look at him.

Still focused on Leora.

> “Nothing inevitable is ever yours first.”

Directed at Sukuna.

But not limited to him.

● CHŌBEI INTERRUPTION

Chōbei steps forward slightly.

Voice tight.

> “You talk like she’s already decided.”

Eirvorr glances at him once.

Then back to Leora.

> “No.”

Beat.

> “I talk like she will eventually arrive where she belongs.”

Leora scoffs immediately.

Sharp.

Alive.

> “You’re going to be disappointed for a very long time.”

A faint smile touches her mouth.

Not warmth.

Challenge.

● TSUKIHIKO REALIZATION

Tsukihiko understands something deeply unsettling:

Eirvorr is not threatening Leora.

He is **tracking her trajectory.**

That is worse.

Because it implies:

> she is already moving within a system larger than choice.

● FINAL EIRVORR BEAT

He looks at Sukuna once more.

Then Leora.

Then speaks softly:

> “Now you understand him.”

Sukuna answers immediately.

> “I understood him before.”

Eirvorr’s flame-eyes brighten slightly.

> “No.”

Beat.

> “Before, you understood what he became.”

A pause.

> “Now you understand what survived.”

Silence deepens.

Then—

Eirvorr’s gaze lingers on Leora.

Almost reverent.

Almost final.

> “Love that survives systems built to destroy it...”

The air tightens.

> “...does not stay where it begins.”

Beat.

> “It follows inevitability.”

And then—

he is gone.

● END STATE

Silence returns.

But it is no longer neutral.

It is *loaded.*

Because now everyone understands:

- * Chōbei understands Sukuna more deeply
- * Tsukihiko understands Friedhelm completely differently
- * Mizuki and Kurohiko understand Leora in a new structural way
- * Sukuna understands Friedhelm too well for comfort
- * and Eirvorr has openly marked Leora as something inevitability tracks

And Leora—

still standing straight.

Still defiant.

Still unclaimed.

exhales once.

and says nothing.

Because she does not belong to inevitability.

She defines where it ends.

Chapter LVII - Eirvorr's Departure

The silence after Eirvorr's departure did not settle—it *lingered*, like something unfinished had been left embedded in the air.

The training grounds were cold again. Normal again.

That was the problem.

Nothing about the people standing in it was normal anymore.

Leora stood a few paces from Sukuna, arms loose at her sides, hair stirred faintly by the wind. Friedhelm remained slightly behind her, still, watchful in a way that suggested he was listening to things no one else could hear.

Sukuna didn't move.

Not toward the estate.

Not toward anyone.

Just... there.

Leora tilted her head slightly, studying him with quiet irritation.

Then she spoke, flat and unimpressed.

> "Are you going to stand there sulking all night, or are you coming with us back to the chambers?"

Sukuna's eyes flicked to her at last.

Slowly.

His expression was sharp in that familiar way—controlled cruelty dressed up as boredom.

> "How generous of you," he said. "Commanding me like I'm one of your servants instead of your husband."

Friedhelm's gaze shifted slightly, but he said nothing.

Leora didn't react to the bite. Not outwardly.

Sukuna continued, voice sharpening just enough to draw blood without breaking skin.

> "Perhaps I should be grateful. I've been promoted from battlefield weapon to emotionally managed accessory."

Still nothing from her.

But her eyes had narrowed a fraction.

Sukuna shifted his weight.

And then—

Leora noticed it.

His hand moved again.

Not consciously.

Just... touching.

The bracelet.

Thumb pressing lightly against the blackened silver like it was something he needed to verify was still real.

Again.

And again.

Leora's gaze dropped to it.

Then back to his face.

Quietly:

> "You keep doing that."

Sukuna didn't answer immediately.

> "Doing what?"

A pause.

He touched it again.

Leora's voice remained calm—but sharper now.

> "When you touch the bracelet, you can't look at me."

That landed.

For a moment, Sukuna went still.

Entirely still.

Friedhelm's eyes lowered slightly, as if he was suddenly very interested in the ground.

Sukuna exhaled through his nose.

A dismissive sound.

> "You're imagining patterns where there are none."

Leora's expression didn't change.

> "Mm."

A small, amused sound.

Not convinced.

Not accusing.

Just observing.

Sukuna continued, too quickly now—voice picking up momentum the way it did when he was trying to outrun something internal.

> “If I wanted to avoid looking at you, I would simply do it. I don’t need your permission or your analysis of my habits.”

Leora’s eyes narrowed further.

And then she smiled faintly.

Not warm.

Not mocking.

Something worse.

Understanding.

> “You found out,” she said.

Sukuna’s gaze snapped back to her.

Instant.

Controlled.

> “Found out what.”

Leora tilted her head slightly.

> “About how I made it.”

A beat.

Friedhelm’s shoulders tightened almost imperceptibly.

Sukuna’s expression didn’t change—but the air around him did.

> “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

A lie.

Not in content.

In intent.

Leora hummed softly.

> “You do that thing,” she said lightly. “Where you pretend denial is the same as ignorance.”

Sukuna’s jaw tightened.

> “Careful.”

Leora didn’t react to the warning.

Just watched him.

Then, softly:

> “I’m disappointed in your reaction.”

That was it.

No anger.

No hurt.

No escalation.

Just a clean, precise assessment—as if she had evaluated a result and found it insufficient.

Sukuna’s eyes sharpened.

> “My reaction to what, exactly? Your decision to weave yourself into artifacts that bind fate? Or your tendency to assume I exist to approve of your self-destruction?”

Leora blinked once.

Slow.

Then turned away.

Friedhelm looked up sharply, like he might speak—but didn’t.

Leora stepped back toward the path leading to the estate.

Not rushed.

Not storming off.

Just finished.

Her voice carried back without turning.

> “Come when you’re done performing.”

A pause.

Then, almost absent:

> “We’ll be in the chambers.”

And she walked.

Friedhelm hesitated only a moment longer before following her.

Neither looked back.

Sukuna remained where he was.

Still touching the bracelet.

Not because he needed to.

Because he could not seem to stop.

And for the first time since Eirvorr had spoken, the silence did not feel empty.

It felt like something had been named—and was now waiting to be answered.

Tsukihiko didn’t make it back to their private room with any composure left to spare.

The moment the door shut behind them, whatever restraint he had been holding together in public finally broke.

He clung to Chōbei like the world had tilted and there was nothing else stable enough to hold onto.

His shoulders shook violently.

Not quiet tears—*sobbing*, raw and unguarded, the kind that comes when thought has already burned through every excuse and only feeling remains.

> “They did that to him,” Tsukihiko choked out. “To *uncle...*”

Chōbei held him tighter immediately.

No hesitation.

One arm around his back, the other steadying the back of his head as if anchoring him to the present.

Tsukihiko’s fingers curled into his clothing hard enough to wrinkle the fabric.

> “He was just a child,” Tsukihiko whispered, voice cracking. “Mama—she—she saw it too, didn’t she? And Eirvorr—he—”

His breath hitched.

> “I don’t understand why they’re all looking at her like that. Like she belongs to something that’s going to take her away.”

That name—*Eirvorr*—made Chōbei’s expression tighten faintly.

Tsukihiko didn’t stop.

> “And Friedhelm—Skugga—what if he comes back for him? What if he just—just takes him the same way?”

A sharp inhale.

> “What if they take *you* one day too?”

That landed differently.

He wasn’t just afraid of stories anymore.

He was afraid of *loss that had already been proven possible.*

Chōbei exhaled slowly through his nose.

Then gently guided Tsukihiko back, hands firm but careful.

> “Alright,” he said quietly. “Look at me.”

Tsukihiko did—but barely.

His eyes were red, unfocused.

Chōbei studied him for a moment longer, then made a decision.

Without ceremony, he began loosening their outer robes.

Tsukihiko blinked in confusion.

> “What are you—”

> “You’re spiraling,” Chōbei said simply. “And I’m not listening to you do it in armor.”

He peeled his own robe off first, then Tsukihiko’s, leaving them both skin to skin and exposed. The room felt smaller like that.

Safer.

Chōbei walked to the hearth and stoked the fire until it flared warmer, light spilling across the room in steady gold.

Only then did he cross to the door.

A servant appeared quickly, already anticipating the need.

A small bundle was handed over.

Kohaku.

The child made a soft, pleased chirping sound almost immediately, tail twitching with sleepy satisfaction.

Chōbei's entire expression softened at once.

All tension drained from his face like it had never existed.

He kissed Kohaku's head without restraint—slow, affectionate, almost reverent.

Once.

Twice.

Then again, lingering at his fox ears as Kohaku squirmed happily.

> "There you go," Chōbei murmured. "Safe."

He carried him carefully to the crib and set him down.

Kohaku's small tail draped over the edge, twitching once before he settled.

Only then did Chōbei return to Tsukihiko.

Tsukihiko was still sitting where he had been left, breathing unevenly, watching everything like he was afraid it would disappear.

Chōbei crossed the room and guided him down gently.

Tsukihiko resisted only for a second before collapsing into him again.

This time, Chōbei lowered them both into the bed properly.

No force.

Just control.

He pulled Tsukihiko beneath him. He always settled on top of him and despite Tsukihiko being equally dominate he melted and never questioned it. He simply allowed Chobei to touch, pin, and smother him.

Tsukihiko's hands clutched at him again immediately.

Chōbei leaned down and kissed him slowly.

Not rushed.

Not to silence him.

To steady him.

Again and again.

Tsukihiko's breathing began to slow under it—ragged at first, then uneven, then finally less fractured.

Chōbei stayed close until the shaking eased.

Only when Tsukihiko was quieter did he pull back slightly, forehead still near his.

His voice softened completely.

> "Listen to me."

Tsukihiko blinked up at him.

Chōbei didn't look away.

> "I will make sure you get as much time with Friedhelm as you want. Whenever you want it. As long as I have anything to do with it, that won't change."

A pause.

> "I will always love you. I already love you somethin' fierce, somethin' ugly, somethin' feral. I love you more than those words have any meaning."

Tsukihiko's breath hitched again—but this time it wasn't panic.

Chōbei continued, quieter now.

> "And I will never do anything to you like that. Or to Kiba. Ever."

His fingers tightened slightly in Tsukihiko's hair.

Not possessive.

Grounding.

Then, after a moment—

> "And I will not let Eirvorr take your mama."

Tsukihiko stiffened faintly at that name again.

Chōbei's expression sharpened just slightly.

> "Because she isn't something to be taken."

A beat.

> "Neither are you."

He exhaled.

Then, softer again:

> "Both of you are something that chooses."

Silence settled between them.

The fire cracked quietly in the hearth.

Kohaku shifted once in his crib, making a small content sound in his sleep.

Tsukihiko finally loosened his grip—just slightly.

And stayed.

Chapter LVIII - After Vardlokk

By the time Sukuna returned to their chambers with Leora, the estate had gone quiet.

Not truly silent.

The distant sounds of guards changing watch still drifted faintly through the halls. Somewhere below, water moved through the winter pipes beneath the estate stones. Wind brushed softly against the outer screens.

But compared to earlier—

after the song,
after Eirvorr,
after the conversations—

the quiet felt unnaturally fragile.

Friedhelm was already asleep.

Or at least pretending well enough that neither of them disturbed him.

He lay curled on his side beneath heavy blankets near the inner hearth, pale hair loose across the pillow, one arm tucked beneath his face. The firelight softened him enough that he almost looked younger.

Too young for everything Sukuna now knew.

Leora paused briefly beside him.

Not long.

Just enough to brush loose hair away from Friedhelm's forehead with unbearable gentleness.

Then she straightened.

Sukuna watched her silently.

She disappeared behind the changing screen for a few moments.

Fabric shifted softly.

Jewelry set aside.

The faint sound of water.

When she emerged again, she wore one of her lighter night robes, pale and loose around her shoulders, silver hair unbound down her back.

She looked calmer than she had any right to.

That irritated him instantly.

She noticed, of course.

She always noticed.

Leora crossed the room slowly.

Then stopped near the open veranda doors where cold night air drifted inward.

Moonlight silvered the floorboards.

Without turning around, she said:

“Come outside with me.”

Sukuna's expression darkened immediately.

He hated when she said things like that.

Not because he feared conversation.

Because Leora only asked for talks like this when she had already decided something.

And worse—

because she became impossibly clear during them.

Not emotional.

Not reactive.

Sharp.

Steady.

Unavoidable.

Sukuna stayed where he was.

“You say that like I'm about to be disciplined.”

Leora snorted softly.

“That depends.”

“Are you planning to continue acting strange?”

He crossed his arms.

“I'm always strange.”

“Mm.”

“Not like this.”

That annoyed him further.

Sukuna watched her standing in the moonlight near the veranda doors.

Relaxed posture.

Bare feet against cold wood.

One sleeve slipping slightly down her shoulder.

Like she had not spent the evening unveiling horrors one after another.

Like she had not casually informed everyone that gods apparently intended to orbit her existence forever.

Like she had not completely ruined him by speaking about dying in his arms with that unbearable softness in her voice.

His eyes dropped involuntarily.

To the bracelet.

Still around his wrist.

Still warm.

Immediately, his jaw tightened.

Leora saw it.

Of course she did.

Her gaze sharpened slightly.

Then she sighed.

Not frustrated.

Just knowing.

“There it is again.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed.

“What.”

“You touch it every time you stop being able to look at me.”

Silence.

Sukuna stilled instantly.

Then immediately recovered by becoming meaner.

“Maybe I’m simply tired of your face.”

Leora looked entirely unconvinced.

Worse—

amused.

That little narrowing of her eyes.

That almost-smile.

She stepped onto the veranda fully now, moonlight catching silver in her hair.

“You found out how I made it.”

Not a question.

Sukuna looked away first.

Which answered everything.

Leora watched him for a long moment.

Then folded her arms lightly against the cold.

“And instead of speaking to me honestly,” she said softly, “you’ve decided to sulk like a wounded animal.”

His irritation flared instantly.

“You ripped pieces out of your soul for me.”

“Yes.”

Immediate.

Simple.

Like it wasn’t insanity.

That made him angrier somehow.

“You traded a thousand lives.”

Leora tilted her head slightly.

“You say that like I didn’t know exactly what I was doing.”

“You should have told me.”

Now she looked genuinely puzzled.

“Why?”

Sukuna stared at her.

Actually stared.

As though the answer should be obvious.

Leora understood anyway.

Her expression softened slightly.

Not enough.

Still too calm.

“You think you would have stopped me?”

Silence.

Because yes.

He would have tried.

Leora smiled faintly at that realization.

Not mocking.

Just affectionate.

Which somehow made it worse.

Sukuna looked away again.

His hand touched the bracelet unconsciously.

Again.

Leora watched it happen.

Then her expression changed very slightly.

Not hurt.

Not angry.

Just...

disappointed.

“I don’t like this reaction from you.”

Sukuna’s gaze snapped back immediately.

Leora continued before he could interrupt.

“Not because you’re upset.”

“You’re allowed to be upset.”

Her voice stayed calm.

Steady.

“But because you’re treating what I chose like something shameful.”

That landed hard.

Sukuna opened his mouth immediately—

to argue,

deny,

say something sharp—

but Leora shook her head once.

Stopping him effortlessly.

“I made that bracelet because I love you.”

A pause.

Cold wind moved softly through the veranda.

“Not because I was forced.”

“Not because I regretted it.”

“Not because I was trapped.”

Her eyes held his completely now.

“I chose it.”

Sukuna couldn’t answer.

Because every time he looked at the bracelet now he saw:

black bells,
blood,
her soul-thread,
that forge,
her saying:
Then I will touch him harder.

And underneath all of it—

the memory of him failing to recognize her in the mud.

Leora watched the shame move across his face in real time.

Then sighed softly through her nose.

“I’m disappointed in you.”

Not cruel.

Not cold.

Which made it infinitely worse.

Then she turned away from him completely.

And walked back inside.

Leora had almost reached the doorway when Sukuna moved.

Fast.

One sharp pull of her robe and she was back against him, the veranda doors rattling softly behind her from the force of it.

His grip was firm enough to stop her instantly.

Not enough to hurt.

Never enough to hurt.

But enough that she understood immediately:

he was unraveling.

Sukuna pulled her fully back onto the veranda.

Cold night air swept around them.

Then his hands were on her face.

Large.

Warm.

Shaking slightly.

And finally—

finally—

Leora saw it.

Not anger.

Not possessiveness.

Not irritation.

Pain.

Real pain.

The kind he almost never allowed anyone to witness.

And beneath it—

hurt.

Beneath that—

shame.

It startled her so deeply she forgot to breathe for a moment.

Because this was the same man who had knelt in the shrine and confessed love like a catastrophe. The same man who had looked at her after her death with naked devastation carved openly across his face.

But this?

This looked worse somehow.

Like something inside him had split open quietly.

Her hand rose instinctively.

Gentle.

So gentle.

Her fingertips brushed beneath his eye—

and came away wet.

Sukuna visibly startled.

Actually startled.

His gaze snapped downward immediately toward his own hand as though he genuinely did not understand what had happened.

He wiped at his face once.

Then looked at the moisture on his fingers.

Confused.

Another breath.

Another wipe.

More wetness.

His brows furrowed harder each time like he was trying to solve a problem that refused to obey logic.

Leora stared at him.

Fear beginning to bloom slowly in her chest.

Not fear *of* him.

Fear *for* him.

“Sukuna...”

Her voice had gone quiet now.

Careful.

“Why are you so upset?”

He didn’t answer.

He kept wiping at his face like he could somehow stop it manually.

But the more he touched it—

the more there was.

Leora took one involuntary step backward.

Not fleeing.

Just startled by the sheer unfamiliarity of what she was seeing.

Immediately—

Sukuna's grip tightened.

“No.”

Sharp.

Instant.

The word cracked out of him hard enough that she trembled slightly.

The moment he felt it—

his expression changed again.

Horror.

Not at her.

At himself.

Because he never wanted that from her.

Never.

He wanted her trembling beneath him in laughter, in desire, in fury, in joy—

but not fear.

Never fear.

And somehow that realization hollowed him further.

Leora watched him carefully now.

Completely still.

Moonlight silvered the wetness across his face.

Sukuna looked at her—

and suddenly felt impossibly empty.

Because he did not know how to explain any of this.

Didn't know how to put shape to it.

Didn't know how to say:

You gave your soul for me.

Or:

I looked at you dying in the mud and did not know you.

Or:

A god looked at you and saw inevitability and all I could think was that he was right to look.

And she was still looking at him now.

Still beautiful.

Still radiant.

Still *herself*.

Gods.

She had stood in front of Eirvorr and said:

I chose him.

Not hesitating.

Not ashamed.

Not uncertain.

She had stepped toward a god as though daring inevitability itself to challenge her choice.

She loved him.

She loved *him*.

And suddenly Sukuna could not stop seeing himself through the contrast.

A curse.

A thing born wrong.

Malformed.

Cruel.

Violent.

Cannibalistic once.

Emotionally barren.

Genocidal.

Narcissistic.

A creature people prayed against.

A thing mothers used to frighten children.

And yet—

Leora stood before him in silver light with tears in her eyes because *he* was hurting.

Eirvorr's voice echoed through him again:

“I made a place worthy of her glory.”

“If you could make her a moon, wouldn't you?”

Sukuna's face was wetter now.

He didn't even seem aware of it anymore.

Leora's fear vanished completely then.

Because suddenly she understood.

Not fully.

Not yet.

But enough.

Enough to realize this was not rage.

This was collapse.

Her hands rose carefully and wrapped around his wrists where he held her face.

Warm.

Steady.

“Sukuna...”

He shut his eyes hard.

And when he finally spoke—

his voice sounded ruined.

“You should not love me this much.”

The words hit her like a physical blow.

Sukuna laughed once afterward.

Sharp.

Broken.

“Do you understand?”

“You should not.”

He opened his eyes again.

Red-rimmed now.

Wet still.

“You stood in front of a god and chose *me*.”

Leora’s expression changed immediately.

Not softening.

Sharpening.

Because now she understood exactly where this pain was coming from.

And she hated it instantly.

“Don’t,” she said quietly.

But Sukuna kept going.

Like once the wound opened he no longer knew how to stop bleeding from it.

“You gave pieces of your soul for me.”

“You walked beneath death for me.”

“You traded a thousand lives for me.”

His breathing grew uneven.

“And I looked at you in the mud and thought you were some dying stranger.”

Leora’s eyes widened.

There it was.

The center of it.

The real wound.

Sukuna looked physically sick now saying it aloud.

“I didn’t know it was you.”

The shame in his voice was unbearable.

Leora’s entire expression broke open then.

Not with disappointment.

Not anger.

With devastation.

Because now she understood why he had been unable to look at her every time he touched the bracelet.

Slowly—

carefully—

she stepped closer again.

This time when Sukuna tightened his grip it wasn’t panic.

It was desperation.

Leora reached up and touched his face again despite the wetness there.

Despite everything.

Her thumbs brushed beneath his eyes gently.

“Look at me.”

He did.

Barely.

Leora held his gaze firmly.

“I was dying.”

“You were terrified.”

“And you still carried me home.”

Sukuna shook his head immediately.

“I should have known.”

“No.”

Firm now.

“You should have *loved me enough to try anyway.*”

A pause.

Then softer:

“And you did.”

Chapter LVIII - After Vardlokk

Sukuna stared at her like he still could not reconcile what he was seeing with what he believed himself to be.

Moonlight caught against the wetness on his face.

Leora held him there.

One hand against his wrist.
The other against his cheek.

Steady.

Present.

Alive.

And still loving him with terrifying certainty.

She watched the shame trying to devour him whole and finally said softly:

“The moment you realized, your face said everything.”

Sukuna’s breathing hitched slightly.

Leora smiled faintly then.

Sad.
Warm.
Endlessly in love.

“You don’t understand.”

He swallowed hard.

No.
He didn’t.

Leora continued quietly:

“I crawled back to see you.”

The words alone nearly destroyed him again.

But she kept speaking.

Not cruelly.
Not to wound him.

To make him understand.

“I hated that Kurohiko saw me.”

“I hated Mizuki saw me.”

“I hated Chōbei saw me.”

Her gaze drifted downward briefly.

“And when you first looked at me...”

“When I saw the exact moment it dawned on you that those injuries were fatal...”

Her voice caught slightly there.

The first real crack.

“I regretted it more than anything I’ve ever done.”

Sukuna looked shattered hearing that.

Leora shook her head softly.

“More than when I found Friedhelm collared after those four years.”

“More than anything.”

The night wind moved through her hair.

Then slowly—

her expression changed.

Light entered it again.

Not madness.

Not delusion.

Something worse.

Complete certainty.

“And then you changed.”

Sukuna froze.

Leora's face brightened softly at the memory despite everything.

"The moment you stopped thinking:

she cannot survive this..."

Her hand pressed lightly against his chest.

Right over his heart.

"...and started thinking:

I will rewrite reality itself so that she does."

Sukuna shut his eyes briefly.

Because yes.

That had happened.

Instantly.

Without hesitation.

Leora's smile became radiant then.

Almost unbearably so.

"I knew I could die without regret."

Sukuna's eyes snapped open immediately.

But she kept going before he could stop her.

"Because the man I love..."

"The man whose soul is made from the same thing as mine..."

Her voice softened into something intimate enough to hurt.

"Loves me."

The words landed inside him like prayer.

Like violence.

Like worship.

“He loves me.”

“He loves me and I love him.”

Leora stepped closer until there was almost no space left between them.

“My Sukuna.”

“My Tenshi.”

Sukuna visibly broke at that.

That name.

That softness.

Her fingers slid slowly against his jaw.

“The heartbeat I instinctively search for in sleep.”

“The pulse I hummed songs to our children against.”

“That mind.”

“That body.”

“That laugh.”

“That everything.”

Her eyes never left his.

“He loves me.”

Sukuna could not breathe properly anymore.

Leora continued anyway.

Because now that she had started, everything long-buried inside her was surfacing too.

“What Friedhelm and I showed you tonight...”

Her voice quieted.

Not weaker.

Older.

“We survived that to get here.”

A pause.

“We survived to be here.”

“With you.”

“In this estate.”

“In a country that will never truly be our home.”

Sukuna listened silently.

Unable to interrupt.

Leora’s gaze drifted upward toward the winter sky.

“Our children will never know our culture fully.”

“Our songs.”

“Our traditions.”

“The things that were good before our father poisoned them.”

There was grief there now.

Quiet grief.

The kind that had lived inside her for years without voice.

“They will never sing with me about Loki.”

“Or Yggdrasil.”

“Or Ymir.”

Her mouth trembled faintly.

“They will never know why certain melodies make me stop breathing for a moment.”

“Or why certain words feel ancient in my mouth.”

“Or the memories attached to ordinary things.”

Sukuna’s expression shifted slowly.

Because now he understood another sacrifice she had made.

Not survival.

Inheritance.

Leora looked back at him finally.

“We did that intentionally.”

Firm again.

“We severed those things from them.”

A long pause.

“To protect them.”

Another.

“To break the cycle.”

The wind swept between them softly.

“To make sure responsibility died with us instead of being inherited.”

Sukuna stared at her like she was something holy and horrifying all at once.

Leora smiled gently then.

And somehow that softness made the next words infinitely more terrifying.

“Everything I have lost is worth it to be with you.”

Sukuna visibly shook once.

Tiny.

Involuntary.

Leora stepped even closer.

Now fully inside his space.

Her forehead nearly touched his.

“One second alone with you is worth an eternity of darkness.”

His breath caught sharply.

“I would kneel on broken glass for you.”

“Crawl through fire.”

“Drink poison.”

“Give up my soul for the touch of your hand.”

Sukuna looked overwhelmed by the sheer scale of it.

But Leora was not finished.

Not even close.

Her eyes sharpened suddenly.

Possessive now.

Ancient.

Terrifying.

“I would have sacrificed one million innocent children at the forge to keep you yourself.”

Sukuna inhaled sharply.

Not horror.

Recognition.

Because that was not metaphor.

She meant it.

Leora’s hand slid against his throat possessively.

“I would not let others touch what is perfection.”

“They are unworthy.”

The intensity in her voice made the cold air feel thinner.

“I would have placed myself into the fire willingly.”

Then finally—

softly.

Almost reverently.

“Because what you gave me is waking heaven.”

Sukuna’s face crumpled slightly at that.

Leora touched beneath his eyes again.

Careful with the tears still there.

“And I will protect it until there is not even dust left of me.”

Chapter LX - After Vardlokk Part II

Leora’s hand remained at his throat.

Warm.

Possessive.

Not restraining him.

Claiming him.

Sukuna stood motionless beneath it, eyes still wet, still fractured open in ways he did not know how to survive gracefully.

Then Leora spoke.

Quietly.

Calmly.

Which made every word worse.

> “If you think *you* are terrifying...”

Her thumb brushed slowly against his pulse.

> "...then let me show you what lies inside of *me* when someone comes for you."

Sukuna's breathing slowed.

Not calming.

Listening.

Leora's eyes held his completely now.

Ancient.

Clear.

Terrible.

> "Let me show you that you do not know me as completely as you think you do."

A pause.

Then softly—

almost lovingly:

> "Let me show you that had you not been chosen as mine..."

>

> "...you would have died the moment you moved against me."

The words should have sounded arrogant.

Instead—

they sounded factual.

Sukuna felt something cold move slowly down his spine.

Not fear.

Recognition.

Because for the first time since meeting her, he suddenly understood there were parts of Leora even *he* had never truly seen.

Not hidden because she feared him.

Hidden because she loved him.

Leora continued:

> "Let me show you what over two thousand years of selective breeding..."

>

> "...and the open affection of deities older than life and death..."

>

> "...is capable of."

The night seemed quieter around her suddenly.

Like the estate itself was listening.

Leora's fingers slid from his throat to the bracelet around his wrist.

The piece of her soul.

The thing he kept touching because he could not stop remembering.

Her fingertips brushed it once.

Then—

she flicked it lightly.

The soft metallic sound rang between them like a bell.

Leora's gaze sharpened.

> "For you, there is no line."

A pause.

Then lower:

> "Not for me."

Sukuna stared at her.

Actually stared.

And for the first time in a very long time—

he understood what Eirvorr had meant.

Not inevitability.

Magnitude.

Leora slowly stepped away from him then.

The loss of her touch felt immediate.

Cold.

She moved toward the edge of the veranda and looked out over the sleeping estate below.

Lanterns glowed softly through the dark.

Snow silvered the rooftops.

Inside those walls:

their children.

Their grandchildren.

Their life.

Leora folded her arms loosely.

> “People don’t see it as much because I play the game better than you.”

There was no mockery in it.

Only truth.

She glanced back at him slightly over her shoulder.

Moonlight caught the pale silver of her hair.

> “I’m just a prettier package.”

Then:

> “What lies inside isn’t.”

The words settled heavily between them.

Not dramatic.

Not performative.

A warning.

No—

worse.

A confession.

Sukuna watched her silently.

And slowly he began replaying every moment he had mistaken softness for harmlessness.

Every time she smiled while calculating.

Every time she yielded strategically.

Every time she soothed violence instead of unleashing her own.

Every time she chose restraint.

Not inability.

Choice.

Leora's gaze lowered briefly toward the grounds below.

When she spoke again, her voice had softened.

Not weakened.

Sadder.

> "One day..."

>

> "When I finally let it out..."

She exhaled slowly into the cold night air.

> "I hope you understand why I didn't before."

Sukuna felt something in his chest tighten painfully.

Because suddenly—

he did understand.

Leora was not afraid of what the world would think of her.

She was afraid of what would happen if she stopped loving gently.

Afraid of what remained underneath all that control.

Afraid that once she truly became what she had been shaped into—

she might never fit back inside this life again.

Inside motherhood.

Inside warmth.

Inside softness.

Inside *him.*

Sukuna crossed the veranda slowly.

No sharpness now.

No dominance.

Just inevitability of another kind.

He stopped behind her.

Then wrapped all four arms around her body and pulled her firmly against his chest.

Leora went still briefly.

Sukuna lowered his face into her hair.

And quietly—

with terrifying sincerity—

he said:

> “Then let it out one day.”

>

> “And I’ll love that part too.”

Leora made a small startled sound when Sukuna pulled her fully against him.

Soft.

Bright.

Happy.

It was such an unbearably *cute* noise that it nearly ruined him again.

One of his hands stayed at her waist.

Another slid upward, cupping her cheek carefully.

She immediately leaned into it without hesitation.

Without fear.

Her own hands moved instinctively too:

one threading into his hair,
the other resting lightly over the hand against her face.

And then—

she relaxed.

Completely.

Sukuna felt it happen in real time.

The tension leaving her body.
The vigilance easing.
The old instincts quieting.

All because it was him holding her.

Leora sighed softly.

The sound was warm and content enough to make something raw tear deeper inside Sukuna's chest.

Because she trusted him this much.

After everything.

After death.

After gods.

After blood and memory and inevitability itself.

She still melted against him like she had finally come home.

Leora hummed quietly beneath her breath.

Not consciously.

Just naturally.

The vibration carried through her chest into his arms.

Sukuna closed his eyes for one brief moment just to feel it.

Then Leora tilted her head slightly against his hand and asked softly:

> "Can I give you a song?"

Sukuna opened his eyes again immediately.

Leora watched him carefully now.

Not teasing.

Not playful.

Earnest.

Like this mattered.

And after everything he had learned tonight—

after seeing what songs truly were—

the question did not feel small.

It felt intimate.

Dangerously intimate.

More intimate than touch.

Sukuna's thumb moved slowly against her cheek.

His voice came rougher than intended.

Still emotionally wrecked open in ways he hated her for seeing.

> "You're asking like there's a possibility I would refuse you anything."

Leora smiled at that.

Small at first.

Then softer.

Fonder.

And Sukuna realized with sudden terrifying clarity that this—

this right here—

was probably what she had fought so violently to crawl back toward.

Not power.

Not safety.

Not survival itself.

Just this.

His arms around her.

Her heartbeat against him.

The ability to ask him for something gentle and know he would give it immediately.

The winter wind moved softly around the veranda.

Inside the room behind them, Friedhelm still slept.

And outside, the estate remained quiet beneath the snow while Sukuna held his wife like letting go would split the world open again.

The room was quiet in that heavy, post-silence way—where nothing had actually ended, it had only *stopped speaking*.

Leora barely made it to the bed.

Exhaustion had caught up with her all at once, like her body had been waiting for permission to collapse. She crawled in without ceremony, without dignity, and curled immediately into Friedhelm's side as if it were the most natural place in the world.

Friedhelm shifted instinctively.

Not startled.

Not surprised.

Just... accommodating, like a habit older than thought.

His arm came around her without hesitation, drawing her in close. Leora's hand found his wrist mid-motion, fingers curling around it lightly. Friedhelm's hand tightened in response, his grip settling there as though confirming something real still existed.

He made a small, soft sound—barely audible.

Content.

Relieved, even.

And then he leaned in, pressing his forehead gently against hers.

A pause.

Then he nudged his face into the crown of her head, slow and careful, like someone who had learned long ago that affection had to be deliberate to survive where they came from.

Leora exhaled once.

Long.

Finally still.

Sukuna sat in the chair.

The one Mizuki and Kurohiko had started calling *his* without asking permission from anyone involved, as if naming it made it inevitable.

He didn't correct them.

He just watched.

Friedhelm's fingers shifted slightly against Leora's wrist again. Leora responded in kind without opening her eyes. A loop of quiet understanding passed between them—wordless, practiced, older than anything anyone at the table had heard tonight.

Sukuna's gaze lingered on them.

Not jealous.

Not confused.

Just... calculating the shape of it.

The way they fit.

The way they always had, apparently, even through everything that had been spoken tonight.

Leora's breathing steadied first.

Friedhelm followed.

Eventually, even the tension in Friedhelm's shoulders eased, like something inside him had finally decided he was allowed to stop holding himself together.

Sukuna leaned back slightly in the chair.

The room felt too small for what he now knew.

Too domestic for what had been revealed.

Too warm for what the world outside clearly still was.

Leora, Friedhelm.

Tsukihiko and Chōbei.

Kiyomi.

The grandchildren.

The foxfire.

The god who did not introduce himself properly.

Eirvorr's words still sat somewhere behind his eyes like a splinter he could not remove.

And Sukuna, King of Curses, who had once believed himself the center of inevitability—

watched a woman fall asleep holding a man made of broken history.

Watched a family that should not have survived anything behave as if survival was simply what they did.

His eyes narrowed slightly.

Not in anger.

In something quieter.

Something almost... unsettled.

Because despite everything he had learned tonight—

despite Lieders, memory, song-structure, gods, wolves, inevitability—

the simplest truth in the room was still the hardest to process:

They weren't following him.

They weren't even orbiting him.

They were building something beside him.

And he had somehow ended up inside it.

Sukuna's hand lifted absentmindedly.

Touching the bracelet once.

Then stopping.

He looked at Leora again.

At Friedhelm.

At the way they slept like nothing in the world could reach them here.

And for the first time in a very long time—

Sukuna did not think about conquest.

He thought, very quietly:

How did I end up here?